

Final Report of the Forty-eighth Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting

ANTARCTIC TREATY
CONSULTATIVE MEETING

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of the Forty-eighth
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Consultative Meeting**

Hiroshima, Japan
11 - 21 May 2026

Volume I

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PART I

Final Report

1. ATCM 48 Final Report

Final Report of the Forty-eighth Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting

Hiroshima, Japan, 12 to 21 May 2026

- (1) Pursuant to Article IX of the Antarctic Treaty, Representatives of the Consultative Parties, Argentina, Australia, Belgium, Brazil, Bulgaria, Chile, China, the Czech Republic, Ecuador, Finland, France, Germany, India, Italy, Japan, the Republic of Korea, the Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Peru, Poland, the Russian Federation, South Africa, Spain, Sweden, Ukraine, the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, the United States of America, and Uruguay met in Hiroshima from 12 to 21 May 2026, for the purpose of exchanging information, holding consultations, and considering and recommending to their Governments measures in furtherance of the principles and objectives of the Treaty. The Meeting was held in person with a virtual audience.
- (2) The Meeting was also attended by delegations from the following Contracting Parties to the Antarctic Treaty, which are not Consultative Parties: Belarus, Canada, Colombia, Estonia, Greece, Guatemala, Malaysia, Monaco, Portugal, Saudi Arabia, Switzerland, the United Arab Emirates, Türkiye, and Venezuela. One Contracting Party not in attendance, Romania, followed the Meeting remotely.
- (3) In accordance with Rules 2 and 31 of the Rules of Procedure, Observers from the Commission for the Conservation of Antarctic Marine Living Resources (CCAMLR), the Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research (SCAR) and the Council of Managers of National Antarctic Programs (COMNAP) attended the meeting.
- (4) In accordance with Rule 39 of the Rules of Procedure, Experts from the following international organisations and non-governmental organisations attended the Meeting: the Antarctic and Southern Ocean Coalition (ASOC), the International Association of Antarctica Tour Operators (IAATO), the International Hydrographic Organization (IHO), the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN), and the World Meteorological Organization (WMO).
- (5) The Host Country, Japan, fulfilled its information requirements towards the Contracting Parties, Observers and Experts through the Secretariat, Circulars, letters, and a dedicated website.

Item 1: Opening of the Meeting

- (6) The Meeting was officially opened on 12 May 2026. On behalf of the Host Government, in accordance with Rules 5 and 6 of the Rules of Procedure, the Head of the Host Country Secretariat, Ms Masami Fukata, called the Meeting to order and proposed the candidacy of Ambassador Hideki Uyama as Chair of ATCM 48. The proposal was accepted, and Ambassador Hideki Uyama was elected as Chair of ATCM 48 in accordance with Rule 6.
- (7) The Chair warmly welcomed all Parties, Observers, and Experts to Hiroshima. The Chair wished the delegates a fruitful and productive meeting and encouraged Parties to act not only in their own national interest but also in that of all humankind.
- (8) Delegates observed a minute of silence in honour of friends, colleagues and service members who had been active in the Antarctic community and had passed away during the previous year. France paid respect to the deceased diver and French citizen, Gérald Malaussena, and thanked Parties for their assistance for the search and for his repatriation.

- (9) The Chair noted that ATCM 48 would be conducted in person, with a virtual audience.
- (10) Her Excellency, the State Minister for Foreign Affairs, Dr Ayano Kunimitsu, welcomed the Meeting and reflected on the deep affinity between the Antarctic Treaty, which upheld the peaceful use of Antarctica and international cooperation, and the city of Hiroshima, which experienced the devastating consequences of an atomic bombing and had continuously sent messages of peace to the world. She lauded the Antarctic Treaty System's success as a legal framework for addressing global challenges and urged Parties to unite in their efforts and demonstrate to the world the ATCM's determination to advance international cooperation for peaceful scientific activities and for environmental protection amidst deepening divisions and conflicts in the international community. Dr Kunimitsu highlighted the importance of further advancement of international cooperation for Antarctic observation and scientific research for predicting global environmental changes, while also noting that formulation of a framework to minimise the impact of tourism was an urgent issue. In particular, Dr Kunimitsu emphasised the necessity of enhancing transparency in Antarctic activities, reminding Parties that ensuring transparency was the foundation of trust among Parties that had enabled peaceful cooperation, noting that it was the Parties' responsibility to future generations to enhance transparency and to strive for the maintenance and further development of the Antarctic Treaty System. Dr Kunimitsu marked the 70th anniversary of Japan's Antarctic Research Expedition and highlighted Japan's scientific contributions, including the discovery of the ozone hole, ice core drilling, and meteorite exploration. Finally, Dr Kunimitsu encouraged delegations to visit the Peace Memorial Museum adjacent to the International Conference Center Hiroshima to learn more about the realities of the atomic bombing and to reflect on the preciousness of peace, as a helpful reminder of the vital importance of the Antarctic Treaty for the future of humanity.
- (11) His Excellency, the State Minister of the Environment, Mr Kiyoto Tsuji, welcomed the Meeting to Japan and noted the useful discussions during the joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring that Japan had hosted prior to the Meeting. Referring to Antarctica as the largest remaining wilderness, Mr Tsuji emphasised the importance of conservation and effective multilateral collaboration, particularly considering climate change. Mr Tsuji also drew the Meeting's attention to the significance of holding the ATCM in Hiroshima, a city of peace. Mr Tsuji noted Japan's progress in implementing Annex VI to the Environmental Protocol and called on Parties that had not yet ratified Annex VI to do so in support of its early entry into force and effective implementation. He highlighted several issues of concern to Japan, including working towards a tourism framework for Antarctica, sea-ice reduction, and the protection of emperor penguins. He wished the Parties a fruitful meeting in Hiroshima.
- (12) The Mayor of Hiroshima, Mr Kazumi Matsui, emphasised that the ATCM was an international meeting of great significance for the peaceful use of Antarctica and for the promotion of scientific research. He warmly welcomed all delegates to the city of Hiroshima, which continues to appeal to the peaceful coexistence and prosperity of all humanity. He drew attention to some important issues on the agenda, including tourism, climate change, and transparency. With reference to Article V of the Antarctic Treaty and on the hibakusha's plea for peace and the abolition of nuclear weapons, Mayor Matsui urged Parties to return to the basic principles of the Antarctic Treaty.
- (13) The Meeting warmly thanked the speakers for their addresses and for the warm welcome extended to delegates to the historic city of Hiroshima, which stood as a testament to the consequences of conflict and humanity's commitment to peace. The Meeting reaffirmed the importance of maintaining its steadfast commitment to prioritising science and

evidence-based decision making to protect the continent's unique environment, and to maintain the spirit of peace and cooperation that defined the Antarctic Treaty.

- (14) The United States recalled its participation in the Hiroshima Peace Memorial Ceremony on 6 August 2025 and observed that the people of Hiroshima and Nagasaki and their message of peace and hope were an enduring reminder of the power of reconciliation. It stated that the strong partnership between the United States and Japan today stood as a beacon of freedom, peace, and progress for the world, which was a very apt inspiration for the work the ATCM would do for Antarctica and the world at this meeting.

Item 2: Election of Officers and Creation of Working Groups

- (15) Mr Keeyong Chung, Head of Delegation, Special Representative to the ATCM of the Republic of Korea, Host Country of ATCM 49, was elected Vice-Chair. In accordance with Rule 7 of the Rules of Procedure, Mr Francisco Berguño, Executive Secretary of the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat, acted as Secretary to the Meeting. Ms Masami Fukata, head of the Host Country Secretariat, acted as Deputy Secretary.
- (16) The Meeting noted that the meeting of the Committee for Environmental Protection was led by its Chair, Ms Ceisha Poirot of New Zealand.
- (17) Three Working Groups were established:
- Working Group 1: Policy, Legal and Institutional Issues;
 - Working Group 2: Operations, Science and Tourism; and
 - Special Working Group 3: Tourism Framework.
- (18) The following Chairs of the Working Groups were elected:
- Working Group 1: Ms Romi Brammer from South Africa.
 - Working Group 2: Mr Rodrigo Waghorn from Chile.
 - Special Working Group 3: Prof. Dr René Lefebvre from the Netherlands.

Item 3: Adoption of the Agenda, Allocation of Items to Working Groups and Consideration of the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan

- (19) The following Agenda was adopted:
1. Opening of the Meeting
 2. Election of Officers and Creation of Working Groups
 3. Adoption of the Agenda and Allocation of Items to Working Groups and Consideration of the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan
 4. Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Reports by Parties, Observers and Experts
 5. Report of the Committee for Environmental Protection
 6. Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System
 - a. Request from Canada to become a Consultative Party
 - b. Request from Belarus to become a Consultative Party
 - c. Request from Türkiye to become a Consultative Party
 - d. General matters
 7. Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Matters related to the Secretariat
 8. Liability
 9. Biological Prospecting in Antarctica

10. Exchange of Information
 11. Education Issues
 12. Multi-year Strategic Work Plan
 - a. Policy, Legal and Institutional priorities
 - b. Science, Operations and Tourism priorities
 13. Safety and Operations in Antarctica
 14. Inspections under the Antarctic Treaty and the Environment Protocol
 15. Science issues, future science challenges, scientific cooperation and facilitation
 16. Implications of Climate Change for Management of the Antarctic Treaty Area
 17. Tourism and Non-Governmental Activities in the Antarctic Treaty Area, including Competent Authorities Issues
 18. Development of a Tourism Framework
 19. Preparation of the 49th Meeting
 20. Any Other Business
 21. Adoption of the Final Report
 22. Close of the Meeting
- (20) The Meeting adopted the following allocation of agenda items:
- Plenary: Items 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6a, 6b, 6c, 19, 20, 21, 22.
 - Working Group 1: Items 6d, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12a.
 - Working Group 2: Items 12b, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17.
 - Special Working Group 3: Item 18.
- (21) The Meeting also decided to allocate draft instruments arising out of the work of the Committee for Environmental Protection and the Working Groups to a legal drafting group for consideration of their legal and institutional aspects.

Item 4: Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Reports by Parties, Observers and Experts

- (22) Pursuant to Recommendation XIII-2, the Meeting received reports from depositary governments and secretariats.
- (23) The United States, in its capacity as Depositary Government of the Antarctic Treaty and its Environmental Protocol, reported on the status of the Antarctic Treaty and the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty (IP 15). Since the previous report, there had been no new accessions to the Antarctic Treaty or the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty, and there were currently 58 Parties to the Treaty and 42 Parties to the Protocol. With respect to the Annexes to the Environmental Protocol, Türkiye had deposited a notification of accession to Annexes V and VI on 6 October 2025. Furthermore, on 7 October 2025, Türkiye had submitted a Request to become a Consultative Party, and on 18 December 2025, Colombia had submitted a Request to become a Consultative Party, dated 10 October 2025.
- (24) Australia, in its capacity as Depositary for the Convention on the Conservation of Antarctic Marine Living Resources (CCAMLR), reported that since ATCM 47, there had been no new accessions to the Convention (IP 9). Australia noted that there were currently 37 Parties to the Convention and encouraged all Parties to join the Convention to further reinforce the conservation of Antarctic marine living resources.

- (25) Ukraine drew the Meeting's attention to the unresolved question of the detention of marine biologist, Dr Leonid Pshenichnov, a Ukrainian citizen and an adviser to Ukraine's delegation to CCAMLR, by the Russian Federation. Ukraine demanded Dr Pshenichnov's immediate release and urged all Parties to ensure the protection of the freedom of science and to prevent future interference.
- (26) Many Parties expressed their concern over the imprisonment of an Antarctic scientist, and joined Ukraine in calling upon the Russian Federation to uphold its obligations under international law and to release Dr Pshenichnov.
- (27) In response, the Russian Federation stated that the matter had been previously discussed at CCAMLR and explained its position that, since Dr Pshenichnov also held Russian nationality, its authorities were taking actions in accordance with Russian legislation.
- (28) The United Kingdom, in its capacity as Depositary of the Convention for the Conservation of Antarctic Seals (CCAS), reported that it had not received any requests to accede to the Convention or any instruments of accession since ATCM 47 (IP 1). The United Kingdom reminded Contracting Parties to CCAS that the deadline for the Exchange of Information referred to in paragraph 6(a) of the Annex to the Convention, for the reporting period of 1 March 2025 to 28 February 2026, was on 30 June 2026. The United Kingdom encouraged all Contracting Parties to CCAS to submit their returns on time.
- (29) Australia, in its capacity as Depositary for the Agreement on the Conservation of Albatrosses and Petrels (ACAP), reported that there had been no new accessions to the Agreement since ATCM 47 and that there were currently 13 Parties to the Agreement (IP 10). Australia encouraged Parties to join the Agreement, which supported the conservation objectives of the Antarctic Treaty and the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty.
- (30) CCAMLR presented IP 83 *Report on the 44th meeting of CCAMLR by the CCAMLR Observer to ATCM 48*, which reported on the 44th Annual Meeting of the Commission for the Conservation of Antarctic Marine Living Resources (CCAMLR-44), held in Hobart from 20 to 31 October 2025 and chaired by Mr Robbie Bulloch (United Kingdom). CCAMLR added that the Standing Committee on Implementation and Compliance (SCIC) and the Standing Committee on Administration and Finance (SCAF) had also met in Hobart in the week of 20 to 24 October. No agreement had been reached on how to implement the new krill management approach harmonised with the Domain 1 MPA and discussions would continue intersessionally. The Commission had also not been able to reach consensus on re-implementing Conservation Measure 51-07, which had previously ensured the distribution of catch limits for krill in Statistical Subareas 48.1, 48.2, 48.3, and 48.4. The 2024/25 krill fishery reached the trigger level of 620,000 tonnes, for the first time and the fishery was closed on 1 August 2025. The Commission had noted SC-CAMLR's framework and timeline for the 10-year review of the Ross Sea region MPA. The Commission thanked South Africa for hosting important activities during the previous year and noted the continuing positive engagement of non-Contracting Parties. CCAMLR also informed the Meeting that the Commission had appointed Mr Nathan Walker (New Zealand) as its new Executive Secretary. The 45th Meeting of the Commission would be held in Hobart, Australia, from 19 to 30 October 2026, and would be chaired by the United Kingdom.
- (31) Many Parties thanked CCAMLR for its report and reiterated concern that CCAMLR had not been able to adopt a new framework for the distribution of krill catch around the

Antarctic Peninsula, nor re-implement the Conservation Measure related to the existing spatial distribution for this krill catch.

- (32) SCAR presented IP 13 *The Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research Annual Report 2026 to the 48th Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting*, which summarised its recent work to advance Antarctic research, including observations, and to promote scientific knowledge and education on the Antarctic region and its role in the Earth system. SCAR reconfirmed that the latest research continued to make clear that the impacts of anthropogenic climate change were becoming ever more evident, and that they were clearly visible in measurements of Antarctic climate and sea ice, and the prognosis for emperor penguins and seals, suggesting that Antarctica was nearing threshold change. Noting the significant discoveries still being made in Antarctica, SCAR reminded Parties that the world's eyes were on them. SCAR invited Parties to participate in the forthcoming second SCAR Antarctic and Southern Ocean Science Horizon Scan in 2026-27, in its work on the SCAR Antarctic Environments Portal, and in the preparations of the forthcoming IPY-5. Noting with concern the rising geopolitical tensions and the rising costs of science, SCAR assured its commitment to supporting Antarctic research and its integration with policy development. SCAR also invited all Parties to attend the 12th SCAR Open Science Conference in Norway and to draw their attention to the several achievements and milestones outlined in its report, as well as its other information papers that further reported on these activities.
- (33) The Meeting thanked SCAR for its report and, noting the large number of papers submitted by SCAR to the meeting, highlighted SCAR's invaluable role in supporting ATCM discussions and decision-making through the provision of evidence-based, policy-relevant science. Parties also noted the upcoming 12th SCAR Open Science Conference, to be held in Oslo from 10 to 14 August 2026, and looked forward to the publication of SCAR's second Antarctic and Southern Ocean Science Horizon Scan (2026/27) and the 2029-2034 SCAR Strategic Plan.
- (34) COMNAP presented IP 12 *Annual Report 2025/2026 for the Council of Managers of National Antarctic Programs*, noting that the Colombian National Antarctic Program was approved for membership and the 37th COMNAP AGM was held in Warsaw, Poland, where Agnieszka Kruszewska (Poland) was elected as Chair for a three-year term. COMNAP reported on its 21st Symposium "Our Antarctic Future", noting that symposium proceedings were available on the COMNAP website. The 38th COMNAP AGM would be held in Tromsø, Norway, hosted by the Norwegian Polar Institute, with all in-person activities complemented by virtual activities. COMNAP reported that the 2025/26 Antarctic season was highly successful. COMNAP also noted its strong focus on safety and medicine, particularly on preparedness and response to HPAI in the Antarctic Treaty area (IP 4), prevention of harassment, and, in accordance with ATCM Resolution 4 (2013), through triennial SAR workshops (WP 2). COMNAP also highlighted its science facilitation work through projects such as RINGS and Antarctica InSync. COMNAP acknowledged the national Antarctic programme experts and their inspirational contributions to the delivery of internationally collaborative research in the Antarctic Treaty area and reminded the Meeting that COMNAP products, guidance, and tools could be found on the COMNAP website.
- (35) The Meeting thanked COMNAP for its report and acknowledged its ongoing work to support national Antarctic programmes in coordinating science activities in Antarctica. Parties congratulated Agnieszka Kruszewska on her appointment as COMNAP Chair and Colombia on its COMNAP membership. Parties also extended their appreciation to outgoing COMNAP chairs, vice chairs and executive members, congratulated recipients

of COMNAP awards and medals, and reaffirmed the importance of strengthening cooperation among national Antarctic programmes.

- (36) In relation to Article III-2 of the Antarctic Treaty, the Meeting received reports from other international organisations.
- (37) WMO presented IP 147 *Annual Report of the World Meteorological Organization (WMO)*, informing the Meeting of relevant ongoing WMO activities supporting Antarctic observations, research and operational services. WMO noted that through the World Climate Research Programme (WCRP) and the World Weather Research Programme (WWRP), it supported several research and modelling activities in which the Antarctic region was a key focus, including the Climate and Cryosphere (CliC) core project and the Polar Coupled Analysis and Prediction for Services (PCAPS) project. WMO continued to strengthen international coordination of observations and data systems relevant to the cryosphere under the strategic direction of the Panel on Polar and High-Mountain Observations, Research and Services (PHORS), and to develop best practice guidance for cryospheric observations to improve the consistency, quality and interoperability of cryosphere data, through the Global Cryosphere Watch (GCW) and its Advisory Group. WMO also highlighted its role in supporting national meteorological and hydrological services in providing maritime safety information services for vessels operating in the Antarctic. WMO thanked Parties, SCAR and COMNAP for their collaboration and looked forward to continuing this positive, mutually beneficial engagement with Parties in Antarctic weather and climate observations, services and research.
- (38) The Meeting thanked WMO for its report and reaffirmed WMO's pivotal role in coordinating and providing global meteorological data. It was noted that WMO's Panel on Polar and High-mountain Observations, Research and Services (PHORS) was actively supporting activities in the Antarctic region and that a new Antarctic Regional Climate Centre (AntRCC) Network had been established, with the next Antarctic Climate Forum to be held in June 2026, hosted by India (virtual).
- (39) ASOC presented IP 114 *ASOC Report to the ATCM*, which summarised ASOC's participation in activities relevant to Antarctic environmental protection over the past year. This included attending a diverse range of international meetings with relevance to Antarctica, such as Our Ocean, UN Ocean Conference, UN General Assembly and CCAMLR. ASOC reported that it had launched a Vulnerable Marine Ecosystem (VME) identification and monitoring programme, submitted a paper and recommendations focused on sedimentary blue carbon to the joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshop for discussion, and supported research to inform CCAMLR's work on a representative system of marine protected areas and a krill fishery management approach. ASOC also supported the photo exhibition "From Antarctica to Hiroshima: Thoughts about Peace and the Environment" by Japanese photographer Shunya Mizumoto.
- (40) IAATO presented IP 194 rev. 1 *Report of the International Association of Antarctica Tour Operators 2025-26*, thanking those Parties and Experts who attended IAATO's annual meeting and welcoming all Parties to join in the coming year in the Czech Republic. IAATO drew attention to its five-year strategic plan, "Embracing Our Role as Stewards of Antarctica", as well as its new Vision Pillars. IAATO highlighted its actions during the previous Antarctic summer season and its continued collaboration with SCAR, COMNAP, and CCAMLR to address HPAI in the Antarctic area. IAATO also reaffirmed its continued support of scientific and conservation work in the Antarctic Treaty area. IAATO noted two stranding incidents in the Antarctic Treaty area, which

did not require external support. It also expressed its appreciation for the opportunity to continue to participate in intersessional work and meetings with other stakeholders.

- (41) IUCN presented IP 162 *IUCN Report to the ATCM*, which summarised IUCN's work on Antarctica and the Southern Ocean over the past year in three key areas: biodiversity and species protection, protected areas, and tourism. IUCN highlighted its focus on the IUCN Red List and referred to the March 2026 Red List Workshop held in Puerto Varas, Chile to assess the conservation status and risk of 320 species of marine bony fishes, with input from several CCAMLR scientists. IUCN also mentioned this year's Red List reassessments of emperor penguins and six Antarctic seal species. IUCN welcomed the opportunity to collaborate as an invited Expert to the ATCM.
- (42) The Meeting thanked IUCN for its report and acknowledged its support in the protection of various Antarctic species, particularly seals and emperor penguins.

The SCAR Lecture

- (43) Professor Jill Mikucki delivered a lecture referring to IP 21 *SCAR Lecture at ATCM 48: Linking Land, Ice, and Sea: Antarctic Groundwater's Emerging Role in a Changing World*. Professor Mikucki introduced new insights into Antarctic groundwater systems, challenging the picture of Antarctica as a solid, frozen continent. Professor Mikucki explained that Antarctic groundwater systems represented a critical and emerging frontier integrating ice-sheet physics, subsurface hydrology, microbial ecology and ocean biogeochemistry, with implications that were only beginning to be understood. Professor Mikucki spoke to the history and methods of groundwater investigations in Antarctica and highlighted modern methods used in the McMurdo region from 2011 to 2018. She advised of recent findings on the connection between groundwater and ice sheet dynamics, the drainage of groundwater, and the transfer of nutrients, carbon, gases, and microbes to other waters, coastal areas, and the broader oceans. She noted that addressing Antarctic groundwater as an emerging science priority would require coordinated, international collaboration across science, logistics and policy communities, including access drilling, sample collection, direct measurements and longer-term monitoring through wider logistical cooperation between SCAR, national Antarctic programmes and COMNAP.
- (44) In response to a question about which challenges relating to Antarctic groundwater were the most urgent, Professor Mikucki informed the Meeting of the challenges posed by the icy fringe of the continent in identifying and measuring fluxes. She recommended a coordinated effort to provide access to coastal areas and to conduct drilling to measure direct fluxes that were transferred to the coastal marine system. Professor Mikucki also highlighted that, from a policy perspective, the investigation and measurement of groundwater and its fluxes were critical to, but not yet included in, modelling and projecting future environmental changes.
- (45) SCAR noted the establishment of a dedicated Groundwater Action Group to unite international expertise and guide research priorities, specifically to develop thinking on what was required to protect the environment in relation to the transfer of microbes, climate relevant gases and nutrients from groundwater, the impacts of groundwater flux and flow, and sea level rise.
- (46) In response to a question about the ability of groundwater to freeze, Professor Mikucki advised that high salinity groundwaters, in most instances, could avoid freezing, and also that pressure and the insulating properties of ice could also keep groundwater liquid. She further noted there were conditions where groundwater at the bed of the ice sheet may freeze. In response to a question about the ability of groundwater to be replenished from

other sources other than basal melt, Professor Mikucki noted the large body of legacy groundwater from previous eras that may also be a source for groundwater emerging at the coast, and that marine incursions could also contribute to accumulating groundwater.

- (47) The Meeting thanked Professor Mikucki for the informative lecture and acknowledged the importance of SCAR's work and contributions to the ATCM.
- (48) Many Parties recognised the need for international cooperation, acknowledged the collaborative efforts of SCAR, and noted the value of basing Parties' and ATCM decision-making in science. Some Parties referred to the value of SCAR's lectures at the ATCM and noted the upcoming SCAR Open Science Conference in August 2026 in Oslo, Norway as well as their interest in understanding the impacts of groundwater systems on sea level rise.

Item 5: Report of the Committee for Environmental Protection

- (49) Ms Ceisha Poirot, Chair of the Committee for Environmental Protection, introduced the report of CEP 28. The CEP had considered 40 Working Papers, 85 Information Papers, five Secretariat Papers, and 13 Background Papers. Ms Poirot noted that representatives of 39 of the 42 Parties to the Protocol and 10 Observers had attended CEP 28.

Opening of the Meeting (CEP Agenda Item 1)

- (50) The CEP Chair reported that, under Agenda Item 1, the Committee had acknowledged the fitting setting for the meeting in the Hiroshima Peace Memorial Park, recalling the Parties' commitment to ensure that Antarctica shall be used for peaceful purposes only and that the Protocol designated Antarctica as a natural reserve, devoted to peace and science. Under this agenda item, the CEP Chair thanked Japan for organising and hosting the meeting as well as the third Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshop which had been held prior to the meeting and noted the upcoming 35th Anniversary of the signing of the Environmental Protocol in Madrid in 1991.
- (51) The CEP Chair also summarised the work undertaken during the intersessional period, noting that many of the actions arising from CEP 27, with outcomes anticipated for CEP 28, had been addressed. The CEP Chair further noted that since CEP 27, no new accessions to the Environmental Protocol had occurred, and that the Committee had continued to comprise 42 Members.
- (52) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had agreed on a revised agenda that more directly aligned with its updated Five-year Work Plan priority issues in a visible manner, which would help keep track of progress, including during the intersessional period.
- (53) The Meeting thanked the CEP Chair and the Committee for its work during CEP 28 and welcomed the advice provided to the ATCM. Many Parties highlighted the CEP's important role in supporting the implementation of the Protocol amid rapid environmental change and growing human activity in Antarctica, and that the 35th anniversary presented an opportunity to intensify Parties' individual and collective efforts as the stewards of Antarctica.
- (54) Some Parties recalled Article 10 of the Protocol, including that ATCMs shall draw fully upon the advice and recommendations of the CEP, as well as upon the Advice of SCAR.

Strategic Discussions on the Future Work of the CEP (CEP Agenda Item 3)

- (55) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had considered the CEP Five-year Work Plan and, in keeping with its agreement at CEP XV (2012), had reviewed it at the end of each agenda item.
- (56) The CEP Chair further reported that the Committee had revised and updated its Five-year Work Plan to incorporate actions arising from the meeting (Appendix 1 to the CEP Report).
- (57) The Meeting welcomed the Committee's ongoing effective and strategic approach to its work, and expressed appreciation for the forward-looking approach and the strong scientific basis underpinning its revised Five-year Work Plan.

Operation of the CEP (CEP Agenda Item 4)

Cooperation with other Organisations

- (58) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had received reports from SCAR, SC-CAMLR, COMNAP, IAATO, ASOC and WMO. The Committee had noted the importance of observers to the work of the CEP, had acknowledged ongoing efforts by observers to provide timely, policy-relevant information and to foster collaboration, and had noted that these contributions significantly enhanced the Committee's ability to ground its discussions and recommendations in the best available scientific and technical advice, including in relation to climate change, biodiversity conservation, environmental monitoring, tourism, outreach and scientific research.
- (59) The CEP Chair further reported that the Committee had nominated CEP representatives to attend meetings of other organisations over the coming year.
- (60) Several Parties emphasised the need to maintain a strong scientific basis to inform the Committee's work, including through continued cooperation among the bodies of the Antarctic Treaty System, including SCAR and SC-CAMLR.

Operations and Strategic Planning

- (61) The Committee had considered a proposal to facilitate a process to review and track progress against the CEP's compiled list of science knowledge and information needs. The Committee had recognised the importance of ensuring that the scientific knowledge and information needs identified by the CEP were communicated in a manner that was accessible and useful to the scientific community, research institutions and domestic research funders.
- (62) The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had discussed a proposal to establish a process for reviewing and tracking progress against the CEP's compiled list of science knowledge and information needs, and to continue informal intersessional discussions on the matter, including in collaboration with SCAR, SC-CAMLR, and other relevant expert bodies, with a view to reporting back to CEP 29.
- (63) The Committee had also encouraged ongoing outreach and communication activities with Members, Observers and the wider Antarctic community regarding the upcoming 35th Anniversary of the signing of the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty and the use of the shared hashtag #AntarcticaProtected.
- (64) The Meeting noted the significance of the 35th Anniversary of the signing of the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty and reaffirmed their commitment to the comprehensive protection of the Antarctic environment. The Meeting welcomed the Committee's efforts to clearly articulate the science needed to progress priority issues, in consultation with SCAR and SC-CAMLR.

- (65) Some Parties noted that, while the 35th Anniversary of the Protocol was an important milestone, further efforts were still required to ensure that the Protocol framework kept pace with evolving environmental challenges and best practices, including through progressing towards the ratification of Annex VI.
- (66) The United States noted that SCAR is an extremely important partner that enables the ATCM and CEP to do their work with scientific integrity and that collaborations with SCAR are the best way to ensure that ATCM information needs are met. The United States further emphasised the importance of understanding the specific environmental concerns that impact the environment, science, and national Antarctic programme operations, in Antarctica, and noted that Parties should take concrete steps, based on the best available science, to address them.

Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) (CEP Agenda Item 5)

Environmental Impact Assessment: The EIA Process

- (67) The Committee had considered the importance of understanding the initial environmental reference state to support the effectiveness of the EIA process.
- (68) The Committee had considered a list of information types to provide non-mandatory guidance to Members for describing the initial environmental reference state, and several Members had noted that methodologies and information requirements for environmental baseline condition surveys would necessarily vary depending on the nature and scale of the proposed activity. Noting the non-mandatory nature of the list the Committee had agreed to forward to the ATCM guidance for describing the initial environmental reference state to replace Appendix 1 in the *Revised Guidelines for Environmental Impact Assessment in Antarctica* (Resolution 1 (2016)), to supplement the considerations listed in Section 3.2 of the guidelines.
- (69) The Meeting welcomed the revisions to the Guidelines as a means to better understand the initial environmental reference state as an essential part of the EIA process. New Zealand noted the relevance of the description of environmental reference states to tourism management.
- (70) The Meeting adopted Resolution 1 (2026) *Revised Guidelines for Environmental Impact Assessment in Antarctica*.
- (71) The Committee had also considered the report of the informal ICG on cumulative environmental impacts. The Committee had noted that cumulative impacts were complex but of significant importance given the increasing scope and intensity of human activities in Antarctica and had recognised that some impacts arose from activities governed by other components of the Antarctic Treaty System, including CCAMLR, adding to the complexity. The Committee had also recalled that the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop had recommended adding cumulative human impacts to the list of joint priority areas between the CEP and SC-CAMLR.
- (72) The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that, having considered the report of the informal ICG on cumulative environmental impacts, it had agreed to:
- encourage Members to share their experience in undertaking cumulative impact assessment; develop further guidance on cumulative impact assessment to support those conducting and assessing EIAs in accordance with the Protocol;
 - adapt existing tools, where they were being developed, to help support cumulative impact assessment; include enhanced provision for assessing

cumulative impacts in the Procedures for Comprehensive Environmental Evaluation when next revised;

- develop an EIA manual and/or a repository of information to support cumulative impact assessment and EIA more broadly;
- encourage interested Members to undertake pilot studies on standalone cumulative impact assessment; and
- retain improvements to cumulative impact assessment in the CEP Five-year Work Plan.

- (73) The Meeting noted the continued importance of better understanding cumulative impacts and supported the CEP's focus on this topic, as it aided in minimising the impacts of activities on the Antarctic environment. It also noted the relevance of the CEP's work in the ATCM's ongoing discussions on tourism management.
- (74) The CEP Chair also reported that the Committee had considered the independent environmental review of the Scott Base Redevelopment project and had expressed appreciation for New Zealand's transparency in its approach and information sharing. The Committee had considered that independent and internal reviews were good practice and a useful means of sharing information. The Committee had noted that further guidance and procedures for assessing changes in an activity to give effect to Article 8(3) of the Protocol would be useful, while also noting that each project was likely unique in detail and that sharing experiences would therefore be valuable guidance for similar processes.

Other Annex I Matters

- (75) Under Agenda Item 5c, the Committee had considered information presented by ASOC on the concept and application of intrinsic value under the Environmental Protocol.
- (76) The Committee had thanked ASOC for raising awareness of this topic and had encouraged further research and sharing of information to develop practical approaches to give effect to the protection of the intrinsic values of Antarctica under the Protocol.

Conservation of Antarctic Flora and Fauna (CEP Agenda Item 6)

Introduction of Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease

- (77) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had considered the revised CEP Non-native Species Manual. Noting that in recent years, the Committee's work had increasingly addressed the dispersal of wildlife pathogens, notably highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI), the CEP Chair further reported that the draft manual title had been amended to CEP Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease Manual. The Committee had emphasised that the introduction and spread of non-native species in the Antarctic Treaty area remained a major concern and should remain a priority for action.
- (78) The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had endorsed a revised version of the CEP Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease Manual and forwarded it to the ATCM for approval by means of a Resolution, and to encourage the dissemination and use of the revised Manual. It had further agreed to advise the ATCM that it would:
- continue to develop the Manual with the input of SCAR and COMNAP (on scientific and practical matters, respectively) and other expert organisations, as required;

- request that the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat publish the Manual on its website as an online dynamic tool, to be updated as new developments occur;
 - encourage closer work between the CEP and SC-CAMLR on non-native species and wildlife disease issues; and
 - undertake a review of the Manual's progress and contents in five years.
- (79) The Meeting welcomed the CEP's work on the Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease Manual and HPAI management. Highlighting that effective biosecurity measures were crucial in protecting Antarctic environments, the Meeting urged Parties to take action and disseminate the Manual to stakeholders and the public.
- (80) The Meeting adopted Resolution 2 (2026) *The Committee for Environmental Protection Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease Manual*.
- (81) The Committee had also considered a Secretariat topical review of CEP documents and information exchange on Antarctic biosecurity, non-native species and wildlife diseases from 1998 to 2025. The Secretariat had reported that most records had focused on preventing and minimising introduction risks associated with non-native species and had noted that while the EIES was actively used for reporting contingency plans and EIA monitoring and follow-up activities, references to biosecurity measures were identified in only a relatively small proportion of records.
- (82) The CEP Chair reported that some Members had suggested including a requirement to share information on biosecurity measures in the EIES, while others had noted that further work would be needed on whether and how best to include such information sharing in the EIES.
- (83) The CEP Chair also reported that the Committee had considered surveillance and monitoring efforts relating to HPAI in Antarctica. The Committee had emphasised the importance of sustained, coordinated monitoring across national Antarctic programmes and of ongoing information sharing.
- (84) The CEP Chair also reported that several Members had acknowledged the need to continue monitoring the effects of HPAI on Antarctic fauna and highlighted the experience already gained by SCAR and COMNAP, suggesting that the use of their reporting mechanisms, protocols and guidelines be encouraged.
- (85) The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered the recommendations relating to the surveillance of HPAI in Antarctica and had agreed to promote best practices among research groups studying the impacts of HPAI in Antarctica to avoid duplication of efforts and foster collaboration. It had emphasised the need to provide new information on the impact of other possible diseases affecting populations, had encouraged the use of SCAR and COMNAP reporting mechanisms, protocols, and guidelines, and had agreed to promote the effective communication of findings recorded in the field so that all those operating in the area could take appropriate precautions.
- (86) The Chair of the CEP reported that the Committee had also considered findings presented by SCAR regarding the establishment of non-native insects in Antarctic natural environments, including protected areas, based on coordinated multinational monitoring undertaken on King George Island. The Committee had acknowledged the significance of these findings and encouraged continued monitoring, collaborative research and consideration of possible eradication and response measures.

- (87) The Committee had jointly considered SCAR's assessment that the emperor penguin had met the IUCN Red List classification of "Endangered", and a recommendation to designate the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species under Annex II. The Committee had acknowledged the importance of developing additional protection measures for the emperor penguin and supporting continued research and monitoring. Many Members had expressed strong support for designating the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species, emphasised the need to use the tools available to the Committee to address the impacts of climate change on vulnerable species, and considered that decisions should be made on the basis of the best available science.
- (88) Two Members had considered that, without addressing global climate change as the root cause, designation as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species would fail to fundamentally reverse the reported population decline, and that other tools, such as ASPAs, provide adequate protection. Many Members had expressed a desire to make progress on this important topic, noting that designation of the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species would improve protection for the species and would send an important signal regarding the Committee's commitment to addressing climate change in Antarctica.
- (89) The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had various management tools to support the protection objectives for the emperor penguin. Most Members had strongly supported designation as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species, informed by the best available science and in accordance with established procedures, but consensus could not be reached. Some Members considered that other tools, such as ASPAs, could achieve the protection objectives. The views expressed in the discussion were reflected in paragraphs 91-100 of the CEP 28 Report.
- (90) The Committee had further advised the ATCM that it had:
- shared concern about the future of the emperor penguin, recognising the risks to the survival of the species due to the implications of declining sea ice, while acknowledging that sea ice decline was not caused by activities in the Antarctic region;
 - reaffirmed the importance of protecting the emperor penguin as a priority;
 - recognised the need to further implement the tools available under the Antarctic Treaty System to manage activities in the Antarctic Treaty area, and to communicate internationally the need to address pressures from outside the Antarctic region;
 - encouraged continued monitoring, research and reporting of research results on the status of the emperor penguin; and
 - agreed to continue discussions on appropriate management measures during the intersessional period.
- (91) The Meeting thanked the Committee and welcomed the consensus language on the emperor penguin, commending the Committee for advice on this important issue. Observing the emperor penguin's role as a symbol of endangered wildlife, the Chair invited the Meeting to consider moving forward with its designation as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species.
- (92) Most Parties noted with concern the decline in emperor penguin populations, which had prompted SCAR to reassess the species as "Endangered" using the Red List criteria. Those Parties strongly supported the designation of the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species, based on best available science and in accordance with

established procedures. They observed that the scientific assessment by SCAR had clearly determined that the species was at significant risk of extinction. Several Parties cautioned against weighing conservation measures against one another in the Committee, noting the importance of utilising all available tools as also highlighted in the Helsinki Declaration. Those Parties stressed the importance of a precautionary approach, and reiterated that the ATCM shall draw fully upon the advice and recommendations of the CEP as well as on the advice of SCAR, and there were no procedural or other barriers to affording Antarctic Specially Protected status to the emperor penguin, and no reason not to designate.

- (93) China shared the other Parties' concern, but maintained that the designation of the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species remained premature, as China detailed within the CEP, while supporting continued intersessional discussions consistent with the CEP consensus. The Russian Federation, supporting the intervention by China, also indicated that according to the existing rules such designation shall be considered by the ATCM on the basis of a proposal from CEP with proper justification, which were not presented at this meeting.
- (94) ASOC and SCAR thanked the Committee for its work and stressed that the weight of scientific evidence on the matter was conclusive. ASOC urged the Parties to adopt a precautionary approach. SCAR emphasised the extensive evidence supporting the decline of the emperor penguin. SCAR noted that every model regardless of climate variability and uncertainty, predicts dramatic future declines for emperor penguins; only the timeline and magnitude of change differ. SCAR further clarified that its assessment of the emperor penguin was based not only on models and observational data but also on field work at colonies. This included field studies that date back as far as 1952 at Pointe Géologie, along with additional field studies at a range of other colonies across Antarctica. SCAR also highlighted that declines were predicted in almost every colony, with only 8 of the 66 colonies not predicted to decline, amounting to 77 per cent of the population being predicted to decline by 2100.
- (95) IUCN noted its appreciation for the Parties' support of the Red List, and expressed its hope that outcomes from the Meeting would reflect the strength of scientific data provided.
- (96) The Meeting welcomed and supported the progress of the CEP. The Meeting expressed concern about risks to the emperor penguin and reaffirmed the importance of protecting the species as a priority.
- (97) The Meeting agreed to:
- further implement the tools available under the Antarctic Treaty System to manage activities in the Antarctic Treaty area;
 - communicate internationally the need to address pressures from outside the Antarctic region;
 - encourage continued monitoring, research and reporting of results on the status of the emperor penguin; and
 - continue consideration at ATCM 49 on appropriate management measures to protect emperor penguins, based on advice from the CEP.
- (98) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had considered updated IUCN Red List assessments of Antarctic seals and noted with concern declines in southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal populations. The Committee had also received and supported SCAR's recommendations on the matter, including the commencement of assessments

for the southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal for consideration as Antarctic Specially Protected Species.

- (99) The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that, having noted with concern the significant population declines in southern elephant seals and Antarctic fur seals, and acknowledging that these species had been reassessed by IUCN as “Vulnerable” and “Endangered” respectively, it had:
- requested SCAR commence assessments for the southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal for consideration as Antarctic Specially Protected Species;
 - encouraged ongoing regular, spatially extensive monitoring of all six Antarctic seal species;
 - encouraged Members to communicate widely the declines in Antarctic fur seal and southern elephant seal populations; and
 - requested that information on this species be shared with SC-CAMLR.
- (100) Welcoming the Committee’s advice and taking note of the concerning developments, including the significant impact rapid environmental change can have on Antarctic species that forage in marine environments, the Meeting endorsed the recommendations and supported the CEP’s request to commence assessments for the southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal for consideration as Antarctic Specially Protected Species and also noted the importance of sharing findings with SC-CAMLR.

Understanding Antarctic Biodiversity

- (101) The CEP Chair reported that no papers had been submitted under this item.

Other Annex II Matters

- (102) The Chair of the CEP reported that the Committee had considered the need for guidance to ensure effective management of aircraft operations near concentrations of marine mammals. The Committee had noted the importance of clear guidelines for the operation of aircraft near concentrations of marine mammals, in addition to existing guidelines related to avian wildlife.
- (103) The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that guidance was needed to ensure effective management of aircraft operations near concentrations of marine mammals, and that the Committee had agreed that COMNAP and the United States would facilitate intersessional work to prepare advice for CEP 29, as a basis for initiating a process to revise and update the Guidelines for the Operation of Aircraft near Concentrations of Birds in Antarctica and to include guidance on aircraft operations near marine mammals.
- (104) The Committee had also welcomed France’s Information Paper on the regulation of remotely piloted aircraft systems (RPAS) in the Antarctic Treaty area and had encouraged the ongoing sharing of experiences and best practices regarding RPAS operations.

Waste Management and Pollution (CEP Agenda Item 7)

Repair and Remediation of Environmental Damage

- (105) The Chair of the CEP reported that the Committee had discussed the review of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual. The Committee had recognised the value of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual as a practical tool to support the fulfilment of obligations under Annex

III of the Environmental Protocol and had acknowledged the timely nature of the proposal to review it, noting several new developments since its initial adoption.

- (106) The Committee advised the ATCM that it had established an ICG to review the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual with the following terms of reference: review information on developments and advances in matters relevant to the clean-up of Antarctic past waste disposal sites, past work sites, and contaminated sites; review the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual appended to Resolution 1 (2019), and suggest any modifications and additional guidance, including to provide further guidance on limiting the adverse impacts of rapid environmental change in Antarctica; and report to CEP 29 on its progress.
- (107) The Meeting welcomed the CEP's work on waste management and clean-up, including its planned review of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual, and encouraged interested Parties to participate in the review.

Long-range and Local Pollution

- (108) The Committee had considered information provided by Belarus about contaminants, including paints and varnishes, as a potential source of pollutants entering the Antarctic environment. Many Members had noted the need for further discussion of contaminants, especially the potential environmental impacts of national Antarctic programmes on logistics and station infrastructure.
- (109) The CEP Chair advised the ATCM that paints and varnishes used at Antarctic stations, field bases and other infrastructure could be a source of heavy-metal and other pollutants in Antarctic soils, particularly through the degradation and dispersion of paint coatings from older painted surfaces and at unused work sites, and that this matter warranted greater attention in the environmental management of Antarctic facilities. The Committee had further agreed to advise the ATCM that it had encouraged interested Members to share information and experience on this topic.

Area Protection and Management Plans (CEP Agenda Item 8)

New and Revised ASPA/ASMA Management Plans

- (110) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had considered the report of the Subsidiary Group on Management Plans (SGMP) on its 2025/26 intersessional work reviewing revised and proposed new ASPA management plans. The Committee had thanked the SGMP, the convenors of the pre-meeting review processes, and all proponents for their extensive intersessional work.
- (111) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had also considered continued intersessional discussions regarding the proposed new ASPA Otto-von-Gruber-Gebirge (Dronning Maud Land, East Antarctica). Germany and China had reported constructive ongoing discussions aimed at resolving outstanding technical issues, with a view to possible adoption at ATCM 49.
- (112) The Committee had also considered five-yearly reviews of ASPA management plans that had not been reviewed by the SGMP.
- (113) The Committee had also agreed to forward the following management plans for revised and new protected areas to the ATCM for adoption by means of a Measure:
- ASPA 101, Taylor Rookery, Mac.Robertson Land
 - ASPA 102, Rookery Islands, Holme Bay, Mac.Robertson Land

- ASPA 103, Ardery Island and Odbert Island, Budd Coast, Wilkes Land, East Antarctica
 - ASPA 116, New College Valley, Caughley Beach, Cape Bird, Ross Island
 - ASPA 120, Pointe-Géologie Archipelago, Terre Adélie
 - ASPA 121, Cape Royds, Ross Island
 - ASPA 124, Cape Crozier, Ross Island
 - ASPA 125, Fildes Peninsula, King George Island, South Shetland Islands
 - ASPA 150, Ardley Island, Maxwell Bay, King George Island
 - ASPA 166 Port-Martin, Terre Adélie
 - ASPA 167 Hawker Island, Princess Elizabeth Land
 - ASPA 176 Rosenthal Islands, Anvers Island, Palmer Archipelago
 - ASPA 178 Inexpressible Island and Seaview Bay, Ross Sea
 - NEW ASPA at Parts of Signy Island and adjacent islands, South Orkney Islands
 - NEW ASPA at Collins Bay, Kyiv Peninsula, Graham Coast, Antarctic Peninsula
- (114) The Committee had further agreed to forward the management plan for the proposed new ASPA for the Wreck of Endurance in the Weddell Sea to CCAMLR for approval, in accordance with Decision 9 (2005), to be followed by ATCM adoption through a Measure at ATCM 49.
- (115) The Meeting thanked the SGMP convenor, Ji Hee Kim (Republic of Korea), and all SGMP participants for their work. Parties highlighted this work as crucial to ensuring a systematic approach to further developing the Antarctic protected area system and to promoting the robust and lasting protection of Antarctica's outstanding values. The Meeting welcomed the high-quality proposals for protected areas, and noted the importance of ensuring that ASPA and ASMA management plans remained up to date.
- (116) Belgium welcomed progress on the intersessional discussion on the proposed new ASPA Otto-von-Gruber-Gebirge (Dronning Maud Land, East Antarctica) and encouraged ongoing intersessional discussions with a view to it being designated an ASPA at ATCM 49.
- (117) The Meeting adopted the following Measures on Protected Areas:
- Measure 1 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 101 (Taylor Rookery, Mac.Robertson Land): Revised Management Plan*
 - Measure 2 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 102 (Rookery Islands, Holme Bay, Mac. Robertson Land): Revised Management Plan*
 - Measure 3 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 103 (Ardery Island and Odbert Island, Budd Coast, Wilkes Land, East Antarctica): Revised Management Plan*
 - Measure 4 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 116 (New College Valley, Caughley Beach, Cape Bird, Ross Island): Revised Management Plan*
 - Measure 5 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 120 (Pointe-Géologie Archipelago, Terre Adélie): Revised Management Plan*

- Measure 6 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 121 (Cape Royds, Ross Island): Revised Management Plan*
- Measure 7 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 124 (Cape Crozier, Ross Island): Revised Management Plan*
- Measure 8 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 125 (Fildes Peninsula, King George Island, South Shetland Islands): Revised Management Plan*
- Measure 9 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 150 (Ardley Island, Maxwell Bay, King George Island): Revised Management Plan*
- Measure 10 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 166 (Port-Martin, Terre-Adélie): Revised Management Plan*
- Measure 11 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 167 (Hawker Island, Princess Elizabeth Land): Revised Management Plan*
- Measure 12 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 176 (Rosenthal Islands, Anvers Island, Palmer Archipelago): Revised Management Plan*
- Measure 13 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 178 (Inexpressible Island and Seaview Bay, Ross Sea): Revised Management Plan*
- Measure 14 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 183 (Parts of Signy Island and adjacent islands, South Orkney Islands): Management Plan*
- Measure 15 (2026) *Antarctic Specially Protected Area No 184 (Collins Bay, Kyiv Peninsula, Graham Coast, Antarctic Peninsula): Management Plan*

Other Matters Relating to Management Plans for Protected/Managed Areas

- (118) The Chair of the CEP reported that Monaco had informed the Meeting that the instrument of approval of Annex V had been signed by H.S.H. the Sovereign Prince of Monaco on 5 May 2026. Monaco had reported that the approval would enable it to fulfil its obligations under the Protocol and strengthen its involvement in work relating to protected areas in Antarctica.

Historic Sites and Monuments

- (119) The Committee had considered plans towards the relocation of HSM No. 19 Vince's Cross, Hut Point, Ross Island, due to risks posed by coastal erosion. The Committee had supported the proposed relocation and had acknowledged the importance of engaging with relevant stakeholders, including the wider Antarctic heritage community, in identifying appropriate long-term solutions to safeguard Antarctic heritage threatened by environmental change.
- (120) The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered the plans towards relocating Historic Site and Monument (HSM) No. 19, Vince's Cross, Hut Point, Ross Island, due to coastal erosion, and had encouraged interested Members, Observers and experts, including the Antarctic heritage community, to engage in informal discussions during the forthcoming intersessional period, with a view to reporting back to CEP 29.

Area Protection and Management Plans: Site Guidelines

- (121) The Committee had considered proposed revisions to the Visitor Site Guidelines for Detaille Island and Damoy Point, prepared jointly by the United Kingdom and IAATO. The Committee recognised the timeliness of the proposal, given the increasing tourism.

(122) The Committee had agreed to forward the following revised Visitor Site Guidelines to the ATCM for adoption:

- Dettelle Island; and
- Damoy Point.

(123) The Meeting adopted Resolution 3 (2026) *Site Guidelines for Visitors*.

Marine Spatial Protection and Management

(124) The Committee had considered information presented by ASOC on marine protected area discussions within CCAMLR and broader issues relating to marine spatial protection in the Southern Ocean. Several Members had reiterated the importance of a harmonised approach to marine spatial protection and management across the Antarctic Treaty System and had highlighted their commitment to the further development of representative systems of protected areas under the Environmental Protocol and the CAMLR Convention, as well as to protecting Antarctic threatened species. Several Members had also welcomed continued collaboration between the CEP and SC-CAMLR in these areas.

Other Annex V Matters

(125) The Chair of the CEP reported that the Committee had considered the report of the SGMP on its intersessional work under Terms of Reference 4 to 6. The Committee had noted progress on the review of management tools relating to climate change and had noted ongoing work to revise the Guidelines for the Preparation of ASMA Management Plans to better address climate change considerations.

(126) Members had welcomed the revisions to the Guidelines for the Preparation of ASMA Management Plans and had observed that the proposed changes improved clarity and usability, including regarding management intent, remote sensing and engagement with CCAMLR, but had noted that some work was still required. The Committee had agreed to continue intersessional discussions within the SGMP to further review the revised Guidelines.

(127) The Committee had also adopted the SGMP work plan for 2026/27, noting that all Members were free to decide on their individual levels of participation in the work of the SGMP.

(128) The Committee had also considered joint work by the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat and the CCAMLR Secretariat on improving the accuracy and distribution of spatial data associated with ASPAs and ASMAs. The Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had agreed to have informal discussions, facilitated by the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat, to progress the development of a standardised definition of spatial objects, drawing on the SC-CAMLR “*Rules for the definition of geospatial polygons and lines used by CCAMLR*”.

(129) Parties welcomed the joint work of the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat and the CCAMLR Secretariat on accurately defining protected areas boundaries, noting the practical benefits of collaboration on their shared responsibilities.

Climate Change Implications for the Environment (CEP Agenda Item 9)

Implementation and Review of the Climate Change Response Work Programme

(130) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had considered an update from the Subsidiary Group on Climate Change Response (SGCCR). Many Members had

emphasised the urgency of continued monitoring and addressing the implications of climate change, including sea ice change, and of implementing the CCRWP, as a top priority for the Committee. The Committee had acknowledged SGCCR's contribution to the implementation of the CCRWP and had supported continued information exchange with SC-CAMLR, noting the two bodies had different mandates. Recognising the high priority of this work and the value of the SGCCR as a forum for bringing it together, the Committee had endorsed the recommendations of the SGCCR.

(131) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had made progress in implementing the CCRWP (2024) during the 2025/2026 intersessional period. The key areas of focus included CCRWP actions related to:

- assessing the status of climate-vulnerable Antarctic species (Action 6c): the Committee had considered the appropriateness of a trait-based framework for assessing the vulnerability of Antarctic species to climate change, noted the scientific workshop on this topic tentatively to be organised by SCAR in the first quarter of 2027, and encouraged Members to engage in continued intersessional discussions, including on which (groups of) species should be given priority;
- enhancing coordination on climate change response in the marine realm with SC-CAMLR (Action 3e): the Committee had noted the outcomes of the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring held in Hiroshima on 8-9 May 2026, and agreed to further strengthen coordination with SC-CAMLR on these matters while recognising the different mandates of the two bodies;
- decontamination of past sites of activities in the Antarctic area (Action 5f): the Committee had encouraged Members and Observers to continue exchanging information on this topic, and many Members supported the integration of climate change considerations in the revision of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual;
- assessing the risk of climate change for Antarctica's existing and projected infrastructure and associated environmental consequences (Actions 5a and 5d): the Committee had encouraged Members and Observers to continue exchanging information on the risks to infrastructure, including in light of the ongoing work of COMNAP;
- changing sea-ice (Action 7c): the Committee had noted the progress made and encouraged continued work on this topic, including through SCAR's continued provision of advice;
- non-native species introduction, notably through ballast water and biofouling (Action 1b): the Committee had encouraged Members to participate in planned informal work led by Australia, New Zealand and the United Kingdom to assess the ongoing utility of the Practical Guidelines for Ballast Water Exchange in the Antarctic Treaty Area (Resolution 3 (2006)); and
- stocktaking of progress towards implementation of the CCRWP: the Committee had noted the assessment of progress, and many Members encouraged further engagement and active participation in the work of the SGCCR and the timely implementation of the CCRWP.

(132) The Meeting thanked the SGCCR and its convenor, Mr Nils Vanstappen, for its extensive and important work and progress implementing the CCRWP. Noting that collaboration with SC-CAMLR was essential for a holistic approach to protection and conservation of the Antarctic marine environment, the Meeting further thanked the co-convenors of the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop, Mr Nils Vanstappen (Belgium) and Dr Rachel

Cavanagh (United Kingdom). The Meeting welcomed SCAR's continued work on updating the Antarctic Climate Change and the Environment Decadal Synopsis report.

- (133) Underscoring the alarming rate at which the observed impacts of climate change were progressing in Antarctica, including rapid sea ice loss, glacier melt, changes in Southern Ocean circulation, populations of penguins and seals, and the introduction of non-native species, most Parties emphasised that addressing the impacts of climate change was a clear priority in pursuing Parties' joint commitment to the overarching objectives of the Environmental Protocol and the Antarctic Treaty at large. Those Parties emphasised the central role of climate change in ATCM's work. Parties stressed the reality of climate change as firmly established through observation and data analysis, as shown in SCAR's ACCE update, and reaffirmed their firm commitment to combat the adverse impacts of climate change in Antarctica, recalling Resolution 2 (2023) *Helsinki Declaration on Climate Change and the Antarctic*. Further emphasising the importance of continuously updating international fora dedicated to addressing climate change and reducing greenhouse gas emissions, such as those under the UNFCCC, many Parties underlined the role of SCAR in this process. Parties noted updates should cover observations and scientific findings associated with the critical role of Antarctica and the Southern Ocean in the global climate system, and the implications of Antarctic cryospheric and oceanographic changes for global climate and sea-level rise.
- (134) Most Parties raised concerns about the apparent caution by some within the CEP to reference climate change and underscored the scientific consensus, based on the best scientific evidence available, that climate change is happening and is affecting the Antarctic environment and its biodiversity. The United States stressed the need to focus efforts on understanding and addressing the impacts of specific changes to the Antarctic environment rather than on broad discussions that did not necessarily lead to action.
- (135) ASOC reiterated the global need for accelerated action on climate change and noted that, though the Environmental Protocol came into force decades ago, it still allowed for action today. ASOC further noted that ATCM's success in addressing climate change by applying all tools available under the Protocol would send a powerful signal about the international community's ability to address existential crises.
- (136) The CEP Chair reported that SCAR had provided a circumpolar update on Antarctic sea-ice change, which included information on the sharp decline of Antarctic sea ice since 2016, with the most significant driver being a sustained build-up of heat in the upper Southern Ocean. The Committee highlighted the importance of continued observations, research and modelling to improve understanding of regional variability and the consequences of sea-ice decline for Antarctic species, ecosystems and infrastructure and supported SCAR's recommendations.

The Outcomes of the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring

- (137) The Committee had been updated on the Joint Workshop of CEP and SC-CAMLR held in Hiroshima, Japan, from 8 to 9 May 2026. Noting that the last joint workshop took place over a decade ago, the Committee welcomed this effort to further enhance cooperation and information-sharing between the two committees in overlapping areas of interest.
- (138) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had:
- recognised the valuable contributions of the joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshop to the Committee;

- acknowledged the recommendations as a basis that could guide ongoing work in the intersessional period; and
 - agreed to review the progress of work annually.
- (139) The Meeting welcomed the valuable contribution of the workshop to the work of the Committee and encouraged the CEP to continue work to strengthen collaboration with SC-CAMLR, using the workshop's recommendations as a basis.

9b) Other Climate Change Matters

- (140) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had discussed climate change impacts on the Antarctic Peninsula. The Committee had noted that the Antarctic Peninsula had experienced rapid warming, associated with more frequent and intense extreme weather events, including heatwaves, heavy precipitation, and atmospheric rivers, causing record surface melt and disrupting ecosystems and human activities.
- (141) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that:
- Research showed that the Antarctic Peninsula was experiencing environmental changes, such as rapid sea ice loss, warming ocean waters, and coastal erosion; that these changes were already affecting marine and terrestrial ecosystems; and that they posed risks to scientific infrastructure and marine operations.
 - The Committee had encouraged Members' engagement across all of the Committee's work plans to address environmental impacts on Antarctica, including in the SGCCR.
 - The Committee had agreed that options for more ambitious, adaptive and forward-looking approaches should be considered in its advice to the ATCM.
- (142) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had also considered how changing Antarctic conditions affected the built infrastructure of national Antarctic programmes and the consequential environmental impacts. The Committee had agreed that environmental change in Antarctica had implications beyond the natural environment and was increasingly affecting infrastructure and operations.
- (143) The CEP Chair reported that SCAR had presented its *Antarctic Climate Change and the Environment: 2026 Update*, which provided an update on recent scientific developments on climate change in Antarctica and its implications for Antarctic and global systems. SCAR had noted that abrupt changes were underway, including continued sea-ice decline and glacial retreat occurring over short timeframes. The CEP Chair noted that SCAR had provided the example of the recent retreat of the Hektoria Glacier by 25km over two years.
- (144) The CEP Chair reported that many Members had welcomed the annual update and had expressed concern about the rapid, accelerating environmental changes observed across Antarctica. The Committee had supported continued research to understand the changing Antarctic environment.
- (145) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered SCAR's 2026 update on Antarctic Climate Change and the Environment and had noted the evidence of abrupt and accelerating environmental changes already underway in Antarctica. These changes included continued sea-ice decline, glacial retreat, and impacts on Antarctic biodiversity and ecosystems, with implications for Antarctic and global systems, and were supported by continued research to understand the changing Antarctic environment.

- (146) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had also discussed several other papers on climate change and its implications for the environment.

Environmental Monitoring and State of the Environment Reporting (CEP Agenda Item 10)

- (147) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had considered how tourism-related monitoring initiatives could be better integrated to ensure that monitoring practices were developed in a coordinated and policy-relevant way. The Committee had acknowledged the complexity of the issue and the relationship with ongoing monitoring initiatives, and that the proposals mentioned were a useful starting point for further consideration of the coordination of tourism-related monitoring in Antarctica.

- (148) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered the structural consolidation of tourism-related monitoring under the Antarctic Treaty System, and that in its consideration, the Committee had:

- acknowledged the timely nature of the proposal in light of the growth of tourism in Antarctica and the parallel development of multiple monitoring initiatives;
- recognised the relevance of this work to its Five-year Work Plan and to the outcomes of the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Climate Change and Monitoring Workshop, as well as the discussions on the development of a comprehensive and consistent framework on tourism and other non-governmental activities, and on an international environmental monitoring framework;
- noted the importance of an incremental approach focused on the collection of comparable datasets and the avoidance of duplication with existing monitoring tools, while acknowledging the financial implications of such work; and
- agreed to undertake informal intersessional discussions on this topic, with Germany acting as convenor, with a view to reporting progress to CEP 29.

- (149) The Committee had discussed the long-term monitoring of Antarctic nearshore marine and terrestrial flora and fauna. SCAR had reported that most monitoring efforts were concentrated on the Antarctic Peninsula and focused on more charismatic species, with limited data available on less visible species and microbial communities. Initiatives such as Antarctica InSync and IPY-5 were highlighted as useful to facilitate sustained circumpolar and regional monitoring efforts.

- (150) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had discussed the long-term monitoring of Antarctic nearshore marine and terrestrial flora and fauna, and encouraged Members to:

- commit national resources to existing and new nearshore and terrestrial monitoring programmes;
- align ongoing research programmes across meteorology, climate science and biology to better understand the drivers of biodiversity change;
- take advantage of advances in automated sensing, artificial intelligence and machine learning for real-time monitoring of Antarctic environments; and
- collaborate, including with COMNAP and SCAR, to leverage IPY-5 and Antarctica InSync in developing a sustained, circum-Antarctic platform for monitoring environmental change and biodiversity responses.

- (151) The Committee had discussed results from the ICG on the international framework for environmental monitoring established at CEP 25 to support the Protocol's

implementation. Several Members had suggested that further progress could be advanced through other ongoing work of the Committee, including the proposed review of the Committee's science and knowledge needs, and some Members suggested that the ICG could be paused while this progressed. SCAR had expressed an interest in the continued development of the framework and highlighted existing initiatives that could contribute to it.

- (152) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered the ICG's report on the development of an international framework for environmental monitoring and had reaffirmed the vital importance of environmental monitoring within the Committee to fulfil its objective of effective implementation of the Environmental Protocol. The Committee had also agreed to advise the ATCM that it had paused the ICG for one year, while informal intersessional discussions to develop a roadmap towards such a framework took place, and encouraged consideration of next steps towards a framework to be informed by discussions arising in the review of the Committee's science and knowledge needs. Finally, the co-convenors of the ICG would report to CEP 29 on the outcomes of these informal intersessional discussions.
- (153) The CEP Chair reported that the Committee had discussed the recommendations to progress the development of an inventory of sites of past activities, as a priority action under the CEP Five-year Work Plan. A three-phased approach had been proposed to advance the inventory, starting with a pilot phase focusing on the CEP's core priorities, then extending to high-value applications, including identifying sites where past activities may affect scientific measurements, and subsequently to a comprehensive record of human activities.
- (154) Members had acknowledged the usefulness of the inventory and had emphasised the need to consider how data had been captured and stored, and ensure it was interoperable with existing systems. Some Members had highlighted that sharing even basic information about sites of past activities had been helpful, given difficulties in determining whether a site had previously been documented and if remains were historical. The Committee had encouraged interested Members to continue further informal intersessional work on the inventory, including practical approaches to structure, format, and data requirements.
- (155) The Chair of the CEP reported that the Committee had considered a knowledge review from SCAR on plastic pollution in the Antarctic Treaty area, which identified that microplastics had been found in every part of the Antarctic environment examined to date, including throughout marine food webs, and that the cumulative impacts could be significant. The Committee had also considered information presented by SCAR on the Antarctic Environments Portal, highlighting recent publications including one on emerging evidence of abrupt changes in the Antarctic environment, and had encouraged all Members to support its ongoing operation and further development.
- (156) Reflecting on a growing demand for data and monitoring, several Parties commended the CEP for its ongoing work to support environmental monitoring and highlighted the importance of systematic coordinated monitoring to the work of the ATCM. Parties also noted the importance of tourism-related monitoring given the increasing number of tourists visiting Antarctica and the importance of the data for the development of the Tourism Framework.
- (157) The Meeting also welcomed the CEP's ongoing work on implementing an inventory of sites of past activities.

- (158) The United Kingdom welcomed the work of the CEP in considering different forms of data collection, but reflected that greater consideration needed to be given to how the data would be used once collected, noting some Parties had suggested data not collected from the field was less valid.
- (159) Some Parties also drew attention to initiatives such as IPY-5, Antarctica InSync and the Antarctic Environments Portal as important tools for environmental monitoring and reporting on the state of the Antarctic environment.

General Matters (CEP Agenda Item 12)

- (160) The Chair of the CEP reported that most Members and ASOC had expressed concern to the Committee about the gradual disappearance of references to climate change in the Committee's work, recalling that only three years ago the ATCM had adopted the Helsinki Declaration, in which the ATCM reaffirmed its firm commitment to combat the adverse impacts of climate change in Antarctica.

Election of Officers (CEP Agenda Item 13)

- (161) The Committee had re-elected Ms Ceisha Poirot (New Zealand) for a further two-year term and had congratulated her on her re-election.

Preparation for the next CEP (CEP Agenda Item 14)

- (162) The Committee had adopted the Preliminary Agenda for CEP 29 (Appendix 2 to the CEP Report).
- (163) Recalling the 35th Anniversary of the signing of the Environmental Protocol which remained the cornerstone of Parties' joint commitment to the comprehensive protection of the Antarctic environment, the Meeting thanked the CEP for its work and reaffirmed the importance of the CEP's advice to the ATCM in informing the Meeting's decisions.
- (164) The Meeting thanked all Members of the Committee for their dedication and contribution to discussions, and emphasised the need for broad and active participation in the CEP's future work to ensure its discussions, advice and recommendations continue to be informed by a range of perspectives and experience, and the best available scientific, environmental and technical advice. The Meeting congratulated Ms Ceisha Poirot for her successful management of the CEP with a steady hand, and ready smile.

Item 6a: Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Request from Canada to become a Consultative Party

- (165) Canada presented IP 148 *The Canadian Antarctic Research Expedition 2026*, providing further information in support of its request for Consultative Party status submitted in 2021. Canada reiterated its enduring commitment to the principles and objectives of the Antarctic Treaty and to the Antarctic Treaty System, including through its participation in the CEP, SCAR, COMNAP and CCAMLR. Canada recalled the significance of its past contributions to Antarctic research and reported on the Canadian Antarctic Research Expedition (CARE) 2026, conducted from 12 to 25 March 2026 in partnership with Chile, which had supported research priorities in marine geology, ocean sciences and contaminants in the South Shetland Islands and the Antarctic Peninsula. Canada highlighted its active engagement on the International Maritime Organisation's Polar Code, its progress towards ratification of the Agreement on Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction (BBNJ), and its active engagement in the development of the tourism framework. Canada thanked the Consultative Parties for their continued

consideration of its request and requested that the Meeting welcome it as a Consultative Party to the Antarctic Treaty.

- (166) The Consultative Parties thanked Canada for its presentation. Most Parties supported Canada's request for Consultative Party status. They recognised the quality, capability and diversity of science demonstrated in Canada's presentation, and acknowledged that, in their assessment, Canada met the requirements for substantial scientific research activity under Article IX (2) of the Antarctic Treaty and the criteria in Decision 2 (2017) and guidelines annexed thereto. Several Parties highlighted that the ATCM would benefit from Canada's Consultative Party status and that the request should be considered on its merits.
- (167) China expressed its support for the requests of Canada, Belarus and Türkiye. China stated that the requests of Canada and Belarus have been jointly discussed in previous meetings, and proposed that, on the basis of equitable treatment, the requests of Belarus and Canada should be jointly considered under unified arrangements and integrated review. This initiative aimed to uphold a fair and reasonable Antarctic Treaty System.
- (168) The Russian Federation stated that, although Canada's presentation had progressed, it did not consider that Canada had met the requirements in Article IX (2), in particular the absence of dedicated Antarctic research infrastructure and a fully established Antarctic programme that might have a negative impact on the consistency and scope of their scientific research.
- (169) Recalling Decision 2 (2017) and Article IX (2) many Parties stated that neither a dedicated national Antarctic programme nor research infrastructure in Antarctica was a requirement for Consultative Party status, and several Parties emphasised that each request should be considered on its own merits.
- (170) The Chair took the initiative to have informal consultations in which Canada was given the opportunity to clarify several points including among others more information on its Antarctic programme and further detail on its legislative framework in response to questions by the Russian Federation. The consultations were held in a positive and constructive atmosphere.
- (171) There was no consensus on the request from Canada to become a Consultative Party. Based on the suggestion by the Chair, Parties encouraged the Russian Federation and Canada to have intersessional exchange of information and views, involving relevant organisations from each Party to identify relevant steps forward.
- (172) Parties welcomed the consideration of Canada's request at the next ATCM and encouraged Canada to continue to pursue Consultative Party status. Accordingly, that item has been included on the preliminary agenda for ATCM 49, and there is no need for resubmission.

Item 6b: Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Request from Belarus to become a Consultative Party

- (173) Belarus presented IP 95 *Additional information on the development of scientific expeditionary, publication, and international activities of the Republic of Belarus in Antarctica in support of its application for Consultative Party status to the Antarctic Treaty*, addressing different aspects of its participation in Antarctic Treaty bodies, its national Antarctic legislation and implementation of the Antarctic Treaty and Environmental Protocol, and its scientific activities and infrastructure in Antarctica. Belarus described steady growth in the number, quality, and diversity of its publications,

and drew attention to the regular, multidisciplinary character of the scientific research it conducted across various Antarctic regions. Belarus noted the discovery of a new lichen species in Antarctica, named in honour of the Belarusian biologist Yuri Giginyak. Belarus also highlighted that in 2025, the Republican Polar Research Center signed a Memorandum of Understanding on scientific, logistical and technical cooperation in Antarctica with the Sultan Mizan Antarctic Research Foundation of Malaysia. Belarus stated that it consistently expanded its scientific and research potential in Antarctica, including through its Gora Vechernyaya Base, and reaffirmed its commitment to preserving Antarctica as a natural reserve dedicated to peace and science.

- (174) The Consultative Parties thanked Belarus for its presentation. Several Consultative Parties considered that Belarus had shown progress in the number and diversity of its scientific activities in Antarctica and had met the requirements for substantial scientific research activity under Article IX (2) of the Antarctic Treaty and the criteria in Decision 2 (2017) and guidelines annexed thereto.
- (175) Many Consultative Parties considered that, while the number of publications and the volume of scientific output had increased, the datasets were largely inaccessible and the publications were mostly in domestic rather than internationally indexed, high-impact journals. Some Parties considered the scientific activities to have a relatively narrow focus on the environment around the Belarusian research station on Vechernyaya Hill, and that international collaboration was still too limited. These Parties also noted that Belarus was not yet a full member of SCAR.
- (176) Several Consultative Parties noted that full membership of SCAR was not a requirement for Consultative Party status. The Russian Federation observed that some international publications discriminated against Belarusian scientists, and that some Parties placed obstacles to their broader participation in international collaboration.
- (177) The Chair took the initiative to have informal consultations in which Belarus was given the opportunity to clarify several points including among others issues related to peer-reviewed publications, SCAR full membership, and greater international cooperation in response to questions by several interested Parties. The consultations were held in a positive and constructive atmosphere.
- (178) There was no consensus on the request from Belarus to become a Consultative Party. Based on the suggestion by the Chair, Parties encouraged Belarus to have intersessional exchange of information and views with interested Parties, involving relevant organisations from each Party to identify relevant steps forward.
- (179) Parties welcomed the consideration of Belarus's request at the next ATCM and encouraged Belarus to continue to pursue Consultative Party status. Accordingly, that item has been included on the preliminary agenda for ATCM 49, and there is no need for resubmission.

Item 6c: Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Request from Türkiye to become a Consultative Party

- (180) Türkiye presented IP 68 *Türkiye's Antarctic Activities and Basis for Consultative Party Status under the Antarctic Treaty*, submitting that it had fulfilled the requirements for Consultative Party status under Article IX (2) of the Antarctic Treaty and Decision 2 (2017). Türkiye recalled that its scientists had participated in Antarctic research since the 1960s, and that since its ratification of the Environmental Protocol in 2017, it had conducted ten Antarctic expeditions without interruption, coordinated by the Scientific

and Technological Research Council of Türkiye(TÜBİTAK) Polar Research Institute (KARE) supported by dedicated institutions at the ministry level, and following a long-term polar science strategy for 2023–2035. Türkiye noted that a total of 150 research projects across disciplines, including Earth sciences, physical sciences, life sciences and social sciences, had resulted in more than 200 peer-reviewed publications, the majority published in internationally indexed journals, covering climate processes, oceanography, biodiversity and environmental change. Türkiye also highlighted its scientific research camp and monitoring systems on Horseshoe Island, the operation of the Turkish Polar Data Center under open science principles, and its plans for a new scientific vessel. Noting that it had implemented all the relevant legal frameworks of the Antarctic Treaty, including Annex V and Annex VI, Türkiye drew the Meeting's attention to the compliance of its operations with the environmental protection standards in the Environmental Protocol, including its decision to initiate a draft CEE for its station project. Türkiye also highlighted its full membership of SCAR and COMNAP. Türkiye thanked the Consultative Parties for receiving its request and requested that the Meeting welcome it as a Consultative Party to the Antarctic Treaty.

- (181) In response to questions from Parties, Türkiye further elaborated on the role of polar science in its long-term polar science strategy, its international collaborations with other national Antarctic programmes, its compliance with data-sharing and environmental guidelines, its domestic legislative framework for environmental protection in Antarctica, and its emphasis on broad participation in Antarctic science based on scientific merit.
- (182) Many Parties thanked Türkiye for its presentation and commended Türkiye's consistent contributions to Antarctic science and institutions over the past decade, as well as its engagement with the Antarctic Treaty System. These Parties underscored the scientific record and visibility of Turkish scientists, Türkiye's investments in Antarctic research and infrastructure, the environmental protection standards of Turkish Antarctic operations, and the continued development of the programme.
- (183) Most Parties supported Türkiye's request for Consultative Party status. These Parties confirmed that, in their assessment, Türkiye's substantial scientific research activities in Antarctica met the requirements of Article IX (2). They agreed that the information provided in Türkiye's request on its scientific programmes and activities, sustained contributions to science, logistical support activities, and engagement in international cooperation satisfied the criteria of Decision 2 (2017) and the guidelines annexed thereto.
- (184) India informed the ATCM that although Türkiye has made progress with their scientific activities, there should be consistent criteria applied across the applications. Therefore, India is unable to support Türkiye's request at this time and proposes to defer its request to the ATCM 49.
- (185) Peru noted that India, while expressing reservations about the treatment of the other request, had recognised that all three applicants, including Türkiye, had demonstrated substantial scientific research activity in Antarctica. Therefore, Peru considered that this recognition could have constituted an acknowledgement from India that Türkiye had met the requirements under Article IX (2) of the Antarctic Treaty and Decision 2 (2017). Peru suggested that, in addition to supporting or opposing a request, a Party could abstain, and observed that India, having declined to endorse Türkiye's request without expressing opposition, could take this path to enable consensus.
- (186) The Republic of Korea noted its understanding that Türkiye's candidacy had been discussed on the basis of the relevant criteria for Consultative Party status. In this regard,

the Republic of Korea emphasised the importance of applying the relevant rules and established practice in a clear, consistent and predictable manner, including with respect to the operation of consensus.

- (187) There was no consensus on the request from Türkiye to become a Consultative Party.
- (188) Parties welcomed the consideration of Türkiye's request at the next ATCM and encouraged Türkiye to continue to pursue Consultative Party status. Accordingly, that item has been included on the preliminary agenda for ATCM 49, and there was no need for resubmission.

Item 6d: Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: General Matters

- (189) Australia introduced WP 27 *Supporting enhanced transparency and communication – further improvements to the timeframes for public release of annual meeting reports*. Australia emphasised the value of continued efforts to enhance transparency within the Antarctic Treaty System. Australia recalled discussions at ATCM 47, where Parties had noted that it would be highly desirable to find ways to publish the Final Report sooner after its adoption at the end of each meeting. Australia noted that the dissemination of the Final Report was an important mechanism for informing stakeholders and the general public about the ATCM and CEP's work across environmental protection, science, operations, tourism management, and governance. Australia noted that a range of factors influenced the report publication timeline, including to meet important language equality commitments. Australia recommended that: the ATCM consider, with advice from the Secretariat as appropriate, the process, considerations and timing involved in meeting report publication, with a view to identifying opportunities for earlier release of the preliminary and final meeting reports; and that the ATCM invite the Secretariat to provide an update at ATCM 49 on a revised timeline for releasing the preliminary and meeting reports, including advice on any budgetary or other implications and any necessary administrative changes required to give effect to it.
- (190) The Executive Secretary noted that, following discussion of this matter at ATCM 47, the Secretariat had produced and published the Final Report ahead of schedule. The Secretariat had since undertaken further work to expedite the Final Report's publication. This included producing the preliminary Final Report in English within 20 days of the meeting's conclusion, and in the other three official languages in approximately one month. This would allow the Final Report to be published within three months of the meeting's conclusion. In response to WP 27, the Executive Secretary asked Parties for guidance on whether they would support the "as adopted" version of the Final Report being released to the public immediately following the conclusion of the meeting, and whether they would support the English version of the preliminary Final Report being released in advance of translations in the other three official languages.
- (191) The Meeting thanked Australia and agreed to the paper's recommendations, and reiterated the importance of enhancing transparency within the Antarctic Treaty System. The Meeting also acknowledged the efforts of the Secretariat to deliver last year's Final Report ahead of schedule, and its willingness to further improve the process and timing of the Final Report's publication.
- (192) Some Parties suggested that paper summaries could be excluded from the Final Report and replaced by hyperlinks to papers published on the Secretariat website to reduce the report's length and thereby improve the timeliness of translation. It was further suggested that reducing the time for Parties to review the "as adopted" version of the Final Report would expedite its public release. Some Parties supported the release of the English version of the preliminary Final Report in advance of translations into the other official

languages, while other Parties highlighted the need for simultaneous release of the Final Report in all official languages.

- (193) There was broad support for the Secretariat's proposal to attempt to publish the preliminary Report in all four languages within 35 days, after which the report would be proofread and edited, with the definitive version being published in all four languages within three months from the date of adoption. The Meeting agreed that the Secretariat would report back to ATCM 49.
- (194) Argentina introduced WP 18 *Efficiency and effectiveness in the ATCMs: Outcomes and proposals of the Intersessional Contact Group*, which summarised the areas of convergence and the reservations identified by ICG participants relating to four topics: efficiency and effectiveness of the Working Groups and the Final Report; access to leadership roles; hybrid and virtual technologies; and guidelines for ad hoc events. On the basis of the agreement identified in the ICG, Argentina proposed that the ATCM: adopt a draft Decision concerning good practices and operational guidelines for the ATCM; adopt a draft Decision concerning the minimum criteria for the consideration, approval and organisation of ad hoc events associated with the ATCM and CEP; establish an ICG to deepen discussion on financial and non-financial measures aimed at broadening Parties' access to leadership roles in the ATCM; and include in the Final Report agreed text from the ICG discussions reflecting Parties' intention to promote more equitable participation and to distinguish between the annual ATCM/CEP meeting and intersessional meetings and/or online workshops.
- (195) The Meeting thanked Argentina and ICG participants for their valuable work, and welcomed efforts to strengthen meeting efficiency, reduce duplication and support participation. Belgium considered that the consistent application of existing practices and procedures could contribute to improving meeting efficiency.
- (196) Many Parties supported prioritising Working Papers and improving sequencing between the CEP and ATCM to avoid repetition. Several Parties cautioned against treating Information Papers as "taken as read" as a strict rule, particularly where information was relevant to discussions, noting that non-Consultative Parties and Experts could only submit Information Papers and might need opportunities to present them when relevant.
- (197) Regarding minimum criteria for ad hoc events, many Parties welcomed clearer, more transparent criteria and supported steps to manage their growth so that annual meetings were not unnecessarily extended. Several Parties encouraged the use of online or hybrid options to broaden participation, whilst it was noted that consideration should be given to capacity constraints faced by certain Parties in relation to hybrid participation. Some Parties also cautioned that overly prescriptive criteria could reduce flexibility to respond to emerging issues.
- (198) Regarding the facilitation of access to leadership roles, many Parties agreed that broadening access would strengthen diversity and participation, and recognised that smaller delegations faced constraints in assuming chairing responsibilities. Many Parties expressed support for exploring financial and non-financial mechanisms to enable wider participation through the establishment of an ICG.
- (199) The Meeting agreed to establish an ICG with the general objective of exploring and proposing concrete mechanisms to deepen discussion and build consensus around financial and non-financial measures aimed at broadening Parties' access to leadership roles in the ATCM, while at the same time strengthening the capabilities associated with the exercise of such chairing roles. The mandate of the ICG included:

1. analysing and proposing financial mechanisms aimed at encouraging the early submission of candidatures to chair the ATCM Working Groups, in accordance with Decision 4 (2017) *the Procedures for Appointing Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting Working Group Chairs*, within this context, consider and discuss proposals submitted by the Parties, with a view to strengthening the predictability of the process, intersessional planning, and more balanced participation among Parties;
2. studying and proposing non-financial measures to strengthen the role of Working Group Chairs and introducing improvements to the existing Manual for ATCM Working Group Chairs, with a view to providing support and guidance for capacity building, including:
 - mentoring and training initiatives, including support from former Chairs, where possible;
 - aspects related to time management;
 - facilitation tools;
 - the structure of discussions and the management of repetitive interventions;
 - a focus on decision-oriented proposals; and
 - good practices for hybrid sessions.

(200) It was further agreed that:

- the ICG should operate virtually, using the Secretariat's online forum.
- structured virtual consultation rounds, through written comments or online meetings, should be organised between July 2026 and February 2027.
- Parties should be invited to participate actively, share experiences, and submit proposals in support of the work of the ICG.
- a Working Paper would be submitted to ATCM 49 containing: financial and non-financial proposals to encourage the submission of candidatures for Working Group chairing roles; and proposals to improve processes and strengthen the capacities of such Chairs through the introduction of improvements to the Manual for ATCM Working Group Chairs.
- Argentina would act as convenor and would facilitate discussion, systematise the contributions received, prepare and circulate progress documents and a draft Working Paper.
- the Secretariat would provide technical support and open the ATCM forum for the ICG.

(201) The Meeting adopted Decision 1 (2026) *Efficiency and effectiveness in the Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meetings: good practices and operational guidelines* and Decision 2 (2026) *Minimum criteria for the consideration, approval and organisation of workshops associated with the Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting or the Committee for Environmental Protection*.

(202) The Russian Federation introduced WP 39 *International cooperation as an ATS principle*, highlighting that international cooperation was a fundamental principle of the Antarctic Treaty System and constituted a legal obligation for all Parties. The Russian Federation noted that cooperation underpinned key objectives of the ATS, including the promotion of scientific research and the protection of the Antarctic environment, and was applied across a range of activities both within and beyond the Treaty area. The Russian Federation emphasised that, while cooperation was essential, it did not replace the responsibility of individual States for the planning and implementation of their national

Antarctic programmes, including the provision of necessary resources and logistical support. The Russian Federation further noted the particular importance of cooperation in the transport and logistics sector, including coordination among Parties, national Antarctic programmes and private operators, as well as the role of Port States in facilitating access to Antarctica. The Russian Federation recommended that the ATCM: confirm the importance of the principle of international cooperation as a fundamental norm of the ATS; confirm that international cooperation did not substitute the responsibility of States for the implementation of their national Antarctic programmes; note the practical significance of international cooperation within the framework of the ATS, particularly in transport and logistical support for national Antarctic programmes, including outside the scope of the Treaty; suggest that Parties report on possible national-level restrictions that may have a negative impact on transport links to Antarctic stations and on the provision of their activities; call on Parties to be prepared to cooperate through competent agencies to resolve emerging issues within the framework of international cooperation in transport and logistics; and share insights on other aspects of international cooperation in order to facilitate transport links with Antarctica to meet the demands of national Antarctic programmes.

- (203) The Meeting thanked the Russian Federation for its paper and reiterated that international cooperation, particularly to advance peaceful scientific activity, was a longstanding and central principle of the Antarctic Treaty System. Many Parties noted that the paper raised matters of general principles of international law, and emphasised that the ATCM was not the appropriate forum to debate such matters. Many Parties stated that international cooperation under the Antarctic Treaty could not be characterised as a peremptory norm of international law (*jus cogens*), noting instead that the scope and form of cooperation were matters for Parties to decide when entering into relevant cooperative arrangements.
- (204) While acknowledging that many Antarctic logistics activities occurred outside the Treaty area and might rely on gateway cities for support, several Parties pointed out that COMNAP, which already facilitated coordination and information-sharing on logistics, was a more appropriate forum to discuss such challenges.
- (205) Norway reported a recent incident on 31 March 2026 in the Bransfield Strait, in which the vessel *M/V Bandero* deliberately collided with lawfully operating fishing vessels, creating a serious risk to human life, maritime safety, and the Antarctic environment. In the days that followed, the *M/V Bandero*, which was registered in Saint Kitts and Nevis and owned by the Captain Paul Watson Foundation, continued to engage in hazardous conduct intended to disrupt lawful fishing operations, including attempts to interfere with fishing gear. Norway advised that aspects of the incidents relevant to CCAMLR had been addressed within the CCAMLR framework. In addition, Norway had raised the incident with the vessel's flag state, Saint Kitts and Nevis. Norway noted that the Foundation had proclaimed that it had launched a "War on Krill". As this "war" was taking place in Antarctica, this conduct was incompatible with Article I of the Antarctic Treaty, under which Antarctica was to be used for peaceful purposes only. It was further noted that the vessel did not appear to be registered in the Electronic Information Exchange System (EIES) or authorised by any Party. Norway considered the conduct to be in contravention of the Environmental Protocol and noted that it could also have adverse implications for scientific activities and place an additional burden on safety operations. It added that the Captain Paul Watson Foundation's complex organisational arrangements made it difficult to identify State responsibility, with the charity, according to publicly available information, registered in multiple countries, including at least the United States and the United Kingdom, its founder holding dual United States and Canadian citizenship; and the vessel's captain at the time of the incidents being a Spanish citizen. Norway

encouraged relevant Antarctic Treaty Parties to consider follow-up steps within their respective legislation, including national Antarctic legislation, as well as all Antarctic Treaty Parties to identify relevant steps to prevent a recurrence and to send a clear message that such conduct was unacceptable.

- (206) The Meeting thanked Norway for bringing this incident to its attention and expressed serious concern at the reported conduct and the threat it posed to life, safety and the environment in a remote and challenging operating area. Many Parties agreed that, while peaceful protest was legitimate, the conduct as described had crossed a line, undermined international cooperation, placed at risk the peaceful purposes of the Antarctic Treaty and the objectives of the Environmental Protocol, and was wholly unacceptable.
- (207) On this matter, Chile informed that, after receiving a call of the attacked vessel alerting the incident, its Navy ordered the deployment of the *ATF Lientur* to the location of the occurrence, in order to establish a presence and take action in the event, urging the *M/V Banderó* to cease its conduct and informing it that such acts of harassment would be reported to competent authorities. After these events, this situation was formally informed by Chile to the Executive Secretary of the CAMLR Commission.
- (208) The United Kingdom noted that an observer on board the fishing vessel had corroborated the account of events and reported that it had taken such action as was available to it to prevent the *M/V Banderó* from resupplying and had reported the matter to CCAMLR. Spain noted that, having become aware that one of its nationals had been involved, additional information would be sought to enable appropriate action. CCAMLR reported that its Chair had written to the vessel's flag State expressing grave concern that such conduct, given the remoteness and challenging conditions of the Antarctic region, threatened maritime safety and the Antarctic environment and undermined CCAMLR. CCAMLR had received an acknowledgement of receipt but no substantive response. Argentina noted that, prior to the incident, the captains of the *Antarctic Sea* and the *Antarctic Endurance* had already conveyed their concerns to the Argentine authorities while the country was carrying out CCAMLR inspections. Argentina expressed its concern regarding the incident and underscored the importance of ensuring safe navigation in these remote waters, taking into account its search and rescue responsibilities in the area.
- (209) Many Parties emphasised the importance of ATCM work on non-governmental activities which warranted further consideration within the Antarctic Treaty System, including to prevent similar activities in the future. Some Parties suggested that additional follow-up could include exploring relevant liability and compliance issues and considering practical preventive measures, such as engaging with port authorities.
- (210) The Executive Secretary introduced SP 9 *The Establishment of a Capacity-Building Programme*, outlining a proposal for a multi-year capacity-building programme to strengthen technical expertise and support Parties in meeting information exchange obligations, including through improved understanding and use of Secretariat databases and tools. The Executive Secretary noted that the proposal responded to the increasing number of first-time participants, the greater diversity of professional profiles among delegates, and the growing workload during the intersessional period. Implementation would begin using existing Secretariat resources, with delivery initially in English and Spanish and expansion to all four official languages over time. The Secretariat recommended that the ATCM endorse the proposed multi-year capacity-building programme and request the Secretariat to report on progress at ATCM 49.

- (211) The Meeting thanked the Secretariat for its proposal and supported the initiative. Many Parties noted that the training and webinars already delivered by the Secretariat, including sessions on the EIES and briefings for new delegates, had been well received and had assisted Parties in inducting new officials and enhancing transparency and engagement. The Netherlands suggested that turning part of the training programme into a publicly available tool on the ATCM and CEP framework in general could also support broader public education and outreach on the Antarctic Treaty System.
- (212) In response to questions about the financial implications of the programme, the Secretariat reiterated that the programme would begin in English and Spanish due to existing competence in these languages, and indicated that anticipated savings from the ongoing procurement of translation and interpretation services could help meet future translation needs. Expressing support for the programme, the Russian Federation offered to assist with translating the training materials into Russian.
- (213) The Meeting approved the Secretariat's proposed multi-year capacity building programme and requested the Secretariat to report on progress at ATCM 49.
- (214) The Executive Secretary introduced SP 10 *Integrating artificial intelligence into Secretariat activities: A strategic multi-year initiative*, proposing a strategic, multi-year initiative to incorporate artificial intelligence (AI) into the operations of the Secretariat, with the objective of modernising Secretariat services, supporting informed decision-making, producing cost savings and improving efficiency. The Deputy Executive Secretary provided examples of how AI tools could support the ATCM, such as by assisting the legal drafting group with research and verifying draft text and assisting rapporteurs and Chairs in the production of ATCM and CEP reports. Acknowledging the risks associated with the use of AI tools, the Secretariat stressed that the project envisaged measures to ensure that Chairs and editors retained accountability and that human oversight in decision-making was maintained, including by communicating any AI-assisted work transparently. The Secretariat recommended that the Meeting endorse the strategic multi-year project and committed to providing yearly updates on its implementation. The Secretariat also recommended that the Meeting authorise the establishment of a Special Fund to cover the Secretariat's costs of AI developments and encourage Parties to provide voluntary contributions to it.
- (215) Several Parties thanked the Secretariat and expressed support for its proposal, emphasising that the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat should not fall behind developments that were increasingly used across international organisations. Several Parties noted that, if approached prudently and transparently, modern tools could help the Secretariat respond to the growing complexity of its work and enhance efficiency. Several Parties also welcomed the proposal for annual reporting, which would enable continued oversight as implementation progressed.
- (216) Some Parties raised concerns about costs, confidentiality and oversight, including: the need for clear boundaries to ensure that AI supported administrative and technical functions rather than deliberative or diplomatic processes, and that human supervision and accountability remained central. Some Parties stressed that decision-making on this matter should be guided by concrete terms of reference, sound procurement principles and appropriate steering arrangements by or on behalf of the ATCM. Several Parties requested further information on expected costs and the balance between savings and new expenditures, including the operation of the proposed Special Fund.
- (217) In response to the concerns raised, the Secretariat explained that implementation would be gradual and accompanied by safeguards, with ultimate responsibility for text

production remaining with Chairs and editors. The Secretariat noted that initial steps could be covered within existing resources and budgets, and that efficiencies generated over time could help offset future costs. The Secretariat reiterated its intention to provide yearly updates on actions taken, tools used and the path for implementation, enabling Parties to maintain control and review progress. On procurement and providers, the Secretariat explained that it would rely on regulated providers under contractual arrangements that provided appropriate guarantees, and that it would welcome continued consultation with CCAMLR and other relevant organisations to share experience and good practice. Regarding financing, the Secretariat indicated that while special financing would not be required at the outset, additional costs could arise at later stages and could be complemented through voluntary contributions to the Special Fund.

- (218) Following further consideration, the Meeting agreed that the Secretariat should proceed with Phase 1 of the proposed strategic multi-year project to incorporate AI into the operations of the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat and provide a report to ATCM 49. Based on progress made during the intersessional period, the ATCM would consider continuing the project and establishing a Special Fund.
- (219) The Executive Secretary presented SP 3 *List of Measures with status “not yet effective”*, and presented an updated overview of the Measures adopted by the ATCM that had not yet entered into force, including Measure 4 (2004), Measure 1 (2005), and Measure 15 (2009). SP 3 also listed the Parties whose approval was still pending, the most recent approvals, and noted a general slowing in the rate of ratifications since 2017. The United States, in its capacity as Depositary Government of the Antarctic Treaty and its Environmental Protocol, reported that Norway had approved Measure 15 (2009).
- (220) The Meeting thanked the Secretariat for providing the up-to-date information. The United Kingdom emphasised that the effectiveness of the Antarctic Treaty System depended on Measures entering into force and noted with concern that progress on ratification had slowed in recent years. The United Kingdom further observed that, since the outstanding Measures were closely related to tourism and other non-governmental activities, their continued non-entry-into-force constituted a particular gap in the regulatory framework.
- (221) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:
 - IP 5 *Commemoration of the 40th anniversary of the first Brazilian wintering in Antarctica and continuous presence of Brazil in the region* (Brazil), which marked the 40th anniversary of the first Brazilian winter-over mission, conducted in 1986 at the Comandante Ferraz Antarctic Station, and reported on Brazil’s continuous presence in the region maintained for four decades through scientific research, logistical support and international cooperation under the Antarctic Treaty System.
 - IP 51 *Antarctic Parliamentarians Assembly 8 to 9 December 2025: Wellington, New Zealand* (New Zealand), which reported on the third Antarctic Parliamentarians Assembly, held in Wellington on 8 and 9 December 2025 on the 66th anniversary of the Antarctic Treaty, attended by 22 Parliamentarians and two special advisors from 14 Antarctic Treaty Parties. The Assembly reaffirmed its shared commitment to safeguard and champion the Antarctic Treaty System and the cooperation that underpinned it.
 - IP 73 *Consolidation of the Guiding Document of the Colombian Antarctic Program* (Colombia), which reported on the completion of a strategic restructuring of the Colombian Antarctic Program (PAC) following its first decade of operation, including the reformulation of the Program’s general and specific

objectives, components and cross-cutting axes, supported by an updated Antarctic Scientific Agenda aligned with the principles of the Antarctic Treaty System and SCAR priorities.

- IP 104 *Strengthening support for the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty* (Australia, France, Spain), which reported on a sixth round of representations conducted in 2025 and 2026 by Australia, France and Spain, with the support and participation of 19 other Consultative Parties, to encourage 15 non-Consultative Parties not yet party to the Environmental Protocol to accede to it. The paper noted that the renewed efforts were considered particularly timely given the celebration of the 35th anniversary of the signing of the Environmental Protocol, and that the representations had indicated overall support for the Protocol's objectives and principles.
- IP 115 *Implementation and Initiatives under the "Law relating to Protection of the Environment in Antarctica" by the Ministry of the Environment of Japan* (Japan), which provided an overview of the initiatives and activities for the implementation of the law and the environmental protection measures undertaken by the Ministry of the Environment of Japan staff members accompanying the Japanese Antarctic Research Expedition (JARE).
- IP 143 *Visita de embajadores de países puerta de entrada a la Antártica a la isla Rey Jorge y seminario sobre ciudades puerta de entrada a la Antártica* (Chile), which reported that in January ambassadors from Antarctic gateway countries (Argentina, Australia, New Zealand and South Africa) had met in Punta Arenas to promote dialogue and the exchange of experience on Antarctic logistics, scientific cooperation and the role of gateway cities in supporting activities under the Antarctic Treaty System. The initiative included a visit to King George Island undertaken by some of the participants.
- IP 167 *Clarification of the Status of Decisions and Resolutions* (South Africa), which addressed the absence of a consistent practice for indicating when Decisions and Resolutions adopted by the ATCM replaced, revised or revoked earlier instruments, and proposed elements for consideration in clarifying their status.
- IP 171 *Strengthening the Antarctic Governance of Colombia: Institutional Overhaul* (Colombia), which reported on the recent update to Colombia's institutional framework for coordinating Antarctic affairs through the strengthening of the National Commission for Antarctic Affairs, including its interinstitutional approach and integration with the national Antarctic programme.

(222) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 11 *Venezuela mantiene su interés y trabaja para ascender a Miembro Consultivo* (Venezuela).
- BP 17 *Establishment of the National Polar Coordination Board of Türkiye* (Türkiye).
- BP 22 *Reorganization of the Polar Research Institute of Türkiye (KARE)* (Türkiye).
- BP 46 *Amendment to Canada's Antarctic Environmental Protection Regulations* (Canada).

Item 7: Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Matters related to the Secretariat

- (223) The Executive Secretary introduced SP 4 *Secretariat Report 2025/2026*, SP 5 *Secretariat Programme 2026/2027* and SP 6 *Five-Year Forward Budget Profile 2027/28 – 2031/32*, which together provided an account of the Secretariat's activities during the Financial Year 2025/26 (1 April 2025 to 31 March 2026), including the organisation of ATCM 47 and CEP 27 in Italy and the preparation for ATCM 48 and CEP 28 in Japan; the activities proposed for the Financial Year 2026/27 (1 April 2026 to 31 March 2027); and the Secretariat's budget profile for the period 2027/28 to 2031/32.
- (224) The Executive Secretary drew the Meeting's attention to the intersessional activities the Secretariat had supported during the Financial Year 2025/26, including support to ATCM and CEP online discussion forums and workshops assisting delegates and Chairs upon request, and providing quarterly updates on the status of intersessional discussions. The Executive Secretary also highlighted the training provided to Parties on the EIES and the implementation of an onboarding programme for new ATCM and CEP delegates. The Executive Secretary noted that the Secretariat had improved its digital tools, including the launch of an updated version of the Antarctic Treaty application for both Android and iOS devices, the incorporation of a beta-version artificial-intelligence-powered search function for the entire website, and the establishment of a new webpage outlining the process for obtaining Consultative Party status in response to a request from the United States as Depositary Government. The Deputy Executive Secretary attended the 2025 COMNAP Annual General Meeting (AGM) in Poland, while the Executive Secretary provided a briefing to Parties at CCAMLR-44 and would continue to represent the Secretariat at relevant meetings, including the 2026 COMNAP AGM in Tromsø, Norway and CCAMLR-45 in Hobart, Australia.
- (225) The Executive Secretary further outlined the Secretariat's regular activities for the upcoming period, including the preparation of ATCM 49 and ATCM 50, the publication of reports, and other tasks assigned to the Secretariat under Measure 1 (2003). The Executive Secretary highlighted the Secretariat's aim to shorten the timeframes within which it produced reports, to put out a new tender for translation and interpretation in line with best practice in fiscal management, and the proposal of multi-year initiatives to incorporate AI tools into its operations, and to establish a capacity building programme to strengthen technical proficiency in the ATCM and promote consistent compliance with information exchange obligations.
- (226) The Meeting thanked the Secretariat for its detailed report on the range of activities it undertook in the service of the Parties. The Meeting commended the Secretariat for its continued work to improve information-sharing tools, such as the EIES, as well as practical measures to improve the flow of information prior to and during Meetings, through the app and annotated agendas with embedded links to meeting papers. While supportive of exploring the use of AI to increase administrative efficiency, some Parties cautioned against its use in decision-making, citing concerns about impartiality.
- (227) In terms of personnel and finances, the Executive Secretary noted that on 1 September 2025, he had succeeded Mr Albert Lluberas, and that otherwise no personnel changes were foreseen in the upcoming period. The Executive Secretary highlighted the increased workload of the Support Officer position and proposed converting it to a full-time position with minimal financial implications. In recognition of the Deputy Executive Secretary's commitment and efficiency in his work over the past years, the Executive Secretary stated that he intended to renew Mr Wydler's position as Deputy Executive

Secretary for an additional four-year period, following further consultation during ATCM 48 in line with Staff Regulation 6.3 (e).

- (228) The Executive Secretary further presented the externally audited financial report for the Financial Year 2024/25, noting no deviations from the Provisional Report presented at ATCM 47 (SP 4). The Executive Secretary introduced the provisional Financial Report 2025/26, including changes in the presentation aimed at enhancing transparency in these matters. The operating result was almost balanced, with a deficit of USD 6 859 instead of the USD 73 307 originally budgeted, however the exchange loss suffered by the Secretariat was higher than expected, contributing to a provisional deficit of USD 93 192 at the end of the period, which ended with an accumulated cash surplus in the General Fund of USD 591 667. The Executive Secretary noted that the current deficit was mainly attributable to financing, compounded by its dual-currency nature, which meant it could not be eliminated, although the Secretariat was taking several measures to mitigate the loss. He reported that the Secretariat had been working with the Host Country to minimise exchange losses arising from the payment of contributions and the reimbursement of expenses and had implemented changes to administrative processes to streamline the claim of tax returns and cash and short-term investment management strategies.
- (229) The Executive Secretary reported that, since ATCM 47, the following Parties had moved to a higher level of contributions: Belgium had moved from D to C, Bulgaria from E to D, Chile from C to B, Italy from B to A, the Republic of Korea from D to C, Germany from B to A, and the Russian Federation from C to A. Except for Bulgaria, which will start paying its new contribution level in 2027, all of these Parties had started paying their new contribution level in 2026, providing additional income of USD 47 947, which was already included in the budget. Considering global inflation and the continued rise in the living costs in Argentina, the Executive Secretary proposed increasing the Secretariat's salaries by 2.4 per cent. The Executive Secretary reported that due to the combination of considerable savings and increased income the operating result of the budget would be almost balanced with a deficit of a USD 4 154, and the net result estimates a deficit of USD 75 087 compared with USD 160 802 as originally forecasted. The Executive Secretary reported that the forecast budget for 2027/28 estimated a USD 90 199 deficit and that the contributions for the Financial Year 2027/28 would show only marginal fluctuations, resulting from the change in contribution categories of several Parties (SP 5).
- (230) The Executive Secretary noted that the outlook for the Secretariat's budget profile had improved due to several Consultative Parties' move to higher contribution categories, while savings in the budget's expenditure lines had reduced costs, and inflation had been decreasing both globally and locally. This could lead to deficits of around 10 per cent of the forecasted budget or less. The Executive Secretary further noted that the General Fund surplus would temporarily absorb these additional costs but cautioned that the financial situation was not sustainable. Regarding the long-term sustainability of the Secretariat's finances, the Executive Secretary reiterated the Secretariat's willingness to support Parties in their evaluation of income options for the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat.
- (231) The Meeting thanked the Executive Secretary for his prudence in finding ways to improve the Secretariat's budgetary position.
- (232) The Meeting adopted Decision 3 (2026) *Secretariat Report, Programme and Budget*.
- (233) Germany introduced WP 1 *Report of the ICG on evaluating options for income for the ATS*, prepared jointly with Belgium. Germany recalled that the expenses of the

Secretariat had risen due to inflation, coupled with a zero increase in contributions since 2014, resulting in a situation where a deficit of USD 90 000 could occur in 2027/28, as reported by the Executive Secretary. Noting that the deficits had been covered by the General Fund, Germany stressed the practice was not sustainable, and the ICG had been established to consider options for increasing income.

- (234) Germany noted the participants in the ICG had discussed increasing income from mandatory contributions from Consultative Parties, and recommended: encouraging Consultative Parties who had not done so to increase their contribution categories; simplifying contribution categories by making Category A the standard category; a one-off percentage increase, noting 7 per cent would cover the current deficit for 2026/27; and a change of system from zero nominal growth to zero real growth for mandatory contributions from Consultative Parties.
- (235) Germany noted that participants had also recommended encouraging a voluntary contribution system for non-Consultative Parties, Observers and Experts. Germany also reported on other suggestions for increasing income, including: changing Financial Regulations (Decision 5 (2006)) to ensure that voluntary contributions could be used to reduce the budgetary deficit, and selling customised products.
- (236) The Meeting thanked Germany and Belgium for their work and the participants in the intersessional contact group, and welcomed the opportunity to reassess the options available for securing and sustaining the Secretariat's funding.
- (237) The Meeting supported encouraging Consultative Parties to move categories who had not done so. Several Parties referred to their own category changes and encouraged others to do the same. Parties agreed that the determination of categories should remain a voluntary consideration for each Party. Parties also supported maintaining equitable categories to reflect different capabilities, and did not support making Category A the standard contribution.
- (238) Some Parties expressed that they could not support a one-off increase to contributions.
- (239) While some Parties did not agree with the use of zero-real-growth accounting for inflation, others supported it or found it worth considering. The Meeting agreed that pursuing this option would require further research into the appropriate indices to ensure a fair and equitable outcome.
- (240) The Meeting agreed that any contribution from non-Consultative Parties, Observers or Experts could be established only after meaningful and transparent consultation with those who would be impacted. Many Parties also recommended that the ATCM avoid making such contributions mandatory for these participants, so as not to deter additional states from acceding to the Antarctic Treaty, the Environmental Protocol, or deter organisations from participating in the ATCM.
- (241) The Meeting supported promoting voluntary contributions, although some Parties cautioned against relying on them as a sustainable source of income.
- (242) The Meeting exchanged views on whether it would be appropriate to grant the Secretariat the authority to autonomously reallocate unused balances from Special and Trust Funds into its General Fund, or whether the Secretariat should obtain approval from the ATCM. Several Parties considered this would be appropriate where reallocations concerned funds whose original purpose had been fulfilled or concluded. Other Parties proposed seeking the consent of contributors.

- (243) The Meeting agreed to amend the Financial Regulations to allow the Secretariat to use voluntary contributions to reduce its budgetary deficit and, subject to the fulfilment of certain conditions, to enable the Executive Secretary to transfer unused funds from Special and Trust Funds to other Funds, including the General Fund.
- (244) Concerning the sale of customised products, some Parties agreed it should be considered, but noted that merchandising alone would not remedy the current budgetary deficit.
- (245) The Meeting adopted Decision 4 (2026) *Amendment to the Financial Regulations for the Secretariat of the Antarctic Treaty*.
- (246) Norway introduced WP 37 *The Antarctic Treaty Secretariat Data Policy*, prepared jointly with Australia, Belgium, South Africa, and Spain, which proposed developing a Secretariat data policy. Noting that the information technology landscape had evolved considerably since the establishment of the Secretariat in 2004, Norway highlighted the utility of a formal policy to clarify the terms and conditions under which data curated and delivered through the Secretariat could be shared and distributed, including the rights of data users and data providers. The proponents recommended that the Meeting discuss the utility of a Secretariat data policy to clarify how data curated and delivered through the Secretariat should be managed. The proponents further recommended that the Meeting agree to develop a draft data policy for presentation at ATCM 49.
- (247) The Meeting thanked Norway and the co-proponents for their proposal to develop a data policy for the Secretariat. Many Parties welcomed the recommendations and offered to contribute to drafting the Data Policy. Parties suggested that the Secretariat could draw on the data policies of comparable organisations, including SCAR; that the work be developed in connection with the related discussions on artificial intelligence under SP 10; and that it be grounded in the Treaty's information-sharing obligations under Article III. The Meeting agreed that, since the data policy would primarily concern the flow of data through the Secretariat, it would be most appropriate for the Secretariat to take the lead in preparing it.
- (248) SCAR noted that it had published its own data policy in 2022 and that the principles of this policy were intended to be universal. Since such policies shared many commonalities, SCAR volunteered to share its experiences with the Secretariat, as required.
- (249) The Meeting requested the Secretariat, in consultation with SCAR and interested Parties, to prepare a draft data policy to be presented at ATCM 49.

Item 8: Liability

- (250) Recalling Decision 6 (2025) *Liability arising from environmental emergencies*, and the standing commitment of the Parties to develop a comprehensive environmental liability regime in the Antarctic in accordance with Article 16 of the Environmental Protocol, the Meeting investigated the status of implementation of liability arising from environmental emergencies by each Party.
- (251) Japan presented IP 97 *Amending the Law relating to Protection of the Environment in Antarctica to implement Annex VI to the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty*. Japan informed the Meeting that its Cabinet had approved a draft law to amend the Law relating to Protection of the Environment in Antarctica, which constituted the necessary domestic implementing legislation for Annex VI, on 3 April 2026. Japan noted the draft had then been submitted to the National Diet for its approval, where it was under deliberation. Japan restated its firm commitment to implementing the

Environmental Protocol in its entirety, and encouraged all other Parties that had not yet implemented Annex VI to continue, and where possible to expedite, their implementation. Japan welcomed inquiries from other Parties and offered to provide detailed information and bilateral support on the basis of its own implementation experience.

(252) The Meeting welcomed Japan's paper. Noting the importance of the timely implementation of all Annexes, the Meeting called on all Parties that had not yet implemented Annex VI to do so as a matter of priority. The Meeting encouraged all Parties operating in the Antarctic Treaty area to take all necessary measures to avoid and prevent environmental emergencies.

(253) The following paper was submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:

- IP 187 *Implementación del Anexo VI del Protocolo de Madrid en el Perú* (Peru), which reported on Peru's measures in line with its implementation of Annex VI in 2007, including infrastructure improvements at the Machu Picchu Station, specialised personnel training and the adoption of preventative measures consistent with Article 3 of Annex VI.

Item 9: Biological Prospecting in Antarctica

(254) No papers were submitted under this agenda item. The Meeting agreed to keep the subject on the Agenda for ATCM 49.

Item 10: Exchange of Information

(255) Spain introduced WP 28 *Report on the progress of the intersessional contact group on Information Exchange: Permanent Information category review*. Spain reported on the progress of the Intersessional Contact Group (ICG) established at ATCM 47 to review the list of requirements in the Annex to Decision 4 (2023). Recalling that the original motivation for the review had been an analysis by the Secretariat showing that a number of EIES sections were used in a limited way, and that the number of Parties submitting annual reports had declined by over 20 per cent over the previous decade. During the intersessional period, the ICG worked mainly through two rounds of discussion. During the first round of discussions, Parties focused on the rationale for information exchange; criteria for evaluating the addition or removal of requirements, and an initial approach to the current "permanent" information category, including its renaming, aiming to address the limitations of "static" terminology. The second round of discussions analysed Parties' compliance levels in the permanent information category, with a view to identifying systemic challenges in data collection or reporting, and proposed amendments to the list of permanent-information requirements. These proposals were primarily focused on consolidating categories, eliminating redundancies, providing technical clarifications, and modernising access requirements. The convenor reported that a common understanding had been reached on some of these proposals. The convenor further suggested that no changes should be made to the list of requirements until the ICG had completed its comprehensive review, to ensure consistency.

(256) The convenor of the ICG also reflected on Parties' limited participation in the ICG, which had continued to decline. In addition to the significant intersessional workload of Parties, the convenor suggested that there may also be a need for specialists and officers who manage the EIES daily and who do not typically attend Meetings to contribute directly through a technical workshop or an Antarctic Treaty Meeting of Experts.

(257) The ICG proposed that the Meeting:

- extend the mandate of the ICG for a second term to consider pre-season and annual report categories; and
- request the Secretariat to offer technical support and training programmes to facilitate their integration into the EIES.

(258) The Meeting thanked Spain for convening the ICG and reaffirmed the importance of information exchange in fulfilling Parties' obligations under Article VII of the Antarctic Treaty. Many Parties emphasised the importance of information exchange as a tool for transparency. The Meeting encouraged all Parties to be diligent in meeting annual reporting requirements. The importance of exchanging information on military personnel and equipment as specifically required under Article VII (5) of the Treaty was highlighted.

(259) The United States emphasised that meeting Article VII obligations for transparency and information exchange was of vital importance for ensuring that Antarctica was being used for peaceful purposes only, as required by Article I of the Treaty. It further noted that while many Parties were working to fully meet the Treaty's military personnel and equipment advance notification requirement, there was still room for improvement. The United States encouraged all Parties to draw on the Secretariat's training resources on EIES reporting to help meet their obligations to provide the required information, particularly information regarding military personnel or equipment they intended to introduce into Antarctica.

(260) Parties acknowledged the importance of the EIES, noted the need to streamline requirements, and confirmed that information sharing was their obligation under the Antarctic Treaty, and that Antarctica should be used for peaceful purposes only. Many Parties underscored that information sharing was vital to ensuring transparency. Germany suggested that it could be useful for the Secretariat to prepare an overview of the benefits of the EIES.

(261) In response to a question, the Secretariat confirmed that it had previously reached out to Parties that had failed to comply with annual reporting requirements, in order to better understand how it could support them. Several Parties reminded the Meeting of the useful training the Secretariat had provided in the use of the EIES.

(262) Regarding the suggestions put forward by the convenor of the ICG, some Parties expressed support for an ad hoc meeting of specialists, while other Parties considered it superfluous at this point. Many Parties supported the proposal to only make changes to the list of required information following the comprehensive review of the information exchange requirements as reflected in the EIES. In response to a suggestion that the Meeting adopt changes successively, on an annual basis, the convenor replied that categories might shift during the comprehensive review, which could make such an approach inefficient as it may require the adoption of multiple decisions.

(263) The Meeting agreed to continue the ICG on information exchange for another intersessional period with the following revised aims:

- continue reviewing the list of requirements for information exchange, following the pre-season and annual report categories; and
- discuss the need to establish a roadmap to address the review of existing requirements of information exchange, invite Parties to reflect on new approaches aimed at reversing current declining trends—including the possibility of a technical workshop, an Antarctic Treaty Meeting of Experts, or a similar tool, and

submit formal proposals for ATCM 49.

(264) It was further agreed that:

- non-Consultative Parties, SCAR, COMNAP and IAATO would be invited to provide input;
- the Executive Secretary would be invited to make contributions and to offer technical support and training programmes to facilitate the integration of agreed changes into the EIES;
- the Executive Secretary would open the ATCM Forum for the ICG and provide assistance; and
- Spain would act as convenor and report on the progress made by the ICG to ATCM 49.

(265) New Zealand noted that transparency had emerged as a strong theme at the ATCM and suggested that the Meeting consider adopting a Resolution.

(266) The Meeting adopted Resolution 4 (2026) *Emphasising the Importance of Information Exchange to the Antarctic Treaty System*, redoubling efforts to use the EIES to consolidate information exchange as required under the Antarctic Treaty and the Environmental Protocol, and requesting the Secretariat to continue to support Parties to meet those information exchange obligations via the EIES.

(267) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:

- IP 75 *Colombia's Engagement in the Electronic Information Exchange System (EIES)* (Colombia), which presented an overview of Colombia's contribution to the exchange of information on national Antarctic activities through active reporting within the EIES and outlined ongoing actions to address gaps from previous reporting periods.
- IP 130 *Military Personnel and Equipment Transparency Requirements* (United States), which recalled the shared commitment of all Antarctic Treaty Parties to ensure that Antarctica should be used for peaceful purposes only, and urged Parties to reinvigorate efforts to report military personnel and equipment via the EIES in accordance with Article VII of the Treaty and Decision 4 (2023).

Item 11: Education Issues

(268) Bulgaria introduced WP 21 *Ninth report of the Intersessional Contact Group on Education and Outreach*, prepared jointly with Australia, Belarus, Belgium, Brazil, Canada, Chile, Colombia, the Czech Republic, Ecuador, Estonia, Finland, France, India, Italy, the Republic of Korea, Malaysia, Poland, Portugal, Romania, the United Kingdom, Spain, Venezuela, Türkiye, ASOC, COMNAP, IAATO, SCAR and the WMO. Bulgaria outlined the work of the ICG on Education and Outreach (ICG) during the 2025-26 intersessional period, recalling that the ICG was originally established at ATCM XXXVIII (2015) and continued at successive Meetings, most recently at ATCM 47 (paras 255-259). Bulgaria highlighted the wide range of activities reported by Parties, Observers and Experts and emphasised the importance of continued collaboration and information sharing on education and outreach initiatives. Bulgaria also drew attention to the organisation of the Workshop on Education and Outreach held in conjunction with ATCM 48, and which focused on ongoing Education and Outreach projects already being undertaken by Parties, Observers and Experts; closing the ICG and creating a new tool for sharing information; and sharing ideas on education and outreach in preparation for IPY-5. The ICG recommended that the Meeting recognise the usefulness of education

and outreach activities from an Antarctic Treaty perspective; acknowledge the work of the ICG during the intersessional period; and consider the different options discussed during the workshop for Parties, Observers, and Experts to continue exchanging information on education and outreach activities.

- (269) The Meeting thanked the ICG and its participants for their work and recognised the ICG's useful contributions during the past intersessional period. The Meeting reaffirmed the usefulness of education and outreach from an Antarctic Treaty perspective.
- (270) Japan introduced WP 56 *Co-chairs' report of the Workshop on Education and Outreach, Hiroshima, Japan, May 2026*, jointly prepared with Belgium, Brazil, Bulgaria, Chile, Portugal, Spain and the United Kingdom. At ATCM 47, the Meeting decided to organise a second Workshop on Education and Outreach to be held in conjunction with ATCM 48. The workshop aimed to enable Parties, Observers, Experts and the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat to: provide updates on ongoing education and outreach projects already being undertaken by Parties, Observers and Experts; consider the future of the ICG as a new tool for sharing information; and exchange ideas on education and outreach in preparation for IPY-5 (ATCM 47, para 258-259). The workshop featured 25 oral and five digital poster presentations on educational and outreach activities from an Antarctic Treaty perspective. The workshop participants agreed that the Meeting should consider the establishment of an ATCM forum that brought together experts in the field of education and outreach in a 'virtual network' to share education and outreach information, in accordance with the Rules of Procedure of the ATCMs and the main principles and objectives of the Antarctic Treaty System.
- (271) The co-chairs of the Workshop recommended that the Meeting: establish a permanent "Education and Outreach Forum" to facilitate information sharing and discussion, as appropriate; request the Secretariat to open the "Education and Outreach Forum" within the ATCM Forum; request Parties to provide points of contact for education and outreach matters related to the Forum; and invite Parties, Observers and Experts to make contributions to the Forum.
- (272) The Meeting thanked Japan and the workshop co-organisers, and emphasised the importance of education and outreach not only with respect to Antarctica itself, the science conducted there and its significance for humankind, but also with respect to the Antarctic Treaty System. The Meeting also underscored the pertinence of outreach and education in collaborative initiatives such as IPY-5 and Antarctica InSync. Japan highlighted the number and diversity of outreach and education activities undertaken in the city of Hiroshima before and during ATCM 48, which had produced a tangible increase in public interest in the Antarctic Treaty System.
- (273) The Meeting agreed to establish a permanent online forum on "Education and Outreach" within the ATCM Forum with the objective to share education and outreach information.
- (274) The Meeting asked the Secretariat to establish such a permanent forum. Participation would be open to Parties, Observers and Experts.
- (275) Information on education and outreach in the permanent forum would include the development, implementation, and dissemination, at national and international levels, of initiatives promoting scientific observations and results environmental protection, and the work of Antarctic Treaty Parties in managing the Antarctic Treaty area, as a means of reinforcing the importance of the Antarctic Treaty and its Environmental Protocol.
- (276) The Meeting noted the participants of the permanent forum may wish to establish a work plan and to regularly report its work progress to the ATCM.

- (277) Chile introduced WP 51 *Antarctic educational programmes for young people: towards the development of an international Antarctic School Field Party*. Reminding the Meeting of the importance of education and outreach initiatives aimed at young people, particularly secondary school students, Chile described its own experience with the Antarctic School Field Party (Expedición Antártica Escolar), which connected students and teachers with Antarctic scientific research in a competitive setting, and rewarded a winning class with a research trip to Antarctica. Highlighting the potential lifelong impacts of such experiences, Chile invited the Parties to come together with their similar student outreach programmes and to plan a joint international Antarctic School Field Party for the Fifth International Polar Year, which could bring together school children and students from all countries under the umbrella of the Antarctic Treaty System.
- (278) The Meeting thanked Chile for introducing a new education and outreach initiative that would connect the youth with IPY-5. Several Parties showcased their own similar student outreach programmes, and many expressed interest in joining Chile to discuss the possibility of organising an international school field party.
- (279) The Meeting encouraged interested Parties to join Chile in the planning of an Antarctic School Field Trip for IPY-5.
- (280) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:
- IP 2 *India's Initiatives in Antarctic Awareness, Outreach and Capacity Building (2025–2026)* (India), which outlined India's education, outreach and capacity building initiatives led by the National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research, including public engagement activities, use of immersive technologies and academic programmes. The paper noted India's role as the nodal agency for polar programmes under the Ministry of Earth Sciences, and outlined its work across structured awareness, outreach and capacity building initiatives.
 - IP 16 *Education, outreach, and publicity - towards the coordination of ATCM* (Russian Federation), which outlined considerations on the coordination of education, outreach and publicity activities within the Antarctic Treaty System and highlighted the importance of objective representation of information and common approaches, which requires a clear distinction between the agreed norms of the ATS on the one hand, and the interpretation by individual Parties on the other hand. The paper had been prepared in accordance with Priority 2 of the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan (Decision 7 (2025)) and contributed to discussions on potential new formats for information sharing and on preparations for IPY-5.
 - IP 25 *Education Workshop: Initiatives to promote Education & Outreach* (Spain), which described national initiatives, including outreach campaigns, scientific networks, and public engagement activities, aimed at increasing awareness of Antarctic research and conservation. Spain presented three initiatives developed at different institutional levels: an annual call aimed at social media and communication outlets, a scientific network focused on strengthening polar research and training, and a public-engagement initiative, all sharing the common goal of raising awareness of the importance of preserving Antarctica.
 - IP 32 *Antarctic Outreach: Examples from U.S. Research Teams* (United States) provided examples of outreach activities undertaken by research teams, including engagement with educators, students, and the public through a variety of communication tools and programmes. The paper recalled that, while peer-reviewed journal articles remained an essential strategy for sharing research, the U.S. National Science Foundation had recognised the importance of broader social engagement and outreach.

- IP 36 *Italy's Antarctic Outreach at 40: Launching Connections with Italian Schools Abroad* (Italy), which highlighted education and outreach initiatives developed in the context of the 40th anniversary of Italy's Antarctic programme, including exhibitions, school engagement and international cooperation activities. The paper noted that the celebration of the 40th anniversary of Italy's first Antarctic expedition under the National Program of Research in Antarctica (PNRA) had driven a wide range of new initiatives engaging schools, students and the general public.
- IP 41 *New Developments in China's Polar Science Popularization Campaign in 2025* (China), which reported on a range of public engagement and science communication activities, including exhibitions, outreach programmes, open days and international exchange initiatives. Building on the ongoing commemoration of the 40th anniversary of China's polar expeditions, the 2025 campaign had featured targeted activities, including the "From the Mountaintop to the Ocean" Science and Technology Achievements Touring Exhibition, which showcased a scale model of the icebreaker Xue Long 2 and Antarctic meteorite samples.
- IP 50 *Workshop on Education – Leading Antarctic Education & Outreach: A COMNAP update on activities facilitated by National Antarctic Programs* (COMNAP), which provided an update on education and outreach activities across national Antarctic programmes and highlighted their role in promoting public awareness and international collaboration. The paper recalled that COMNAP had presented IP 9 at the First Workshop on Education and Outreach at ATCM XXXVIII (2015) and provided an updated overview of Member national Antarctic programmes' education and outreach facilities and activities.
- IP 69 *Workshop on Education – Education and Outreach Activities of Türkiye in Polar Research (2025-2026)* (Türkiye), which outlined Türkiye's national education and outreach programmes, including competitions, festivals and media engagement activities aimed at raising awareness of polar science and climate change. The paper aimed to enhance awareness of polar regions, promote inclusivity and strengthen communication on climate change through structured national programmes and broad public engagement.
- IP 70 *Overview of polar education and outreach activities carried out or supported by Germany* (Germany), which described a range of initiatives by German institutions, including educational programmes, exhibitions and media campaigns to promote awareness of polar research and environmental protection. The paper outlined activities supported by various German Federal Agencies and Institutions, including the German Environment Agency, across schools, museums and broader public engagement.
- IP 74 *Workshop on Education – Enhancing Polar Engagement: the Role of APECS-Brazil in Education, Outreach, and Early Career Capacity Building* (Brazil), which highlighted education and outreach initiatives led by early-career researchers, including activities aimed at science communication, public engagement and capacity building. The paper presented data on participation, digital engagement and reach, and emphasised the role of the Association of Polar Early Career Scientists (APECS) Brazil in translating Antarctic science into accessible and inclusive formats for diverse audiences.
- IP 79 *Australian Antarctic education, outreach and public engagement* (Australia), which outlined a broad range of activities and initiatives that Australia had implemented, including digital tools and platforms, educational resources, media engagement and programmes, arts fellowships, and partnerships with universities and organisations. The paper highlighted Australia's experience with

connecting national and international audiences to Antarctica, to enhance public understanding of Antarctica and the Antarctic Treaty System, and demonstrate Australia's long-standing commitment to enhancing transparency, supporting science communication and promoting environmental stewardship of the Antarctic region.

- IP 82 *Workshop on Education – Antarctica day as a platform to convey ATCM messages: insights from Malaysia* (Malaysia), which described the use of Antarctica Day as a platform for public engagement, including educational programmes, environmental initiatives and international collaboration activities. The paper presented Malaysia's experience in leveraging Antarctica Day to convey key ATCM messages to the public.
- IP 86 rev. 1 *Education Workshop: Possible options after the conclusion of the Intersessional Contact Group on Education and Outreach* (Spain, Belgium, Brazil, Bulgaria and Portugal), which outlined options for maintaining the exchange of education and outreach information within the Antarctic Treaty System following the conclusion of the ICG. The paper, related to IP 93 rev. 1, presented two options to ensure the continued exchange of education and outreach initiatives among Parties, Observers and Experts within the ATCM forum.
- IP 93 rev. 1 *Education Workshop. Education and Outreach: Two ways to contribute to knowledge about Antarctica* (Spain), outlined the distinction between education and outreach activities and provided guidance to support the development and coordination of such initiatives. The paper, related to IP 86 rev. 1, was intended to assist the ATCM in identifying an appropriate framework through which Parties, Observers and Experts could share their respective initiatives.
- IP 105 *Workshop on Education – Education and Outreach activities from Brazil* (Brazil), which provided an overview of national initiatives, including school engagement, science events, audiovisual activities and programmes aimed at strengthening the connection between Antarctic science and society. The paper described initiatives conducted under the Brazilian Antarctic Programme (PROANTAR).
- IP 107 *Workshop on education: Update on ongoing Education and Outreach projects undertaken by France* (France), which described a wide range of educational programmes, exhibitions, conferences and outreach initiatives aimed at raising awareness of polar issues and climate change. The paper provided an overview of France's activities in education and outreach over recent years.
- IP 116 *Summary of reports of the Intersessional Contact Group on Education and Outreach (2016-2026)* (Bulgaria, Australia, Belgium, Brazil, Chile, the Czech Republic, Ecuador, Finland, France, Germany, India, Italy, the Republic of Korea, Poland, Spain, the United Kingdom, Belarus, Canada, Colombia, Estonia, Malaysia, Portugal, Romania, Türkiye, Venezuela, COMNAP, SCAR, ASOC, IAATO and WMO), which provided an overview of the work of the Intersessional Contact Group on Education and Outreach from 2016 to 2025 and highlighted its role in facilitating information sharing among Parties, Observers and Experts. The paper reported that, between 2016 and 2026, a total of nine reports were delivered, authored by 29 Parties, Observers and Experts, with 294 posts and over 6,100 views in the ATCM Forum from 38 Parties, Observers and Experts.
- IP 129 *Workshop on Education – Education and Outreach Activities carried out by the Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research (SCAR)*, which presented an update on outreach activities, including the Antarctic Environments Portal, training initiatives and preparations for the IPY-5. The paper recalled that the

SCAR Strategic Plan 2023-2028 set the objective of increasing public awareness and understanding of Antarctic issues, and noted that SCAR's extensive Education and Outreach programme aligned closely with the ICG on Education and Outreach.

- IP 131 *Workshop on Education – From Antarctic fieldwork to public engagement: lessons learned from outreach activities conducted within a Polish Antarctic research project* (Poland), which described education and outreach activities linked to field research, including social media communication, school engagement and public events. The activities had been conducted within the framework of the Destruction Bay initiative under the Antarctic Project Supported by ORLEN (APSO), demonstrating how small field teams could contribute to broader awareness of Antarctic environmental protection.
- IP 132 *Workshop on Education – Estonia's Antarctic Education and Outreach Activities* (Estonia), which outlined initiatives including exhibitions, symposia and cross-media events aimed at raising awareness of Antarctic research and environmental protection. The activities included film screenings, scientific symposia and live broadcasts from Antarctica, implemented through international collaboration with polar institutions from other Parties.
- IP 133 *Workshop on Education – Portugal's Antarctic Education and Outreach Activities: an update* (Portugal), which provided an overview of Portugal's national and international initiatives, including educational programmes, workshops and collaborations aimed at promoting Antarctic awareness and engagement. The paper covered activities undertaken since the last Workshop on Education and Outreach in 2015 and involved various national organisations, including the APECS, Polar Educators International (PEI) and the Portuguese Polar Program (PROPOLAR).
- IP 134 *Apoyo a la conciencia educativa y conocimiento para el cuidado y desarrollo sostenible de la actividad antártica* (Chile) which presented various instances through which the Chilean Air Force supported higher education academic initiatives, in line with the guidelines and orientations for the development of Antarctic activities. These initiatives mainly corresponded to university theses developed across different professional fields, which contributed to strengthening knowledge, protecting the Antarctic environment, and improving resource management. The initiatives helped foster greater collective awareness of the importance of Antarctica.
- IP 135 *Ukrainian Antarctic Program: Education and Outreach (2024–2025)* (Ukraine), which outlined a communication strategy combining digital platforms, educational activities and public engagement to promote awareness of Antarctic science and environmental protection. The paper described a multimodal approach implemented during 2024/25 to enhance public awareness of Antarctic environmental protection and scientific research within Ukraine's Antarctic programme.
- IP 136 *Workshop on Education – Antarctic Education and Outreach Activities of the Japanese Antarctic Research Expedition* (Japan), which described a range of initiatives including teacher programmes, live broadcasts, museum activities and student participation in Antarctic research. The Japanese Antarctic Research Expedition (JARE) had carried out the activities in collaboration with the National Institute of Polar Research, the Ministry of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology, the Ministry of the Environment and other ministries.
- IP 137 *Workshop on Education – Bulgarian Education and Outreach Activities in the Past Decade* (Bulgaria), which described a broad range of Bulgarian national

education and outreach activities over the past decade, including exhibitions, lectures, publications and media initiatives aimed at promoting awareness of Antarctic science and international cooperation. The paper covered activities since the First Workshop on Education and Outreach held in Sofia during ATCM XXXVIII, reflecting Bulgaria's sustainable and diverse national approach to promoting awareness of Antarctica.

- IP 138 *Workshop on Education - Bridging Science and Society: Colombian Education and Outreach Initiatives and Early Reflections* (Colombia), which presented national initiatives aimed at strengthening links between science and society, including workshops, digital platforms and public engagement activities. The paper presented initiatives implemented under the Colombian Antarctic Program (PAC) during the 2025/26 period and contributed to discussions under the second Workshop on Education and Outreach and Priority 2 of the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan.
- IP 139 *Workshop on Education – Colombian Project of Art in Antarctica. An Artistic Perspective on the White Continent 2024-2025* (Colombia), which highlighted Colombian artistic initiatives and exhibitions that communicated Antarctic issues and environmental awareness through cultural and creative approaches. The paper described projects and initiatives of the Colombian Antarctic Art Program (PCAA) during the 2024/25 period, contributing to the second Workshop on Education and Outreach and to Priority 2 of the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan.
- IP 140 *Resultado de encuesta sobre percepción pública de la Antártica en las ciudades de Punta Arenas y Puerto Williams* (Chile), which presented the results of a probabilistic survey conducted by the Chilean Antarctic Institute in Punta Arenas and Puerto Williams. The study aimed to understand local residents' perceptions of scientific research, identity, and connection to Antarctica.
- IP 141 *Avances de la Coalición de Jóvenes Antárticos (Punta Arenas, Chile)* (Chile). It presented the Antarctic Youth Coalition Foundation, a non-profit organisation that originated within the framework of the Antarctic Cities project and connected universities in Christchurch, Hobart, Ushuaia, Cape Town, and Punta Arenas.
- IP 142 *Nuevo material educativo y publicaciones antárticas* (Chile). It showcased new Chilean books and educational materials on Antarctica, inviting Parties and other actors to consider the possibility of developing joint editions.
- IP 144 *Workshop on Education – UK polar education: from learning to outreach* (United Kingdom), which presented national approaches to polar education and outreach, including initiatives aimed at strengthening learning and public engagement. The paper accompanied a presentation given at the second Workshop on Education and Outreach at ATCM 48.
- IP 145 *Workshop on Education – Outreach and Education: The Oceanic and Antarctic Route from Venezuela to Antarctica, a Glimpse at Planet Preservation* (Venezuela), which outlined a set of initiatives aimed at strengthening education, scientific outreach, and public awareness of the importance of the Antarctic continent and the oceans. These initiatives were promoted by the Centre for Oceanology and Antarctic Studies (COEA) of the Venezuelan Institute for Scientific Research (IVIC) and the Ministry of People's Power for Science and Technology.
- IP 184 *Difusión de la Temática Antártica* (Peru), which reported on the dissemination of Antarctic-related topics related to the scientific, historical and

natural significance of Antarctica. Peru demonstrated this commitment through initiatives such as the photographic exhibition “Peru in Antarctica” and participation in university fairs and conferences.

- IP 193 *Highlights of Education and Outreach activities about Antarctic research and governance by Belgian scientists* (Belgium), which outlined a range of outreach activities led by Belgian scientists, including public engagement initiatives, digital communication and educational programmes aimed at promoting awareness of Antarctic research and governance. The paper reviewed ten years of education and outreach activities by Belgian scientists, including those linked to the anniversaries of the Belgica expedition (1897–99) and to APECS Belgium’s support for early-career polar scientists.
- IP 197 *Workshop on Education – IAATO Education, Outreach and Ambassadorship – Strategic Overview* (IAATO), which provided an overview of IAATO’s education, outreach and Antarctic Ambassadorship initiatives, including the introduction of phase 2 of the Antarctic Ambassador Program. Phase 2 had been trialed during the 2025/26 season and shifted the programme from awareness-raising to capability building, with strategic priorities focused on action-oriented engagement and sustained community involvement.

(281) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 5 *Workshop on Education – Finland’s contribution to education and outreach* (Finland).
- BP 8 *Actividades de educación y divulgación antártica de la República Bolivariana de Venezuela* (Venezuela).
- BP 27 *Association of Polar Early Career Scientists (APECS) Portugal: relevance of workshops for young scientists* (Portugal, Belgium, Finland, Romania, Türkiye, WMO).
- BP 28 *Polar Educators International (PEI) Portugal: educational activities boosting Antarctic science* (Portugal, India).
- BP 29 *Workshop on Education - Antarctic gigantism in education: example of the Colossal squid* (Portugal, India).
- BP 33 *Education & Outreach Activities of Malaysia in 2025* (Malaysia).
- BP 40 *Overview of Education and Outreach Activities in the Russian Federation in 2025–2026. Second Workshop on Education and Outreach* (Russian Federation).
- BP 45 *An Inclusive Symposium Model for Strengthening Antarctic Research Capacity: Lessons from South Africa’s SANAP Principal Investigator Symposium* (South Africa).
- BP 80 *Antártida Inmersiva: Innovación tecnológica que fortalece la participación y difusión antártica ecuatoriana* (Ecuador).
- BP 83 *Workshop on Education: Romanian Antarctic Education and Outreach activities 2015-2025* (Romania).
- BP 85 *Report of the ATCM 48 Workshop on Education and Outreach* (Japan, Belgium, Brazil, Bulgaria, Chile, Portugal, Spain, United Kingdom).

Item 12a: Multi-year Strategic Work Plan: Policy, Legal and Institutional Priorities

- (282) The Meeting considered the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan (MYSWP) adopted at ATCM 47 (Decision 7 (2025)) and agreed to update Priority 2 to reflect references to the newly established education and outreach forum. No other changes to the MYSWP were proposed.
- (283) The United States proposed that future updates to the MYSWP follow a process like that used for the CEP Five-year Work Plan, where updates would be agreed by the Meeting and reflected on the ATS website, rather than being formally adopted through a Decision. The United States noted that this approach could provide greater flexibility and efficiency in updating the MYSWP.
- (284) The Meeting supported the proposal and, to implement the proposal, adopted Decision 5 (2026) *Multi-year Strategic Work Plan for the Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting*.

Item 12b: Multi-year Strategic Work Plan: Science, Operations and Tourism priorities

- (285) The Meeting considered the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan adopted at ATCM 47 (Decision 7 (2025)) relating to science, operations and tourism priorities. It considered how to advance each priority item in the coming years and whether to eliminate current priorities and introduce new ones.
- (286) The Meeting decided to merge Priorities 8 and 9 of the MYSWP, which covered hydrographic surveys and the implementation of the Polar Code, into a single, overarching priority focused on maritime safety.

Item 13: Safety and Operations in Antarctica

Biosecurity Issues

- (287) Chile introduced WP 53 *Surveillance of the highly pathogenic avian influenza virus (H5N1) in Antarctica: an initiative by the National Antarctic Science Programme*, which presented the results of monitoring of the highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI) during the 2025/26 campaign. The report confirmed the persistent presence of the virus in the Antarctic Peninsula and South Shetland Islands in skuas and Antarctic fur seals, verified through real-time molecular diagnosis of extensive biological and environmental samples. To address this, Chile recommended promoting long-term population studies on susceptible species – such as skuas, elephant seals, and Antarctic fur seals, following best practices and the experience of other efforts such as those from SCAR and COMNAP – while emphasising the need for streamlined communication between research groups to ensure the effective exchange of results and to avoid the duplication of efforts.
- (288) The Meeting acknowledged the informative update on the state of HPAI in the Antarctic Peninsula and nearby areas.
- (289) China presented IP 39 *China's Continued Surveillance of Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza (HPAI) during the 42nd CHINARE (2025/26)*, reporting that surveillance in ASPA 150 during the 2025/26 austral summer had found no evidence of HPAI circulation. China noted that it continued to enhance its genomic testing capacity and monitoring coverage, and to share results and findings with all Parties through COMNAP, SCAR, the ATCM and the CEP.

- (290) Ecuador presented IP 178 *Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza (H5N1) in Antarctica: Contributions from Ecuador and Implications for Biosecurity*. Ecuador reported preliminary results from its first HPAI surveillance activity in the South Shetland Islands in February 2026, with support from a United States university. Ecuador reported no observed clinical symptoms or mass mortality events and indicated that ongoing monitoring would be strengthened through enhanced communication channels.
- (291) COMNAP presented IP 4 *High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (HPAI) in the Antarctic Treaty Area: COMNAP update*, which provided updates on the national Antarctic programmes' vigilance, monitoring, sampling and testing in response to HPAI during the 2024/25 and 2025/26 seasons, therefore updating the previous information provided in ATCM 47 - IP 44. COMNAP reported that it continued to advocate for monitoring and research on the situation, forwarding all HPAI reports, positive or negative, to SCAR's Antarctic Wildlife Health Network (AWHN) and other relevant tools. COMNAP also noted its continued participation in diverse HPAI groups and forums and its ongoing work on training, risk management guidelines and biosecurity protocols.
- (292) SCAR presented IP 103 *Lessons Learnt from Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza (HPAI) for Wildlife Health in Antarctica and the Southern Ocean*. SCAR reported that research had confirmed multiple introductions of HPAI H5N1 into the Antarctic and sub-Antarctic system since the 2023/24 season. SCAR encouraged national Antarctic programmes and others to continue submitting reports to its online database, including negative results, and to encourage independent researchers to share results promptly rather than after publication. SCAR announced that its Antarctic Wildlife Health Network would meet in the margins of the upcoming SCAR Open Science Conference and all were welcome. SCAR would be updating its biological risk assessment and recommendations in August 2026.
- (293) IAATO reported that, during the 2025/26 season, there had been 27 reports of concern. The reports had been assessed by SCAR and other experts, and had led to the precautionary closure of one site in Marguerite Bay. It also highlighted its continued collaboration with CCAMLR, COMNAP and SCAR to keep response protocols current and ensure findings were quickly shared with all stakeholders. IAATO also confirmed that its operators would continue supporting HPAI research, noting that long-term wildlife monitoring benefited both science and visitor education, while increasing safety for wildlife and humans in Antarctic operations.
- (294) The Meeting acknowledged that the papers illustrated the ongoing scientific and operational cooperation among Parties in monitoring and responding to HPAI. Parties specifically commended COMNAP and SCAR for their invaluable role in enabling coordinated responses and ensuring the effective dissemination of accurate research findings and best practices among all Antarctic operators.
- (295) The Meeting took note of the CEP 28 conclusions on HPAI matters, that emphasised the importance of sustained coordinated monitoring of HPAI across national Antarctic programmes and ongoing sharing of information. The Meeting observed that the third consecutive year of confirmed virus presence in the region underscored the need for continued vigilance and the importance of considering broader biosecurity implications including risks to human health and pollution from biosecurity materials. The Meeting encouraged the ongoing use of SCAR and COMNAP reporting mechanisms, protocols and guidelines, and promoting the effective communication of findings recorded in the field, so all those operating in the area could take appropriate precautions.

- (296) COMNAP introduced WP 2 *COMNAP Antarctic Search and Rescue (SAR) Workshop 6 (2026)*, sharing information on the sixth Antarctic Search and Rescue (SAR) Workshop to be held in Tromsø, Norway, in August 2026, hosted by the Norwegian Polar Institute. Noting the importance of SAR coordination and response in the Antarctic Treaty area and mindful of Resolution 4 (2013), COMNAP invited wide participation in these community SAR Workshops, and recommended that Parties support their national delegates to participate in the COMNAP Antarctic SAR Workshop 6.
- (297) The Meeting recognised that search and rescue operations played a vital role in the Antarctic Treaty area, acknowledged the efforts made by COMNAP and Norway in convening the SAR workshop, and supported the recommendation in WP 2. The Meeting encouraged Parties to continue developing the safety and efficiency of search and rescue operations.
- (298) Germany presented IP 44 *Cargo loss at the German Neumayer Station III*, which reported the loss of cargo from the Neumayer Station III ice port (Dronning Maud Land, north-eastern Weddell Sea) during a heavy storm in January 2026. An iceberg approximately 500 by 300 metres had broken off the Ekström ice shelf, carrying seven containers on top, including a fuel container. Germany had tried to retrieve the containers with *RV Polarstern*, but the precarious and unstable condition of the iceberg had made it too dangerous and impossible for the vessel to go alongside the iceberg. Germany reported that only about 1 tonne of materials and equipment could be lifted off by helicopter. Germany reported it had revised the risk assessment for the supply of Neumayer Station III. Germany noted that it and the Alfred Wegener Institute deeply regretted the incident and were relieved that no one was injured during the calving of the iceberg and the subsequent recovery attempts. It was hoped the information could be useful to other Parties with freight operations on ice shelves.
- (299) The Meeting thanked Germany for its transparency and noted the impact of changes in the region.
- (300) New Zealand presented IP 7 *Safety Risks at Cape Evans and Cape Royds, Ross Island*, which reported on potential explosive hazards in Scott's Hut at Cape Evans and Shackleton's Hut at Cape Royds, including the possible presence of picric acid crystals and peroxide crystals. New Zealand reported that temporary barriers and signage had been installed in both huts to minimise the risk of disturbance, and that further assessment and disposal work was planned for the 2026/27 season, subject to sea-ice conditions.
- (301) ASOC presented IP 155 *Vessel safety and environmental protection pertinent to the Southern Ocean*, which provided updates and recommendations on safety and environmental protection in the Antarctic Treaty area, including the harmonised implementation of the Polar Code, greywater discharges from ships, underwater noise, marine plastic litter, and Particularly Sensitive Sea Areas. ASOC spotlighted the review of the Polar Operational Limit Assessment Risk Indexing System (POLARIS) and encouraged Parties to strengthen environmental protections in coordination with the IMO and other relevant bodies.
- (302) IHO presented IP 18 *Report by the International Hydrographic Organization (IHO)*, which provided an overview of Antarctic hydrographic matters, including the impact of climate change and the implementation of the IMO Polar Code. Primarily active in polar regions through the IHO Hydrographic Commission on Antarctica (HCA) and the Arctic Regional Hydrographic Commission (ARHC), the IHO highlighted its ongoing activities and new data services. Notably, IHO drew attention to the IMO's approval to introduce, effective 1 January 2026, onboard navigation devices compliant with the IHO Universal

Hydrographic Data Model (S-100), which would improve surface navigation data. Once these S-100 data services became fully operational in the polar regions, anticipated in 2029, the IHO intended to submit corresponding amendments to the Polar Code. Additionally, the IHO continued to collaborate to improve regional bathymetric charts, such as the International Bathymetric Chart of the Southern Ocean (IBCSO). IHO noted its ongoing cooperation with the Antarctic Treaty System and requested that Parties identify how it could support their work, making several suggestions on what that could entail. Furthermore, IHO offered data to assist with the mapping of marine protected areas under the *Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction Agreement* (BBNJ).

- (303) The Meeting emphasised the importance of precise, up-to-date nautical charts for safe navigation in Antarctic waters, as well as the scientific significance of bathymetric mapping. Many Parties, Observers and Experts highlighted their own activities to improve hydrographic data. The Meeting underlined the importance of a broad exchange of information among all Parties, organisations and operators to produce high-accuracy maps of Antarctic waters.
- (304) In response to a question from the Russian Federation on its data sources, the IHO explained that it used a multitude of sources, including data from national hydrographic offices and vessels in transit. The compiled data sets were open-source and updated annually. The Russian Federation also requested clarification on how the potential amendments to the Polar Code would apply to both polar regions, given that discussion of such amendments had, until then, focused on the Arctic. The IHO replied that it offered enhanced technical tools but could not determine which polar region any amendments to the Polar Code should affect.
- (305) In response to an IHO request for advice on which activities to prioritise, several Parties suggested that the IHO should focus on matters within the remit of the Antarctic Treaty System, which was the competent authority for Antarctica.

Normative issues

- (306) The Russian Federation presented IP 20 *National Inspection of Russian Antarctic Operators*, which provided a comprehensive description of the goals and objectives of national inspection regulations in the context of tour operators and other non-governmental activities. The Russian Federation noted that legislation was drafted in accordance with the obligations set out in Article 13 of the Environmental Protocol and that its implementation was carried out with an ambitious approach that often exceeded the existing requirements, in particular established within the Antarctic Treaty System. The Russian Federation outlined its operational inspection methodology and national regulatory practice for ensuring compliance with the Environmental Protocol. It concluded that the exchange of information between Parties on such inspection and compliance mechanisms would facilitate the development of uniform approaches that would allow to avoid significant differences in the requirements of different Parties to the Protocol and discourage the practice of forum shopping.
- (307) France presented IP 28 *Regulation by the competent French national authority of the use of remotely piloted aircraft systems (RPAS) in the Antarctic Treaty area*, which outlined France's regulatory framework for such systems in Antarctica. The paper aligned with Resolution 4 (2018) Environmental Guidelines for the Operation of RPAS in Antarctica and built on the previous ATCM XLIV - WP 14. France pointed out that, while the recreational use of RPAS was prohibited, their use was permitted for safety and surveillance, scientific purposes, and communication. Furthermore, it imposed category-specific regulations in addition to those required by Resolution 4 (2018). France

concluded by encouraging Parties to exchange information on this topic to actively improve the regulation of RPAS use in Antarctica.

- (308) Several Parties commented that they also prohibited the recreational use of RPAS in Antarctica and that their national competent authorities used the guidelines contained in Resolution 4 (2018) when permitting such use. IAATO noted that, in addition to adhering to relevant national legislation and Resolution 4 (2018), its operators also prohibited the use of recreational RPAS in coastal areas. COMNAP drew the Meeting's attention to its RPAS Operator's Handbook, and SCAR offered to provide scientific input to assist in guideline development.
- (309) The Meeting noted the discussions at the CEP regarding the use of RPAS, and encouraged the ongoing sharing of experiences and best practices, including through the participation of Parties in a workshop on this topic at the upcoming SCAR Open Science Conference and through the Competent Authorities Discussion Forum.

National Antarctic Programmes: Infrastructure and Operational Updates and Proposals

- (310) Peru presented IP 190 *Instalación de cámara web en la ECAMP para transmitir condiciones meteorológicas en Windy y Meteoblue*, which described the installation of a high-resolution web camera at the Machu Picchu base by the Directorate of Aeronautical and Space Meteorology (DIRMA) and the Peruvian Air Force. The web camera enabled real-time transmission of weather conditions and climate data via the Windy and Meteoblue platforms, providing the scientific community and the public with up-to-date information on weather patterns in the vicinity of the station.
- (311) Peru presented IP 186 *Fortalecimiento de las capacidades en el marco de la Trigésimo Segunda Expedición Científica del Perú a la Antártida*, which reported on a month-long specialised training workshop designed to prepare its Antarctic expedition team members. Organised through interagency cooperation between the military and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the programme aimed to strengthen Peru's national Antarctic capabilities by equipping participants with the essential technical, operational, and safety skills required to conduct scientific activities in Antarctica.
- (312) Colombia presented IP 52 *Colombia as a Full Member of COMNAP: Projections to Strengthen National Participation*, which highlighted Colombia's contributions to safety in scientific and related Antarctic activities following its acceptance as a full member of COMNAP. Colombia looked forward to strengthening its participation in line with COMNAP's Antarctic Roadmap Challenges.
- (313) Chile presented IP 173 *Base "Profesor Julio Escudero": una nueva base científica permanente de Chile*. Chile noted that the Professor Julio Escudero research station had transitioned from seasonal to year-round operation in March 2025, becoming Chile's fourth permanent base in Antarctica. Chile reported that the station was managed by Chile's first female base manager, and that its first winter research season focused on atmospheric and rainfall measurements.
- (314) ASOC presented IP 157 *Practical solutions to marine microplastic pollution*, which outlined practical steps and emerging technologies to address marine microplastic pollution from laundry water and antifouling coatings. ASOC encouraged Parties to apply a precautionary approach and to engage with the IMO in its work to control biofouling, and other instruments that may be useful in future contexts.
- (315) The following paper was also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:

- IP 154 *Polar Coupled Analysis and Prediction for Services (PCAPS)* (WMO), which outlined the joint WMO-World Weather Research Programme initiative supporting human safety, operational effectiveness and environmental protection through enhanced Antarctic forecasting. It focused on the growing importance of *in-situ* observations in an era of AI-driven prediction and invited Parties to consider supporting open data policies and coordinated observing infrastructure that would benefit both research and operations.

(316) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 4 *Next-Generation Icebreaking Research Vessel of the Republic of Korea* (Republic of Korea).
- BP 18 *Development of a Research Boat for Turkish Antarctic Operations* (Türkiye).
- BP 20 *The Tenth Turkish Antarctic Expedition (TAE-X)* (Türkiye).
- BP 21 *Pre-Expedition Training Programme of Turkish Antarctic Expeditions* (Türkiye).
- BP 30 *XII Colombian Antarctic Expedition* (Colombia).
- BP 31 *Brazilian Antarctic Program (PROANTAR): activities conducted during OPERANTAR XLIV (2025–2026)* (Brazil).
- BP 35 *On the Progress of Construction of the New Research Expedition Vessel “Ivan Frolov”, 2025–2026* (Russian Federation).
- BP 41 *Action Plan and Parameters for the Russian Antarctic Expedition Activities in 2026–2028* (Russian Federation).
- BP 44 *Recognition of logistical and medical assistance provided by National Antarctic Programs to the Polish Antarctic Program during the 2025/2026 austral summer season* (Poland).
- BP 47 *Capacidades de la Fuerza Aérea de Chile en apoyo a la ciencia en Glaciar Unión* (Chile).
- BP 48 *Mejoramiento de la infraestructura antártica (Villa Las Estrellas y Glaciar Unión)* (Chile).
- BP 49 *Informe del Instituto Geográfico Militar - Campañas Geodésicas en la Antártica* (Chile).
- BP 50 *Actividades Hidro-Oceanográficas en el territorio antártico. Periodo (2024-2026)* (Chile).
- BP 51 *Informe del Instituto Geográfico Militar - Procedimiento para la Confección de la Cartografía antártica* (Chile).
- BP 52 *Report on Argentina’s Autonomous IoT-based situational awareness deployment in Antarctica using INVAP’s “Aleph” platform* (Argentina).
- BP 63 *Capacidades aeronavales de Colombia en apoyo logístico y operacional a Programas Antárticos durante la XII EAC* (Colombia).
- BP 65 *Investigación científica para la seguridad marítima en la Antártica* (Colombia).
- BP 68 *Ejecución de la XXIX Expedición Antártica Ecuatoriana (2025-2026)* (Ecuador).

- BP 71 *Evaluación de la degradación por corrosión en la infraestructura metálica de la Estación Científica Pedro Vicente Maldonado* (Ecuador).
- BP 75 *Efecto del medioambiente antártico sobre la salud bucal y nutricional en la expedición ANTAR XXXI* (Peru).
- BP 78 *Infraestructura segura y sostenible con el proyecto de inversión pública para el mejoramiento de la Estación Científica Antártica Machu Picchu (ECAMP)* (Peru).

Item 14: Inspections under the Antarctic Treaty and Environment Protocol

- (317) The United States presented IP 17 *United States Antarctic Inspection, January 2026*, reporting on inspections conducted in and near the Larsemann Hills area of East Antarctica, pursuant to Article VII of the Antarctic Treaty and Article 14 of the Environmental Protocol. The inspections covered Davis Station (Australia), Law Base field camp (Australia), Zhongshan Station (China), Bharati Station (India), Progress Station (Russian Federation), ASMA 6 Larsemann Hills, East Antarctica, and ASPA 143 Marine Plain, Mule Peninsula, Vestfold Hills, Princess Elizabeth Land. The United States highlighted the area's importance as a logistical hub for several Parties due to its relative accessibility and commended its national Antarctic programmes for its active and reciprocal cooperation. Furthermore, the United States observed that the inspected facilities faced similar challenges, including wastewater management, fuel storage, and the timely removal of waste from the Antarctic Treaty area. In addition to thanking the inspected Parties for their warm hospitality and cooperation, the United States reiterated the fundamental importance of inspections for the Antarctic Treaty System in encouraging transparency and treaty compliance, particularly with Article I obligations. The United States encouraged all Parties to increase their Treaty inspection activity.
- (318) Australia welcomed the inspection report, noting that it regarded inspections as a fundamental component of the Antarctic Treaty System, including to verify compliance with the Treaty and Environmental Protocol, support cooperation, and identify best practice. Australia was pleased to contribute logistics support to the United States inspection team for its activities in the region. Australia welcomed the inspection of Davis Station, Law Base and ASPA 143 and welcomed the inspection team's recommendations. Australia noted that its management of fuel storage was in accordance with Standard Operating Procedures, and the recommendations would be valuable input to their review. Australia noted that the emergency powerhouse referred to in the inspection report remained in use pending replacement and would be removed following decommissioning. Australia also welcomed the comments of the United States on the cooperative arrangements in the Larsemann Hills, which were useful in the context of the review of the ASMA 6 management plan currently underway.
- (319) Many Parties thanked the United States for its effort, noting the importance of inspections and that they were a significant undertaking. The Meeting acknowledged the comprehensive inspection report and discussed its key findings. The inspected Parties expressed their appreciation for the inspection process, including the continuing dialogue during the drafting of the inspection report. They welcomed the findings and noted their utility for continuing efforts to improve Antarctic facilities and operations. The Meeting underscored the importance of inspections in supporting transparency and noted the strong cooperation observed in the Antarctic, demonstrating the strength of the Antarctic Treaty System. Noting the common themes in the findings related to waste and fuel, some Parties suggested that the findings be shared with the CEP in light of its work on

these topics, while others observed that the report would help them plan their forthcoming inspections.

- (320) IAATO stressed the benefit of inspections and their ability to highlight best practices to be shared amongst all Antarctic operators. IAATO confirmed the continued availability of their operators to cooperate with future inspections.
- (321) COMNAP addressed the practical usefulness of inspection reports and their findings regarding national Antarctic programme operations and noted that the recommendations related to waste management and fuel handling would be discussed within COMNAP.
- (322) The Meeting emphasised the fundamental role of continued inspections in the Antarctic Treaty System.
- (323) The following paper was also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:
 - IP 78 *Formulation of the Antarctic Inspection Protocol (PIAs) for Colombia* (Colombia), which presented the efforts made to develop a consistent protocol ensuring the effective conduct of Antarctic Treaty inspections, drawing on international precedents, the provisions of the Antarctic Treaty and the Environmental Protocol, and Decision 2 (2017). Colombia reported that, since the end of 2025, progress had been made with the aim of formalising procedures aligned with its obligations under Article VII of the Antarctic Treaty and Article 14 of the Protocol on Environmental Protection.

Item 15: Science Issues, Future Science Challenges, Scientific Cooperation and Facilitation

Scientific cooperation and facilitation

- (324) The Secretariat presented SP 11 rev. 2 *Results of a Survey About Antarctic Data Management*, which reported the results of a survey originally proposed by Spain at ATCM 47 on Antarctic data management by different Parties. The paper collated anonymous responses from Parties concerning the operation of their national data centres and existing protocols, in accordance with Article III (1)(c) of the Antarctic Treaty and Resolution 4 (1998).
- (325) Spain introduced WP 13 rev. 2 *Digital repositories as a key tool for promoting the exchange of scientific data on Antarctica*, highlighting the need for digital repositories to enable the exchange of Antarctic scientific information under Article III (1)(c) of the Antarctic Treaty. Referring to SP 11 rev. 2, Spain noted that 75.8 per cent of Consultative Parties had responded to the Secretariat's survey on Antarctic data management, which showed that 33.3 per cent of respondents (seven Consultative Parties) lacked national Antarctic data repositories, while only one non-Consultative Party answered. Spain recommended that the ATCM adopt a Resolution on the establishment of national digital repositories of Antarctic data and metadata that would promote the long-term preservation of scientific information; encourage the adoption of international standards for data and metadata management to ensure interoperability between national repositories and international Antarctic information systems; and support open access to scientific data on Antarctica, in accordance with the principles regarding the free exchange of scientific information established by Article III of the Antarctic Treaty. Spain offered to provide advice through its National Polar Data Centre, to Parties requesting assistance in establishing such digital repositories.
- (326) Many Parties underscored the importance of data for understanding changes to the Antarctic environment, for improving climate forecasting and for informing decision-

making, and recalled their obligations under Article III of the Antarctic Treaty to exchange scientific information.

- (327) Some Parties highlighted the need for flexibility to reflect differing national structures and capacities, and noted that sustainable data management could, in some cases, be achieved through broader national data centres rather than stand-alone Antarctic repositories. Parties also noted the importance of metadata integration, the value of technical assistance to narrow gaps in data management capacity, the need for data sharing to be consistent with applicable national laws, and the relevance of existing Antarctic Treaty System mechanisms for information exchange. Parties that had not responded to the Secretariat's survey were encouraged to provide this information at the next meeting.
- (328) SCAR noted that its Standing Committee on Antarctic Data Management (SCADM) facilitated co-operation between scientists and nations on scientific data, which included establishing Antarctic data management policies and priorities, and advising Parties seeking to establish national Antarctic data centres. Recognising the importance of national Antarctic data centres, SCAR highlighted that thematic repositories were also important and were often better equipped to support specific thematic, data standards. SCAR further highlighted the increasing importance of federated search tools, such as the Polar Data Search. SCAR encouraged Parties to apply FAIR (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable) and TRUST (Transparency, Responsibility, User focus, Sustainability and Technology) principles to their data management practices.
- (329) The Meeting adopted Resolution 5 (2026) *Establishment of National Digital Repositories*.
- (330) Germany presented IP 111 *Update 2026: International Science & Infrastructure for Synchronous Observation (Antarctica InSync)*, prepared jointly with Australia, Bulgaria, France, India, Italy, the Republic of Korea, New Zealand, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Sweden, Switzerland and the United Kingdom. Germany reported strong progress in Antarctica InSync's 2024-26 preparatory phase and summarised recent developments and opportunities for coordinated synchronous observations in the whole Antarctic Treaty area, including the interest in an InSync traverse across the East Antarctic plateau from Dronning Maud Land to Victoria Land. Germany reported on the development of the Science Plan and the formation of several National Committees that worked to align scientific priorities with policy needs and encouraged Parties to engage in Antarctica InSync through scientific or logistical contributions.
- (331) The Meeting highlighted the value of Antarctica InSync in integrating data across the coupled ice-ocean atmosphere-ecosystem system. Parties were encouraged to join Antarctica InSync, including by providing data. The Russian Federation observed that the paper had not been translated into the four official Treaty languages.
- (332) IAATO expressed its continued support for, and interest in contributing to, the Antarctica InSync project by both sharing data and offering its member operator vessels and other platforms for data collection.
- (333) Germany presented IP 112 *POLARIN: Access to Polar Research Infrastructures and Recent Project Developments*, prepared jointly with Bulgaria, France, Italy, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Sweden, Türkiye, Ukraine and the United Kingdom. Germany reported on the progress of the EU-funded five-year programme (March 2024 to February 2029), which had provided funded access to 64 polar research infrastructures and core repositories. Germany noted that POLARIN launched its second call for proposals in 2025, which had received a strong response of more than 100 proposals across

disciplines. Germany also reported in the paper that POLARIN had opened a data portal to promote open science and had implemented training activities for research infrastructure users.

- (334) India presented IP 109 *Multinational Logistical Collaboration Enabling RINGS Surveys in Dronning Maud Land and Enderby Land*, prepared jointly with Japan and Norway, which described the multinational logistical collaboration undertaken during the 45th Indian Scientific Expedition to Antarctica. India outlined a collaborative operation to support the Dronning Maud Land and Enderby Land RINGS surveys, an endorsed RINGS project that filled the largest region of Antarctic bed data that had not been surveyed.
- (335) The Meeting valued the strong cooperation in the multinational Enderby Land RINGS project. Several Parties expressed support for RINGS-endorsed projects, and welcomed the resulting data. Germany highlighted the contributions of the Alfred Wegener Institute and the German Federal Institute for Geosciences and Natural Resources, and Switzerland encouraged Parties to support RINGS-endorsed projects.
- (336) SCAR presented IP 168 *Update on Plans for a Fifth International Polar Year 2032-33*, jointly prepared with WMO, which provided an update on this major initiative (IPY-5). SCAR described progress made in the last year, such as the development of an overarching strategic vision and the establishment of five Task Groups to progress the planning process, including aspects like vision and priorities, indigenous leadership and involvement coordination; country and funders involvement; capacity building and early career coordination; and data coordination. SCAR highlighted the growing global collaboration among new IPY-5 National Committees, encouraged Parties to establish IPY-5 National Committees and to actively engage with and support the IPY-5 planning process.
- (337) The Meeting acknowledged the development of the strategic vision for the IPY-5. Reference was made to the legacy of the International Geophysical Year (1957-58), which had led to the negotiation and adoption of the Antarctic Treaty in 1959, demonstrating the value of international scientific cooperation. Some Parties also provided updates on their establishment of National IPY-5 Committees.
- (338) France presented IP 181 *French Polar Research Strategic Plan 2025-2035: an integrative and comprehensive scientific approach*, which outlined the French Polar Research Strategic Plan for the decade ahead, adopted in 2025 by the Centre National de la Recherche Scientifique (CNRS), in accordance with the French National Polar Strategy. France encouraged Parties to share strategic science priorities and to identify opportunities for cooperation.
- (339) Peru presented IP 185 *Fortalecimiento de la Cooperación Regional en Investigación Antártica*, which outlined the development of the PALEOANT project, a cooperative initiative between Peru and Uruguay designed to strengthen research networks in paleoceanographic reconstruction. Within this framework, and supported by the SCAR Visiting Scholar scheme, a training course was organised to provide early-career scientists with technical expertise in analysing marine sediment cores. Peru concluded that enhanced multidisciplinary research and stronger integration between national and international programmes were the most effective means of optimising resources and overcoming logistical and financial challenges.
- (340) Switzerland presented IP 191 *Swiss contribution to atmospheric and snow research in Antarctica - Update 2026*, which provided a brief update on the progress of ongoing Swiss research at Princess Elisabeth Station, East Antarctica. Switzerland also

introduced the recently launched Swiss Polar Institute Flagship Initiative ‘DOMINO’ and noted its coordinated collaboration with Antarctica InSync.

- (341) India presented IP 42 *Asian Forum for Polar Sciences (AFoPS) 2026: an update*, prepared jointly with China, Japan, the Republic of Korea, and Malaysia. India reported that AFoPS, now in its 20th year, was planning its next decade of work to foster scientific cooperation, build capacity and support joint expeditions among Asian member countries. It noted its Annual General Meeting in Goa, India in September 2025 and highlighted the upcoming September 2026 Annual General Meeting with India as Chair.
- (342) Colombia presented IP 53 *INVEMAR becomes a Collaborating Centre of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)*. Colombia described the work of its Marine and Coastal Research Institute (INVEMAR), an organisation partner of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), in using advanced scientific techniques to study microplastics and environmental changes in Antarctica. Colombia underscored the importance of regional cooperation and the use of shared scientific methods in protecting the Antarctic environment and supporting the Treaty's goals.
- (343) The following papers on scientific cooperation and facilitation issues were also submitted and taken as presented:
- IP 57 *Update of Colombia's Antarctic Scientific Agenda 2025–2035* (Colombia), which provided an update of Colombia's Antarctic Scientific Agenda for the 2025–2035 period. The paper outlined ten thematic research areas organised around two cross-cutting axes: global environmental change, and teleconnections between Antarctica and South America. It also set out the alignment of the Agenda with the MYSWP, identifying common scientific priorities to promote new opportunities for collaboration.
 - IP 90 *An Update on Antarctic RINGS* (Norway, the United Kingdom, COMNAP and SCAR), which described the progress of the Antarctic RINGS initiative during the 2025/26 season, updating previous reports submitted since 2022. The paper set out enhanced coordination between SCAR and COMNAP to survey the ice-sheet margin, the endorsement of several projects, and the designation of National Contact Points. It also reported on recent activities, including workshops on next-generation bed mapping and the development of new initiatives for the Antarctic Peninsula and Weddell Sea regions. The proponents invited Parties to engage with the initiative through SCAR and COMNAP.
 - IP 149 *Strengthening Cryosphere Observations and Data Systems* (WMO), which set out WMO's initiatives to strengthen and integrate cryosphere monitoring through the Global Cryosphere Watch (GCW), a mechanism coordinating observations and facilitating access to data, and the WIS 2.0 system, WMO's existing infrastructure, which ensured observations were discoverable and accessible. The paper described how these tools addressed global risks such as sea-level rise by ensuring data interoperability. WMO encouraged the free exchange of data in support of the fifth [International Polar Year](#) (2032–2033) and the International Decade of Cryospheric Sciences (2025–2034).
 - IP 151 *The Climate and Cryosphere (CliC) Project of the World Climate Research Programme (WCRP)* (WMO), which summarised recent Antarctic-related research and capacity-building activities undertaken under the Climate and Cryosphere (CliC) project in 2025. WCRP is co-sponsored by the WMO, the International Science Council (ISC) and the Intergovernmental Oceanographic Commission of UNESCO.

- IP 163 *Enhanced International Logistics and Scientific Cooperation of the Ukrainian Antarctic Program (2024–2026)* (Ukraine), which updated ATCM 47 - IP 132 on the development of international logistics and scientific cooperation within the Ukrainian Antarctic Program. The paper described the continued operation of the RV *Noosfera* as a shared logistics and research platform and outlined expanded cooperation with partner national Antarctic programmes during the 2024-2026 seasons, characterised by further diversification of partnerships and increased multinational participation in scientific activities.
- IP 165 *Concept Study on an International Antarctic Station: a Potential Pathway to Foster Cooperation* (Spain), which set out the results of a concept study on the potential added value of a jointly managed International Antarctic Station as a future model of cooperation. Drawing on the Antarctic Treaty's framework for peaceful international cooperation, scientific collaboration and environmental stewardship, the theoretical study examined whether such a facility could offer additional cooperative value and identified the conditions under which a station might be scientifically justified, operationally credible and institutionally workable.
- IP 182 *Coordination and Engagement of the Southern Ocean Community within the UN Ocean Decade* (SCAR), which updated information on SCAR's activities as host of the Decade Collaborative Centre for the Southern Ocean Region (DCC-SOR), supported by the Southern Ocean Task Force as its Advisory Board, since the release of the Southern Ocean Action Plan in April 2022. During 2025 and early 2026, work had focused on strengthening engagement with global initiatives and fostering connections among stakeholders and emerging projects, such as Antarctica InSync.

(344) The following papers on scientific cooperation and facilitation issues were also submitted:

- BP 16 *Establishment of the Turkish Polar Data Center* (Türkiye).
- BP 24 *Memorandum of Understanding between the Republic of Türkiye and the United Arab Emirates on Cooperation in Polar Research* (Türkiye, United Arab Emirates).
- BP 53 *Brazil-Türkiye Cooperation: CNPq-TÜBİTAK call encourages joint research in polar studies* (Brazil, Türkiye).
- BP 61 *The UAE laboratory at the Bulgarian St Kliment Ohridski Station* (Bulgaria, United Arab Emirates).
- BP 62 *Signing of the Memorandum of Understanding on Scientific and Technological Cooperation between Colombia and Türkiye* (Colombia, Türkiye).
- BP 64 *Campaña marítima para el desarrollo de la ciencia y la promoción de la cooperación internacional en la Antártica* (Colombia).
- BP 66 *Avances de APECS Chile* (Chile).
- BP 67 *Ecuador-Bulgaria Scientific Collaboration* (Ecuador, Bulgaria).
- BP 81 *Cooperación Chile-Canadá – Apoyo científico en el Rompehielos chileno “Almirante Viel”* (Chile).
- BP 82 *Crucero de investigación marina de áreas remotas “CIMAR I Antártica”* (Chile).

- BP 84 *Cooperation of Romania with Italy and National Geographic (USA) in Antarctica 2025* (Romania).

Science issues, future science challenges and National research activities

- (345) Ecuador presented IP 176 *Ocean acidification in the ecosystem-based management of marine areas in Antarctica*, which highlighted ocean acidification as a critical climate-change process to be considered in the ecosystem-based management of Antarctic marine areas. Ecuador noted the Southern Ocean's vulnerability to changes in carbonate chemistry, with potential effects on calcifying organisms, food webs, and ecosystem processes.
- (346) Ecuador presented IP 177 *Monitoring of greenhouse gases and their relevance for Antarctic environmental management*, which reported on the first phase of a three-year study investigating methane and nitrous oxide emissions, as well as oceanographic and nutrient parameters, in the Antarctic marine environment. Ecuador highlighted the need for long-term monitoring and interdisciplinary research to understand Antarctica's role in global climate change.
- (347) Ecuador presented IP 179 *Presence of Microplastics in Antarctica and Their Ecological Implications for Environmental Management*, which reported results from a study conducted during the austral summer 2023/2024 at the Argentinian Carlini Base, detecting and characterising microplastics in water samples under strict contamination controls.
- (348) Ecuador presented IP 180 *Assessment of the Distribution and Density of Macroplastics in the South Shetland Islands (Antarctica) during 2023–2025*, which presented results from macroplastic monitoring in the South Shetland Islands (Greenwich, Robert, Barrientos and Dee) during the 2023-2025 Antarctic campaigns, quantifying density and typology of debris across beach and rocky-shoreline transects.
- (349) Chile presented IP 172 *Proyecto piloto de energías e hidrógeno renovables en la base Escudero*, which outlined the progress of a renewable energy and hydrogen pilot initiative at the Professor Julio Escudero Station, with the collaboration of the EU and the German International Cooperation Agency (GIZ). It noted that its primary goal was to technologically validate those solutions within the Antarctic environment. Chile emphasised the project's potential to foster future national and international collaborations in the field.
- (350) Canada presented IP 148 *Canadian Antarctic Research Expedition 2026*, which reported on the activities of the Canadian Antarctic Research Expedition (CARE) 2026 conducted in the South Shetland Islands and the Antarctic Peninsula. Canada noted that the scientific surveying and sampling activities supported multidisciplinary research in marine geology, ocean sciences, and contaminants through a partnership with Chile, which provided access to a specialised research icebreaker. Canada also noted the work served to supplement and extend the research initiated by CARE in 2025.
- (351) The Meeting acknowledged the continuous efforts made by Parties in conducting scientific research in Antarctica.
- (352) The Chair, pointing out that Parties should channel the information on their scientific activities through the EIES, suggested that these kinds of papers be submitted as background papers in future meetings.
- (353) The following papers on science issues, future science challenges and national research activities were also submitted and taken as presented:

- IP 33 *Transforming Antarctic Science with autonomous and uncrewed observation platforms* (United States), which described the United States National Science Foundation's strategic investments in autonomous and uncrewed observation platforms, such as profiling floats, gliders and uncrewed aircraft systems. The paper set out how these technologies advanced research in oceanography, biology, atmospheric sciences and glaciology while overcoming logistical and environmental barriers, and described how persistent, networked systems reduced human impact and transformed Antarctic science.
- IP 34 *Progress in Antarctic Drilling at Deep Field Sites* (United States), which reported on the impacts of the United States' long-term investment in drilling capabilities, and particularly the recovery of cores from four deep field sites in Antarctica during the 2025/26 field season. The paper noted that these cores provided an important window into Earth's ancient atmosphere and environmental transitions.
- IP 35 *Completion of Upgrade to IceCube Neutrino Observatory at Amundsen-Scott South Pole Station* (United States), which reported on the completion of a multi-year upgrade to the IceCube Neutrino Observatory at the Amundsen-Scott South Pole Station. The paper noted that the upgrade would advance multi-messenger astrophysics by allowing more precise observations of cosmic neutrino sources. Over three field seasons, the upgrade included contributions from the United States and seven international partners and deployed six additional strings, including more than 600 new light sensors and calibration instruments, to the existing facility.
- IP 68 *Türkiye's Antarctic Activities and Basis for Consultative Party Status under the Antarctic Treaty* (Türkiye), which outlined Türkiye's Antarctic programme, noting that, since 2017, Türkiye had established and maintained a continuous, nationally coordinated programme through annual expeditions, research infrastructure development and sustained scientific outputs. The paper described the institutional, legal, and financial frameworks that ensured operational continuity and concluded that Türkiye fulfilled the required criteria for, and was ready to assume the rights and responsibilities of, Consultative Party status.
- IP 113 *Plastic pollution in Antarctica – a brief review of current knowledge* (SCAR), which provided a review of plastic pollution research in the Antarctic Treaty area in response to Resolution 5 (2025). The paper noted that since their discovery in sub-Antarctic sediments in 2009, microplastics had been reported throughout the Antarctic environment and concluded that coordinated monitoring using standardised methodologies was crucial to support best practices and to address plastic pollution in the Antarctic Treaty area.
- IP 169 *Southern Ocean Seasonal Cycle experiments (SOSCEX and SCALE): Closing the seasonal gaps on the distributions of iron and bioactive trace metals in the Southern Ocean* (South Africa), which described the multidisciplinary SOSCEX and SCALE initiatives investigating the role of seasonal dynamics in regulating Southern Ocean climate sensitivity, using integrated ship-based observations, autonomous platforms and modelling. The work contributed to the accurate prediction of biogeochemical responses to climate change and aimed to improve Earth system models by resolving the strong seasonal bias in current datasets.
- IP 170 *Multidecadal Changes in Southern Ocean Phytoplankton: Shifting Bloom Phenology, Declining Net Primary Production, and Increasing Iron Stress* (South Africa), which updated scientific findings on multidecadal changes in Southern Ocean phytoplankton, drawing on two peer-reviewed studies that documented widespread shifts in seasonal bloom phenology and a trend of increasing iron stress

accompanied by declining net primary production in the Southern Ocean. The findings indicated a rapid climate-driven reorganisation of the ecosystem that exceeded current model projections.

- IP 174 *Estudios de micro- y nanoplásticos en la Antártica dentro del Programa Nacional de Ciencia Antártica (PROCIEN)* (Chile), which updated Chile's studies on the assessment, detection and characterisation of plastic and microplastic waste, and its impact on Antarctic marine biota. It outlined activities carried out by national institutions and universities, presented preliminary results and proposed new initiatives. The paper recommended developing new collaborations to work towards harmonised methods that yield comparable results and to provide clear guidance to Antarctic decision-makers.
- IP 183 *Evaluación de la presencia de microorganismos patógenos en Trichocera maculipennis mediante análisis metagenómico en estaciones de la Península Antártica* (Peru), which updated the assessment of the non-native insect *Trichocera maculipennis* as a potential mechanical vector for microorganisms of sanitary and environmental interest in the Antarctic Peninsula. Using metagenomic analysis, the study aimed to identify microbial diversity associated with human activity and wastewater. Peru encouraged international cooperation and the standardisation of sampling protocols to strengthen biosecurity and non-native species management.
- IP 192 *Avances de la red de sensores del cambio climático en la península Antártica* (Chile) which updated the progress of the installation of stations to a total of 17, all of which had satellite data transmission, from King George Island (62° S) to Union Glacier (79° S), including a recent station deployed at Vinson Base Camp (2,140 m a.s.l.), and reported as well on the collection of environmental data being developed by the Chilean Antarctic Institute (INACH). Chile reported it was keen on incorporating international collaboration in the field.

(354) The following papers on science issues, future science challenges and National research activities were also submitted:

- BP 1 *Romania's Antarctic scientific activities and international cooperation through the ROICE expeditions* (Romania).
- BP 2 *Contributions from the 45th Indian Scientific Expedition to Antarctica (ISEA-45)* (India).
- BP 6 *Sustainable energy system and autonomous scientific observations at the Finnish Antarctic research station Aboa* (Finland).
- BP 7 *Finland's Antarctic research projects* (Finland).
- BP 9 *Artículo Científico bajo colaboración internacional titulado: "Huellas de metales pesados en la nieve antártica procedentes de la investigación y el turismo"* (Venezuela).
- BP 10 *Presentación de productos Antárticos Venezolanos en Congresos Nacionales e Internacionales* (Venezuela).
- BP 12 *Reporte del trabajo científico realizado por Venezuela en colaboración internacional, verano austral 2025-2026* (Venezuela).
- BP 13 *Science to support the 10-year review of the Ross Sea region Marine Protected Area* (New Zealand, Argentina, Chile, Italy, Republic of Korea, Norway, United States).
- BP 14 *Australian Antarctic Science Program Highlights 2025-26* (Australia).

- BP 19 *Turkish Polar Science Symposium (2025/2026 Update)* (Türkiye).
- BP 23 *Scientific Contributions of Türkiye to Antarctic Research (2025/2026 Update)* (Türkiye).
- BP 32 *Analysis of Thesis Production Derived from Antarctic Research Projects in Colombia (2014–2025)* (Colombia).
- BP 34 *Malaysia's activities and achievements in Antarctic research, governance and diplomacy* (Malaysia).
- BP 36 *Russian Scientific Research in the Antarctic in 2024–2025* (Russian Federation).
- BP 37 *Oceanographic Research of the Russian Antarctic Expedition* (Russian Federation).
- BP 42 *Plans to install a Small Optical Telescope for Space Situational Awareness (SSA) near the Princess Elisabeth Station* (Belgium).
- BP 54 *National Training Course on Harmonization of Microplastic Protocols - NUTEC Plastics* (Brazil).
- BP 55 *Monitoring Antarctic Stratospheric Conditions through Ground-Level Cosmic Ray Detection at Marambio Station* (Argentina).
- BP 57 *Information on the Implementation of the NUTEC Plastics Initiative in Antarctica* (Argentina).
- BP 58 *30 Years of the Ukrainian Vernadsky Station: Evolution into a Multidisciplinary Scientific Hub under the Ukrainian Antarctic Program* (Ukraine).
- BP 59 *Albedo of the bare ice of the ablation zone of the Nansen Ice Shelf* (Switzerland).
- BP 60 *Japan's Antarctic Research Highlights 2025-26* (Japan).
- BP 69 *Constitución de la primera red ecuatorial de investigación polar* (Ecuador).
- BP 74 *Reconstrucción paleoceanográfica en Isla Rey Jorge: avances y aportes al estudio del cambio climático* (Peru).
- BP 79 *Trigésima Segunda Expedición Científica del Perú a la Antártida (ANTAR XXXII)* (Peru).

Diversity in Antarctic Science

(355) Many Parties highlighted the importance of these issues, which were included as a priority in the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan, took note of the papers presented, and encouraged Parties, Observers and Experts to continue reporting on these matters.

(356) The following papers on diversity in Antarctic science were submitted and taken as presented:

- IP 56 *Towards Safe Environments in Antarctica: Progress of Colombia in the prevention of GBV* (Colombia), which outlined recent measures to prevent and respond to sexual harassment, discrimination and other forms of gender-based violence within the Colombian Antarctic expeditions.

- IP 99 *Avances en equidad de género y entornos laborales seguros en las actividades antárticas: acciones recientes del Instituto Antártico Chileno* (Chile), which reported measures by the Chilean Antarctic Institute to promote gender equity and safe working environments in Antarctica, including training, outreach activities, policy advice, and anti-harassment protocols. The initiatives demonstrated Chile's commitment to protecting the dignity of individuals across all Antarctic operations.
- IP 118 *Advancing SCAR's work on Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion: Achievements and Future Plans of the SCAR EDI Action Group* (SCAR), which noted that SCAR had published its first Equality, Diversity and Inclusion (EDI) Code of Conduct in 2025, developed by its EDI Action Group. The paper highlighted the Group's international knowledge-sharing and outreach, including a flagship initiative showcasing women in Antarctic science.

(357) The following papers on diversity in Antarctic science were also submitted:

- BP 3 *Enhancing Equity, Diversity and Inclusion in the Korean Antarctic Program* (Republic of Korea).
- BP 15 *Diversity, equity and inclusion in the Australian Antarctic program* (Australia).
- BP 70 *Acciones de Ecuador para promover la equidad de género en grupos de investigación antártica* (Ecuador).

Item 16: Implications of Climate Change for Management of the Antarctic Treaty Area

(358) The United Kingdom introduced WP 3 *Climate change impacts on the Antarctic Peninsula: implications for governance, environmental protection and operations*, which drew out policy implications based on recently published peer-reviewed scientific evidence on the current and future impacts of climate change on the Antarctic Peninsula under different emissions scenarios. The United Kingdom highlighted that the Antarctic Peninsula was one of the fastest-warming regions on Earth and an early indicator of climate thresholds likely to affect wider parts of Antarctica, and noted that the evidence indicated warming trajectories were likely to go beyond 1.5°C. It concluded that warming beyond 2°C would result in substantial, long-lasting and potentially irreversible changes to ice shelves, sea ice, glaciers, ecosystems and the operational environment. The United Kingdom invited the ATCM to:

- recognise the Antarctic Peninsula as a region experiencing particularly rapid and consequential climate-driven change, with potential implications for wider Antarctic systems;
- encourage continued international scientific collaboration and sustained observation in the Antarctic Peninsula to support informed, timely decision-making; and
- support SCAR, and others, to highlight to the UNFCCC and more widely the consequences for Antarctica, and the global implications, if global temperatures go beyond 2°C.

(359) SCAR introduced WP 31 *Antarctic Climate Change and The Environment: 2026 Update*, which presented key findings from recent published scientific research. Building upon the ACCE Decadal Synopsis Report and its 2025 update, SCAR drew Parties' attention to abrupt changes in the region, most prominently, a precipitous decline in sea ice extent

since 2016 that was exceptional within natural variability over the past 110-300 years, and likely represented a regime shift. SCAR highlighted the accelerating contribution of the Antarctic ice sheets to sea level rise, marked by 12,820 square kilometres of grounding line retreat between 1996 and 2025, while critical tipping points for West Antarctic glacial basins were likely to be triggered at temperature thresholds as low as 1°C above pre-industrial levels. SCAR noted that these changes to the physical environment had substantial biological implications, being among the primary causes for both the emperor penguin and the Antarctic fur seal being reclassified on the IUCN Red List from “Least Concern” to “Endangered.” SCAR emphasised that projected ongoing changes could still be mitigated through the rapid decarbonisation of the global economy. SCAR recommended that Parties continue their efforts to support research to understand the changing Antarctic environment across physical and living systems. SCAR also recommended, in keeping with the ACCE Decadal Synopsis, that clear communication to a wider audience of a changing Antarctic and its Earth System implications remained an important way to ensure that ongoing impacts to the region are understood and reduced.

- (360) COMNAP introduced WP 8 *Built Infrastructure in a Changing Antarctica: Challenges and opportunities encountered by National Antarctic Programs* reporting further examples of impacts on built infrastructure and operations in a changing Antarctica, with consequences for human safety, continued support for research, and capacity to meet environmental obligations. It stressed that these effects were occurring in areas where Antarctic programmes had operated for a long time, confirming that environmental change was having a tangible impact on field operations, including through changes in sea ice, coastal erosion, the exposure of legacy sites and past activities, and implications for search and rescue response. COMNAP noted its appreciation for the information presented in WP 3, and the value of regional change information for national Antarctic programme planning. COMNAP recommended that Parties support the sharing of information on a changing Antarctica, the impact of those changes on their built infrastructure, and on any environmental consequences of that impact, especially to support the CEP in its discussions on the issue, and that Parties continue to support research on local and regional Antarctic changes to clarify uncertainty around changing Antarctic conditions.
- (361) Many Parties expressed strong support for the papers and their recommendations, recognising the urgency of rapid and consequential climate-driven change in the Antarctic. Many Parties noted their operational experience of the impacts of climate change on infrastructure and the environment, and reaffirmed their commitment to support scientific research, long-term monitoring and international collaboration. Many Parties underlined the importance of deploying conservation tools available to the Parties to mitigate environmental impacts already underway, and of clearly communicating the implications of a changing Antarctica, including for global sea level rise, to the wider international community. They further emphasised the importance of receiving updates on the science and requested SCAR to continue to provide updates on Antarctic climate change and the environment.
- (362) Australia highlighted the fundamental role Antarctica played in the global climate system and the importance of ensuring international discussions about climate change mitigation and adaptation were informed by Antarctic climate change research, including understanding of the global implications of changes in the Antarctic. Australia noted this reflected commitments made in Resolution 2 (2023) *Helsinki Declaration on Climate Change and the Antarctic*, and previous action by the ATCM to communicate Antarctic science to the UNFCCC and IPCC. Australia further highlighted IP 94 from Türkiye, and

welcomed opportunities to communicate relevant Antarctic research in the context of COP 31.

- (363) The United States noted the importance of focusing research on the impacts of specific environmental changes affecting Antarctica and supported research on particular changes affecting infrastructure and operations.
- (364) Some Parties cautioned against using a 2°C threshold in discussions, urging alignment with the 1.5°C goal of the Paris Agreement. In response, SCAR noted that the International Energy Agency's World Energy Outlook 2025 indicated that, under current emissions trajectories, a 2°C increase in global temperatures above pre-industrial levels could be reached between 2050 and 2060, while not ruling out 1.5°C with strong action to reach net zero by 2050.
- (365) The Russian Federation considered that the recommendations in WP 3 were vague in nature, promoting approaches not shared by all Parties as in case of 2°C threshold and that the ATCM was not the appropriate platform to discuss matters extending beyond Antarctica, including those related to the UNFCCC. China shared the view that the UNFCCC was the primary platform for climate change mitigation, and that the Antarctic Treaty System should respect that existing mechanism.
- (366) In response, the United Kingdom clarified that it did not propose duplicating the work of the UNFCCC, but rather to make available to that body the information gathered by the Antarctic community.
- (367) In response to concerns from some Parties on the appropriateness of SCAR's role at the UNFCCC and other bodies, SCAR stressed that it did not represent the ATCM, but attended conferences of these bodies as an independent thematic organisation of the International Science Council. SCAR confirmed that it would continue to contribute to forthcoming COP meetings in that capacity, and reiterated the importance of Parties helping to convey the global significance of a rapidly changing Antarctica.
- (368) IAATO noted that the findings in WP 3 were shared with its members to inform its ongoing decarbonisation discussions, noting that meaningful progress depends on the rapid development, availability and accessibility of zero or near-zero emission fuels from sustainable sources alongside supporting infrastructure, and reiterated its support for broader monitoring efforts, including those related to IPY-5.
- (369) The Meeting expressed its continued support for sharing information on a changing Antarctica, the impact of those changes on built infrastructure, and any resulting environmental consequences, and reiterated its support for research on local and regional Antarctic changes to clarify uncertainty about changing Antarctic conditions.
- (370) Although many Parties expressed support for the recommendations in all three papers, the Meeting was unable to reach consensus on the recommendations contained in WP 3 and WP 31. The Meeting agreed to the recommendations contained in WP 8 that:
- Parties support the sharing of information on a changing Antarctica, the impact of those changes on their built infrastructure, and on any environmental consequences of that impact especially to support the CEP in its discussions on the issue.
 - Parties continue to support research on local and regional Antarctic changes to clarify uncertainty around changing Antarctic conditions.
- (371) India presented IP 65 *Project Maitri II: Replacement of existing Maitri Research Station*, which discussed the recent preparatory activities for the reconstruction and replacement of the Maitri Research Station in the Schirmacher Hills. These had included site

identification and key environmental-impact domains for assessment under the CEE, in line with the relevant EIA guidelines and the Indian Antarctic Act. India invited other Parties to share their experiences and provide suggestions and best practices regarding the CEE.

- (372) China presented IP 37 *Pioneering Clean Energy Solutions at Chinese Antarctic Research Stations: The Case of Qinling Station*. It reported that China's first green-energy system in Antarctica had been inaugurated at Qinling Station on 1 March 2025, combining multiple energy sources including wind, solar, hydrogen, stored energy and diesel. China explained that the system had now been running for one year and had successfully adapted to extreme conditions, including low temperatures, strong winds, and the seasonal polar night. China nevertheless calculated that its system had utilised clean energy for over 60 per cent of the total, saving 120 tonnes of diesel and reducing carbon emissions by 380 tonnes. China concluded that the implementation of clean energy could effectively reduce diesel dependence and environmental footprint under Antarctic conditions.
- (373) South Africa presented IP 166 *Climate-Driven Structural Stability Risks at Antarctic Ice-Shelf Margins: Implications for Coastal Logistics Corridors and Research Station Access*, prepared jointly with Germany and Norway. South Africa noted the role of seasonal coastal access routes across floating ice shelves as critical transport infrastructure between research vessels and inland stations in both east and west Antarctica. The proponents noted that smaller-scale structural processes in ice shelves remained comparatively under-observed, despite their direct relevance for logistics and safety.
- (374) Poland presented IP 120 *An update on the progress of the renovation of the Henryk Arctowski Polish Antarctic Station (King George Island)*. Poland reported that after carrying out major works during the 2025/26 season, it planned to commission the new station by February 2027.
- (375) Türkiye presented IP 94 *Connecting Antarctica to COP31: Strengthening Ocean-Climate Policy Linkages*. Highlighting Antarctica's role as a primary indicator of climate change and a fundamental driver of global feedback mechanisms, Türkiye volunteered to promote Antarctica's special concerns at the forthcoming COP 31 in Antalya, Türkiye, to help inform decision-making and drive effective climate action.
- (376) ASOC presented IP 160 *Critical warming thresholds for the Antarctic Ice Sheet and implications for irreversible sea-level rise*, which summarised the current scientific understanding of critical thresholds and tipping points within the Antarctic Ice Sheet. ASOC highlighted evidence of differences among over a dozen ice-sheet sectors in their sensitivity to global warming.
- (377) ASOC presented IP 161 *Overshoot of 1.5°C and implications for Antarctica and the Southern Ocean*, which introduced the concept of climate overshoot, suggesting that even a temporary exceedance of 1.5 °C global warming followed by a permanent return to lower temperatures could nevertheless have irreversible consequences to the Antarctic Ice Sheet and Southern Ocean system.
- (378) The Meeting valued the additional perspectives on environmental change presented and encouraged continued efforts to support research into the changing Antarctic environment.
- (379) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:

- IP 14 *Scott Base Redevelopment: Environmental Impact Assessment Update* (New Zealand), which provided an update on the Scott Base Redevelopment in line with Resolution 2 (1997) and Resolution 1 (2016), in the context of the ATCM's priority work on the modernisation of Antarctic Stations (MYSWP item 7).
- IP 62 *Australian Antarctic Program actions towards decarbonisation* (Australia), which provided information on ongoing efforts to reduce greenhouse-gas emissions in the Australian Antarctic Program, consistent with the *Helsinki Declaration on Climate Change and the Antarctic* (Resolution 2 (2023)) and the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan priority for sharing information on projects to decarbonise and increase energy efficiency in Antarctic operations.
- IP 153 *Climate response report card 2026* (ASOC), which presented an updated climate change report card evaluating the state of the ATCM's response to recent Antarctic climate science findings. ASOC drew attention to the growing evidence of serious impacts of climate change on Antarctica and made recommendations for the ATCM's continuing response.

(380) The following paper was also submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 43 *UN Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences (2025–2034)* (ASOC).

Item 17: Tourism and Non-governmental Activities in the Antarctic Treaty Area, including Competent Authorities Issues

(381) The Meeting noted that there had been no updates on the implementation or entry into force of tourism-related measures and resolutions, including Measure 4 (2004) and Measure 15 (2009). The Meeting encouraged those Parties that had not done so to ratify the relevant instruments.

Policy and management

(382) The United Kingdom introduced WP 4 *Direct Human Immersion into Antarctic Waters: Assessing Current Tourism Practice and the Need for Greater Consistency*, noting that its national competent authority had received a growing number of applications for tourist activities involving direct human immersion in Antarctic waters, such as “polar plunges”, snorkelling, recreational diving, freediving, swimming, surfing, kite-surfing, water-skiing and endurance-style water events. The United Kingdom invited the Meeting to encourage Parties to share information on their experiences of authorising such activities; to express views on whether increasing tourist numbers and diversifying forms of direct immersion activities raised environmental, safety or operational issues warranting attention; and to consider whether the ATCM should seek to develop guidance, with input from IAATO, to provide clarity and consistency for the future authorisation of these activities.

(383) IAATO presented IP 195 *IAATO Draft Operational Procedures for Shallow Water Freediving and Polar Plunging*, which outlined recent draft additions to IAATO's operational procedures for shallow water freediving and polar plunging. IAATO noted that following trial during the 2026/27 season the draft guidance would be submitted for full adoption at its annual general meeting in Prague, Czech Republic, 20-22 April 2027. IAATO also noted that, due to their likely impact on Antarctic wildlife, most of its operators had voted to ban high-velocity water-surface activities such as jet skis, kite surfing, skim, and wind boarding.

(384) Several Parties emphasised that operators should provide proof of self-sufficiency, contingency plans, and measures in place to ensure human and environmental safety

during such activities, in addition to meeting the standard EIA requirements. With respect to human safety, some Parties highlighted that operators must ensure the health, fitness, and relevant skills of those undertaking the activities, taking into account the different age demographics of tourists in Antarctica, and noted it would be useful to learn from adverse experiences and incident reports.

- (385) The Meeting encouraged Parties to continue exchanging information on permitting activities involving human immersion in water, including through the Competent Authorities Discussion Forum, and consider these issues during the intersessional work on Building Block 2 of the Tourism Framework.
- (386) Germany introduced WP 12 *Addressing Media and Influencer Activities in Antarctica: Proposal for an Intersessional Contact Group*, which proposed the establishment of an ICG to examine media and influencer activities in Antarctica. Germany highlighted that media in Antarctica had evolved; while traditional documentaries and journalism were still important, digital platforms allowed individual travellers and influencers to share content globally and instantly, completely bypassing traditional editorial or institutional control. Germany observed that increased social media visibility increased tourism demand by portraying Antarctica as an exclusive destination. Furthermore, this content was not always neutral, as it could shape unrealistic visitor expectations and sometimes showed behaviour that appeared inconsistent with established environmental guidelines. Germany also noted that AI image generation and digital enhancement made it hard for audiences to separate real documentation from modified content. While acknowledging Antarctica's long history of traditional media and educational projects, Germany proposed that an ICG compile information on existing national approaches, review relevant operator and stakeholder guidance including IAATO materials, identify good practices, and consider whether ATCM guidance addressing media and influencer activities would be useful.
- (387) Chile presented IP 152 *Incidente de vuelo y aterrizaje de avioneta no autorizada en la Isla Rey Jorge*, which outlined an incident involving an American 19-year-old influencer who sought to be the first person to visit all continents by light aircraft in order to raise awareness of childhood cancer, and raise funds for cancer research. The pilot submitted a false flight plan to Chilean authorities, took off from Punta Arenas, and unexpectedly landed at Lieutenant Rodolfo Marsh Martin Airport on King George Island. The landing occurred in winter, requiring an expensive and dangerous logistical response and providing accommodation for the pilot for several months. The incident provided a useful example of the complexity and safety issues involved in this type of activity.
- (388) The United States thanked Chile for its efforts to accommodate the pilot but could not comment any further for privacy reasons.
- (389) The Meeting thanked Germany for the information set out in WP 12 and acknowledged the emerging issues arising from increased social media activity. The Meeting also thanked Chile for the information provided on the incident and recognised it as a useful example of some of the issues identified in WP 12. Several Parties considered the issues raised in WP 12 and IP 152 to be relevant, urgent, and complex to address.
- (390) Norway noted that freedom of speech and freedom of the press are core principles, and therefore could not support the Working Paper's recommendations, as they were seen to limit some people's right of expression. Norway was of the view that instead of regulating a specific group of people, a better way forward would be to address relevant activities, and for instance set distance requirements and/or speed limits for periods when different species are vulnerable to disturbance.

- (391) IAATO provided information on its internal guidance for its members on travelling with social media influencers. IAATO highlighted that social media influencers were typically private guests, so operators had limited ability to control or monitor their social media activities beyond their operational and environmental protection obligations. IAATO advised that operators typically addressed these challenges through adaptive practices. IAATO also acknowledged that social media influencers offered an opportunity to support and share values in responsible tourism and stewardship, as well as other Antarctic values. IAATO expressed its willingness to share its experiences working with influencers.
- (392) Germany emphasised that the intention of the proposed ICG was not to influence what journalists, travellers, or content creators said or published. Rather, it proposed to focus on the regulatory and practical aspects of media and influencer related activities, including permitting practices, and practical guidance to help ensure that media and influencer-related activities were carried out consistently with visitor guidelines, environmental protection requirements, and the values of the Antarctic Treaty System. Germany also noted that the outcomes of such intersessional work could inform the broader framework discussions, in particular the assessment of activities, and could provide a procedural example for addressing emerging or evolving activities.
- (393) The Meeting encouraged interested Parties to participate in informal intersessional discussions regarding influencer activities in Antarctica. The Meeting noted these would be held via the ATCM Forum and convened by Germany.
- (394) ASOC presented IP 123 *The regulation of deep-field and land-based facilities for tourism in Antarctica*, which drew the Meeting's attention to deep-field and airborne activities as a small but rapidly expanding segment of Antarctic tourism and other non-governmental activities, including developments in the Andromeda Earth Observatory (ATCM XLIII-WP 35). ASOC noted that the projects association with the government or national competent authority was unclear and that it might therefore not be fully aligned with Resolution 5 (2022).
- (395) ASOC, supported by several Parties, noted that the paper also raised broader issues related to the growth of deep-field and land-based activities and called for closer attention to and discussion of these and other non-governmental activities.
- (396) Many Parties noted that the complex logistics of deep-field tourism exposed national Antarctic programmes to significant risks, and that permanent and semi-permanent infrastructure owned by private entities posed complications regarding property rights and liability. Some Parties also raised concerns about the carbon intensity of deep-field activities and their potential threat to Antarctic wilderness values.
- (397) Noting the growing number of deep-field camps in Antarctica, the Netherlands encouraged Parties to pay close attention to this development, including in the development of the Tourism Framework. On this point, Argentina emphasised the importance of ensuring that a national competent authority was always involved in overseeing any activity in Antarctica. Parties were specifically concerned about the lack of information regarding the Andromeda Earth Observatory.
- (398) Referring to IP 123, IAATO suggested that it could be useful to decouple deep-field and ship-based tourism during discussions on the Tourism Framework, as they were distinct activities. IAATO also noted that many of the issues raised in this discussion, such as safety, contingency planning, environmental assessments, and visitor management, were already covered by Antarctic Treaty provisions and other relevant international regulations. IAATO noted that members were required to adhere to ATCM instruments even when they had not yet been ratified.

(399) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:

- IP 101 *Antarctic tourism: an overview of Dutch funded research publications* (Netherlands), which provided an overview of Dutch-funded research publications on trends, impacts and risks of tourism in Antarctica, including options and recommendations for regulatory purposes. The compiled publications were organised by the six building blocks of growth, diversification, monitoring, compliance and enforcement, and overall governance.
- IP 119 *Online Repository of Scientific Research Supporting the Development of a Comprehensive and Consistent Framework for Antarctic Tourism Management* (SCAR), which built on ATCM 46 IP 173 and drew the Meeting's attention to an updated bibliography of scientific publications relevant to tourism management. SCAR noted that the publications had been made available online on the SCAR website and that the repository would continue to be updated.

Monitoring, trends and compliance

(400) The United Kingdom introduced WP 29 rev. 1 *Data Collection and Reporting on Yachting Activity in Antarctica in 2025-26*, prepared jointly with Argentina, Chile, Spain and IAATO. The paper consolidated data on yachts sighted in Antarctica or indicating an intention to travel there during the 2025/26 season, noting that a significant number of unauthorised yachts continued to visit Antarctica, with IAATO-authorised yachts now outnumbered by unauthorised yachts. The United Kingdom expressed concern about activities, including waterskiing, kitesurfing, unauthorised landings and entry into ASPAs, and disturbance to Antarctic wildlife. The United Kingdom requested that the Meeting advise whether it would be helpful to continue collating and presenting information on this topic at future ATCMs. The United Kingdom recommended that:

- the ATCM continue to monitor the level of yachting activities in Antarctica and compliance with the Antarctic Treaty and Environmental Protocol;
- Parties consider investigating unauthorised vessels under their flag;
- Parties ensure the EIES was updated regularly to include all authorised tourism vessels in line with Resolution 10 (2021);
- the Secretariat be requested to publish a list of authorised yachts at the start of each season; and
- the ATCM continue to discuss how national competent authorities could improve cooperation to address unauthorised yachts.

(401) The Meeting recognised the importance of continued efforts to address the issue of unauthorised yachts visiting Antarctica, emphasising that such activities fostered disregard for the rules and norms of the Antarctic Treaty System.

(402) Regarding the request that the Secretariat further facilitate Parties' ability to visualise the list of authorised yachts each season, the Secretariat noted that information on non-governmental vessels (including yachts) was already available on its website, based on data submitted by Parties through the EIES. It added that it would explore introducing database filters specifically for yachts (vessels carrying fewer than 12 passengers). The Meeting noted that providing the EIES with adequate information on authorised yachts would help the Secretariat to collate and make this information available.

(403) Several Parties noted that the information provided by WP 29 rev. 1 was not an exhaustive list of unauthorised vessels entering the Antarctic Treaty area, and that the true number was unknown and might be much larger. They also highlighted the

concerning regulatory and safety implications of the increasingly common practice of yachts switching off their Automatic Identification Systems to avoid detection by regulators and other vessels. It was also noted that the Competent Authorities Discussion Forum was a useful mechanism through which Parties could become aware of activities by non-governmental actors requiring their attention.

- (404) Several Parties noted that vessels registered under their flag appeared on the list of unauthorised yachts in WP 29 rev. 1 and highlighted that they took any instance of potential non-compliance very seriously, reported on actions undertaken thus far to investigate these instances, and underlined the value of collaboration between national competent authorities to address the issue.
- (405) Argentina highlighted instances in which passengers on unauthorised yachts had visited refuges on the Antarctic continent. Argentina noted with concern that this posed risks to infrastructure, Antarctic wildlife, and the ability of refuges to fulfil their essential function of protecting human life.
- (406) The Russian Federation noted that it was important to account for all types of vessels when discussing unauthorised visits to Antarctica, and that narrowing the scope of the discussion to yachts would undermine the Meeting's effectiveness in addressing broader issues related to non-governmental activities in Antarctica. The Russian Federation also expressed concern about unauthorised visits by vessels flagged to non-Consultative Parties that had not ratified the Environmental Protocol, noting that this was not something the Meeting should encourage.
- (407) Estonia noted that, as a non-Consultative Party that had not yet ratified the Environmental Protocol, it did not have domestic legislation that could authorise yachts to visit Antarctica. Despite this, it had worked to ensure that yachts flagged to Estonia had completed an EIA in line with IAATO procedures.
- (408) IAATO thanked Parties for their collaboration on this topic, noting with particular concern the repeated visits by unauthorised yachts previously identified as bad actors. IAATO also highlighted that some yacht operators might be using their status as non-IAATO vessel operators to appeal to tourists wishing to undertake unauthorised activities. IAATO noted that its operators often engaged in education and outreach activities to share information on Treaty and IAATO protocols and guidance relevant to non-governmental actors planning to visit Antarctica.
- (409) Many Parties supported the recommendations set out in WP 29 rev. 1, noting that a focus on yachts was warranted and necessary, given that separate requirements applied to vessels which had more than 12 passengers. Many Parties encouraged Parties to continue to monitor the level of yachting activities in Antarctica, compliance of yachting activities with the Antarctic Treaty and the Environmental Protocol, and with the authorisation issued by the national competent authority.
- (410) The Meeting urged Parties to ensure that the EIES was updated regularly to include all authorised tourism vessels through the EIES Pre-Season Information facility and via the post-visit site reports, in line with Resolution 10 (2021).
- (411) New Zealand presented IP 47 *On-board Observation of Tourist Vessels during the 2025-26 Season under Resolution 9 (2021)*, prepared jointly with France. New Zealand reported that the joint observation of one tourist voyage carried out by New Zealand and France during the 2025/26 Antarctic season had met the objectives and requirements of Resolution 9 (2021).

- (412) New Zealand presented IP 48 *Implementation of an Observer Scheme for Antarctic Tourism: New Zealand Experience*, which provided practical information on the operation and benefits of New Zealand's observer scheme. Noting that observer schemes provided a direct and independent mechanism for verifying compliance with EIA, including direct observations of actual and potential impacts, feedback loops, and other requirements, New Zealand encouraged further discussions about the use of observers to support the ATCM's priority work on the management of Antarctic tourism.
- (413) Australia presented IP 61 *Report of Australian on-board tourism vessel observation in the 2025/26 season*, which reported on Australia's first observation of an Antarctic tourist voyage during the 2025/26 season pursuant to Australia's Environmental Protocol implementing legislation and the voluntary on-board observation framework annexed to Resolution 9 (2021). Australia stated that the observation had demonstrated compliance with domestic legislation implementing the Environmental Protocol and had met the objectives and requirements of Resolution 9 (2021).
- (414) The Meeting, noting Resolution 9 (2021), underscored that the voluntary on-board observer operational framework for vessel-based tourism in the Antarctic Treaty area was useful in facilitating engagement between operators and national competent authorities in the field. The Meeting also reflected on the usefulness of the tool for developing the Tourism Framework.
- (415) IAATO welcomed the sharing of lessons learned from national competent authorities' work in monitoring non-governmental vessels and noted the utility of such work in making existing observation programmes more robust. IAATO reported that all new operators, vessels and camps underwent an initial observation, which was repeated every five years for established activities. During the 2025/26 season, IAATO performed 22 observations, some in collaboration with France and Germany. It provided information about planned updates to its observer forums and training programmes in preparation for the 22 observations scheduled for the next season, and welcomed further collaboration with national competent authorities in monitoring.
- (416) IAATO presented IP 200 rev. 1 *IAATO Overview of Antarctic Vessel Tourism: The 2025-26 Season, and Preliminary Estimates for 2026-27*. In addition to historical data around visitors and activities, IAATO provided data compiled from Post Visit Reports for the 2025/26 season and noted that the numbers reported reflected only those travelling with IAATO operators and did not include those individuals taking part as observers, government officials or in research projects that had been supported by IAATO Operators. IAATO reported that the overall number of visitors travelling on vessels in 2025/26 was 112,328, a 4.2 per cent decline from the previous season. IAATO's 2026/27 estimates indicated that passenger numbers might decline.
- (417) IAATO presented IP 201 *IAATO Deep Field and Air Operators' Overview of Antarctic Tourism: 2025-26 Season and Preliminary Estimates for 2026-27 Season*. In addition to historical data on visitors and activities, IAATO provided data compiled from Post Visit Reports for the 2025/26 season, noting that the numbers reported reflected only those travelling with IAATO operators and did not include individuals participating in research projects supported by IAATO Operators. IAATO reported that the overall number of visitors in 2025/26 was 1,027 Intracontinental Deep Field visitors and 79 Air-Land visitors. IAATO's 2026/27 estimates indicated that client numbers could rise to 1,492 across both modalities.
- (418) The Meeting noted the information provided by IAATO was instrumental to the proper understanding and management of matters related to Antarctic tourism.

- (419) Argentina presented IP 158 *Report on the flow of visitors and Antarctic tourism vessels operating at the port of Ushuaia during the 2025/2026 season*, which provided long-term data on the movement of passengers and vessels transiting through Ushuaia en route to Antarctica during the 2025/26 season, including statistics on vessels, voyages, passengers and nationalities. Argentina reported a decrease in the number of vessels, voyages and visitors compared with the previous season. Argentina advised that it intended to present a paper at ATCM 49, which would provide comparative data of the last 18 seasons to show how tourism activity had evolved over that period and to support decision-making, particularly in the development of the proposed comprehensive Tourism Framework. Argentina further advised that its data aligned with IAATO's, noting the benefits of having multiple data sources and the ability to compare them.
- (420) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:
- IP 19 *Report on tourist and non-governmental activities authorised by France in the Antarctic Treaty area – 2024-2025 season* (France), which reported that tourist and other non-governmental activities authorised by France for the 2024/25 season had been slightly lower than in the two previous seasons, mainly due to the absence of a cruise ship, which had resumed its visits in the 2025/26 season. France noted that the authorisations and post-season reporting demonstrated continued compliance with the Environmental Protocol's requirements.
 - IP 102 *Information on Malaysian flagged yachts reported in the Antarctic Treaty Area during the 2024-2025 season* (Malaysia), which followed up on ATCM 47-WP 43 rev. 2, which had reported three unauthorised Malaysian-flagged yachts sighted in Antarctic waters. Malaysia reported that it had verified registration details, tried to engage with the three yachts, and had advised the operators of the authorisation requirements where contact had been established.
 - IP 199 *IAATO Operator Use of Antarctic Peninsula Landing Sites, Including ATCM and IAATO Site Guidelines: 2025-26 Season Report and Five-Year Overview* (IAATO), which presented data collected by IAATO from Post Visit Report Forms for the 2025/26 season (as of 10 April 2026), together with a five-year historical overview to support discussions on site usage and management. IAATO reported that during 2025/26, 98 per cent of seaborne tourism with landings around the Antarctic Peninsula was conducted by IAATO operators, and that the number of sites visited had decreased compared to prior seasons. This was attributed in part to its multilayered strategy to encourage operators to spread activities across a range of platforms and sites, and to increased use of marine activities under IAATO's Marine Only Site Guidelines.

Item 18: Development of a Tourism Framework

- (421) The Chair of Special Working Group 3, Prof. Dr René Lefebvre (the Netherlands), recalled the mandate established in Decision 6 (2023) and further operationalised through Decision 5 (2024), to develop a comprehensive and consistent framework for the regulation of tourism and other non-governmental activities in Antarctica. The Chair welcomed the work undertaken during the intersessional period across the six workstreams established at ATCM 47.
- (422) The Netherlands introduced WP 30 *Report on the Intersessional Contact Group on the Development of a Comprehensive and Consistent Framework for Tourism and Other Non-governmental Activities*, which reported on the main outcomes of the ICG. Workstream 1 (Consolidation) provided cross-cutting input; Workstream 2 (Spatial approaches) contributed primarily to Building Block 1 (Managing growth); Workstream

3 (Assessment of activities) contributed primarily to Building Block 2 (Managing diversification); Workstream 4 (Environmental data) contributed to Building Block 3 (Monitoring); and Workstreams 5 (Institutional arrangements) and 6 (Practicalities) contributed to Building Block 5 (Governance), with elements relevant to Building Blocks 4 (Compliance and enforcement) and 6 (General topics).

- (423) The Meeting thanked all participants in the workstreams for their extensive intersessional work and agreed that the outcomes provided an important foundation for the discussions during the session.
- (424) The Russian Federation proposed that further work on the Framework be based on the Building Blocks established by Decision 5 (2024) rather than on the outcomes of the workstreams.
- (425) The Chair presented a synthesis which organised the workstream outcomes under the Building Blocks adopted under Decision 5 (2024).

Building Block 1: Managing growth (Workstream 2)

Spatial approaches

- (426) The Netherlands, which co-convened Workstream 2 with India, presented Attachment 3 to WP 30 *Spatial Approaches: Antarctica Scale, Regional Scale and Site-Specific Management*. There was significant support in the workstream for the concept of spatial approaches, including temporal aspects, forming an important part of the Framework, and considering management responses across three geographical levels (Antarctica-wide, regional, and site-level) could be useful. Participants had developed concrete proposals at each level. These proposals reflected the suggestions of individual ICG participants rather than a workstream consensus, but did not exclude one another and could be combined within the eventual Framework.
- (427) Many Parties supported multi-scale spatial planning that incorporated Antarctic-wide, regional, and site-specific elements in line with the comprehensive approach adopted for the development of this Framework. These Parties also underlined that this work should draw on the ATCM's previous work, remain linked to activity assessment, monitoring, and regular review, and provide for adaptive management and decision-making informed by the best available science, so that management responses remain precautionary, adaptive, and proportionate to the issues identified. The Russian Federation pointed out the need to establish clear criteria for the spatial management of tourism to accommodate various tools, not limited to the Site Guidelines. Some Parties noted that channelling tourism and other non-governmental activities to designated areas was a good way forward in consideration of science needs, wilderness values and safety concerns.
- (428) Several Parties supported the inclusion of general temporal limits at the Antarctic spatial level, in the form of an Antarctic season, in the comprehensive Framework. Some Parties expressed hesitation about setting broad or absolute spatial or temporal limits for the Antarctic tourist season, emphasising that such measures would require further analysis and should be grounded in the best available science, ecological principles, safety and site-specific conditions. Several Parties noted that limiting the number of sites could lead to the concentration and intensification of impacts from tourism and other non-governmental activities in specific areas, and that it might be more appropriate to adaptively manage permits for the number of visitors to each site rather than to fix the number of sites. Some Parties emphasised that avoiding the ongoing expansion of tourism into new areas remained an important consideration in developing the Framework. The United Kingdom noted the need to consider deep-field tourism

separately from coastal tourism, given the different operations and requirements, and that a blanket approach would not be effective.

- (429) Several Parties stressed the importance of a site-specific approach, including through site guidelines and management measures tailored to local sensitivities, wildlife cycles, ecosystem characteristics, and actual patterns of use. Some Parties noted the benefits of using existing regional spatial management tools, citing IAATO tools that had achieved beneficial regional outcomes in addressing concentrations of activity while preserving flexibility. Parties emphasised the importance of site guidelines, noting that they were not a substitute for the requirements of the Environmental Protocol, including prior assessment and monitoring.
- (430) Several Parties emphasised the merits of taking a regional approach, particularly in addressing cumulative pressures, concentrations of activity, and the coherent management of access, restrictions, or closures across wider areas. Others noted the challenges of regional approaches, including the need to discourage activity in areas during high wildlife breeding while supporting activities in those same areas during low-breeding periods.
- (431) Several Parties emphasised that spatial management should not only be based on ecological values, but also on other values that required protection under the Environmental Protocol. In this context, particularly wilderness values, scientific values and historic values were mentioned.
- (432) Several Parties also highlighted the role of national competent authorities and the importance of them taking a precautionary approach in spatial approaches to avoid impacts. Some Parties noted that, for this reason, it might be more appropriate to determine agreed principles than to develop an exhaustive list of permitted activities at each site.
- (433) ASOC informed the Meeting that it was developing a systematic conservation planning tool that enabled the visualisation of tourism-impact scenarios. The tool would build on, and use data from, the previous SCAR-IAATO systematic conservation planning project. The tool was intended to support decision-making regarding the spatial demands of Antarctic tourism, in particular on the Antarctic Peninsula. ASOC invited Parties, Experts, and Observers to engage in further development of the tool and to participate in future workshops on its use and on the development of scenarios.
- (434) The Meeting agreed to continue to work on options for Building Block 1 (Managing Growth), to keep the range of options under consideration open, and to encourage the addition of further ideas and insights as work progressed.

Infrastructure

- (435) ASOC referred to IP 123, which drew the Meeting's attention to deep-field and airborne activities as a small but rapidly expanding segment of Antarctic tourism and other non-governmental activities. The paper included a reference to a proposed permanent non-governmental infrastructure whose association with a governmental or competent authority was unclear and which might not be in conformity with Resolution 5 (2022) *Permanent facilities for tourism and other non-governmental activities in Antarctica*.
- (436) The Meeting thanked ASOC for bringing the information to the ATCM and expressed its concern that permanent station-like infrastructure, in this instance the Andromeda Earth Observatory, was being planned for Antarctica, which was not congruent with tourism, appeared to be separate from a national Antarctic programme, and would likely have a more than minor or transitory impact. The Meeting took note of information that

this project aspired to be multinational in nature, without any confirmed government support at this stage, and was based on three pillars: an Antarctic university, a research and development facility, and an earth observatory, and was planned to be launched by IPY-5.

- (437) Some Parties highlighted that it was essential for the Antarctic Treaty System that all activities and installations could be traced or linked to a responsible State Party and that the Meeting needed to develop an instrument that addressed the challenges posed by a range of activities and actors that were not directly linked to a State Party and clarify the responsibilities for non-governmental activities and strengthen the rules on cooperation between the Treaty Parties.
- (438) Several Parties stressed the importance of a precautionary approach to new or expanded semi-permanent facilities, and some Parties considered that the criteria for assessing both existing and proposed infrastructure should be applied consistently under any future framework. Some Parties underscored that the development of new or expanded semi-permanent facilities should be prohibited or highly regulated.
- (439) The Meeting recalled Resolution 5 (2022), where Parties emphasised that, given recent plans for such facilities, national competent authorities may urgently need advice; and recommended that their governments make every effort to prevent, and not authorise, permit or approve, the construction and/or exploitation of any structure or facility exclusively for tourism and other non-governmental activities to be operated in Antarctica over multiple seasons, where its construction, operations or removal is expected to have more than a minor or transitory impact on the Antarctic environment and its dependent and associated ecosystems, or the intrinsic natural wilderness and historical values of Antarctica. Examples include, but are not restricted to, buildings, wharves, jetties, and graded runways on exposed ground.
- (440) The Meeting encouraged information sharing on such non-governmental activities and reiterated that the scope of the Framework included them.
- (441) IAATO clarified that under IAATO by-laws, Resolutions and Measures were binding on members even if not in force. In relation to the proposed Andromeda Earth Observatory project, IAATO shared concerns raised by Parties that a permanent non-governmental facility, in the deep field, would introduce permanent infrastructure which did not appear to be a national Antarctic programme, nor is it congruent with tourism activities which have less than a minor or transitory impact. IAATO noted that the project would be inconsistent with Resolution 5 (2022). IAATO's commitment through its by-laws was that members have less than a minor or transitory impact, and IAATO requested Parties to avoid permitting such a precedent.
- (442) In the context of the Meeting's concern about planned permanent non-governmental infrastructure in Antarctica, New Zealand proposed codifying Resolution 5 (2022) as a binding Measure.
- (443) Many Parties supported the proposal to make Resolution 5 (2022) binding, and several considered that the urgency of the issue justified immediate action while work continued on the comprehensive Framework. Several Parties identified practical challenges to the adoption of the Measure at ATCM 48.
- (444) Following the presentation of the draft text for a Measure based on Resolution 5 (2022), the Meeting agreed to come prepared to consider this draft Measure at ATCM 49.

Building Block 2: Managing diversification (Workstream 3)

- (445) Australia and Germany, on behalf of Workstream 3, presented Attachment 4 to WP 30 *Assessment of Activities*. It was noted that the report reflected the range of issues and ideas considered in the discussion but did not represent any consensus. Different options for assessment approaches, including national assessment processes, collective assessment by the ATCM, or establishment of lists of permitted and not permitted activities, were discussed. Existing challenges included variability in how activities were classified and assessed, the absence of shared terminology and data on activity types, limited mechanisms for early consultation on emerging activities, and challenges in addressing cumulative and regional impacts. The discussions included: consideration of principles to underpin the assessment of activities; criteria for assessing activities; support tools and guidance mechanisms; and consideration of using scenarios to test different approaches, tools, and criteria.
- (446) Germany presented IP 43 *Tourism Product Evolution in Antarctica: From Individual Activities to Inter-connected Systems*, which provided an overview of tourism development trajectories focusing on land-based, deep-field, and air-supported activities and underscored that tourism developments entailed not only growing visitor numbers but also product evolution and infrastructure dependency.
- (447) Many Parties reaffirmed the continuing importance of EIA processes under the Environmental Protocol as an important mechanism for evaluating proposed tourism activities, and called for more consistent and harmonised approaches across national competent authorities to improve consistency and address concerns about potential forum shopping. Several Parties stated that, for certain categories of activities, more structured collective consideration and tools at the level of the ATCM, informed by technical advice from the CEP, would need to be considered in developing the Framework.
- (448) The Russian Federation indicated that the general principles and criteria for assessing activities should be consistent with the requirements of the Protocol, emphasised the relevance of a science-based approach and highlighted the need for sufficient information for evaluation purposes. The Russian Federation did not support further discussions to be based on the outcomes of Workstream 3 during the 2025/26 intersessional period.

Building Block 3: Monitoring (Workstream 4)

- (449) Spain, on behalf of Workstream 4, co-convened with Uruguay and Ecuador, presented Attachment 5 to WP 30 *Environmental Data including Baselines, Monitoring, Science, Cumulative Impacts and Precaution*. The proponents had proposed a systematic and adaptive tourism monitoring strategy, guided by four principles (utility, simplicity, economic capacity, and realism) and designed incrementally. The strategy was based on an ecosystem-based focus typifying frequently visited sites into the five environmental domains (high plateaus and areas of permanent coastal ice; low coastal zones, including marine coastal ecosystems; rocky insular coastal zones; areas with vegetation; and nunataks), within which observable and measurable indicators would be selected on the basis of vulnerability, management relevance, and feasibility.
- (450) Many Parties supported the incremental, stepwise approach, emphasising the need for a practical approach, the intention to build on existing knowledge and data, and the CEP's role in providing advice on monitoring. Several Parties stressed that assessing cumulative impacts should be a central objective, and that the precautionary approach is particularly important. Some Parties noted that monitoring plans should also include historical

values, distinguish between tourism impacts from those of government activities, and serve as a basis for periodic reviews of any list of sites open to tourist activity.

- (451) SCAR agreed that monitoring would be essential moving forward and should be based on the best available science. Noting that, once implemented, new monitoring programmes took time to accumulate data, SCAR stated that a precautionary approach should be applied to decision-making while data accumulated. This approach could then be adapted once data was analysed. SCAR also drew the Meeting's attention to IP 119, which described an online repository of scientific publications relevant to Antarctic tourism, and WP 33, which synthesised information on existing long-term monitoring programmes and recommended several improvements that could be readily implemented.
- (452) In support of the monitoring discussion and the role of observation in any monitoring scheme under the Framework, New Zealand presented IP 47 *On-board Observation of Tourist Vessels during the 2025-26 Season under Resolution 9 (2021)*, prepared jointly with France, and IP 48 *Implementation of an Observer Scheme for Antarctic Tourism: New Zealand Experience*. New Zealand reported that observer schemes provided a direct and independent mechanism for verifying compliance, and noted that this could inform the design of any observer mechanism within the Framework.
- (453) The Meeting commended New Zealand and France on their cooperation and encouraged broader participation in observer schemes under Resolution 9 (2021).
- (454) Noting the progress on the development of a framework for tourism and other non-governmental activities during the 2025/26 intersessional period and ATCM 48, in particular relating to monitoring the potential impact on the Antarctic environment and dependent and associated ecosystems from tourism and other non-governmental activities, and recognising that monitoring efforts may be associated in the future to attribution studies, the Meeting requested the CEP to prepare advice for ATCM 49 relating to the monitoring of impacts of tourism and other non-governmental activities, in particular, at sites in the context of management provisions and understanding cumulative impacts to:
- provide guidance on techniques to identify sensitivity and vulnerability of sites within Antarctic ecological domains; and
 - general and/or domain-specific simplified indicators to assess the ecological impacts caused by visitation in each domain.

Building Block 5: Governance (Workstreams 5 and 6)

- (455) New Zealand and Argentina, on behalf of Workstream 5, which they co-convened, presented IP 76 *Development of a Tourism Framework: Status report on the discussions on institutional arrangements, including the role of the CEP as well as possible collection of fees and their use (Workstream 5)*. Workstream 5 had been structured around seven topics, including guiding principles, the proposed functions of institutional arrangements, supporting arrangements and subsidiary bodies, and the role of the CEP. Participants had noted that consideration of institutional options should follow clarification of the intended objectives, scope and functions of the Framework, while observing that the scale and complexity of tourism and other non-governmental activities might warrant arrangements that enabled coordinated decision-making, supported implementation and compliance, and ensured the CEP's appropriate involvement.
- (456) France and Norway, on behalf of Workstream 6, which they co-convened, presented IP 84 *Development of a Tourism Framework: Status report on the discussions on*

practicalities, including cooperation between national competent authorities, in-field cooperation, safety and the role of observers. Workstream 6 had been structured around four categories: cooperation between national competent authorities; cooperation including in-field cooperation and coordination; safety; and the role of observers. Participants had emphasised the need for feasible, implementable measures to support the safe conduct of activities and appropriate contingency planning, particularly in remote areas where search and rescue capability was limited, and highlighted the value of cooperation with relevant stakeholders, including IAATO. Some participants indicated that the discussions in Workstream 6 might be a little premature and that many of the topics were closely linked to parallel discussions in other workstreams. The paper identified the following topics for further discussion: observations and inspection, arrangements that would support further cooperation between national competent authorities, even if this was relevant beyond tourism discussions in WG 3, a ship scheduling system that could encompass all relevant activities and further encouragement to approve Measure 4 (2004) as soon as possible.

- (457) In support of the discussion on the role of operators within any future framework, IAATO presented IP 198 *The Development of a Framework for the Regulation of Tourism: An IAATO Perspective*, noting that IAATO's 120 international members included 54 operators that account for approximately 98 per cent of all tourism visitation to Antarctica. IAATO emphasised that, as a trade association, it was not a regulatory body. IAATO stated that it could not legally impose caps on visitors, vessels or operators without exposing itself to antitrust concerns, and the authority to set binding limits and enforce compliance against all operators rested with outside regulatory bodies. IAATO described several challenges and opportunities to developing a framework to regulate tourism, identifying pathways for collaboration and existing tools that could support it. IAATO noted its full support for the development of a comprehensive framework and emphasised that any new process should continue to be based on a collaborative approach between regulators and industry.
- (458) Many Parties thanked IAATO for its continued efforts to share details about the operation of the tourism industry and noted that this was valuable context to consider when developing a framework.
- (459) Drawing on its national experience of tourism regulation, Chile presented IP 106 *Política y normas chilenas sobre turismo antártico*, which described Chile's domestic legislative framework for Antarctic tourism, including the 2024 National Antarctic Policy, the 2020 National Antarctic Tourism Policy, and the Chilean Antarctic Law (Law No. 21.255) and its implementing regulations, under which tourist operators were required to undergo an environmental impact assessment approved by an Operating Committee under the Ministry of the Environment and to hold mandatory insurance, among other requirements.
- (460) Reflecting on progress across the workstreams since ATCM 47, ASOC presented IP 156 *Looking back, moving forward: Antarctic tourism framework*, reporting that it had advocated for a more precautionary, structured, and enforceable framework across the six workstreams, and encouraged the ATCM to address these areas going forward.

Fees

- (461) Furthering discussion on IP 76, New Zealand, as co-convenor of Workstream 5, recalled that the intersessional discussion on fees suggested six principal topics for the discussion on fees: the objectives of fee collection; guiding principles for fee collection; who would contribute fees; the model for assessing contributions; how fees would be collected; and

how funds would be managed and allocated. Many Parties emphasised the importance of the fund covering monitoring, data collection, the administration of spatial management tools, and resourcing for any additional administration and management roles required of the Secretariat. The Meeting stressed the need for transparency and clear linkages to the Framework's objectives. The Russian Federation cautioned that, until the Framework's monitoring obligations and institutional arrangements were settled, the introduction of fees risked shifting responsibility away from permit-issuing States and operators.

- (462) Many Parties expressed general support for the implementation of tourism fees. It was suggested that a new fee system should generate additional revenue, avoid duplication, and capture IAATO and non-IAATO operators. Most Parties supported the use of fees to fund data collection and monitoring to shed light on the environmental impact of tourism and other non-governmental activities, and that such an effort could be pursued on a faster timeline within the Framework discussions. Several Parties highlighted that fees could be used to: develop and revise spatial management tools, such as Visitor Site Guidelines; fund data collection and analysis of tourism and other non-governmental activities; fund projects related to environmental and cumulative impacts; and possible management responses; and determine whether regulations were effective. Some Parties indicated that fees could also be used to support the Secretariat's work in implementing the Framework and to fund observations.
- (463) On the principles and modalities of fee collection, there was broad support in the Meeting for fairness and a simple, pragmatic approach. Many Parties expressed a strong preference for the direct transfer of funds from operators to the Secretariat. Switzerland suggested that an electronic travel authorisation system could enable the Secretariat to administer the fee directly, and Canada proposed that fee payment be tied to the authorisation and permitting process. Spain proposed that any fund established under the Framework be managed independently of Parties, dedicated exclusively to the assessment and monitoring of tourism activities, and resourced through expert contracts. Several Parties supported the establishment of a panel or committee to advise on the allocation of funds, while the United States cautioned against creating a new advisory body. Several Parties acknowledged that fees for non-governmental activities should be specifically considered, and that any fee collection should also apply to independent visitors who did not travel to Antarctica through an operator.
- (464) Several Parties were in favour of differential fees, calculated based on factors such as length of time in the Antarctic Treaty area, the type of operation (ship-based, land-based, air-based), the number of landings/sites visited, visits to sites with higher maintenance costs (e.g. historic huts), visits to remote or deep-field sites, and the environmental impacts associated with the activities. Some Parties favoured a simple flat fee.
- (465) IUCN presented IP 45 rev. 1 *Tourism Fees: Global Examples and Lessons Learned*, which set out twelve examples of tourism fees implemented in protected, conserved, or natural areas as illustrative input to the Framework's consideration of financing options.
- (466) IAATO explained how its fee system operated as a fully self-funded member association, with a per-passenger fee from operators making up the bulk of its income, and an annual draft budget scrutinised by members at the Annual General Meeting.
- (467) The Meeting agreed that work on a fee system would continue intersessionally, co-led by Argentina and New Zealand, and that the six topics introduced by New Zealand would structure that work.

Building Block 6: General Topics

(468) Several Parties reaffirmed the primacy of scientific research and that the obligation to protect the Antarctic environment must remain central to any approach to tourism and other non-governmental activities in Antarctica, and that tourist activities in Antarctica should focus on increasing public understanding and environmental education. Many Parties emphasised that the Framework should be anchored in the Environmental Protocol and underpinned by agreed principles, including those set out in Resolutions 7 (2009) and 5 (2022), and should codify the precautionary approach, the consideration of cumulative impacts, the conservation of wilderness and other intrinsic values, the priority of scientific research, and the non-discriminatory application of the Framework by all Parties.

(469) Noting consideration of various proposals relating to the Framework, including those captured in the Chair's revised synthesis paper (see Appendix 1), and acknowledging different positions expressed during the discussions, the Meeting decided to continue working intersessionally through the ICG on the development of a framework for tourism and other non-governmental activities in Antarctica, as established by Decision 5 (2024). The aim of the ICG would be discussing issues in the following workstreams, with a view to further develop and refine concrete proposals and to provide specific options for the Building Blocks to be considered for the Framework outlined in the Annex of Decision 5 (2024), accompanied by an explanatory note, for subsequent consideration of ATCM 49:

1. managing growth (Building Block 1);
2. managing diversification (Building Block 2);
3. monitoring, including possible arrangements to be updated on the progress on related intersessional work by the CEP (Building Block 3); and
4. potential establishment of fees, including collection of fees and their use, with special attention to objectives, principles, who would contribute, how fees would be collected, and the management and allocation of collected fees.

(470) The Meeting welcomed the offer of:

- The Netherlands and India to convene Workstream 1;
- Australia and Germany to convene Workstream 2;
- Spain, Uruguay and Ecuador to convene Workstream 3; and
- Argentina and New Zealand to convene Workstream 4.

(471) It further decided that:

- The ICG would operate in a virtual format during intersessional periods, using online tools provided by the Secretariat, and via virtual workshops (at alternating times to facilitate broad engagement across time zones).
- The schedule of the ICG, including proposed timing of any online workshops, would take into account the time differences and festival arrangements among different Parties.
- The Chair of Special Working Group 3 would circulate the schedule at the beginning of the intersessional period.
- The workstream discussions would be co-led by at least two Parties who would facilitate work under each workstream, in the context of the ICG.

- The co-leads of the workstreams may propose workplans and schedules within the workstreams as necessary.
- The outputs from the workstreams, in the form of concrete proposals and specific options, accompanied by an explanatory note, would inform the ICG report, to be prepared by the convenor, for discussion at ATCM 49.
- The Secretariat would establish a dedicated space within the online Discussion Forum to facilitate exchanges, including as necessary for each workstream, and would provide technical and logistical support to the ICG.
- Prof. Dr René Lefebvre would act as convenor and report to the next ATCM on the progress made in the ICG.
- Non-Consultative Parties, Observers and Experts participating in the ATCM would be invited to provide input.

(472) The following papers were also submitted under this agenda item and taken as presented:

- IP 119 *Online Repository of Scientific Research Supporting the Development of a Comprehensive and Consistent Framework for Antarctic Tourism Management* (SCAR), which presented an updated list of peer-reviewed scientific publications relevant to the development of the Framework, hosted in a regularly updated online repository on the SCAR website.
- IP 201 *IAATO Deep Field and Air Operators' Overview of Antarctic Tourism: 2025-26 Season and Preliminary Estimates for 2026-27 Season* (IAATO), which provided statistical data on IAATO's deep-field and air tourism operations during the 2025/26 season.

(473) Prof. Dr Lefebvre thanked the Parties for their contributions to discussions in Special Working Group 3 and encouraged them to make further progress during the intersessional period.

Item 19: Preparation of the 49th Meeting

a. Date and place

(474) The Republic of Korea noted that ATCM 49 would take place at the Songdo Convensia Convention Centre in the city of Incheon from 17 to 27 May 2027.

(475) The Meeting welcomed the kind invitation of the Government of the Republic of Korea to host ATCM 49 and CEP 29.

(476) For future planning, the Meeting took note of the following likely timetable of upcoming ATCMs:

- 2028 the Netherlands; and
- 2029 New Zealand.

(477) The following paper was submitted under this agenda item:

- IP 49 *Preparations for the 49th ATCM and the 29th CEP Meeting Incheon, 2027* (the Republic of Korea), which provided information on the host country's preparations for ATCM 49, to be held at Songdo Convensia, Incheon, from 17 to 27 May 2027. The Republic of Korea noted that this would be the second time it hosted the Meeting, following its first occasion in 1995.

b. Invitation of International and Non-governmental Organisations

- (478) In accordance with established practice, the Meeting agreed that the following organisations having scientific or technical interest in Antarctica should be invited to send experts to attend ATCM 49: the ACAP Secretariat, ASOC, IPCC, IAATO, the International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO), IHO, IMO, IOC, IOPC Funds, the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN), UNEP, UNFCCC, WMO and the World Tourism Organization (WTO).

c. Preparation of the Agenda for ATCM 49

- (479) The Meeting approved the Preliminary Agenda for ATCM 49 (see Appendix 2).

d. Organisation of ATCM 49

- (480) In accordance with Rule 11 of the Rules of Procedure, the Meeting decided to propose the same Working Groups for ATCM 49 as observed in this meeting. According to the Rules of Procedure, Chairs for these groups should be appointed before the close of the Meeting, and in the absence of any nominations, Chairs will be appointed at the start of the next ATCM. The Meeting agreed to appoint Ms Romi Brammer from South Africa as Chair of Working Group 1 for ATCM 49. The Meeting agreed to appoint Mr Rodrigo Waghorn from Chile as Chair of Working Group 2 for ATCM 49. The Meeting agreed to appoint Prof. Dr René Lefebvre from the Netherlands as Chair of Special Working Group 3 for ATCM 49.

e. The SCAR Lecture

- (481) Taking into account the valuable series of lectures given by SCAR at several ATCMs, the Meeting decided to invite SCAR to deliver another lecture to raise awareness of its work with respect to scientific issues relevant to ATCM 49. SCAR was invited to provide its presentation 45 days prior to the ATCM and to avoid, as much as possible, duplication of information to be presented between its papers at the ATCM and in the lecture.

Item 20: Any Other Business

- (482) The Meeting agreed that, given questions as to whether Colombia had submitted to the Depositary Government a request to become a Consultative Party after the deadline imposed in Decision 2 (2017), Colombia would be welcome to make a presentation regarding its submission to the Meeting and that it would then be considered at ATCM 49.
- (483) Colombia made a presentation regarding its request for Consultative Party status. Colombia described its institutional framework, led by the National Commission of Antarctic Affairs within the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and noted that its Antarctic expeditions, regularly held since 2014, were the outcome of a coordinated effort by academia, government and logistical support from the Colombian Defence Capabilities. Noting the multidisciplinary and interdisciplinary nature of its research activities, Colombia highlighted scientific work on the teleconnections between Antarctica, Colombia and other South American countries. In addition to being a full member of SCAR and COMNAP, Colombia described its participation in international programmes including Antarctica InSync and the Southern Ocean Observing System (SOOS), its engagement in strategic science planning, and its enhanced Antarctic research infrastructure. Colombia reaffirmed its commitment to the Antarctic Treaty System, including its provisions on peace, international cooperation, science and environmental protection.

- (484) The Parties thanked Colombia for its presentation. The Meeting noted that the item had been included on the preliminary agenda for ATCM 49 and that Colombia would not be required to resubmit the request.
- (485) Canada thanked Japan for hosting ATCM 48 and stated that despite a productive meeting, where one additional party recognised that Canada met the criteria agreed in Decision 2 (2017), they understand that one Party still has questions about how they are meeting those criteria. Canada thanked the Consultative Parties for the strong and almost unanimous support it has received for its request for Consultative Party status. Canada noted it is also available to answer any remaining question on its request in the intersessional period. It reiterated its strong support and continued engagement in the Antarctic Treaty System.
- (486) Türkiye expressed its great disappointment that consensus was prevented in the absence of a clear and substantive justification. Türkiye requested that the reasons preventing consensus, as well as any expectations or additional considerations for the future evaluation of its request, be clearly reflected in the Final Report. Türkiye also underlined its unwavering commitment to Antarctica will stand, and stated that it will continue to support the Antarctic Treaty System in the strongest possible manner and contribute to Antarctic science and cooperation with the same determination and sincerity, while expressing sincere gratitude to all Parties that supported its request.
- (487) Noting its appreciation for the opportunity to submit its request for Consultative Party status, Belarus expressed regret that, despite its materials, presentation, and additional clarifications, it was unable to convince individual Consultative Parties to support the request. Belarus noted that the decisions of those individual Consultative Parties were subjective and had considered not only qualitative, but also quantitative criteria in assessing scientific activity. Belarus noted it would present to ATCM 49 both quantitative indicators of its scientific activities and an in-depth analysis in comparison to other Consultative Parties.
- (488) Argentina stated that it considered there were no technical grounds to support a separate reference for the area referred to as “Southern Ocean”, which corresponds to the southern zones of the Indian, South Atlantic and South Pacific Oceans, as it had expressed in its reservation to IHO Resolution 02/2023/A-3.
- (489) Uruguay reaffirmed its firm commitment to the Antarctic Treaty System and the constructive spirit that had guided discussions. Noting the wide range of issues addressed by the Meeting, and that not all discussions had led to identical positions, Uruguay expressed the value it placed on the efforts made by Parties to continue to engage in respectful and constructive dialogue. Uruguay underlined the importance of continuing to strengthen other relevant international frameworks, while preserving the integrity and unique character of the Antarctic Treaty System. Uruguay stressed the value of consensus as the cornerstone of the Antarctic Treaty System, noting dialogue, cooperation, science and mutual respect were the best tools for addressing the shared challenges in Antarctica.
- (490) The Meeting agreed to ask the Secretariat to update its practice to support ATCM Host Governments to rotate the Consultative Parties’ seating by one position each year.
- (491) China made a statement: China recalled that the Host Country Communiqué of previous years, especially those of the 46th and 47th ATCM sessions, were open to consultation and revision by all Parties. China expressed its concern that no consultation had been conducted in the formulation of the Host Country Communiqué of the ATCM 48. China expressed its position that the Communiqué failed to fully and objectively reflect the outcomes of the Meeting. China stated it was imperative that the Host Country

Communiqué should embody unity and consensus among all Parties, and avoid overemphasising divisive issues. China reserved its position on certain contents of the Communiqué.

- (492) China called for an assessment and review of the formulation modalities and working mechanisms of the Host Country Communiqué. China requested that the ATCM refrain from posting the Host Country Communiqué that had not been reviewed by the Meeting on its official website.
- (493) The Russian Federation supported China's position, noting the Host Country Communiqué should seek to unite Parties rather than divide Parties.
- (494) In response to China, many Parties stated the Host Country has full discretion over the Host Country Communiqué, and that while the Host Country has the prerogative to share it prior to its publication, it is not subject to negotiation. Those Parties noted as Host, there was more interest in ATCM matters, including media, and the Party needed a document that could be published on the same day to satisfy public interest and information. Those Parties further noted the Host Country Communiqué was a well written and accurate account of ATCM 48. Germany and Italy, who had recently hosted ATCM, indicated this had been the practice in ATCM XLIV and ATCM 47.
- (495) Several Parties noted that, in previous years, a press release by all Parties had been attempted to be negotiated but it had not been successful. Many Parties noted they fully supported Japan to communicate a summary of the outcomes of the Meeting in a way that it sees fit and in accordance with ATCM practice, and thanked Japan for sharing the document.
- (496) China noted that it maintained its position on the Host Country Communiqué. China also noted that Japan's newspaper contained some information that was private to the Meeting. China requested the Secretariat to examine the matter and prevent the recurrence of such incidents.
- (497) Several Parties noted a number of delegates had received emails from external parties and, while noting that the interest of the wider community in the issues addressed by the ATCM was always welcome, sought assurance that their private information had not been released. The Secretariat confirmed ATCM points of contact were public on the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat website.

Item 21: Adoption of the Final Report

- (498) The Meeting adopted the Final Report of the 48th Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting. The Chair of the Meeting, Ambassador Hideki Uyama, made closing remarks.

Item 22: Close of the Meeting

- (499) The Meeting was closed on Thursday, 21 May at 16:50.

2. CEP 28 Report

Report of the Twenty-eighth Meeting of the Committee for Environmental Protection (CEP 28)

Hiroshima, Japan, 11 – 15 May 2026

- (1) Pursuant to Article 11 of the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty, Representatives from 39 of the 42 Parties to the Protocol (Argentina, Australia, Belarus, Belgium, Brazil, Bulgaria, Canada, Chile, China, Colombia, the Czech Republic, Ecuador, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, India, Italy, Japan, Malaysia, Monaco, the Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Peru, Poland, Portugal, the Republic of Korea, the Russian Federation, South Africa, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, Türkiye, Ukraine, the United Kingdom, the United States, Uruguay, and Venezuela) met in Hiroshima, Japan, from 11 to 15 May 2026, for the purpose of providing advice and formulating recommendations to the Parties in connection with the implementation of the Protocol.
- (2) In accordance with Rule 4 of the CEP Rules of Procedure, the meeting was also attended by representatives of the following Observers:
 - Three Contracting Parties to the Antarctic Treaty that were not Parties to the Protocol: Estonia, Guatemala, and the United Arab Emirates;
 - The Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research (SCAR), the Scientific Committee for the Conservation of Antarctic Marine Living Resources (SC-CAMLR), and the Council of Managers of National Antarctic Programs (COMNAP); and
 - Scientific, environmental and technical organisations: the Antarctic and Southern Ocean Coalition (ASOC), the International Association of Antarctica Tour Operators (IAATO), the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN), and the World Meteorological Organization (WMO).
- (3) The meeting was held in person with a virtual audience. One of the Parties to the Protocol not in attendance, Romania, followed the meeting remotely.

Item 1: Opening of the Meeting

- (4) The CEP Chair, Ceisha Poirot (New Zealand), opened the meeting on Monday, 11 May 2026 and thanked Japan for organising and hosting the meeting in Hiroshima. The Chair acknowledged and remembered those who had passed from the Antarctic family during the last year. The Chair commented on the successful third Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshop held prior to this meeting, which provided a great opportunity to connect with SC-CAMLR colleagues, and noted the upcoming 35th Anniversary of the signing of the Environmental Protocol in Madrid in 1991.
- (5) The Committee acknowledged the fitting setting for the meeting, in the Hiroshima Peace Memorial Park, recalling the Parties' commitment to ensure that Antarctica shall be used exclusively for peaceful purposes, and that the Protocol designates Antarctica as a natural reserve, devoted to peace and science.
- (6) The Chair summarised the work undertaken during the intersessional period, noting that many of the actions arising from CEP 27, with outcomes anticipated for CEP 28, had been addressed (IP 196). The Chair noted that since CEP 27, no new accessions to the

Environmental Protocol had occurred, and that the Committee continued to comprise 42 Members.

Item 2: Adoption of the Agenda

- (7) The Committee adopted the following agenda and confirmed the allocation of 41 Working Papers (WP), 85 Information Papers (IP), 5 Secretariat Papers (SP) and 13 Background Papers (BP) to the agenda items:
1. Opening of the Meeting
 2. Adoption of the Agenda
 3. Strategic Discussions on the Future Work of the CEP
 4. Operation of the CEP
 - a. Cooperation with other Organisations
 - b. Operations and Strategic Planning
 5. Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA)
 - a. Draft Comprehensive Environmental Evaluations
 - b. The EIA Process
 - c. Other Annex I Matters
 6. Conservation of Antarctic Flora and Fauna
 - a. Introduction of Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease
 - b. Specially Protected Species
 - c. Biodiversity
 - d. Other Annex II Matters
 7. Waste Management and Pollution (Annex III and Annex IV)
 - a. Repair and Remediation of Environmental Damage
 - b. Long-range and local pollution
 - c. Other Annex III and IV Matters
 8. Area Protection and Management Plans
 - a. Management Plans
 - b. Historic Sites and Monuments
 - c. Site Guidelines
 - d. Marine Spatial Protection and Management
 - e. Other Annex V Matters
 9. Climate Change Implications for the Environment
 - a. Implementation and Review of the Climate Change Response Work Programme
 - b. Other Climate Change Matters
 10. Environmental Monitoring and State of the Environment Reporting
 11. Inspection Reports
 12. General Matters
 13. Election of Officers
 14. Preparation for the Next Meeting
 15. Adoption of the Report

16. Closing of the Meeting

Item 3: Strategic Discussions on the Future Work of the CEP

CEP Five-year Work Plan

- (8) The Committee considered the Five-year Work Plan adopted at CEP 27 (SP 2 *CEP Five-year Work Plan (5YWP)*) and, in keeping with its agreement at CEP XV (2012), briefly reviewed the Five-year Work Plan at the end of each agenda item.
- (9) The Committee revised and updated its Five-year Work Plan (Appendix 1).

Item 4: Operation of the CEP

4a) Cooperation with other Organisations

- (10) SCAR presented IP 13 *The Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research Annual Report 2026 to the 48th Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting*. SCAR noted that it continued its mission, as an independent and objective body, facilitating Antarctic research, coordinating the international scientific community and providing independent, policy-relevant scientific advice to the Antarctic Treaty System. SCAR reported that its advisory work over the past year had focused on changes in the sea ice system and implications for sea ice-dependent species, including Antarctic seals and the emperor penguin. SCAR had also provided, in keeping with requests from the CEP and the Parties, updated advice on Antarctic Climate Change and the Environment, and a review of lessons learned to date on HPAI, which continued to have an impact across the region. SCAR emphasised that its significant finding across all of its work was the rapid pace of change being reported across Antarctic physical and living systems. SCAR noted this was evident in the shifting sea ice regime, new information on imminent tipping points of the continent's glaciers, and in the increased concern about the extinction risks faced by the Antarctic fur seal and the emperor penguin, indicated by their IUCN Red List Status change to "Endangered". SCAR reported on its continued development of tools and outputs to support the Antarctic Treaty System, including the Antarctic Environments Portal, and indicated that it stood ready to respond to the Committee's needs.
- (11) The Committee commended SCAR for its ongoing role in providing independent, scientific knowledge and advice informing the Committee's discussions. Noting the fast pace of changes to the Antarctic environment, including loss of sea ice, the Committee emphasised protection actions in response should not be delayed. Members highlighted the value of the SCAR Antarctic Environments Portal in providing policy-relevant scientific information to the Committee, expressed interest in SCAR's planned Antarctic and Southern Ocean Horizon Scan, and acknowledged and encouraged participation in the upcoming 12th SCAR Open Science Conference (OSC), hosted by Norway and the Norwegian Polar Institute in Oslo, Norway, from 10 to 14 August 2026.
- (12) SC-CAMLR presented IP 26 *Report by the SC-CAMLR Observer to the CEP*. SC-CAMLR thanked Members for their participation in the Joint CEP / SC-CAMLR Workshop held

from 8-9 May 2026 in Hiroshima, Japan. SC-CAMLR reported that the work plans of SC-CAMLR's five working groups had been consolidated into a single five-year strategic work plan, organised around Article II of the CAMLR Convention (SC-CAMLR-44, paragraphs 11.18-11.27), with the 2023 CCAMLR Climate Change Workshop outcomes integrated throughout. SC-CAMLR endorsed the timeline and review process for the 10-year review of the Ross Sea region Marine Protected Area, to take place in 2027, and reported on extensive discussions in the Antarctic Peninsula region Marine Protected Area proposal (Domain 1 MPA). In this regard, no agreement had been reached on proposals from Norway and the United Kingdom on how to implement the new krill fishery management approach harmonised with the Domain 1 MPA, and discussions would continue intersessionally. The 2024/25 krill fishery reached the trigger level of 620,000 tonnes, for the first time, and the fishery was closed on 1 August 2025. SC-CAMLR endorsed a proposal for a workshop to develop a harmonised plan for Subarea 48.2. SC-CAMLR also reported on updates to the CCAMLR Ecosystem Monitoring Program (CEMP), a new two-level reporting framework for State-of-the-Antarctic-Environment reporting, and progress on the marine debris monitoring programme. SC-CAMLR noted that data from 2008 and 2025 from the marine debris monitoring programme had identified spatial patterns in the likelihood of losing longline gear allowing for more targeted management.

- (13) The Committee thanked SC-CAMLR for its update, and underlined the importance of continuing the ongoing collaboration on areas of joint interest. The Committee further stressed the importance of these Observer reports for exchange of information between both committees and noted that additional areas for collaboration could be considered when discussing the outcomes from the Joint Workshop, such as CEMP, and the marine debris programme. The Committee also discussed the opportunity to learn from, and potentially develop, capacity building initiatives similar to SC-CAMLR's scholarship programme.
- (14) Members expressed concern regarding the significant amount of fishing gear lost to the Southern Ocean annually. SC-CAMLR noted that the industry had held a workshop to identify gear configuration options, behaviours and new materials to reduce gear loss, while some CCAMLR members had proposed the use of technological solutions such as subsurface floats to mitigate gear loss. On a related question of whether there was knowledge of the ecological consequences of lost gear that could be of relevance to the Committee's work, in particular in the hot-spot areas, SC-CAMLR noted that formal studies had not yet been conducted and it was an issue for further research.
- (15) New Zealand congratulated Nathan Walker on his appointment as Executive Secretary of CCAMLR.
- (16) COMNAP presented IP 12 *Annual Report 2025/2026 for the Council of Managers of National Antarctic Programs (COMNAP)*. COMNAP reported that national Antarctic programmes continued to be committed to protecting the Antarctic environment through improving efficiency in Antarctic operations and science support, contributing to understanding sustainable fuel and alternative energy options, and sharing information on infrastructure modernisation. COMNAP noted that it had continued its work on understanding risks to Antarctic infrastructure from environmental change (WP 8), on preparedness and response to HPAI (IP 4), and on advancing energy management and efficiency, in particular through the COMNAP Smart Energy Manual and the Alternative

Fuel Taskforce (IP 46). COMNAP further noted that it had advanced its understanding of the sources and impacts of plastics on the Antarctic environment, including the safe disposal of contact lenses, and on decarbonisation, including funding one of the COMNAP Early Career Awards for research on this topic. COMNAP noted the 2026 round of applications was open until 14 June 2026. COMNAP also noted that recipients of both the 2022 and 2024 awards had focused on understanding the sources and impacts of plastics on the Antarctic environment.

- (17) The Committee commended COMNAP for its work, which demonstrated the practical implementation of the Environmental Protocol in achieving the environmental protection of Antarctica.
- (18) ASOC presented IP 114 *ASOC Report to the ATCM*. ASOC reported it had engaged in a variety of forums including the International Maritime Organization, the Antarctic Wildlife Research Fund, tourism-related projects under the Dutch Research Agenda, the Weddell Sea Observatory of Biodiversity and Ecosystem Change (WOBEC), and the Ross Sea Research Coordination Network. ASOC had supported scientific initiatives including the Pelagic High Seas Ocean Ecoregionalization and Indian Sub-Antarctic (PHOCIS), and launched the Southern Ocean Citizen Submersible Initiative. ASOC members co-authored publications on sedimentary blue carbon and potential emissions scenarios for the Antarctic Peninsula, and supported research to inform krill fishery management and marine protection in the Antarctic Peninsula region. ASOC observed that science was important for environmental protection, and conversely environmental protection was important for science.
- (19) New Zealand thanked ASOC for its ongoing work and advocacy for Antarctica and the Southern Ocean, and for reminding the Committee of the importance of ambitious environmental governance. New Zealand acknowledged that ASOC serves as another avenue through which scientific information can be brought to the Committee's attention, and that ASOC supports the communication of Antarctica's critical role in the Earth system to the rest of the world.
- (20) WMO presented IP 147 *Annual Report of the World Meteorological Organization*, which reported on its programmes and initiatives related to observations, climate research, prediction services, and cryosphere monitoring, including in support of IPY-5 and the Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences (2025-2034). WMO reported on its continued work through the World Climate Research Programme's Climate and Cryosphere (CliC) core project (IP 151), World Weather Research Programme's Polar Coupled Analysis and Prediction for Services (PCAPS) project (IP 154) and the Global Cryosphere Watch (GCW), strengthening cryosphere observations and data systems, including new standards and best-practice guidance for snow, glacier, permafrost, and sea-ice observations. (IP 149). WMO announced the establishment of the Antarctic Regional Climate Centre Network, with an inaugural Antarctic Climate Forum held in Cambridge, United Kingdom, in January 2026, producing an initial consensus statement on climate conditions and seasonal outlooks in support of regional planning and operations. WMO reaffirmed its commitment to providing maritime safety information services for vessels operating in the Antarctic region, especially given the increased tourism and fishing activities, and encouraged further engagement with ATCM Parties, Experts and Observers.

- (21) IAATO presented IP 194 rev. 1 *Report of the International Association of Antarctica Tour Operators 2025-26*. IAATO highlighted its continued collaboration with SCAR, COMNAP, and CCAMLR to address HPAI in the Antarctic Treaty area. IAATO drew attention to its work on its five-year strategic plan, “Embracing Our Role as Stewards of Antarctica”, and noted that 8 new IAATO Visitor Site Guidelines had been approved at its 2026 Annual General Meeting. IAATO welcomed all Members to join in its 2027 meeting in the Czech Republic. IAATO reaffirmed its continued support of scientific work in and about Antarctica, including SCAR and the joint early career award schemes with COMNAP, and logistical support to the national Antarctic programmes. IAATO highlighted work in its specific programmes including Site Stewardship. IAATO noted two stranding incidents in the Antarctic Treaty area which did not need external support outside IAATO. IAATO also expressed its appreciation for the opportunity to continue to participate in intersessional work and meetings with other stakeholders.
- (22) The Committee thanked IAATO for its report on trends in tourism and noted with concern the growing number of activities, landing and diversity of tourism activities, and encouraged Members to contribute to the discussion on the development of a tourism framework.
- (23) The Committee thanked the Observers for their contributions and work, and welcomed the progress reported across several areas of continuing interest to the Committee. It acknowledged the Observers’ ongoing efforts to provide timely and relevant information and to foster collaboration. The Committee noted that these contributions significantly enhanced its ability to base its discussions and recommendations on the best available scientific and technical advice.

Nomination of CEP Representatives to other organisations

- (24) The Committee nominated:
- Ceisha Poirot (New Zealand) to represent the CEP at the 38th COMNAP Annual General Meeting to be held in Tromsø, Norway, from 4 - 6 August;
 - Andrew Titmus (United States) to represent the CEP at the 45th SC-CAMLR meeting to be held in Hobart, Australia, from 19–23 October 2026; and
 - Ceisha Poirot (New Zealand) to represent the CEP at the XXXIX SCAR Delegate Meeting to be held in Oslo, Norway, from 17 to 19 August 2026.

4b) Operations and Strategic Planning

- (25) New Zealand introduced WP 14 *Facilitating a process to review and track the progress of the CEP's compiled list of science knowledge and information needs*, prepared jointly with Australia, Norway and the United Kingdom. New Zealand recalled recent CEP efforts to strengthen its strategic approach to Antarctic environmental challenges, including identifying the science knowledge and information needs underpinning the CEP's environmental priorities, and the recent revision of the Five-year Work Plan to incorporate more detailed descriptive information on each priority issue. New Zealand emphasised the challenge of presenting these needs in a form readily understood and acted on by researchers and research-funding agencies and suggested, given the recent updates, that it might be timely to review the CEP's compiled list of needs to ensure their ongoing

relevance and usefulness in supporting the Committee's work. The proponents recommended that the Committee:

- share views on the proposed process to review and track progress against the CEP's compiled list of science knowledge and information needs; and
 - continue informal intersessional discussions on the proposal, with the aim of reporting back to CEP 29 on the outcomes.
- (26) The Committee thanked the proponents for the paper and expressed strong support for the recommendations to facilitate a process to track progress and review against the compiled list of science knowledge and information needs against the CEP priorities, including in its Five-year Work Plan. The Committee recognised the importance of ensuring that the science knowledge and information needs identified by the CEP were communicated in a manner that was accessible and useful to the scientific community, research institutions and domestic research funders.
- (27) Many Members noted that the proposal was timely in light of the revised Five-year Work Plan and CEP agenda, as well as the increasing environmental pressures in Antarctica, including climate change, pollution and growing human activity.
- (28) The Committee agreed to continue informal intersessional discussions on the proposal, including in collaboration with SCAR, SC-CAMLR and other relevant expert bodies, with a view to reporting back to CEP 29.

CEP advice to the ATCM on a process to review and track the progress of the CEP's compiled list of science knowledge and information needs

- (29) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had discussed the proposal to facilitate a process for reviewing and tracking progress against the CEP's compiled list of science knowledge and information needs, and had agreed to continue informal intersessional discussions on the matter, including in collaboration with SCAR, SC-CAMLR and other relevant expert bodies, with a view to reporting back to CEP 29.
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- (30) Australia presented IP 59 *The 35th Anniversary of the adoption of the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty: Updates on the work of the Committee for Environmental Protection*. The paper highlighted that in the 10 years since the 25th Anniversary of the Protocol in 2016, the Committee conducted a substantial body of work, and had provided over 100 pieces of advice to ATCM in support of the comprehensive protection of the Antarctic environment and the maintenance of Antarctica as a natural reserve devoted to peace and science. For the 35th Anniversary of the Protocol on 4 October 2026, Australia invited CEP Members and other Antarctic partners and stakeholders to use the shared hashtag #AntarcticaProtected when sharing public information on their continuing commitment and actions to protect the Antarctic environment, similar to the community approach taken during the 25th Anniversary.
- (31) The Committee encouraged continued outreach and communication activities involving Members, Observers and the wider Antarctic community, and supported the invitation to use the shared hashtag #AntarcticaProtected on the occasion of the 35th Anniversary of

the Protocol, as an opportunity to communicate the enduring importance of the Protocol, and the collective commitment to the comprehensive protection of the Antarctic environment.

- (32) ASOC noted it would be pleased to participate in the communication efforts; and observed that the anniversary was also an opportunity to reflect on the effectiveness of implementing the Protocol.
- (33) The Committee noted the following Information Paper submitted under this agenda item:
- IP 196 *Committee for Environmental Protection (CEP): Summary of activities during the 2025/26 intersessional period* (New Zealand).

Item 5: Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA)

5a) Draft Comprehensive Environmental Evaluations

- (34) No papers were submitted under this agenda item.

5b) Environmental Impact Assessment: The EIA Process

- (35) The United Kingdom introduced WP 38 *Describing the initial environmental reference state to inform Environmental Impact Assessment*, prepared jointly with Australia, Belgium, Japan, New Zealand, and Norway. The United Kingdom recalled that the Protocol sets out that an understanding of baseline environmental conditions was an important consideration in the EIA process to limit adverse impacts on the Antarctic environment. The United Kingdom noted that, for EIAs to be effective, there was a need for information describing the initial environmental reference state against which environmental change could be compared. It further noted that providing appropriate information to fulfil this need could be complex and recalled that the CEP had previously recognised the need for further work on this issue in the Five-year Work Plan.
- (36) The United Kingdom noted that Annex A to WP 38 provided examples of the types of information that could be used to describe the initial environmental reference state and emphasised that comprehensive information would not be necessary for all proposed activities, and that the focus should instead be on collecting information meaningful to the specific proposed activity and location. The proponents recommended that the Committee:
- note the importance of the provision of detailed and site-specific information describing the initial environmental reference state for the effectiveness of the EIA process;
 - invite Members to share information on the delivery of environmental baseline condition surveys, including the addition of further suggested information categories to the list provided in Annex A;
 - consider adding the list provided in Annex A, as well as any additions identified by the Committee, to the Revised Guidelines for Environmental Impact Assessment in Antarctica (Resolution 1 (2016)) as an Appendix to supplement the considerations listed in Section 3.2.

- (37) The Committee thanked the proponents for the paper and agreed on the importance of understanding the initial environmental reference state as an essential part of the EIA process. The Committee welcomed and emphasised the importance of sharing information and experiences on environmental baseline condition surveys to support Members on the EIA process and improve guidance on this topic, and noted that several other papers submitted to the meeting usefully shared Members' recent experiences.
- (38) Several Members noted that, given the diversity of Antarctic environments and activities, methodologies and information requirements would necessarily vary depending on the nature and scale of the proposed activity. The need for baseline assessments and ongoing monitoring to be developed through iterative and often multidisciplinary processes was emphasised, although it was acknowledged that operational and resource challenges exist in the context of conducting comprehensive environmental baseline studies.
- (39) Norway, referring to IP 87, shared some of its experiences with baseline mapping and drew to the attention of the Committee its intent to submit a Draft CEE for the modernisation of Troll Research Station for consideration by the CEP in 2027.
- (40) ASOC noted that having comprehensive information on the reference state was particularly important at a time of rapid environmental change and a growing human presence in Antarctica. ASOC encouraged the addition of the proposed Annex to the EIA guidelines and hoped that in future years it could be enhanced to include consideration of values in Article 3(1) of Annex V to the Protocol.
- (41) The Committee noted the non-mandatory nature of Annex A as practical guidance, and agreed to add the list provided in Annex A to WP 39 to the Revised Guidelines for Environmental Impact Assessment in Antarctica (Resolution 1 (2016)), with modifications to address discussions during the Meeting, to replace Appendix 1 in the current guidelines to supplement the considerations listed in Section 3.2.

CEP advice to the ATCM on describing the initial environmental reference state to inform Environmental Impact Assessment

- (42) The Committee agreed to forward to the ATCM guidance for describing the initial environmental reference state to replace Appendix 1 in the Revised Guidelines for Environmental Impact Assessment in Antarctica (Resolution 1 (2016)), to supplement the considerations listed in Section 3.2. of the guidelines.
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- (43) The United Kingdom introduced WP 40 *Cumulative Environmental Impacts – Report of Informal Intersessional Contact Group*, noting that the informal ICG was established to discuss the findings of a report on cumulative impacts submitted to CEP 27 (2025) as WP023. The United Kingdom explained that participants of the informal ICG discussed a set of questions regarding approaches to assessing cumulative impacts in Antarctica and expressed broad support in several areas, including the phased framework proposed in ATCM 47 - WP 23, and the importance of iterative, adaptive assessment processes. Participants had welcomed additional guidance on cumulative impacts in Antarctica, but expressed differing views on which tools and assessment methods should be prioritised. In particular, participants discussed the distinction between cumulative impacts integrated in activity-focused EIAs and standalone cumulative impact assessments.

- (44) Following discussions on cumulative environmental impacts in the informal ICG, the United Kingdom recommended that, in relation to activity-focused EIAs, the CEP:
- encourage Members to share experience in undertaking cumulative impact assessment;
 - develop further guidance on cumulative impact assessment to support those conducting and assessing EIAs in accordance with the Protocol;
 - adapt existing tools, whenever they are being developed, to help support cumulative impact assessment;
 - include enhanced provision for assessing cumulative impacts in the ‘Procedures for Comprehensive Environmental Evaluation follow-up’ when next revised;
 - develop an EIA manual and/or a repository of information that can support cumulative impact assessment and EIA more broadly; and
 - retain improvements to cumulative impact assessment in the Five-year Work Plan.
- (45) On consideration of a standalone cumulative impact assessment, the United Kingdom further recommended that the Committee encourage interested Members to undertake a pilot study.
- (46) The Committee thanked the United Kingdom for its leadership and also thanked those who participated in the informal ICG. The Committee noted that cumulative impacts were complex but of significant importance given the increasing scope and intensity of human activities in Antarctica and recognised that some impacts arose from activities governed by other components of the Antarctic Treaty System, including CCAMLR, adding to the complexity. In this context, the Committee recalled that the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop had recommended adding cumulative human impacts to the list of joint priority areas between the CEP and SC-CAMLR.
- (47) Many Members highlighted that enhanced coordination and improved information exchange would support better understanding of cumulative impacts, referring to the Electronic Information Exchange System (EIES) as a useful tool and noting the relevance of discussions on a possible inventory of past activities, as well as those related to monitoring.
- (48) The Committee encouraged pilot studies of stand-alone cumulative impact assessment, suggesting that sites with high levels of human activity, such as parts of the Antarctic Peninsula, would be suitable locations; and noted Spain’s consideration of undertaking such an assessment in ASPA 126 as a site with low impact and Whalers Bay (Deception Island) as a site of intense visitation.
- (49) Some Members noted that stand-alone cumulative impact assessments were not an obligation under the Protocol, and suggested that, at present, sharing information using the best available science and taking a precautionary approach would be important until guidance was more developed.
- (50) IAATO stressed the importance of maintaining dialogues with all operators and competent authorities, highlighted its Site Stewardship Programme as a potential contribution, and expressed willingness to support pilot studies if requested.

- (51) ASOC noted the importance of the topic of cumulative impacts and the ongoing discussion in the Committee, and welcomed further discussions to develop guidance. It considered that a pilot study could be a good starting point and suggested selecting areas of concentrated activity on land and at sea.
- (52) The Committee endorsed the recommendations in WP 40 and supported retaining the topic of cumulative impacts in its Five-year Work Plan. The Committee further agreed to continue informal discussions on this topic during the intersessional period.
- (53) The Committee further agreed that a pilot study of stand-alone cumulative impact assessment would be useful and agreed that it would continue informal intersessional discussions on cumulative environmental impact assessment.

CEP advice to the ATCM on cumulative environmental impact assessment

- (54) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that, having considered the report of the informal Intersessional Contact Group on cumulative environmental impacts, it had agreed to:
 - encourage Members to share their experience in undertaking cumulative impact assessment;
 - develop further guidance on cumulative impact assessment to support those conducting and assessing EIAs in accordance with the Protocol;
 - adapt existing tools, where they were being developed, to help support cumulative impact assessment;
 - include enhanced provision for assessing cumulative impacts in the *Procedures for Comprehensive Environmental Evaluation* when next revised;
 - develop an EIA manual and/or a repository of information to support cumulative impact assessment and EIA more broadly;
 - encourage interested Members to undertake pilot studies on standalone cumulative impact assessment; and
 - retain improvements to cumulative impact assessment in the CEP Five-year Work Plan.

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- (55) The United Kingdom introduced WP 42 *Independent environmental review of the Scott Base Redevelopment*, prepared jointly with Belgium and New Zealand. The United Kingdom noted that the plans described in the Comprehensive Environmental Evaluation prepared for the Scott Base Redevelopment project considered by the CEP/ATCM in 2021 had changed from a single-stage, ten-year rebuild of Scott Base to a three-stage redevelopment over a longer timeframe. The United Kingdom stated that, following the project reset, New Zealand intended to undertake an updated EIA for stage 1 of the project to meet the provisions of Article 8(3) of the Protocol. The United Kingdom stated that an independent review conducted in November 2025 had found Antarctica New Zealand's assessment of the change to be robust and appropriate in the absence of Antarctic Treaty

System guidance on procedures for assessing changes to activities. It noted an opportunity for the CEP to clarify procedures for major project changes. The United Kingdom reported that the reviewers had found the CEE not to be an ideal communication mechanism. Instead, the reviewers had suggested providing staff and contractors with summary information to highlight key environmental information, such as the footprint of construction activities, presented through maps or imagery. The proponents recommended that the CEP:

- note the report's findings and recommendations;
 - discuss further guidance and procedures for assessing changes in an activity to give effect to Article 8(3) of the Protocol; and
 - acknowledge the benefit of independent audits.
- (56) The Committee supported the recommendations and expressed its appreciation for the transparency of the approach and sharing of information by New Zealand, and considered that independent as well as internal reviews were good practice and a useful way to share information. Further guidance and procedures for assessing changes in an activity to give effect to Article 8(3) of Protocol would be useful but it was noted that each project was likely unique in detail and a single approach might not be suitable and that sharing of experiences would therefore also be very valuable as guidance for similar processes.
- (57) New Zealand thanked the reviewers for their efforts and collaboration in reviewing the Scott Base Redevelopment project in the context of the original EIA and more recent changes to the project plans, and for developing actionable recommendations on the basis of the review. It noted it was updating the EIA for Stage 1 of the Scott Base Redevelopment reset, was actively considering how to incorporate the reviewers' recommendations, and offered to share its experience with any Members planning similar independent audits.
- (58) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this agenda item:
- IP 14 *Scott Base Redevelopment: Environmental Impact Assessment Update* (New Zealand).
 - IP 64 *Monitoring landscape impacts and camp rehabilitation during the Denman Terrestrial Campaign Edgeworth David Base, Bunger Hills* (Australia).
 - IP 66 *Use of whole life carbon management standard as a valuable tool for informing construction project decisions* (United Kingdom).
 - IP 77 *Projection of Continuous Improvement Elements in the EIA Methodology advanced by Colombia* (Colombia).
 - IP 87 *Environmental Baseline Mapping supporting the EIA process for the Modernization of Troll Research Station* (Norway).
 - IP 89 *Cumulative environmental impacts at Rothera Research Station* (United Kingdom).

5c) Other Annex I Matters

- (59) ASOC presented IP 150 *Intrinsic value: concept, application and ongoing research*. Noting the Environmental Protocol's requirement to protect Antarctica's intrinsic value,

ASOC reported on an ongoing research project that considered to what extent and through which mechanisms the concept of intrinsic values have been used in practice in Antarctica. Noting the term is rarely mentioned in ATS documents, the research highlighted several key ATCM actions relevant to the implementation of intrinsic value. ASOC stressed the clear need to take proactive action to protect a range of features and values in Antarctica, including those associated with intrinsic value. It also suggested that Members consider intrinsic values in other frameworks, such as IUCN Resolution 8.054, adopted in 2025, to strengthen cooperation under the ATS and protect the intrinsic values of Antarctica and its dependent and associated ecosystems. Consistent with the innovative environmental protections developed under Antarctic instruments, ASOC recommended that Members should proactively increase their focus on intrinsic value, for instance in EIAs and the establishment of protected areas.

- (60) The Committee thanked ASOC for raising awareness of this topic and encouraged further research and sharing of information to develop practical approaches to give effect to the protection of the intrinsic values of Antarctica under the Protocol.
- (61) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this agenda item:
- IP 30 *Implementation of the EIA feedback process for an ice core drilling project at a remote field camp* (United States).
 - IP 38 *Report on the 2025/2026 Austral Summer Activities for the Construction of the Blue Ice Runway in the Grove Mountains, Antarctica* (China).
 - IP 40 *Marie Byrd Land Research Station: Supplementary Environmental Baseline Survey* (China).
 - IP 65 *Project Maitri II: Replacement of existing Maitri Research Station* (India).
 - IP 98 *Long-term Monitoring Initiatives to Assess Environmental Impacts of Station Operations and Scientific Activities* (Japan).
- (62) The Committee noted the following Secretariat Paper submitted under this agenda item:
- SP 7 rev. 1 *Annual List of Environmental Impact Assessments* (ATS).
- (63) The Committee noted the following Background Paper submitted under this agenda item:
- BP 42 *Plans to install a Small Optical Telescope for Space Situational Awareness (SSA) near the Princess Elisabeth station* (Belgium).

Item 6: Conservation of Antarctic Flora and Fauna (Annex II)

6a) Introduction of Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease

- (64) The United Kingdom introduced WP 5 *Report of the Intersessional Contact Group on the Revision of the CEP Non-native Species Manual*, prepared jointly with New Zealand. The paper reported on the outcomes of an ICG that revised the CEP's Non-native species manual during the 2025-26 intersessional period. The United Kingdom recalled that the CEP's Non-native Species Manual had been an important source of information on non-native species in the Antarctic Treaty area for the past 15 years. Noting that in recent years

the Committee's work increasingly addressed the dispersal of wildlife pathogens, notably highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI) H5N1, the draft manual title had been amended to "CEP Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease Manual" to reflect this. The co-conveners noted that the change would improve alignment between the Manual, the CEP Five-year Work Plan and Article 4 of Annex II to the Protocol. The proponents recommended that the Committee:

- consider the revised CEP Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease Manual (Attachment A) and, if agreed, recommend that the ATCM encourage the dissemination and use of the Manual by means of a Resolution;
 - continue to develop the Manual with the input of SCAR and COMNAP (on scientific and practical matters, respectively) and other expert organisations, as required;
 - request that the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat publish the Manual on its website as an online dynamic tool, to be updated as new developments occur;
 - encourage closer work between the CEP and SC-CAMLR on non-native species and wildlife disease issues; and
 - undertake a review of the Manual's progress and contents in five years.
- (65) The Committee thanked the United Kingdom and New Zealand and those who participated in the ICG to review the CEP's Non-native species manual. The Committee considered that the introduction and spread of non-native species and wildlife disease in the Antarctic Treaty area remained a major concern and that the topic should remain a priority area for action. The Committee commended the proponents for the timely and important work of reviewing and updating the Manual.
- (66) Some Members considered non-native species were one of the greatest threats to Antarctic ecosystems, noting that recent studies had shown a growing number of non-native species reaching the region and an increasing likelihood of their persistence. Members illustrated the breadth of the problem through reference to the eradication of the non-native grass *Poa annua* on the west shore of Admiralty Bay (IP 121) and the spread of *Trichocera maculipennis* in the vicinity of Arctowski Station and ASPA 128 (IP 164). Some Members emphasised the value of sustained, coordinated and standardised monitoring, citing the example of consolidated monitoring of *Trichocera maculipennis* in the South Shetland Islands (IP 117, IP 164, IP 183) and SCAR's presentation of information regarding non-native insect persistence and reproduction in the Antarctic environment (IP 128). Some Members expressed support for ongoing joint monitoring, and underscored the importance of continued partnerships to address non-native species, including on King George Island.
- (67) Many Members noted the appropriateness and timeliness of adding wildlife diseases to the remit of Non-native Species Manual, especially given the surge of HPAI cases over the last few years, and the danger it poses to Antarctic fauna.
- (68) The Committee agreed that regular updates to the Manual would be particularly important as scientific understanding of HPAI and other wildlife diseases and methods for their study and monitoring continued to advance.

- (69) The United States, while supporting the revisions in general, suggested that the Manual could be improved with a focus on specific changes to the Antarctic environment relevant to the spread of non-native species.
- (70) SCAR, COMNAP, IAATO and SC-CAMLR thanked the United Kingdom and New Zealand for convening the ICG, welcomed the revised Manual, and reaffirmed their commitment to contribute to the CEP's work in minimising the introduction and spread of non-native species and wildlife disease in Antarctica.

CEP advice to the ATCM on the Non-Native Species Manual

- (71) The Committee agreed to forward to the ATCM for approval a draft Resolution regarding revisions to the *CEP Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease Manual* and encouraging dissemination and use of the revised manual. It further agreed to advise the ATCM that it would:
- continue to develop the Manual with the input of SCAR and COMNAP (on scientific and practical matters, respectively) and other expert organisations, as required;
 - request that the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat publish the Manual on its website as an online dynamic tool, to be updated as new developments occur;
 - encourage closer work between the CEP and SC-CAMLR on non-native species and wildlife disease issues; and
 - undertake a review of the Manual's progress and contents in five years.
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- (72) The Secretariat introduced SP 8 Topical review of CEP documents and information exchange on Antarctic biosecurity: Non-native species and wildlife diseases (1998-2025). Following a request from CEP 27, the Secretariat reported on documents submitted to the CEP and information uploaded to the EIES on non-native species and wildlife diseases from 1998 to 2025. The Secretariat detailed that it had based its review on two repositories: the meeting documents database and the EIES, both publicly available on the ATS website. The study had centred on records related to non-native species, wildlife diseases, or both. For each category, the Secretariat had organised the records according to the three major categories of non-native species management: prevention, monitoring and response. The Secretariat reported that the review of the meeting documents from 1998 to 2025 had yielded 154 records, most of which had been devoted to non-native species, with a focus on preventing and minimising introduction risks. Among documents on wildlife diseases, the Secretariat noted that prevention had also been the focus. When reviewing the EIES, the Secretariat stated that it had focused on information provided in "Contingency Plans" and "Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) monitoring and follow-up activities". The Secretariat highlighted that while the EIES was actively used for reporting Contingency Plans and EIA monitoring, specific references to biosecurity measures were identified in a relatively small proportion of these records. It noted that the current list of information exchange requirements did not include a requirement to share information on biosecurity measures. Finally, it confirmed that it stood ready to conduct further reviews at the Committee's request.

- (73) The Committee expressed its gratitude to the Secretariat for reviewing the documents submitted to the CEP and for the information exchange on biosecurity.
- (74) Some Members suggested including a requirement to share information on biosecurity measures in the EIES, while others pointed out the need for further work on whether and how best to include information sharing on biosecurity measures in the EIES
- (75) Chile introduced WP 53 *Surveillance of the highly pathogenic avian influenza virus (H5N1) in Antarctica: an initiative by the National Antarctic Science Programme*. Chile presented the results of its National Antarctic Science Programme's monitoring efforts for HPAI, which had confirmed the virus's presence in skuas and Antarctic fur seals. Chile noted that this had marked the third consecutive year in which it had confirmed the virus's presence in Antarctica. Chile underlined the need for sustained and coordinated monitoring programmes and recommended that the Committee:
- promote, as priority lines of research, the inclusion of long-term population studies in species that have shown greater susceptibility to H5N1 HPAI, in particular: skuas in the Antarctic Peninsula and sub-Antarctic areas, elephant seals and other marine mammal species in key areas such as the South Georgia Islands, where unusual increases in mortalities have been observed;
 - harmonise sampling designs and surveillance protocols among national programmes, so that data on mortality, abundance and population structure are comparable with the efforts carried out by other programmes and operators;
 - establish a collaborative system for monitoring morbidities and mortalities in the Antarctic and sub-Antarctic region, with standardised records of sightings of animals with signs suggestive of HPAI, carcasses and unusual mortalities, integrated with surveillance programmes for HPAI and other emerging pathogens;
 - encourage integrated projects that combine population ecology, genetics and health surveillance to understand not only the numerical impact of HPAI, but also its effect on genetic diversity and the resilience of populations to future threats; and
 - explicitly incorporate the need for population studies on these species into the ATCM Antarctic Fauna and Flora Conservation work agenda and propose the creation of a technical working group on HPAI and Antarctic fauna, with the participation of scientists from all the national programmes.
- (76) The Committee congratulated Chile for the work being done to monitor and understand HPAI in Antarctic wildlife. The Committee emphasised the importance of sustained, coordinated monitoring of HPAI across national Antarctic programmes as well as ongoing sharing of information, observing that the third consecutive year of confirmed virus presence in the region underscored the need for continued vigilance. The Committee noted the importance of considering broader biosecurity implications, including risks to human health and pollution from biosecurity materials such as plastics when considering any sampling protocols for this virus.
- (77) Portugal reiterated the importance of the topic and, referring to IP 72, showed that the historical description of the arrival of HPAI in the Antarctic was possible due to

surveillance data resulting from the monitoring system in place both in Antarctic and sub-Antarctic islands.

- (78) Some Members noted that previous efforts to establish additional coordination mechanisms had encountered practical challenges. Some Members also highlighted the importance of ensuring flexibility in monitoring protocols and compatibility with different technical capabilities.
- (79) Several Members acknowledged the need to continue monitoring the effects of HPAI on Antarctic fauna, primarily birds and marine mammals, and emphasised the need to provide new information on the impact of other possible diseases affecting the populations. The experience that SCAR and COMNAP had already gained in these matters was also highlighted, and it was suggested that the use of their reporting mechanisms, protocols and guidelines be encouraged.
- (80) COMNAP highlighted the extensive surveillance and monitoring efforts undertaken by national Antarctic programmes, noting that thousands of samples had been collected to better understand the risks posed by HPAI to human health, wildlife and Antarctic ecosystems. Referring to IP 4, COMNAP noted the work led through the COMNAP Secretariat to ensure proactive access to risk mitigation, improved training, management guidance, and biosecurity protocols in support of safety of human life. COMNAP recommended that biosecurity guidelines and procedures were robustly implemented to eliminate or mitigate the risk to humans, and the risk of spreading the disease within the Antarctic Treaty area through human activities.
- (81) SCAR highlighted the importance of long-term wildlife health surveillance programmes, including the testing of both healthy and diseased animals and carcasses. It also highlighted the need for comprehensive population census data. Referring to IP 103, SCAR informed the Committee that its Antarctic Wildlife Health Network continued to maintain an online database and map to record and monitor suspected and confirmed outbreaks, and noted that more than 280 reports had been received since its establishment. SCAR also advised that harmonisation of sampling methodologies could be challenging due to differing national practices. SCAR confirmed that its biological risk assessment and recommendations on HPAI would be updated in August 2026 and would consolidate previous SCAR guidance on sampling designs and surveillance protocols.
- (82) IAATO reported on 27 reports of concern from IAATO Operators during the 2025-26 season, which were assessed through collaboration by IAATO, SCAR, and other experts to determine the level of risk and action needed at specific sites. One report had led to a closed site on Jenny Island, and IAATO noted it would continue to collaborate closely with COMNAP, SCAR, and CCAMLR on evolving the HPAI protocols, and share 2026-27 protocols ahead of the season.

CEP advice to the ATCM on the surveillance of the highly pathogenic avian influenza virus (HPAI) in Antarctica:

- (83) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered the recommendations in WP 53 relating to the surveillance of HPAI in Antarctica, and agreed that best practices be promoted among research groups studying the impacts of HPAI in Antarctica to avoid duplication of efforts and foster collaboration, emphasising the need to provide new

information on the impact of other possible diseases affecting the populations, and encouraging the use of SCAR and COMNAP reporting mechanism, protocols and guidelines, as well as to promote the effective communication of findings recorded in the field, so all those operating in the area can take appropriate precautions.

- (84) SCAR introduced IP 128 *Establishment of Non-native Insects in Antarctic Natural Environments, including Protected Areas*, which summarised recent coordinated multinational monitoring undertaken on King George Island. SCAR noted that two non-native fly species were no longer confined to Antarctic research station infrastructure and had been detected in natural ice-free environments, including within ASPAs 128, 132 and 150. SCAR noted that the findings demonstrated that risks previously identified by the Committee regarding the establishment and spread of non-native species in Antarctica had now materialised. SCAR also noted that the second non-native fly species, *Psychoda albipennis* had also been recorded in natural substrates within ASPA 150 Ardley Island. SCAR emphasised the importance of strengthened biosecurity measures, early detection strategies, coordinated international monitoring, and rapid-response capacity to prevent further spread.
- (85) The Committee thanked SCAR and acknowledged the significance of the findings regarding the establishment of non-native species in Antarctic natural environments, including protected areas. The Committee encouraged continued monitoring, collaborative research and consideration of possible eradication and response measures.
- (86) The Republic of Korea noted that one non-native species had previously been successfully eradicated from a Korean station and confirmed that monitoring efforts on King George Island would continue in cooperation with neighbouring National Antarctic Programmes, SCAR and COMNAP.
- (87) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this agenda item:
- IP 4 *High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (HPAI) in the Antarctic Treaty Area: COMNAP update* (COMNAP).
 - IP 8 *High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (HPAI) preparedness in the Ross Sea region: Ongoing collaboration and monitoring* (China, Germany, Italy, the Republic of Korea, New Zealand, the United States, SCAR, IAATO).
 - IP 39 *China's Continued Surveillance of Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza (HPAI) during the 42nd CHINARE (2025/26)* (China).
 - IP 60 *Progress with the review and comparison of existing ballast water management provisions applicable within the Antarctic Treaty area* (Australia, New Zealand, the United Kingdom).
 - IP 72 *Unexpected delay of incursion of Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza H5N1 (Clade 2.3.4.4b) in the Antarctic region: an historical context* (Portugal, France).
 - IP 80 *Assessing and managing risks of marine non-native species introductions associated with vessel hull biofouling in Antarctic operations* (Australia).
 - IP 88 *Potential for the transmission of rabies to the Antarctic Treaty area by seals* (United Kingdom, South Africa).

- IP 103 *Lessons Learnt from Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza (HPAI) for Wildlife Health in Antarctica and the Southern Ocean* (SCAR).
- IP 117 *Recent advances in the coordinated monitoring of the non-native fly *Trichocera maculipennis* in the South Shetland Islands* (Uruguay, Brazil, Chile, Ecuador, the Republic of Korea, Peru, Poland, Russian Federation).
- IP 121 *Eradication of non-native grass *Poa annua* on the west shore of Admiralty Bay, King George Island* (Poland).
- IP 128 *Establishment of Non-native Insects in Antarctic Natural Environments, including Protected Areas* (SCAR).
- IP 164 *Monitoring of *Trichocera maculipennis* in the vicinity of Arctowski Station and ASPA No. 128 (2025/2026 season)* (Poland, Chile, Uruguay).
- IP 178 *Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza (H5N1) in Antarctica: Contributions from Ecuador and Implications for Biosecurity* (Ecuador).
- IP 183 *Evaluación de la presencia de microorganismos patógenos en *Trichocera maculipennis* mediante análisis metagenómico en estaciones de la Península Antártica* (Peru).
- IP 189 *Monitoreo de la presencia de *Trichocera maculipennis* en la Estación Científica Antártica Machu Picchu (ECAMP) durante el verano austral 2025/2026* (Peru).

(88) The Committee noted the following Background Paper submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 39 *Russian Studies of the HPAI Situation in the Period 2025–2026* (Russian Federation)

6b) Specially Protected Species

(89) SCAR introduced WP 6 *Status of the Emperor Penguin – 2026 update*, following the Committee’s request at CEP 27 that SCAR provide an update on the status of the emperor penguin. Building on its previous assessment (ATCM XLIII-WP 37), and drawing on published, ensemble trajectories for the species alongside expert opinion and recent research, SCAR reported that the emperor penguin met the IUCN Red List classification of “Endangered”. SCAR reported many emperor penguin colonies were projected to decline drastically or face functional extinction by 2100, as reported in Jenouvrier *et al.* (2025). SCAR emphasised that, regardless of climate variability and uncertainty, every model predicted declines for the species; only the timeline and magnitude of change differed. SCAR reiterated that the projected decline in emperor penguin populations was linked directly to projected reductions in sea ice, which reduce breeding habitat and impact prey availability, leading to decreased reproductive success and higher mortality rates. Remote-sensing studies since 2021 had also provided new information on the abundance of emperor penguins. At a circumpolar scale, a ten-year assessment of very high-resolution satellite imagery for 50 colonies (approximately 72 per cent of the known colonies) reported a mean 9.6 per cent decline. Two major regions also showed significant declines over the last 15-20 years. In the Weddell Sea, emperor penguins across 16 colonies decreased by approximately 22 per cent. The Ross Sea, which hosts seven colonies of

emperor penguins, comprising some of the largest colonies in the world, also experienced an approximately 23 per cent overall decline in populations. Based on recent observed decreases in springtime abundance from satellite imagery, and the model from Jenouvrier *et al.* (2025), SCAR reported that the emperor penguin met the IUCN Red List classification of “Endangered”. SCAR recommended that Members:

- consider management options to reduce or eliminate stressors affecting emperor penguin populations, including designating the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species and implementing spatial protections for climate refugia; and
- support, encourage and undertake further international collaborative initiatives to monitor emperor penguin populations, understand demographic processes and behaviour both on land and at sea, and inform conservation and management plans in an adaptive way.

(90) The United Kingdom introduced WP 46 *Proposal for the listing of the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species*, prepared jointly with Australia, Belgium, Brazil, Finland, France, Germany, Japan, Monaco, the Republic of Korea, South Africa and Sweden, and referred to IP 124 *Supporting Information to Status of the Emperor Penguin - 2026 Update* (SCAR). Recalling the *Helsinki Declaration on Climate Change and the Antarctic* (Resolution 2, 2023), the proponents emphasised the ATCM’s commitment to combat the adverse impacts of climate change in Antarctica. The United Kingdom highlighted the significant decline in the emperor penguin population due to reductions in the extent and duration of sea ice, and drew the Committee’s attention to recent advice from SCAR (WP 6) and the latest IUCN assessment of the emperor penguin’s conservation status. The United Kingdom noted that the classification as “Endangered” exceeded the minimum threshold of “Vulnerable” that was required for a species to be considered appropriate for listing as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species. It further outlined threats to emperor penguin adults from the decline in fast ice during moulting (IP 31) and risks to emperor penguins from vessel movements through fast ice in the vicinity of their colonies (IP 29). Considering these findings and earlier advice from SCAR, the co-authors recommended that the Committee:

- recognise the adverse impacts of climate change on the emperor penguin population number and its breeding success;
- forward SCAR’s assessment of the conservation status of the emperor penguin as Endangered (WP 6) to the ATCM; and
- recommend to the ATCM (i) the designation of the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species under Annex II to the Protocol at ATCM 48 through adoption of the draft Measure in Appendix A, and (ii) that it encourages Parties to implement the draft Antarctic Specially Protected Species Action Plan, whilst the CEP further develops this during the forthcoming intersessional period.

(91) The Committee thanked SCAR for WP 6 and the United Kingdom and co-proponents for WP 46, and welcomed SCAR’s prompt response to the Committee’s request at CEP 27 for an updated assessment on the status of the emperor penguin. The Committee expressed concern about the change in conservation status of the emperor penguin to “Endangered”,

as assessed by SCAR, and emphasised the need for continued international collaboration on further research on emperor penguin population trends, demographic processes, and the species' behaviour both on land and at sea. The Committee underlined that the protection of Antarctic biodiversity is an essential part of its role.

- (92) Many Members expressed strong support for designating the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species and for the Committee to initiate a process to finalise the draft Action Plan. This course of action was viewed by many Members as consistent with the Guidelines for CEP Consideration of Proposal for New and Revised Designations of Antarctic Specially Protected Species under Annex II to the Protocol, which required that if SCAR's assessment determines that a species is at significant risk of extinction – meaning that the conservation status is determined as “Vulnerable” or higher – then the CEP should recommend Antarctic Specially Protected Species designation to the ATCM. Commitments under the Helsinki Declaration were recalled and many Members emphasised the need to use the tools at the Committee's disposal to address the impacts of climate change on vulnerable species. It was emphasised that an urgent response was required, and many Members expressed that, in the face of the overwhelming scientific evidence presented by SCAR, a failure to act could lead to further population declines, which could reduce the effectiveness of future management actions. Although the Committee agreed that further research and monitoring was desirable to enhance our understanding of this species, many Members emphasised that the Environmental Protocol calls for decisions to be made on the basis of the best available science, and urged that Specially Protected Species designation should not be delayed. Designation of the species was viewed by many as a pathway to enhancing emperor penguin research and the draft Action Plan was described as a roadmap for coordinating future research and monitoring, as well as a framework for identifying practical protection and management measures to combat threats to the emperor penguin. The Committee also acknowledged that collaboration and coordination towards emperor penguin research could be enhanced in connection with forthcoming international initiatives such as Antarctica InSync and IPY-5.
- (93) The Committee acknowledged the importance of developing further protection measures for the emperor penguin and supporting continued research and monitoring.
- (94) Two Members considered that without addressing global climate change as the root cause, the designation of the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species would fail to reverse the reported population decline and noted that existing tools, such as ASPAs, provide adequate protection. China considered the data underpinning SCAR's assessment of the status of the emperor penguin as insufficient, as the reported data covered only one quarter of a sector of Antarctica rather than the whole continent, and the methods used for monitoring relied heavily on remote sensing, while field surveys were inadequate and noted that population declines were not uniform across the continent. The Russian Federation raised concerns about inconsistencies between the IUCN Red List Criteria and the criteria under the Guidelines for CEP Consideration of Proposal for New and Revised Designations of Antarctic Specially Protected Species under Annex II to the Protocol. The Russian Federation cited the differing status of the Ross seal (*Ommatophoca rossii*) between the IUCN and the ATCM, and indicated concern that Specially Protected Species designation might impede scientific access to areas where emperor penguins' nest.

- (95) In response, many Members acknowledged that it would be important to utilise all available management tools to address population declines or the threat of extinction, and emphasised that further measures would be required, and noted that there were no procedural impediments to proceeding with designating the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species. Many Members also stressed that the designation would neither prevent nor restrict research but rather, reduce direct and additional pressures, including, for example, placing additional management measures on activities like vessels transiting through fast ice in the vicinity of colonies. Many Members also emphasised that the Antarctic Specially Protected Species tool can be used flexibly as new scientific evidence and knowledge become available.
- (96) The United States noted the importance of being specific about the environmental changes driving the decline in emperor penguin populations and suggested that recommendations explicitly refer to reductions in sea ice rather than to climate change more broadly.
- (97) IUCN thanked Members for their long-term research and interest regarding the emperor penguin and agreed with the need for coordinated and collaborative international research and monitoring. Referring to IP 3, IUCN emphasised that of the potential threats to emperor penguins, the loss of sea ice habitat was identified as the primary cause of decline across colonies, and that sea ice habitat loss was directly linked to a changing climate. Acknowledging that recommendations to the ATCM regarding designation as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species rest with the Committee, IUCN noted that substantial evidence was required to support a shift in IUCN categories. IUCN reported that sufficient evidence had been available to support a change in status for the emperor penguin, while insufficient evidence currently existed to revise the status of the Ross seal. ASOC and IAATO expressed support for the designation of the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species. ASOC stressed that a failure by the Committee to act would send a concerning signal to the international community regarding Antarctic environmental protection. Referring to IP 29, IAATO noted that updated guidance had recently been adopted by its operators in 2026, including a strong recommendation to avoid vessel transit through fast ice except where necessary for safety or scientific purposes, and confirmed its commitment to continue reviewing operational procedures to support environmentally responsible tourism in Antarctica.
- (98) SCAR thanked Members for the discussion and noted that the body of scientific work presented to the CEP, including contributions from Members and SCAR's own assessment, provided strong and clear evidence regarding the threats facing emperor penguins. SCAR emphasised that climate change and the associated loss of sea ice habitat represented the primary threat to the species, while also stressing the importance of reducing additional stressors through management tools such as ASPAs and the possible designation of the species as a Specially Protected Species. SCAR noted that current ASPAs covered only a limited proportion of emperor penguin colonies and populations, highlighting the importance of coordinated circumpolar monitoring efforts. In response to questions raised regarding the scientific basis of the assessment, SCAR clarified that its conclusions were based on both modelling and extensive long-term observational and field data collected across Antarctica over several decades. SCAR further noted that although observed declines had not been uniform across all emperor penguin colonies, almost every colony was projected to decline significantly in the future. SCAR concluded that the

available scientific evidence clearly demonstrated that emperor penguin populations were already declining and that delayed action could increase risks to the species.

- (99) The United Kingdom acknowledged that all species were important but that, in accordance with the best available science, the emperor penguin was particularly at risk. The United Kingdom underlined that the draft Action Plan provided practical opportunities for further coordinated action, and that the Committee should make use of the tools at its disposal to protect the species.
- (100) Many Members expressed a desire to make progress on this important topic, noting that designating the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species would send an important signal regarding the Committee's commitment to addressing climate change in Antarctica.

CEP advice to the ATCM on emperor penguins

- (101) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had various management tools that would support protection objectives for the emperor penguin. Most Members strongly supported designation as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species, informed by the best available science and in accordance with established procedures, but consensus could not be reached. Some Members considered that other tools such as the use of ASPAs could achieve the protection objectives. The views expressed in the discussion are presented in paragraphs 91-100.
- (102) The Committee advised the ATCM that it:
- shared concern about the future of the emperor penguin, recognising the risks to the survival of the species due to the implications of declining sea ice, acknowledging that sea ice decline is not caused by activities in the Antarctic region;
 - reaffirmed the importance of protecting the emperor penguin as a priority;
 - recognised the need to further implement the tools available under the Antarctic Treaty system to manage activities in the Antarctic Treaty area, and to communicate internationally the need to address pressures from outside the Antarctic region;
 - encouraged continued monitoring, research and reporting of research results on the status of the emperor penguin; and
 - agreed to continue discussions on appropriate management measures during the intersessional period.

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- (103) SCAR introduced WP 34 *Status of Southern Ocean seals*, prepared jointly with the IUCN which reported on the updated IUCN Red List assessments of all six Southern Ocean seals. Two species statuses had been changed. The southern elephant seal was reassessed from “Least Concern” to “Vulnerable” due to dramatic population declines caused by HPAI since 2023. Mortality rates of up to 97 per cent of pups have been reported in the South and Southeast Atlantic, with 47-67 per cent fewer adult females hauling out to breed following disease outbreaks. This had led to a change in IUCN Red List status for southern elephant seals to “Vulnerable”. The Antarctic fur seal moved from “Least Concern” to

“Endangered” because of population declines that were related to climate-driven changes in habitat, resulting in decreases in prey accessibility. A demographic reassessment of Antarctic fur seals in 2025 showed substantial population declines of approximately 57 per cent over the last 20 years. Other genetically distinct subpopulations, for example, those in the South Shetland Islands, had undergone particularly severe reductions of over 90 per cent over three generations. SCAR reported that the IUCN had updated the Red List status of the Antarctic fur seal from “Least Concern” to “Endangered”. The other four seal species (leopard, crabeater, Weddell and Ross seals) remained classified as “Least Concern”. The proponents noted that category should not be taken to mean no concern. Climate change impacts, including declines in Antarctic sea ice extent, ocean warming and acidification, and climate-driven changes in prey accessibility and habitat, would continue to pose a significant threat to all six seal species. Likewise, disease presented a sharply increasing risk for seals, especially HPAI. SCAR recommended that the Committee:

- request that SCAR commence assessments for the southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal for consideration as Antarctic Specially Protected Species;
- support endeavours to provide regular, spatially extensive monitoring assessments of all six Antarctic seal species; and
- communicate widely the declines in Antarctic fur seal and southern elephant seal populations and the realised and potential threats from disease, ongoing changes in Antarctic food webs, and climate change faced by all Antarctic seal species.

- (104) The Committee thanked SCAR for the paper and IUCN for the updated assessments, and noted with concern the declines in southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal populations. The Committee supported SCAR’s recommendations, noting that assessments of the southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal for consideration as Antarctic Specially Protected Species would be consistent with Resolution 1 (2002), the Guidelines for CEP Consideration of Proposals for New and Revised Designations of Antarctic Specially Protected Species under Annex II of the Protocol and SCAR’s scientific advisory role to the ATCM and CEP.
- (105) Most Members noted how the decline in the Antarctic fur seal population highlighted the significant impact rapid environmental change can have on Antarctic species that forage in the marine environment, as prey became unavailable by moving to deeper, colder waters. Some Members noted the potential impact of krill fishing on the Antarctic fur seal population. It was further noted that the observed declines in southern elephant seals driven by outbreaks of HPAI underlined the timeliness and importance of the Committee’s decision to revise the CEP Non-Native Species Manual to include wildlife disease.
- (106) Several Members noted ongoing monitoring would be required to conduct the assessments, including identifying the specific causes of mortality, expanding the geographic scope of observations and monitoring, increasing field surveys and applying a broad range of monitoring methods.
- (107) Several Members highlighted the importance of communicating the threats affecting Antarctic seal species to the wider public. Several Members supported strengthening collaboration with SC-CAMLR on these matters and sharing the Committee’s discussion on this issue with SC-CAMLR as this might be of relevance for their discussion.

- (108) ASOC supported the recommendations in WP 34, noting that it was concerning that Antarctic fur seals faced new threats after their previous recovery from overexploitation. ASOC encouraged the CEP to consider re-listing the species as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species given the alarming trends reported by SCAR.
- (109) IAATO noted that the information in WP 34 would be used to inform its operational procedures. IAATO drew attention to its Voluntary Cetacean and Pinniped Sighting Programme (V-CaPS), through which member operators collected data on the presence of marine mammals in the Southern Ocean, noting that details of the programme had been presented at the 2025 SC-CAMLR meeting. SC-CAMLR encouraged further collaboration on this work. Referencing IP 88, IAATO noted that while the likelihood of rabies reaching Antarctica via vagrant seals was considered extremely low, IAATO would include Annex A of this paper in its *Wildlife Disease Handbook* and would follow the recommendation to report suspected sightings to relevant National Competent Authorities.
- (110) IUCN clarified that the four remaining Antarctic seal species had retained their “Least Concern” classification because insufficient data was available to determine whether their status should change. IUCN stressed that “Least Concern” did not mean “of no concern” but rather that the species could not be accurately placed on the threatened spectrum at this time and that sufficient data were not available to report accurate population sizes. IUCN further noted that the Ross, crabeater, Weddell, and leopard seals remained affected by prey accessibility concerns, habitat loss and disease dynamics. IUCN highlighted that climate change-driven sea ice loss could result in the loss of important habitat, including pack ice used by Ross seals for hauling out after moulting, and emphasised that the current classifications should be regarded as a call for further study and understanding of the impacts of climate change on these four species.
- (111) SCAR noted the request for further monitoring, and encouraged broader data collection efforts by Members. In response to comments from some Members, SCAR emphasised that the assessments indicated the reasons for mortality in these species as HPAI for southern elephant seals and climate change, and changes in food accessibility among other cumulative impacts, for Antarctic fur seals. SCAR confirmed it would work intersessionally on assessments of the southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal and report back to the Committee.

CEP advice to the ATCM on Antarctic seals

- (112) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that, having noted with concern the significant population declines in southern elephant seals and Antarctic fur seals, and acknowledging that these species had been reassessed by IUCN as “Vulnerable” and “Endangered” respectively, the Committee had:
- requested SCAR commence assessments for the southern elephant seal and Antarctic fur seal for consideration as Antarctic Specially Protected Species;
 - encouraged ongoing regular, spatially extensive monitoring of all six Antarctic seal species;
 - encouraged Members to communicate widely the declines in Antarctic fur seal and southern elephant seal populations; and

- requested that information on these species be shared with SC-CAMLR.

(113) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this agenda item:

- IP 3 *A revised IUCN Red List category assessment for the Emperor Penguin* (IUCN).
- IP 23 *Update on the Status of the Emperor Penguin Population in Northern Victoria Land, Ross Sea* (Republic of Korea).
- IP 29 *Impacts of ship movement on fast ice in the vicinity of emperor penguin colonies* (United Kingdom).
- IP 31 *Fast ice breakup threatens adult emperor penguins during moulting* (United Kingdom).
- IP 81 *Abrupt changes in the Antarctic environment and heightened extinction risk for emperor penguins* (Australia, France, Germany, United Kingdom).
- IP 124 *Supporting Information to Status of the Emperor Penguin - 2026 Update* (SCAR).
- IP 175 *On the protection of Emperor penguins* (Russian Federation).

6c) Understanding Antarctic Biodiversity

(114) No papers were considered under this agenda item.

6d) Other Annex II Matters

(115) The United States introduced WP 44 *Consideration of the impact of operation of aircraft near concentrations of marine mammals in Antarctica*. The United States noted that it had been 22 years since guidelines on the operation of aircraft near birds had been agreed; and while they had been useful there was a need for a broader approach on how to operate aircraft round all wildlife, including marine mammals, to fully meet obligations under Annex II. The United States recommended that the Committee:

- recognise the need to provide guidance that ensures effective management of aircraft operations near concentrations of marine mammals;
- request COMNAP to propose revisions to the Guidelines for the Operation of Aircraft near Concentrations of Birds in Antarctica to include additional guidance on marine mammals; and
- encourage Parties to expand their standards for the operation of aircraft near concentrations of birds to include marine mammals and to share those updated standards at CEP 29.

(116) The Committee thanked the United States for WP 44 and noted the importance of clear guidelines for the operation of aircraft near concentrations of marine mammals, in addition to guidelines related to avian wildlife.

- (117) Several Members shared information about their domestic legislation prohibiting disturbance of marine mammals, or minimum distances and other guidance for aviation operations around marine mammals and gave broad support to the recommendations.
- (118) Several Members noted factors that should be taken into consideration in the revision of the Guidelines, including: aircraft types; frequency of flights; flight path characteristics; ASPAs with wildlife values; scientific evidence for distances to wildlife; and the use of aircraft for recreational flights, taking into account Resolution 4 (2023) which recommends Parties to discontinue, except in the case of emergencies and for the purpose of enhancing human safety, the use of helicopters for recreational purposes in areas with concentrations of wildlife.
- (119) Several Members noted that disseminating agreed guidelines to national Antarctic Programmes and other operators would be an important aspect of ensuring adherence to these guidelines, citing the value of the COMNAP Antarctic Flight Information Manual.
- (120) SCAR welcomed this proposal to develop additional guidance on aircraft operations near marine mammals and informed the Committee that it had an expert group focussed on birds and marine mammals that can contribute scientific advice to this work.
- (121) COMNAP noted the request to update and report back on new guidance on aircraft operations near marine mammals, and it could raise the matter during its annual meeting, undertake intersessional work on the issue, and report back to the Committee.
- (122) The Committee supported the proposal that COMNAP and the United States undertake intersessional work to develop advice to the Committee on the operation of aircraft near marine mammals. The Committee agreed that this advice would provide a useful basis for initiating a process to revise and update the Guidelines for the Operation of Aircraft near Concentrations of Birds in Antarctica, to include guidance on operations near marine mammals.

CEP advice to the ATCM on the operation of aircraft near concentrations of marine mammals

- (123) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that guidance is needed to ensure effective management of aircraft operations near concentrations of marine mammals, and the Committee had agreed that COMNAP and the United States would facilitate intersessional work to prepare advice for CEP 29, as a basis for initiating a process to revise and update the Guidelines for the Operation of Aircraft near Concentrations of Birds in Antarctica and to include guidance on aircraft operations near marine mammals.
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- (124) France presented IP 28 Regulation by the competent French national authority of the use of remotely piloted aircraft systems (RPAS) in the Antarctic Treaty area (France). The paper presented the framework for the use of remotely piloted aircraft systems (RPAS) put in place by the French National Competent Authority in the Antarctic Treaty area with a view to sharing experience eight years after the adoption of Resolution 4 (2018) Environmental Guidelines for operation of Remotely Piloted Aircraft Systems (RPAS) in Antarctica. France noted that the paper provided an overview of authorised uses, environmental impact assessments and regulations governing permits.

- (125) The Committee thanked France and welcomed the timely information provided on the regulation of RPAS in the Antarctic Treaty area, given the increasing use of RPAS. The Committee encouraged the ongoing sharing of experiences and best practices, including through participation in a workshop on this topic at the upcoming SCAR Open Science Conference.
- (126) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this agenda item:
- IP 188 *Caracterización de los ensamblajes de aves y mamíferos marinos y su relación con descriptores oceanográficos del hábitat y actividades antropogénicas: Península Antártica y el Paso Drake* (Peru).

Item 7: Waste Management and Pollution

7a) Repair and Remediation of Environmental Damage

- (127) Australia introduced WP 24 *Review of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual*, prepared jointly with New Zealand. Australia recalled that, at CEP 27 (2025), the Committee had agreed it would be timely to initiate a review of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual to facilitate the Committee's obligations under Annex III of the Environment Protocol. Australia presented proposed terms of reference for an intersessional review of the Manual, including consideration of opportunities to provide further guidance on climate change considerations as discussed by the Subsidiary Group on Climate Change Response (SGCCR). Australia recommended that the Committee:
- agree to establish an intersessional contact group (ICG) to review the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual during 2026–27 or a future intersessional period;
 - agree on terms of reference for the ICG, drawing where appropriate on the proposed terms of reference identified in the paper; and
 - identify a convener (or co-conveners) for the ICG.
- (128) In keeping with a priority item identified by the SGCCR, Attachment A to the Working Paper presented preliminary ideas on how climate change consideration could be taken into account in a review of the manual.
- (129) The Committee supported the establishment of an ICG to review the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual. The Committee recognised the value of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual as a practical tool to support the fulfilment of obligations under Annex III of the Environment Protocol; and acknowledged the timely nature of the proposal to review it, noting advances in environmental remediation technologies, approaches to the management of activities and contaminants in Antarctica and the implications of changing environmental conditions for waste and contaminant management, among other developments since its initial adoption. Several Members recalled other discussions on climate change and on the establishment of an inventory of sites of past activities that would be of relevance to the revision of the Manual.
- (130) The Committee encouraged Members and Observers to participate in the ICG.
- (131) The Committee welcomed the offer from Australia to convene the ICG.

CEP advice to the ATCM on the review of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual

(132) The Committee agreed to advise that it had established an ICG to review the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual with the following terms of reference:

- Review information on developments and advances in matters relevant to the clean-up of Antarctic past waste disposal sites, past work sites, and contaminated sites;
- Review the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual appended to Resolution 1 (2019), and suggest any modifications and additional guidance, including to provide further guidance on limiting the adverse impacts of rapid environmental change in Antarctica; and
- Report to CEP 29 on progress with the above.

(133) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this agenda item:

- IP 11 *Lessons learned from the removal of Lake Vanda Field Hut using the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual* (New Zealand).
- IP 27 *Decommissioning of a camp structure and environmental monitoring in the McMurdo Dry Valleys* (United States).
- IP 63 *Risk-based reuse of remediated soils at Australian Antarctic stations* (Australia).

(134) The Committee noted the following Background Papers submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 56 *Bioremediation of soils with GOA in Antarctic bases: scaling up at Carlini Base (Arg.) and successful transfer to Petrel Base (Arg.)* (Argentina)
- BP 72 *Estudio del medio ambiente y caracterización de hábitats en la ensenada Mackellar, bahía Almirantazgo y estrecho de Bransfield durante la expedición ANTAR XXX y XXXI* (Peru).

7b) Long-range and Local Pollution

(135) Belarus introduced WP 54 *Paint and varnish coatings as a source of environmental pollution in Antarctica*, drawing the Committee's attention to paints and varnishes as a potential source of pollutants entering the Antarctic environment. Belarus stated that this was an issue that had previously received insufficient attention at the CEP. Belarus presented the results of a recently published study on heavy metal content in soil and paint samples collected at Belarusian and Russian Antarctic stations and field bases. Belarus concluded that high concentrations of heavy metals in Antarctic soils in specific areas might stem from the dispersion of paint fragments by weathering factors such as strong winds. Emphasising the need to monitor and quantify the impact of paints and varnishes in Antarctic environments, Belarus invited the Committee to:

- consider impacts associated with the use of paints and varnishes when preparing plans to improve methodologies of environmental impact assessment in Antarctica;

- consider painted surfaces as a source of contamination when improving Antarctic monitoring guidelines;
 - encourage Parties to consider the need to prevent the dispersion of paint particles from old surfaces and to eliminate spills and leaks of paints and varnishes during painting when developing plans for the reconstruction of stations and field bases and for routine repairs;
 - recommend that Parties strive to use paints and varnishes with low heavy metal content in Antarctica;
 - recommend that Parties consider painted materials and products, including those at unused work sites, when developing waste management plans; and
 - encourage interested Members to participate in informal intersessional discussions to advance this topic and to determine the timeframes for any actions arising.
- (136) The Committee thanked Belarus for bringing this issue forward and supported the recommendations. Many Members noted the need for further discussion of contaminants, especially the potential environmental impacts of national Antarctic programmes with logistics and station infrastructure. Several Members noted that the use and management of surface paints and varnishes in Antarctica was a practical matter that warranted further consideration by national Antarctic programmes, and that should be addressed during EIA development, especially for the maintenance of older facilities and in clean-up activities. Some Members emphasised that there was not enough information on the degradation of paints and varnishes in Antarctic environments and that unforeseen chemical reactions could occur. Switzerland drew the Committee's attention to the United Nations Environment Programme's report: *Information on the implementation of resolution 6/9 on sound management of chemicals and waste to address lead, cadmium, arsenic, and organotins* (UNEP/EA.7/INF/10). Members also discussed the potential for paint and varnish coatings to be a source of microplastic pollution in the Antarctic environment.
- (137) ASOC noted that paints were an often-overlooked source of pollution in both terrestrial and marine environments and underscored the importance of understanding these contaminants for environmental protection planning. ASOC cited IP 157 as a source of information on practical approaches to marine microplastic pollution.
- (138) COMNAP welcomed the information shared in WP 54, noting that national Antarctic programmes recognise that the mismanagement of paints and varnishes could contribute to environmental pollution, and invited further discussion on the topic at its upcoming Annual General Meeting.

CEP advice to the ATCM on paint and varnish coatings as a source of environmental pollution

- (139) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that paints and varnishes used at Antarctic stations, field bases and other infrastructure could be a source of heavy-metal and other pollutants in Antarctic soils, particularly through the degradation and dispersion from older painted surfaces and at unused work sites, and that this matter warranted greater attention in the environmental management of Antarctic facilities.

- (140) The Committee further agreed to advise the ATCM that it had encouraged interested Members to share information and experience on this topic.

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- (141) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this item:

- IP 22 *Implications of Microplastic Emission from Antarctic Research Stations for Environmental Management* (Republic of Korea).
- IP 174 *Estudios de micro- y nanoplásticos en la Antártica dentro del Programa Nacional de Ciencia Antártica (PROCIEN)* (Chile).

7c) Other Annex III and IV matters

- (142) The Committee noted the following Information Paper submitted under this item:

- IP 108 *Plastic debris in Hope Bay: legacy waste and cultural heritage?* (Uruguay).

- (143) The Committee noted the following Background Paper submitted under this item:

- BP 77 *Gestión de Residuos en la Estación Científica Antártica Machu Picchu (ECAMP)* (Peru).

Item 8: Area Protection and Management Plans (Annex V)

8a) New and Revised ASPA/ASMA Management Plans

i) Draft Management Plans which have been reviewed by the Subsidiary Group on Management Plans

- (144) The Convenor of the Subsidiary Group on Management Plans (SGMP), Ji Hee Kim (Republic of Korea), introduced WP 9 *Subsidiary Group on Management Plans – Report on 2025/26 Intersessional Work* on behalf of the SGMP. The convenor thanked Andrew Titmus (United States) for moderating the pre-meeting review of management plans that were not submitted to the SGMP review process. The convenor also thanked all active participants in the SGMP for their work and reminded the Committee that all Members were welcome to join the SGMP.
- (145) The convenor thanked the following representatives for their assistance in coordinating the review process for each draft management plan: Natasha Gardiner (New Zealand) and Katarzyna Fudala (Poland) for ASPA 125 Fildes Peninsula, King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island; Ewan McIvor (Australia) and Robert Bialik (Poland) for ASPA 150 Ardley Island (Ardley Peninsula), Maxwell Bay, King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island; Birgit Njåstad (Norway), together with the convenor, for the proposed new ASPA at Parts of Signy Island and adjacent islands, South Orkney Islands; Antonio Quesada (Spain) and Luis Caro Lara (Chile) for the proposed new ASPA at Collins Bay, Kyiv Peninsula; and Zeyneb Gökçe (Türkiye) and Andrew Titmus (United States), together with the convenor, for the draft management plan for the Wreck of Endurance in the Weddell Sea.
- (146) In accordance with Terms of Reference 1 to 3, the Convenor reported that the SGMP had reviewed two revised draft ASPA management plans of three plans pending from the

2024–2025 intersessional period, (ASPAs 125 Fildes Peninsula and ASPA 150 Ardley Island), and three draft new ASPA management plans referred to the SGMP by CEP 27 for intersessional review: proposed new ASPA at Parts of Signy Island and adjacent islands, South Orkney Islands; proposed new ASPA at Collins Bay, Kyiv Peninsula; and proposed new ASPA for the Wreck of Endurance in the Weddell Sea.

- (147) Regarding the revised management plan for ASPA 125 Fildes Peninsula, King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island (Chile), following further updates from the proponent, the SGMP concluded that the draft Management Plan was well-written, of high quality, and had adequately addressed the key points raised in the SGMP's advice. Accordingly, the SGMP recommended that the Committee approve the revised management plan for the Area.
- (148) Regarding the revised management plan for ASPA 150 Ardley Island (Ardley Peninsula), Maxwell Bay (Fildes Bay), King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island (Chile), the SGMP noted that the proponent had adequately addressed key suggestions to enhance the effectiveness of the revised management plan, including on the boundaries of the Area; the boundaries, descriptions and purpose of the proposed zones within the Area; the extent of tourist access to the Area itself and Ardley Island in general; provisions for access to and within the Area, including limits on the number of visitors allowed within all or parts of the Area; and the relocation of some provisions to more appropriate parts of the management plan. The SGMP concluded that the updated draft management plan was well written and of high quality and recommended that the Committee approve the revised management plan for the Area.
- (149) Uruguay noted that the update of the management plan for ASPA 150 had been pending for more than a decade, and significant changes to the protected values of the area had occurred. Uruguay emphasised the need to include additional provisions in the monitoring plan to better understand the changes in the ASPA and the dynamics of the pressures that put the values in the ASPA at risk.
- (150) Regarding the proposed new ASPA at Parts of Signy Island and adjacent islands, South Orkney Islands (Italy, the Netherlands and the United Kingdom), the SGMP advised that the plan was comprehensive, of high quality and likely to achieve the area management objectives. The SGMP considered that the proponents had addressed the large majority of the SGMP's suggestions and satisfactorily responded to its advice. Accordingly, the SGMP recommended that the Committee approve the management plan for the proposed new ASPA at Parts of Signy Island and adjacent islands, South Orkney Islands.
- (151) Regarding the proposed new ASPA at Collins Bay, Kyiv Peninsula (Ukraine), the SGMP had considered the management plan to be comprehensive, of high quality and likely to achieve the area management objectives. The SGMP considered that the proponents had addressed the large majority of the SGMP's suggestions and satisfactorily responded to its advice. The SGMP recommended that the Committee approve the management plan for the proposed new ASPA at Collins Bay, Kyiv Peninsula.
- (152) Regarding the proposed new ASPA for the Wreck of Endurance in the Weddell Sea (Chile, Spain and the United Kingdom), the convenor of the SGMP noted that the draft management plan was well-written and of high quality and noted that the proponents had considered the SGMP's advice. The SGMP recommended that the Committee approve the

management plan and forward it to CCAMLR for approval, in accordance with Decision 9 (2005) before subsequent approval at ATCM 49.

- (153) The Committee thanked all the proponents for their work, and also thanked the SGMP for its intersessional review and advice. The Committee approved the revised management plans for ASPA 125 Fildes Peninsula, King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island and, with further minor changes to reflect comments raised during the meeting, also approved the revised management plan for ASPA 150 Ardley Island (Ardley Peninsula), Maxwell Bay (Fildes Bay) and King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island. The Committee also approved the proposed management plans for a new ASPA at Parts of Signy Island and adjacent islands, South Orkney Islands, and a new ASPA at Collins Bay, Kyiv Peninsula (Ukraine). The Committee also approved the management plan for a new ASPA for the Wreck of Endurance in the Weddell Sea and agreed to forward it to CCAMLR for approval, in accordance with Decision 9 (2005) before subsequent adoption at ATCM 49.
- (154) Germany introduced WP 10 *Report on the informal discussion on the draft Management Plan of the proposed ASPA Otto-von-Gruber-Gebirge (Dronning Maud Land, East Antarctica)*, which reported on continued intersessional informal discussions on the draft Management Plan of the proposed new ASPA Otto-von-Gruber-Gebirge. Following a first round of comments by six Members, IAATO and ASOC, Germany and China held a video call and agreed to continue their exchange beyond CEP 28, with the aim of reaching consensus on the draft management plan for adoption at ATCM 49. Germany indicated it would continue discussions in video format and reiterated the exceptional values to be protected, including high alpine ecosystems and unique Antarctic freshwater lakes. Germany invited interested Members to participate in these informal discussions and would report back to CEP 29.
- (155) Referring to ASPA 179, Parts of Western Sør Rondane Mountains, Dronning Maud Land, East Antarctica, Belgium noted that in Dronning Maud Land, only two ASPAs protected mountainous areas. Belgium underlined the importance of using reference areas within ASPAs as a tool to protect pristine areas for future research, and indicated that the area of the proposed new ASPA Otto-von-Gruber-Gebirge could serve as a scientific reference area of outstanding interest.
- (156) China appreciated the transparent and science-based communication with Germany, and looked forward to reviewing the forthcoming results of the catchment analysis and digital elevation modelling from the proponent, which would facilitate a shared understanding among interested Parties and in addressing outstanding technical questions. China stood ready to engage in upcoming intersessional discussions to advance the draft management plan.
- (157) The Committee expressed its appreciation for the collaborative approach and encouraged interested Members to participate in future intersessional discussions on this topic.

ii) Revised draft management plans which have not been reviewed by the Subsidiary Group on Management Plans

- (158) The Committee considered five-yearly reviews of two ASPA management plans with major changes that had not been reviewed by the SGMP.

- (159) New Zealand introduced WP 26 *Revision of the Management Plan for Antarctic Specially Protected Area (ASPAs) No. 116 New College Valley, Caughley Beach, Cape Bird, Ross Island*. New Zealand reported that the review had been initiated in response to the ongoing issue of wildlife disturbance through aircraft operations at Cape Bird. It noted that Cape Bird was a complex site for aircraft operations due to the local topography and its close proximity to wildlife, including large penguin colonies. To reduce wildlife disturbance and improve operational safety in the vicinity of the Area, as well as ensure the ongoing protection of the values of the ASPA, New Zealand facilitated a review which involved consultation with the science community, helicopter pilots, environmental managers of National Antarctic Programs operating in or near the Area and other stakeholders. The review also involved field work at Cape Bird in the 2025/26 austral summer season. The proposed management plan revisions were minor, except those relating to air access and overflight provisions.
- (160) The Committee thanked New Zealand for its efforts and approved the revised management plan for ASPA 116 New College Valley, Caughley Beach, Cape Bird, Ross Island.
- (161) India introduced WP 43 rev. 1 *Revision of the Management Plan for Antarctic Specially Protected Area (ASPAs) No 163: Dakshin Gangotri Glacier, Dronning Maud Land*, on the five-yearly review of the Management Plan for ASPA 163 in accordance with Article 6(3) of Annex V to the Protocol. India stated that the revised management plan contained amended boundaries while the total area of the ASPA remained unchanged.
- (162) Noting the significant changes in boundaries, the Committee decided to refer the management plan for review by the SGMP in the 2026/27 intersessional period.
- (163) Argentina reported that revisions to the Management Plans for ASPA 148 Mount Flora, Hope Bay (jointly with the United Kingdom as co-proponent) and ASPA 134 Cierva Point and offshore islands had begun and indicated that both Parties intended to present revised Management Plans for the Committee's consideration at CEP 29.
- (164) The United States presented IP 202 *Report of the 2026 pre-CEP meeting review of ASPAs and ASMA management plans*. The United States noted that ten revised ASPA management plans that had not been reviewed by the SGMP were available for comment through the online CEP Forum. The United States stated that two Members had commented on three management plans and no comments were received on seven management plans.
- (165) The Committee thanked the convenor of the pre-meeting review, Andrew Titmus (United States) for the excellent work undertaken during the intersessional review period.
- (166) The Committee approved the revised management plans for:
- ASPA 101 Taylor Rookery, Mac.Robertson Land (WP 15);
 - ASPA 102 Rookery Islands, Holme Bay, Mac.Robertson Land (WP 16);
 - ASPA 103 Ardery Island and Odbert Island, Budd Coast, Wilkes Land, East Antarctica (WP 17);
 - ASPA 116 New College Valley, Caughley Beach, Cape Bird, Ross Island (WP 26);

- ASPA 120 Pointe-Géologie Archipelago, Terre Adélie (WP 49);
- ASPA 121 Cape Royds, Ross Island (WP 47);
- ASPA 124 Cape Crozier, Ross Island (WP 48);
- ASPA 125 Fildes Peninsula, King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island;
- ASPA 150 Ardley Island (Ardley Peninsula), Maxwell Bay (Fildes Bay), King George Island (25 de Mayo).
- ASPA 166 Port-Martin, Terre Adélie (WP 50);
- ASPA 167 Hawker Island, Princess Elizabeth Land (WP 41);
- ASPA 176 Rosenthal Islands, Anvers Island, Palmer Archipelago (WP 45); and
- ASPA 178 Inexpressible Island and Seaview Bay, Ross Sea (WP 19).

(167) The Committee considered WP 23 *Review of the Management Plans for Antarctic Specially Protected Areas (ASPAs) No. 104 Sabrina Island, Balleny Islands and No. 105 Beaufort Island, McMurdo Sound, Ross Sea (New Zealand)*, which reported the conclusions of the five-yearly review of the two ASPA management plans, and agreed that no changes were required.

CEP advice to the ATCM on new and revised management plans for protected areas

(168) The Committee agreed to forward the following management plans for revised and new protected areas to the ATCM for adoption by means of a Measure:

- ASPA 101 Taylor Rookery, Mac.Robertson Land;
- ASPA 102 Rookery Islands, Holme Bay, Mac.Robertson Land;
- ASPA 103 Ardery Island and Odbert Island, Budd Coast, Wilkes Land, East Antarctica;
- ASPA 116 New College Valley, Caughley Beach, Cape Bird, Ross Island;
- ASPA 120 Pointe-Géologie Archipelago, Terre Adélie;
- ASPA 121 Cape Royds, Ross Island;
- ASPA 124 Cape Crozier, Ross Island;
- ASPA 125 Fildes Peninsula, King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island;
- ASPA 150 Ardley Island (Ardley Peninsula), Maxwell Bay, King George (25 de Mayo/Rey Jorge) Island;
- ASPA 166 Port-Martin, Terre Adélie;
- ASPA 167 Hawker Island, Princess Elizabeth Land;
- ASPA 176 Rosenthal Islands, Anvers Island, Palmer Archipelago;
- ASPA 178 Inexpressible Island and Seaview Bay, Ross Sea;

- NEW ASPA XXX Parts of Signy Island and adjacent islands, South Orkney Islands; and
 - NEW ASPA YYY Collins Bay, Kyiv Peninsula, Graham Coast, Antarctic Peninsula.
- (169) The Committee further agreed to forward the management plan for the proposed new ASPA for the Wreck of Endurance in the Weddell Sea to CCAMLR for approval, in accordance with Decision 9 (2005), to be followed by ATCM adoption through a Measure at ATCM 49.
- (170) The Committee further agreed to advise the ATCM that five-yearly management plans for the following ASPAs had been conducted in accordance with Article 6.3 of Annex V of the Protocol, and that the existing management plans remained in force with the next reviews to be initiated in 2031:
- ASPA 104 Sabrina Island, Balleny Islands
 - ASPA 105 Beaufort Island, McMurdo Sound, Ross Sea.

iii) New draft management plans for protected/managed areas

(171) No papers were considered under this agenda item.

iv) Papers relating to prior assessment of proposed new protected areas

(172) No papers were considered under this agenda item.

v) Other matters relating to management plans for protected/managed areas

- (173) Monaco reported that the instrument of approval of Annex V was signed by H.S.H. the Sovereign Prince of Monaco on 5 May 2026. The approval would enable Monaco to fulfil its obligations under the Protocol and to strengthen its involvement in work relating to protected areas in Antarctica. Following registration with the Depositary Government, Monaco reported it would join Germany and the United States in the assessment and review process of ASPA 180 Danger Islands Archipelago. Monaco stated that existing collaboration with polar and scientific institutions from Germany, the United States, as well as France, had already enabled it to advance scientific research, and expressed its wish that these long-term data collection help ensure the preservation of the Danger Islands Archipelago's biodiversity and the integrity of marine environments around ASPA 180.
- (174) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this agenda item:
- IP 24 *The Danger Islands Expedition 2025 – a successful start of the ASPA 180 management* (Germany).
 - IP 67 *Progress report on review of the Management Plan for ASPA No. 177 Léonie Islands and south-east Adelaide Island, Antarctic Peninsula* (the United Kingdom, the Netherlands).

8b: Historic Sites and Monuments

(175) New Zealand introduced WP 22 *Plans towards the relocation of HSM No. 19, Vince's Cross, Hut Point, Ross Island, due to coastal erosion*, prepared jointly with the United Kingdom. The proponents recalled that HSM No. 19 was a cross erected in February 1904 by members of the British National Antarctic Expedition in remembrance of Able Seaman George T. Vince. They reported that monitoring by the New Zealand Antarctic Heritage Trust had shown that coastal erosion posed a significant risk to the structure's long-term survival and a safety risk to visitors, and that the Trust had identified a nearby potential relocation site. The proponents recommended that the Committee:

- share views on the plans towards relocating Historic Site and Monument No. 19 Vince's Cross, Hut Point, Ross Island, due to coastal erosion; and
- encourage interested Members, Observers and experts, including the Antarctic heritage community, to engage in informal discussions on the relocation plans over the next intersessional period, with the aim of reporting back on the plans to CEP 29.

(176) The Committee thanked the proponents for their paper and supported the proposed relocation, acknowledging the importance of engaging with relevant stakeholders, including the wider Antarctic heritage community, in identifying the best solutions to safeguard heritage under threat from environmental changes in the Antarctic environment, for example as a result of coastal erosion. Several Members expressed interest in participating in informal intersessional discussions and emphasised the importance of ensuring that the relocation provided a long-term solution that would not require the structure to be moved again. Some Members also sought further information on the rationale for selecting the proposed new location, the potential environmental impact of relocating to the new site, and the management of any materials that might remain at the original location. Some Members offered to share information on experience with similar issues and provide relevant material like reports, including photographs and professional assessments.

(177) IAATO reported 286 visitors to the location during the 2025/26 season and expressed appreciation for the continued hard work to preserve historical sites and monuments. IAATO noted that the opportunity to see the historical sites and monuments in person engaged and inspired future Antarctic ambassadors, and that it was pleased to share information on visitor use in this area.

CEP advice to the ATCM on plans towards the relocation of HSM No. 19 Vince's Cross

(178) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered the plans towards relocating Historic Site and Monument (HSM) No. 19, Vince's Cross, Hut Point, Ross Island, due to coastal erosion, and encouraged interested Members, Observers and experts, including the Antarctic heritage community, to engage in informal discussions during the forthcoming intersessional period, with a view to reporting back to CEP 29.

(179) The Committee noted the following Information Papers submitted under this agenda item:

- IP 91 *Assessing the risk of climate change impacts on Antarctic heritage values, Year 3 progress report* (United Kingdom, Australia, New Zealand, Norway)

- IP 110 *Nuevas evidencias materiales sobre presencia indígena en las primeras ocupaciones humanas en la Antártida* (Uruguay)
- IP 159 *Activities for the Development of Conservation Measures of Historic Site and Monument No. 38 (HSM No. 38): Swedish Hut, Snow Hill Island* (Argentina, Sweden).

8c) Area Protection and Management Plans: Site Guidelines

(180) The United Kingdom introduced WP 35 *Proposed updates to two Visitor Site Guidelines*, prepared jointly with IAATO. The United Kingdom noted that climate change in Antarctica was causing changes at many terrestrial and marine sites. It further noted that visitation levels were increasing as tourism levels in Antarctica continued to increase. The United Kingdom recalled that, in accordance with Resolution 4 (2021), IAATO operators and their field staff regularly undertook reviews of individual landing sites to ensure that Visitor Site Guidelines remained current and relevant. The United Kingdom reported that it had also undertaken recent visits to assess several landing locations. Based on these reviews, updates were proposed to the Visitor Site Guidelines for two sites: Site No. 26 Detaille Island (Resolution 4 (2009)) and Site No. 29 Damoy Point (Resolution 1 (2010)). The United Kingdom stated that the revisions reflected changes in the distribution of wildlife and vegetation and provided clarifications on landing guidance to ensure conformity in use and minimise potential confusion. The proponents recommended that the Committee:

- adopt the proposed updates to the Visitor Site Guidelines for Detaille Island and Damoy Point to reflect changes at these sites and ensure consistent visits; and
- agree that revision dates be added to Visitor Site Guidelines whenever they are amended.

(181) The Committee thanked the United Kingdom and IAATO for the revised Visitor Site Guidelines and recognised the timeliness of the proposal as tourist numbers continued to increase. The Committee also welcomed the proposal that revision dates be added to Visitor Site Guidelines whenever they were amended. Some Members noted the need to clarify certain aspects of the Visitor Site Guidelines to ensure the established values of the areas could remain protected.

(182) Following minor revisions, the Committee agreed to approve the revised Visitor Site Guidelines and forward them to the ATCM for adoption. The Committee also requested that the Secretariat update the Site Guidelines on its website.

CEP advice to the ATCM on revised Site Guidelines

(183) The Committee agreed to forward the following revised Visitor Site Guidelines to the ATCM for adoption:

- Detaille Island
 - Damoy Point.
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(184) The Committee noted the following Information Paper submitted under this agenda item:

- IP 199 *IAATO Operator Use of Antarctic Peninsula Landing Sites, Including ATCM and IAATO Site Guidelines: 2025-26 Season Report and Five-Year Overview* (IAATO).

8d) Marine Spatial Protection and Management

(185) ASOC presented IP 126 *ASOC update on marine protected areas in the Southern Ocean 2023-2026*, which updated on CCAMLR marine protected area discussions since ASOC's previous update at ATCM 45. ASOC also noted that MPAs intersect with issues relevant to the ATCM, such as area protection, tourism, wildlife and climate change. As many Members are also CCAMLR Members, ASOC urged those Members to advance their efforts toward agreement on a comprehensive network of CCAMLR marine protected areas. ASOC also recommended that the CEP should expand the network of terrestrial and marine ASPAs and ASMAs and designate the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species.

(186) The Committee thanked ASOC for its paper. Several Members reiterated the importance of a harmonised approach to marine spatial protection and management across the Antarctic Treaty system, and highlighted their commitment to the further development of a representative system of protected areas under the Environmental Protocol and CAMLR Convention, as well as to protecting Antarctic threatened species, and welcomed continued collaboration between the CEP and SC-CAMLR in these areas.

8e) Other Annex V Matters

(187) The convenor of the Subsidiary Group on Management Plans (SGMP), Ji Hee Kim (Republic of Korea), introduced the second part of WP 9 *Subsidiary Group on Management Plans - Report on 2025-2026 intersessional work*. The convenor thanked the coordinators Kevin Hughes (United Kingdom) and Kirstin Storvik (Norway) for coordinating the tasks under SGMP Terms of Reference 4 to 6.

(188) The SGMP's first task under ToR 4 to 6 was to work with relevant Members to ensure progress on the review of management plans overdue for a five-year review. The SGMP convenor reported that no requests were received from Members who may need advice to initiate the five-year review of management plans and reminded Members that the SGMP was available to advise, facilitate or guide such review tasks when necessary.

(189) The SGMP's second task under ToR 4 to 6 was to review and revise, where necessary, existing management tools for the protection and subsequent management of environments and habitats at risk from climate change and to consider if and how they considered climate change issues. The convenor noted during the intersessional period 2025-2026, the SGMP had initiated a review of the Guidelines for the preparation of ASMA Management Plans to consider how effectively the Guidelines addressed climate change. The SGMP had recommended that the Committee endorse the ATCM adopting the revised Guidelines to the preparation of ASMA management plans.

(190) The Committee thanked the Republic of Korea as convenor of the SGMP and acknowledged the work of Kevin Hughes and Kristin Storvik in leading the review.

Members welcomed the revisions and observed that the changes made the Guidelines clearer and easier to use, particularly the additions on management intent, remote sensing, and engagement with CCAMLR, but some further work was required to finalise the revisions.

- (191) The Committee agreed to continue intersessional discussions in the SGMP to further review the revised Guidelines for the preparation of ASMA Management Plans.
- (192) The Committee thanked the SGMP for its advice and agreed to adopt the SGMP's proposed work plan for 2026-27, noting, however, that all Members are free to decide on their individual levels of participation in the work of the SGMP:

Terms of Reference	Suggested tasks
ToR 1 to 3	Review draft management plans referred by CEP for intersessional review and provide advice to proponents (including one pending plan from the previous intersessional period)
	Submit Working Paper to CEP 29 on SGMP ToR 1 to 3
ToR 4 to 6	Work with relevant Parties to ensure progress on the review of management plans overdue for five-year review
	Pre-meeting review of all new and revised Management Plans and submit a summary of recommendations to CEP during the discussion of revised Management Plans.
	Review and update the SGMP work plan (additional task of SGMP considering SGCCR Report): To continue work on CCRWP action 2(e) "Review and revise where necessary existing management tools for protection and subsequent management of environments and habitats at risk from climate change," consider if and how they effectively take climate change issues into consideration and submit a progress report to CEP 29

- (193) The Committee thanked the SGMP for its advice and agreed to adopt the SGMP's proposed work plan for 2026-27
- (194) The Committee noted the increased wide engagement in the SGMP during the last intersessional period, the successful use of mentorship and encouraged even wider participation.
- (195) CCAMLR introduced WP 25 *Improving the accuracy and distribution of spatial data*, prepared jointly with the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat, and noted this was the first paper jointly prepared and submitted to the CEP by the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat and CCAMLR Secretariat. The cooperation had followed the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat's comprehensive update of ASPA and ASMA boundary shapefiles in 2025, which had identified the need for standardised definition and maintenance of geospatial data. Noting that CCAMLR Conservation Measure 91-02 identified ASPAs and ASMAs that include marine areas requiring CCAMLR Members to ensure their vessels were aware of their

guidelines, CCAMLR described their process to specify boundary points of longitude and latitude, which allowed a boundary polygon to be objectively defined. The proponents recommended that the Committee consider providing guidance to Members for the standardised definition of spatial objects to ensure that the spatial datasets associated with ASPAs and ASMAs were documented transparently, able to be revised, and provided in a consistent format.

- (196) The Committee commended the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat and the CCAMLR Secretariat for collaborating on this issue and hoped to see similar collaboration on issues of mutual interest in the future. Some Members stated that this kind of cooperation between the two organisations could contribute to future policy on data sharing and effective environmental protection.
- (197) The Committee recognised the importance of clearly and accurately defining protected area boundaries, and the benefits of developing guidance to support a standardised approach, while acknowledging that additional feature-based boundary descriptions can enhance practical boundary identification in terrestrial areas.
- (198) Many Members welcomed further guidance, capacity building and training by the Secretariats for CEP Members to enhance their understanding of best practices in approaches to spatial boundary definition and enhance data literacy. This would also strengthen the relationship between CEP and SC-CAMLR as recommended by the joint CEP / SC-CAMLR workshop.
- (199) The Committee requested the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat, in consultation with the CCAMLR Secretariat, to facilitate informal discussions to progress the development of spatial guidance, drawing on the SC-CAMLR “Rules for the definition of geospatial polygons and lines used by CCAMLR”, noting this would allow for involvement of Members’ technical experts.

CEP advice to the ATCM on Improving the accuracy and distribution of spatial data

- (200) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had agreed to have informal discussions, facilitated by the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat, to progress the development of a standardised definition of spatial objects, drawing on the SC-CAMLR “Rules for the definition of geospatial polygons and lines used by CCAMLR”.

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- (201) Uruguay introduced WP 52 *Proposal to create an ICG to develop and implement a Monitoring Plan for ASPA No. 150 Ardley Island*, recalling that Ardley Island was a site of high biodiversity, recognised as a CCAMLR Ecosystem Monitoring Programme (CEMP) site, and faced intense pressures from tourism and scientific operations. Uruguay proposed an ICG to advance the development of a coordinated monitoring plan in line with the objectives of the ASPA management plan, with a particular focus on coordination among Members, long-term monitoring, and the prevention of cumulative impacts both inside and outside the area. Uruguay noted that the monitoring plan could also serve as a pilot project for understanding cumulative impacts and improving coordination across the area’s strong marine–terrestrial ecological links.

- (202) The Committee thanked Uruguay for the paper and recognised the high level of scientific, monitoring and logistical activity undertaken within and near Ardley Island. The Committee highlighted the value of improved coordination and information exchange to support the protection of Ardley Island's environmental values and avoid duplication of effort, and noted that experiences developed at Ardley Island could provide useful lessons for other ASPAs where multiple Members undertook activities.
- (203) Many Members supported the establishment of a formal ICG as a mechanism to facilitate collaborative monitoring and coordination, while emphasising the importance of transparency, broad participation and equal opportunities to participate in the discussions. Some Members considered that, given the Management Plan requirement to develop a monitoring plan, and the need for broader participation from Members active in the Area, informal intersessional discussions should continue before a formal ICG was established. It was also noted that establishing an ICG could set a precedent of having dedicated ICGs for individual ASPAs which could become a burden on the Committee's resources; however, it was recognised that Ardley Island was an exceptional case.
- (204) IAATO expressed support for the ongoing collaborative efforts and indicated its willingness to contribute information and data relevant to activities undertaken in areas adjacent to ASPA No. 150.
- (205) In response, Uruguay indicated its willingness to proceed in the manner the Committee considered most appropriate. The Committee supported the continuation of informal intersessional discussions on the development of the monitoring plan, with a view to reporting progress to CEP 29.
- (206) The Committee noted the following Information Paper submitted under this agenda item:
- IP 85 *Update of the volcanic monitoring network on Deception Island* (Spain, Argentina).

Item 9: Climate Change Implications for the Environment

9a) Implementation and Review of the Climate Change Response Work Programme

- (207) The convenor of the Subsidiary Group on Climate Change Response (SGCCR), Nils Vanstappen (Belgium), introduced WP 7 *Report of the CEP Subsidiary Group on Climate Change Response (SGCCR) 2025–2026*, which outlined the work and outputs of the SGCCR during the 2025–2026 intersessional period. The convenor recalled that the SGCCR's mandate was to facilitate the efficient and timely implementation of the CCRWP and reported that the group's work had been progressed through the work of identified leads, discussions on the CEP Forum and two virtual meetings organised at two times of day to facilitate inclusive participation across time zones.
- (208) Referring to the recommendations in the working paper, the convenor highlighted work to implement the CCRWP across seven priority areas:
- 1) assessing the status of climate-vulnerable Antarctic species (Action 6c), led by Norway and France: the convenor referred to further information to be provided by Norway;

- 2) enhancing coordination on climate change response in the marine realm with SC-CAMLR (Action 3e): the convener referred to the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring, which had taken place on 8-9 May just before the Committee meeting as reported in WP 55;
 - 3) decontamination of past sites of activities in the Antarctic area (Action 5f): the convener referred to preliminary considerations on the integration of climate change into the proposed revision of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual, results of which are included in the Annex to WP 24;
 - 4) assessing the risk of climate change for Antarctica's existing and projected infrastructure (Actions 5a and 5d): the convener noted that Members exchanged information during the past intersessional period and referred to further information on this topic provided in COMNAP's WP 8;
 - 5) changing sea-ice (Action 7c), led by Norway and the United Kingdom: the convener explained that work had focused on providing further information on sea-ice in the Antarctic Peninsula; noted that relevant information from this work was provided in IP92; and referred to the relevance of SCAR's WP 32;
 - 6) non-native species introduction, notably through ballast water and biofouling (Action 1b): the convener noted that the SGCCR had decided to prioritize work on assessing the ongoing utility of the Practical Guidelines for Ballast Water Exchange in the Antarctic Treaty Area (ref. Resolution 3 (2006) and referred to IP 60; and
 - 7) with regard to the exercise of taking stock progress towards implementation of the CCRWP: the convener drew the attention of the Committee to Annex 3 of the Working Paper, which comprised an update on progress towards the implementation of priority issues 1, 3, 4 and 5 under the CCRWP.
- (209) The convenor noted recommendation 8 in WP 7 called on all Members to actively engage with the work of the SGCCR.
- (210) At the request of the convener, Norway provided further information on the progress on the priority area on assessing the status of climate-vulnerable Antarctic species. Thanking France for their role as co-lead, and SCAR for their collaboration on this priority action, Norway referred to the progress towards developing a framework to identify climate-vulnerable species using a rolling assessment programme in line with priority 6c from the CCRWP, with a focus on species not currently on the IUCN Red List. Norway further noted the value of adopting a standardized and flexible approach to the objectives of the SGCCR and the Committee and looked forward to further discussions with SCAR.
- (211) The Committee thanked the convenor and all participants in the work of the SGCCR and expressed gratitude to Nils Vanstappen (Belgium) for convening the group, noting the value of the virtual workshop format and other work methods which had helped to generate high levels of engagement.
- (212) Many Members emphasised the urgency of continued monitoring and addressing the implications of climate change, including sea-ice change, and of implementing the CCRWP, as a top priority for the Committee. Those Members recognised the value of the SGCCR as a forum for doing so, allowing for the effective and efficient consideration of

climate change issues. Many Members indicated that they would continue to engage actively in its work. Many Members welcomed the planned workshop on climate-vulnerable Antarctic species. Some Members reiterated the importance of strengthening cooperation in climate monitoring and incorporating climate change consideration in future updates of guidelines, including the Clean Up Manual.

- (213) China agreed with the need for strengthening scientific research but questioned whether a trait-based approach alone would be sufficient, and suggested the assessment should draw on multiple approaches. Considering SCAR currently has no groups working specifically on climate vulnerability assessments, China encouraged parties and observers to continue undertaking relevant research and assessment to facilitate objective outcomes. China welcomed the coordination between CEP and SC-CAMLR and noted the importance to respect the respective mandates and boundaries of each body. China also emphasized the value and necessity of long-term circumpolar monitoring on sea-ice change.
- (214) While expressing willingness to continue to engage with the work of the SGCCR through the broader activities of the Committee, the United States noted that there were other methods to understand the impacts and consequences of a changing Antarctic environment and that the SGCCR was not necessary for the continuation of this work.
- (215) Referring to Recommendation 6 and IP 60, Colombia suggested consideration of a new Resolution incorporating elements related to the implementation of Regulation D-2 of the Ballast Water Management Convention, including contingency measures for ballast water management systems. Colombia also proposed the development of a strategic action plan to minimise the transfer of aquatic organisms through ballast water discharges in the Antarctic Treaty area, including information management and the contingency measures, harmonised procedures, scientific research and risk assessment, and highlighted the importance of monitoring ongoing IMO discussions and implementation experience related to the Ballast Water Management Convention.
- (216) SCAR thanked the convenor and Members for their work and noted that it had been contributing to discussions on climate-vulnerable species, including progress towards the development of a standardised assessment framework likely to involve a trait-based approach. The intention was to begin with a limited number of species and progressively expand the assessments, with an initial technical workshop planned for 2027. In response to comments from a Member, SCAR clarified that while it did not currently have a dedicated group on climate-vulnerability assessments, relevant work was being undertaken through Ant-ICON.
- (217) ASOC welcomed the work of the SGCCR and noted that several areas of preparatory and conceptual work were beginning to lead to concrete actions. ASOC encouraged the Committee to endorse the recommendations contained in WP 7 and continue to apply the best available science and a precautionary approach in responding to climate change impacts in Antarctica.
- (218) The convenor noted the broad support expressed for the SGCCR's work and indicated that the comments received, including Colombia's suggestions on ballast water management and SCAR's clarification regarding Ant-ICON's work on climate-vulnerable species, would inform the group's continuing work, alongside the relevance of the SGCCR's work to the ongoing development of the Antarctic tourism framework.

- (219) The Committee acknowledged the SGCCR's contribution to the implementation of the CCRWP, and noted the many papers across the agenda on this topic. The Committee supported continued information exchange with SC-CAMLR while noting that the two bodies had different mandates. Recognising the high priority of this work and the value of the SGCCR as a forum for bringing together work on cross-cutting issues, the Committee endorsed the recommendations contained in WP 7.

CEP advice to the ATCM on implementation of the Climate Change Response Work Programme

- (220) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had progressed work to implement the CCRWP (2024) during the 2025–2026 intersessional period. The key areas of focus included CCRWP actions related to:

- assessing the status of climate-vulnerable Antarctic species (Action 6c): the Committee considered the appropriateness of a trait-based framework for assessing the vulnerability of Antarctic species to climate change, noted the scientific workshop on this topic tentatively to be organised by SCAR in the first quarter of 2027, and encouraged Members to engage in continued intersessional discussions, including on which (groups of) species should be given priority;
- enhancing coordination on climate change response in the marine realm with SC-CAMLR (Action 3e): the Committee noted the outcomes of the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring held in Hiroshima on 8 - 9 May 2026 (WP 55), and agreed to further strengthen coordination with SC-CAMLR on these matters while recognising the different mandates of the two bodies;
- decontamination of past sites of activities in the Antarctic area (Action 5f): the Committee encouraged Members and Observers to continue exchanging information on this topic, and many Members supported the integration of climate change considerations in the revision of the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual (WP 24);
- assessing the risk of climate change for Antarctica's existing and projected infrastructure and associated environmental consequences (Actions 5a and 5d): the Committee encouraged Members and Observers to continue exchanging information on the risks to infrastructure, including in light of the ongoing work of COMNAP (WP 8);
- changing sea-ice (Action 7c): the Committee took note of the progress made and encouraged continued work on this topic, including through SCAR's continued provision of advice (WP 32);
- non-native species introduction, notably through ballast water and biofouling (Action 1b): the Committee encouraged Members to participate in planned informal work led by Australia, New Zealand and the United Kingdom to assess the ongoing utility of the *Practical Guidelines for Ballast Water Exchange in the Antarctic Treaty Area* (Resolution 3 (2006)); and
- stocktaking of progress towards implementation of the CCRWP: the Committee noted the assessment of progress set out in Annex 3 to WP 7, and many Parties

encouraged further engagement and active participation in the work of the SGCCR and the timely implementation of the CCRWP.

- (221) SCAR introduced WP 32 *Evolution, Drivers and Impacts of Antarctic Sea-Ice Change*, prepared in response to work undertaken through the SGCCR. The paper provided a comprehensive circumpolar update on Antarctic sea-ice change to support the Committee's work in understanding the implications of sea-ice decline for Antarctic ecosystems, human activity and the Earth System. Following a small increase in sea-ice extent between 1979 and 2015, Antarctic sea ice had declined sharply since 2016, with recent losses considered exceptional in the context of natural variability and indicative of an abrupt regime shift. In 2023, Antarctic summer sea ice experienced its most extreme minimum to date, with some areas 50-80 per cent below the long-term average and since 2017, sea-ice season duration has shortened by up to 50 days. The most significant driver of sea ice decline is a sustained build-up of heat in the upper Southern Ocean, and continued increases in heat are expected to drive further decline. Observed and projected sea-ice decline had significant implications for Antarctic ecosystems, including shifting food-web dynamics, habitat loss and changes in prey availability, with impacts on predators including penguins and seals. Sea ice loss also weakens global ocean circulation, contributes to ice shelf instability contributing to global sea-level rise, and affects global ocean productivity, with implications for human livelihoods. SCAR recommended that Members:
- continue to identify priority information needs related to Antarctic sea-ice change so that future updates from SCAR could focus on the most relevant research and provide advice on understanding and mitigating ongoing sea-ice change; and
 - support ongoing and increased observations related to sea ice to improve predictions and inform outcomes for system functioning, including for Antarctic marine life such as penguins and seals.
- (222) The Committee thanked SCAR for the paper and welcomed the comprehensive update on Antarctic sea-ice change and its implications for Antarctica. The Committee highlighted the importance of continued observations, research and modelling to improve understanding of regional variability and the consequences of sea-ice decline for Antarctic species, ecosystems and infrastructure.
- (223) Colombia welcomed the contributions made by SCAR and supported the Working Paper, while noting that it was developing capabilities in ice-trajectory modelling for maritime safety in the Antarctic through the integration of global wind, wave and ocean current data with satellite information.
- (224) The Committee supported SCAR's recommendations, and many Members noted their own national efforts and emphasised the value of ongoing international collaboration through initiatives such as Antarctica InSync and the forthcoming International Polar Year.
- (225) Belgium introduced WP 55 *Report of the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring, Hiroshima, Japan, 8-9 May 2026*, prepared jointly with the United Kingdom. Belgium and the United Kingdom informed the CEP that the Joint Workshop of CEP and SC-CAMLR was held at the International Conference Center Hiroshima, Hiroshima, Japan, from 8 to 9 May 2026. The workshop was co-convened by Rachel Cavanagh (United Kingdom) and Nils Vanstappen (Belgium) and had 114

registered participants. The workshop aimed to strengthen cooperation and coordination between the CEP and SC-CAMLR to monitor and manage the effects of climate change in the Antarctic.

(226) Belgium and the United Kingdom reported that the workshop was highly constructive and led to a comprehensive set of recommendations for CEP and SC-CAMLR. The convenors noted that these would help guide cooperation between the two committees going forward. The United Kingdom acknowledged the guidance of the co-convenor to the previous Joint CEP / SC-CAMLR workshop, Dr Susie Grant, in the preparation of the workshop. The convenors recommended that the Committee:

- endorse the 2026 Joint Workshop recommendations;
- develop pathways for implementation of these recommendations; and
- review progress on these recommendations annually.

(227) The Committee commended both Belgium and the United Kingdom for leading the workshop, Japan as its host, Australia, Belgium, France, the Republic of Korea, New Zealand and IAATO for their financial contribution, and the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat and the CCAMLR Secretariat for their support. Noting that the last joint workshop had taken place over a decade ago, the Committee welcomed this effort to further enhance cooperation and information-sharing between the two committees, on overlapping areas of interest. The participants expressed appreciation for the format of the workshop using breakout groups, which had allowed for inclusive discussions and co-learning among participants. Most Members noted the mismatch between decision-making timeframes and the observed pace of climate change in Antarctica, including rapid sea ice loss and warming ocean waters, underscoring the need for cooperation between CEP and SC-CAMLR.

(228) Several Members acknowledged that the committees had different structures, but shared important roles to progress a harmonised and effective Antarctic Treaty system-wide approach to protecting and conserving the Antarctic marine environment and dependent and associated ecosystems.

CEP advice to the ATCM on the outcomes of the joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop

(229) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM it:

- Recognised the valuable contributions of the joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshop to the Committee;
- Acknowledged the recommendations as a basis that can guide ongoing work in the intersessional period; and
- Agreed to review progress of work annually.

(230) The Committee noted the following Information Paper submitted under this agenda item:

- IP 92 *Information on sea ice in the Antarctic Peninsula region to inform the work of the Subsidiary Group on Climate Change Response (SGCCR)* (United Kingdom, Norway)

(231) The Committee noted the following Background Paper submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 74 *Reconstrucción paleoceanográfica en Isla Rey Jorge: avances y aportes al estudio del cambio climático* (Peru).

Other Climate Change Matters

(232) The United Kingdom introduced WP 3 *Climate change impacts on the Antarctic Peninsula: implications for governance, environmental protection and operations*. The United Kingdom outlined recent peer-reviewed scientific evidence on current and projected climate change impacts in the Antarctic Peninsula region. Noting that the Antarctic Peninsula was a sentinel region for climate change, where impacts were occurring earlier and more rapidly than in most other parts of Antarctica, the United Kingdom stressed that this could potentially implicate other regions through atmospheric and oceanic connections. The United Kingdom detailed that the research had shown that the Antarctic Peninsula had experienced rapid warming, associated with more frequent and intense extreme weather events, including heatwaves, heavy precipitation, and atmospheric rivers, causing record surface melt and disrupting ecosystems and human activities. The research had further shown that under medium-high and very high emission scenarios, the number of days with temperatures above 0 °C was projected to more than double by the end of the century, significantly lengthening the melt season and increasing the likelihood of compound extreme events. The United Kingdom noted that changes in temperature, sea ice, and ocean conditions were already affecting the marine and terrestrial ecosystems of the Antarctic Peninsula and posed a risk to scientific infrastructure and marine operations. The United Kingdom recommended that the CEP:

- encourage broader engagement in the SGCCR and support more rapid progress on its identified tasks; and
- provide advice to the ATCM on options for more ambitious, adaptive and forward-looking approaches.

(233) The Committee thanked the United Kingdom for its paper. Most Members expressed concern about particularly rapid and consequential climate-driven change in the Antarctic Peninsula, and stressed the urgency to act. Several Members shared information about their ongoing monitoring efforts.

CEP advice to the ATCM on climate change impacts on the Antarctic Peninsula

(234) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that research showed the Antarctic Peninsula was experiencing environmental changes such as rapid sea ice loss, warming ocean waters and coastal erosion; that these changes were already affecting marine and terrestrial ecosystems; and posed risks to scientific infrastructure and marine operations.

(235) The Committee encouraged Members' engagement across all of the Committee's work plans to address environmental impacts on Antarctica, including in the SGCCR.

(236) The Committee agreed that options for more ambitious, adaptive and forward-looking approaches should be considered in its advice to the ATCM.

- (237) COMNAP introduced WP 8 *Built Infrastructure in a Changing Antarctica: Challenges and opportunities encountered by National Antarctic Programs*, which provided examples of how changing Antarctic conditions may affect built infrastructure, which may lead to environmental impacts. COMNAP noted that national Antarctic programmes were already considering how a changing Antarctica may impact their built infrastructure as a matter of safety, to ensure continued support for research, to meet their Antarctic Treaty System environmental obligations, and to support operational planning. COMNAP further noted that consideration of this complex topic remained ongoing and recognised that the issue extended beyond environmental impacts alone. Recalling recommendations agreed at ATCM 47, para 365, COMNAP recommended that Members:
- support the sharing of information on a changing Antarctica, the impact of those changes on their built infrastructure, and on any environmental consequences of that impact, especially to support the Committee in its discussions on the issue; and
 - continue to support research on local and regional Antarctic changes to clarify uncertainty around changing Antarctic conditions.
- (238) The Committee thanked COMNAP for the paper and welcomed its continued work to understand the implications of changing Antarctic conditions for built infrastructure and operations. Members shared examples of impacts already being experienced in different regions of Antarctica, including coastal erosion, permafrost degradation, increased storm events, ice instability and changing operational conditions affecting logistics and fuel storage. Several Members noted that climate change impacts on infrastructure and operations were no longer a future concern but already a reality, affecting operational safety, infrastructure resilience, and environmental risk management in Antarctica.
- (239) Several Members highlighted the importance of continued information exchange, research, monitoring and collaboration among national Antarctic programmes to improve understanding of local and regional changes affecting Antarctic infrastructure and operations, support adaptation and operational planning, and minimise associated environmental risks. Members also noted the value of sharing practical experiences and mitigation strategies, including through COMNAP.
- (240) The United States highlighted the importance of focusing research and CEP discussions on specific environmental changes in Antarctica and their operational and environmental consequences, rather than broader approaches.
- (241) The Committee agreed that environmental change in Antarctica had implications beyond the natural environment and was increasingly affecting infrastructure and operations. The Committee noted Members' experiences and supported both recommendations in WP 8, particularly continued information sharing and support for further research into changing Antarctic conditions.
- (242) SCAR introduced WP 31 *Antarctic Climate Change and the Environment: 2026 Update*, which provided an overview of recent scientific developments on climate change in Antarctica and its implications for Antarctic and global systems. Abrupt changes were already underway, including continued sea-ice decline and glacial retreat, with growing evidence that some ice-loss thresholds in West Antarctica could be reached at relatively low levels of warming, with implications for long-term sea-level rise and reduced Southern Ocean carbon uptake through impacts on iron availability and primary productivity.

Climate change was also affecting Antarctic biodiversity and ecosystems, with projected declines in krill habitat under high-emission scenarios, impacts on seals and penguins associated with sea-ice change, and penguin colony locations along the Antarctic Peninsula warming four times faster than the continental average, and the species at them advancing the start of their breeding seasons. SCAR noted that terrestrial biodiversity responses varied between regions and species groups. SCAR emphasised that many projected changes were not inevitable and could still be mitigated through rapid reductions in global greenhouse gas emissions.

- (243) SCAR recommended that the Committee encourage Members to continue their efforts to support research to understand the changing Antarctic environment across physical and living systems, and that clear communication to a wider audience of the impacts of climate change on Antarctica and its Earth System implications remained an important way to ensure that ongoing impacts to the region were understood and reduced.
- (244) Many Members welcomed the annual update on Antarctic climate change and the environment and expressed concern at the rapid and accelerating environmental changes observed across Antarctica — including sea-ice decline, ice-sheet loss, biodiversity change, and impacts on Antarctic species and ecosystems — and noted the importance of continued research, long-term monitoring and international scientific cooperation and emphasised the importance of communicating Antarctic climate change and its global implications to wider audiences, including in climate policy discussions. Several Members shared examples of ongoing national research, monitoring and communication efforts related to krill, glaciers, biodiversity, microbial communities and ecosystem change, and highlighted the value of international initiatives such as Antarctica InSync and the forthcoming IPY-5.
- (245) New Zealand highlighted that the Committee has tools at its disposal to address the impacts of climate change in Antarctica, including tools that can be used to build resilience within Antarctic environmental systems and provide refugia to species and regions that are increasingly under pressure.
- (246) The United States emphasised the importance of focusing research and CEP discussions on specific environmental changes in Antarctica and their direct implications for Antarctic environments and operations, and indicated that, while it supported research focused on specific changes, it could not support broader communication campaigns.
- (247) WMO welcomed SCAR's update, noted that the findings complemented discussions under WP 3 and WP 8 regarding rapid and potentially irreversible environmental changes in Antarctica, and highlighted the importance of sustained observations, prediction capabilities, data exchange and international scientific cooperation to respond to these changes.
- (248) In response to questions from Members, SCAR clarified that "*abrupt*" referred to rapid changes occurring over relatively short timeframes, including the sea-ice decline observed since 2015 and recent retreat of the Hektor Glacier of 25km over two years. SCAR also noted that existing tools under the Antarctic Treaty System could help mitigate some impacts from climate change and welcomed Member support for long-term observations and continued international collaboration.

- (249) The Committee thanked SCAR for the paper and supported continued research to understand the changing Antarctic environment, while recognising differing views among Members regarding broader communication approaches.

CEP advice to the ATCM on the 2026 update to the Antarctic Climate Change and the Environment report

- (250) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered SCAR's 2026 update on Antarctic Climate Change and the Environment, and noted the evidence of abrupt and accelerating environmental changes already underway in Antarctica, including continued sea-ice decline, glacial retreat, and impacts on Antarctic biodiversity and ecosystems, with implications for Antarctic and global systems and supported continued research to understand the changing Antarctic environment.
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- (251) Türkiye introduced IP 94 *Connecting Antarctica to COP31: Strengthening Ocean-Climate Policy Linkages*, which highlighted the central role of Antarctica and the Southern Ocean in the global climate system and emphasised the importance of strengthening linkages between Antarctic science, ocean systems and global climate policy. Türkiye noted that the 31st Conference of the Parties (COP31) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), provide an opportunity to enhance the visibility of Antarctic science and environmental governance within broader climate discussions. Türkiye highlighted the importance of Antarctic observations and scientific data for improving understanding of sea-level rise, ocean circulation and climate feedback mechanisms, and encouraged continued international cooperation to strengthen the science-policy interface and support the integration of Antarctic scientific findings into global climate decision-making processes.
- (252) The Committee thanked Türkiye for the paper. Many Members welcomed the emphasis placed on the importance of Antarctic science and observations for understanding global climate processes and informing international climate discussions. Several Members highlighted the value of strengthening links between Antarctic research, ocean systems and broader climate policy processes, while noting the importance of continued science-based cooperation and communication.
- (253) ASOC introduced IP 153 *Climate response report card 2026*, which updated earlier report cards that provided an overview of Antarctic climate science by also reviewing the ATCM's response to climate change. In the decade since the previous joint CEP-SC-CAMLR workshops in 2016 and 2026, evidence of climate change had become clearer and more alarming. Noting the strong scientific basis for action, ASOC expressed appreciation for CEP Members that sought more ambitious climate action and noted that the Protocol provides many tools for climate response, supported by a substantial and growing body of scientific knowledge. Looking ahead, ASOC expressed hope that the CEP would focus on concrete actions, or at minimum actionable advice, to address Antarctica's greatest threat with the urgency it deserves.
- (254) The Committee thanked ASOC for the paper and noted that, while the report card was critical of aspects of the Antarctic Treaty System's response to climate change, it could also serve as an encouragement to strengthen ongoing efforts. The Committee noted the importance of moving increasingly towards practical action.

(255) The Committee noted the following Information Papers were also submitted under this agenda item:

- IP 149 *Strengthening Cryosphere Observations and Data Systems* (WMO)
- IP 151 *The Climate and Cryosphere (CliC) Project of the World Climate Research Programme (WCRP)* (WMO)
- IP 154 *Polar Coupled Analysis and Prediction for Services (PCAPS)* (WMO)
- IP 169 *Southern Ocean Seasonal Cycle experiments (SOSCEX and SCALE): Closing the seasonal gaps on the distributions of iron and bioactive trace metals in the Southern Ocean* (South Africa)
- IP 170 *Multidecadal Changes in Southern Ocean Phytoplankton: Shifting Bloom Phenology, Declining Net Primary Production, and Increasing Iron Stress* (South Africa)
- IP 176 *Acidificación oceánica en el manejo ecosistémico de áreas marinas en Antártida* (Ecuador)
- IP 177 *Monitoreo de gases de efecto invernadero y su relevancia para la gestión ambiental antártica* (Ecuador)

(256) The Committee noted the following Background Papers were also submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 26 *Permafrost changes in King George Island since 1950* (Portugal, the Republic of Korea, Norway)
- BP 43 *UN Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences (2025–2034)* (ASOC)
- BP 73 *Caracterización del ecosistema glaciar austral utilizando trazadores radiactivos de Tritio y Radón* (Peru)

Item 10: Environmental Monitoring and State of the Environment Reporting

(257) Germany introduced WP 11 *Towards Structural Consolidation of Tourism-Related Monitoring under the Antarctic Treaty System*, inviting the Committee to consider how tourism-related monitoring initiatives could be better integrated to ensure that monitoring practices developed in a coordinated and policy-relevant way. Welcoming the parallel initiatives that were concurrently being prepared to address the Committee's obligations related to environmental monitoring, Germany observed the need to engage in discussion on consolidating approaches including discussions on the development of a framework on Antarctic tourism, priorities on the Committee's Five-year work plan, and work toward the establishment of an international environmental monitoring framework. Germany noted the need to initiate structured discussion on this topic given the rapid expansion of tourism in Antarctica and encouraged the Committee to discuss potential mechanisms to implement a more coordinated approach. Germany recommended that the Committee discuss:

- how existing monitoring-related priorities in the Five-year Work Plan (including actions under 1b and 2a) could be implemented in a coordinated manner;

- possible ways for enhancing alignment and interoperability between ongoing monitoring-relevant initiatives, including focused workshop discussions or voluntary coordination efforts among interested Parties; and
 - guidance on how monitoring coherence should be advanced within its existing governance framework.
- (258) The Committee thanked Germany for bringing this topic to its attention and acknowledged the timely nature of this proposal, given the growth of tourism in Antarctica and the parallel development of multiple different monitoring initiatives. The Committee noted that the topic of monitoring tourism-related activities was part of its Five-year Work Plan and acknowledged the relevance of the outputs of the Joint CEP / SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring, particularly the emphasis placed on long-term monitoring and the addition of cumulative impacts as a joint priority area. The Committee noted the need to structure and organise various monitoring activities in order to effectively assess the impacts of tourism in Antarctica.
- (259) Several Members noted that it was important that work on this topic followed an incremental approach to allow for the timely initiation of coordination processes. To this end, some Members noted that it would be more valuable to focus efforts on collecting comparable datasets rather than establishing a single, overarching monitoring programme. Several Members noted that it was important to consider existing monitoring tools to avoid duplicating effort.
- (260) The Committee acknowledged the complexity of the issue and noted the relationship with different ongoing initiatives on monitoring and that the recommendations set out in WP 11 were a useful starting point for further consideration of the coordination of tourism-related monitoring in Antarctica, further noting that this work would have financial implications. The Committee agreed that informal intersessional discussions would be the most appropriate avenue to continue to this work, with Germany agreeing to lead these discussions.

CEP advice to the ATCM on tourism-related monitoring

- (261) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered the structural consolidation of tourism-related monitoring under the Antarctic Treaty System (WP 11), and that in its consideration the Committee:
- acknowledged the timely nature of the proposal in light of the growth of tourism in Antarctica and the parallel development of multiple monitoring initiatives;
 - recognised the relevance of this work to its Five-year Work Plan and to the outcomes of the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring, as well as the discussions on the development of a comprehensive and consistent framework on tourism and other non-governmental activities, and on an international environmental monitoring framework;
 - noted the importance of an incremental approach focused on the collection of comparable datasets and the avoidance of duplication with existing monitoring tools, while acknowledging the financial implications of such work; and

- agreed to undertake informal intersessional discussions on this topic, with Germany acting as convenor, with a view to reporting progress to CEP 29.

(262) SCAR introduced WP 33 *Long-term monitoring status of Antarctic nearshore marine and terrestrial flora and fauna*, which summarised the findings of a synthesis of published studies on the monitoring of flora and fauna in Antarctic terrestrial and nearshore marine environments. SCAR reported that most monitoring efforts had been concentrated on the Antarctic Peninsula, with less than 10 per cent taking place within ASPAs. SCAR further reported that long-term monitoring efforts were focused on more charismatic species, such as penguins and seals, with limited data available on cryptic taxa and microbial communities. SCAR noted that the limited availability of co-located environmental and biological data made it difficult to attribute drivers of biological change and noted that comparison was complicated by the lack of standardisation in data collection methods. SCAR further noted that the use of artificial intelligence may allow for future harmonisation of disparate datasets. SCAR also highlighted the value of research initiatives such as Antarctica InSync and IPY-5 as avenues to improve long-term monitoring.

(263) SCAR recommended that the Committee encourage Members to:

- support the commitment of national resources to existing and new nearshore and terrestrial monitoring programmes;
- support alignment of ongoing research programmes in meteorology, climate science and biology to improve understanding of the drivers of biodiversity change and strengthen options and decisions for mitigation;
- utilise advances in automated sensing and analysis platforms, alongside new capabilities in AI and machine learning, to monitor environments in real time (e.g., ANTOS, INACH Red and SAEF AIoT), improving responses and decision-making options and supporting more informed and responsive management decisions; and
- collaborate, including with COMNAP and SCAR, to leverage upcoming international programmes (the 5th International Polar Year and Antarctica InSync) to develop a sustained, circum-Antarctic platform for assessing environmental change and biodiversity responses, thereby strengthening the evidence needed to deliver the Protocol's goals.

(264) The Committee thanked SCAR for its synthesis and noted that the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring as well as the ongoing work towards an international environmental monitoring framework, had affirmed the importance of long-term monitoring in Antarctica, and that initiatives such as Antarctica InSync and IPY-5 provide opportunities to facilitate sustained circumpolar and regional monitoring efforts.

(265) Several Members noted that although ensuring comparable data was valuable, total standardisation may not be necessary given that the varying objectives of different monitoring initiatives may require different approaches. Several Members recognised that some data may not have been included in SCAR's synthesis and encouraged Members to share relevant data and research activities. Several Members outlined the efforts of their

national Antarctic programmes to contribute to long-term datasets on Antarctic flora and fauna.

- (266) SCAR thanked the Committee for its support, noting particular interest in automated and remote-sensing techniques to enhance real-time monitoring of physical and biological parameters. SCAR also reiterated the importance of long-term funding allocation, acknowledging that this would require prioritising monitoring activities.
- (267) The Committee supported the recommendations outlined in WP 33, noting the value of enhancing coordination of monitoring activities in Antarctica to support the Committee's work across a number of cross-cutting issues.

CEP advice to the ATCM on long-term biodiversity monitoring

- (268) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had discussed the long-term monitoring of Antarctic nearshore marine and terrestrial flora and fauna, and encouraged Parties to:

- commit national resources to existing and new nearshore and terrestrial monitoring programmes;
- align ongoing research programmes across meteorology, climate science and biology to better understand the drivers of biodiversity change;
- take advantage of advances in automated sensing, artificial intelligence and machine learning for real-time monitoring of Antarctic environments; and
- collaborate, including with COMNAP and SCAR, to leverage the 5th International Polar Year and Antarctica InSync in developing a sustained, circum-Antarctic platform for monitoring environmental change and biodiversity responses.

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- (269) The Netherlands introduced WP 20 *Towards an international framework for environmental monitoring: Report of the ICG and way forward*, prepared jointly with Uruguay. The Netherlands recalled that the ICG had been established at CEP 25 to develop an international framework for environmental monitoring in support of implementation of the Protocol. Progress during the intersessional period had been more limited than anticipated, owing to capacity constraints and the complexity of the issue. Discussions in the ICG, at the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring, and through related initiatives such as SCAR's ANTOS had highlighted both the importance of environmental monitoring and the need for a clearer, more focused approach. The Netherlands also recalled that CEP 27 had reached a general agreement on a description of the framework, its objectives, and a possible structure based on climate change, biodiversity loss and pollution. The Netherlands emphasised that Members often understood the term "monitoring" differently, and stressed the importance of proceeding incrementally, keeping the framework policy-oriented, pragmatic and linked to clear management needs. The proponents recommended that the Committee:

- extend the mandate of the ICG for a further two-year period to continue its work on the Terms of Reference agreed at CEP 27, including the provision of an interim report to CEP 29, and accept the offer of the Netherlands and Uruguay to continue as convenors;

- hold an initial exchange at CEP 28 to identify key policy areas and needs to guide systematic monitoring of climate change, biodiversity loss and pollution in Antarctica, taking into account the Working Paper relating to the SCAR publication, the outcomes of the joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshop, the discussions in WG 3, and relevant work undertaken in the ATS;
- request the convenors, based on the discussions, to develop a discussion note presenting the initial key policy areas and needs identified for subsequent exchange in the ICG following CEP 28;
- invite SCAR (and, as appropriate, COMNAP and SC-CAMLR) to support the ICG over the two-year period in identifying key parameters, indicators, guidelines and methodologies most relevant to the policy areas identified, with priority given to parameters relevant to discussions on a tourism framework; and
- request the ICG to report at CEP 29, including the recommended next steps towards CEP 30.

- (270) The Committee thanked the Netherlands and Uruguay for their continued leadership of the ICG and acknowledged the complex and longstanding nature of the work. Members agreed that environmental monitoring was fundamental to the Committee's work under the Protocol and essential for informing environmental management and decision-making in Antarctica. Many Members emphasised that monitoring should be clearly linked to policy and management needs, and that priorities should be set by identifying what information was needed, what should be monitored, and which parameters and indicators should be prioritised. Several Members also stressed the need for a focused, incremental, and practical approach that builds on existing work across the Antarctic Treaty System, including the Joint CEP/SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring, SCAR initiatives such as ANTOS and SOOS, tourism-related discussions, and the CEP's science and knowledge needs. Several Members further noted the importance of clarifying the different uses of the term “monitoring”: monitoring environmental state and change, operational monitoring, or monitoring to support management responses.
- (271) Several Members suggested that further progress on developing an international environmental monitoring framework could be advanced through other ongoing work of the Committee, in particular the proposed review of the Committee's science and knowledge needs under WP 14. Members considered that review could help identify policy priorities, knowledge gaps, monitoring objectives and key parameters as a first step towards developing an overarching framework. Some Members suggested that the ICG could be paused while this related work progressed, to avoid duplication and ensure coherence.
- (272) SCAR expressed a strong interest in the continued development of the framework and highlighted existing initiatives, including ANTOS and SOOS, that could assist this work to better understand the current landscape of existing monitoring efforts. Referring to IP 125, SCAR noted the development of SOOS tools (including maps of observational coverage and an inventory of long-term monitoring programmes) and availability of standardised ANTOS sensor platform, and informed the Committee of planned workshops and symposia on monitoring and observing systems, encouraging Parties to engage in these initiatives and in future discussions on the framework.

- (273) Uruguay and the Netherlands thanked the Committee for the discussion and underscored the need to make further progress to coordinate efforts to enhance systematic monitoring for the achievement of the key policy objectives of the Committee. Uruguay observed that environmental monitoring had been a long-standing topic for the Committee, noting the challenges involved in monitoring the state of the Antarctic environment, recalling the distinction drawn between operational monitoring and State of Antarctic Environment Reporting (SAER) in earlier ICG work.
- (274) The Committee confirmed its commitment to the importance of working towards establishing an international environmental monitoring framework.
- (275) The Committee agreed to pause the formal Intersessional Contact Group for a year, and for informal intersessional discussions to develop a roadmap on the way forward to develop an international framework for environmental monitoring to be considered at the next CEP meeting.

CEP Advice to ATCM on the international environmental monitoring framework

- (276) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM that it had considered the report of the ICG on the development of an international framework for environmental monitoring and had reaffirmed the vital importance of environmental monitoring for the Committee to fulfil its objective of effective implementation of the Environment Protocol.
- (277) The Committee agreed to advise the ATCM it had paused the ICG for one year, while informal intersessional discussions to develop a roadmap towards such a framework took place, and encouraged consideration of next steps towards a framework to be informed by discussions arising in the review of the Committee's science and knowledge needs.
- (278) The co-convenors of the ICG will report to CEP 29 on the outcomes of these informal intersessional discussions.

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- (279) Norway introduced WP 36 *Inventory of Sites of Past Activities: Outcomes of Intersessional Discussions and Suggested Approach*. Norway recalled that the development of such an inventory was a priority action under the CEP Five-year Work Plan, and that the Committee had endorsed the recommendations of ATCM 47 WP 42. Members had continued informal discussions during the intersessional period, structured around three key questions identified at CEP 27: what the inventory would be used for, on what scale and at what level of detail, and how to define past activities. Based on those discussions, the paper proposed a three-phased approach. The pilot phase would focus on the CEP's core priorities: supporting environmental impact assessments and cumulative impact assessments; identifying inviolate and wilderness areas; and supporting decisions related to clean-up efforts. The inventory could then be extended to high value applications, including identifying sites where past activities may affect scientific measurements. Subsequently, the inventory could be extended to a comprehensive record of human activities, potentially including tourism and non-governmental activity data. Norway recommended that the Committee:

- comment on and discuss the themes and suggested potential way forward presented in this paper, and advise whether key elements have been captured or important aspects are missing.
 - provide some initial thoughts on practical aspects around an inventory of sites of past activities, such as hosting and data management; and
 - encourage interested Members to continue the discussions, with a particular focus on what could be included in a pilot phase, and including also discussions on practical approaches to structure, format, and data requirements
- (280) Noting the complexity of the topic and the need for a comprehensive yet flexible approach, the Committee thanked Norway for leading the intersessional discussions and endorsed the recommendations in WP 36.
- (281) Members acknowledged the inventory's usefulness throughout the CEP's work, including EIAs, tracking of cumulative impacts, waste management, and updating the Clean-Up Manual. Members also noted that an inventory could assist operators and competent authorities in planning activities and in maintaining institutional knowledge of past activities. Noting that such an inventory was long overdue, they appreciated the progressive and phased approach taken by Norway. Members underlined the question of how to capture and store data was an important one, and that the format needed to be practical and interoperable with existing systems such as the EIES. Members showed broad support for a Geographic Information System (GIS)-based approach, noting that an interactive mapped format would be particularly valuable. Some Members pointed out that sharing even basic information about sites of past activities was helpful. Other Members noted it was sometimes difficult to determine whether a site had been documented before and whether remains were historical. Noting that remains could be classified in multiple ways (IP 108 and IP 110), and that it was difficult to define recurring or multi-year activities as past activities, some Members stated that a conceptual analysis was necessary to define what the notion of past activities entailed. Some Members raised specific questions, including whether sites affected by accidents should fall within the scope, and at what point seasonal or recurring activities should be considered "past". On practical aspects, some Members expressed a preference for a centralised approach linked to the Secretariat that would support data consolidation, filtering, and searchable access.
- (282) The Secretariat reported that information on sites of past activities was already available in an interactive map on its website, drawn from the data Members had provided to the EIES. The Secretariat noted it stood ready to consider any requests arising from the intersessional work.
- (283) ASOC underlined that the inventory would serve as a valuable monitoring tool and result in increased transparency, and noted that while the classification of plastic debris as a historical artefact in IP 108 was interesting, it remained unclear how this related to Annex III to the Environmental Protocol.
- (284) Several Members expressed specific support for advancing the work through a pilot phase, as a means of developing the tool from a technical viewpoint, testing its applicability, and drawing lessons from its applications. The Committee encouraged interested Members to continue further informal intersessional work on the inventory, including practical approaches to structure, format, and data requirements.

- (285) Portugal presented IP 71 *Trace elements in soils of the Antarctic ice-free areas*, which provided a regional synthesis of trace element concentrations across Antarctic ice-free soils, with relevance to sites where scientific research stations were known sources of contamination and to areas of permafrost. Portugal invited Members to reinforce cooperation on research and environmental monitoring in ice-free areas, noting the connection to Antarctic groundwaters highlighted in the SCAR Lecture.
- (286) Portugal presented IP 146 *Towards a climate-smart pathway for ocean management in Antarctica*, prepared jointly with Canada and France, which provided examples of how mapping tools could support adaptive, holistic ocean planning and management in response to the accelerating pace of climate change. Portugal noted the alignment of this approach with the recommendations of the Joint CEP / SC-CAMLR Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring (WP 55) and encouraged Members to consider its relevance to the spatial management and protection of Antarctic systems alongside existing tools such as ASPAs and marine protected areas. Portugal informed the Committee of a forthcoming symposium on the topic at the SCAR Open Science Conference in Oslo.
- (287) Poland presented IP 122 *Progress of environmental inventory in the Destruction Bay and North Foreland areas (King George Island) during the 2025/26 season*, which described environmental inventory work undertaken to support the assessment of potential new ASPAs. Poland indicated that it intended to continue these activities and to report further at CEP 29.
- (288) SCAR presented IP 113 *Plastic pollution in Antarctica: a brief review of current knowledge*, prepared in response to Resolution 5 (2025), which reviewed existing scientific knowledge on plastic pollution in the Antarctic Treaty area. SCAR reported that microplastics had been found in every part of the Antarctic environment examined to date, including in species throughout the marine food web, and that the cumulative impacts of plastics could be significant, with some areas at greater risk than others. SCAR noted that, despite an increasing number of studies, large parts of Antarctica remained unexamined and the sources of microplastic debris were significantly understudied. SCAR emphasised that internationally coordinated and standardised monitoring would be critical to understanding the scale, trends and impacts of plastic pollution, and encouraged further coordinated efforts.
- (289) Japan referred to IP 96, which set out its work on harmonised monitoring and data compilation of marine plastic litter, including microplastics. Japan welcomed cooperation from Members in providing monitoring data from the Antarctic region to improve the collective understanding of marine plastic pollution.
- (290) The Committee thanked SCAR for the paper and its active engagement with the issue of plastic pollution, and Portugal and Japan for sharing their experiences and learnings. Recognising plastic pollution as a pressing environmental challenge, the Netherlands noted that the sources of macroplastics remained understudied and that further work was needed to understand the scale of the problem, and encouraged joint efforts and further updates from SCAR.
- (291) SCAR presented IP 127 *Antarctic Environments Portal*, which provided an update on recent publications, and thanked the Committee and Members for their continued support of the Portal as an important vehicle for communicating the best available science. Since

CEP 27, new information summaries had been published. These include a paper on emerging evidence of abrupt changes in the Antarctic environment, relevant to ongoing discussions on sea ice, emperor penguins and the CCRWP. The Portal had also published an overview on the spread of HPAI, as well as papers on vessel biofouling management and Antarctica's contribution to global sea-level rise. In response to comments from CEP 27, earlier information summaries were also being updated, including those relevant to the Antarctic Clean-Up Manual, such as the closure criteria for fuel-contaminated soils and wastewater management. SCAR informed the Committee of the first completed 'Ice Narratives' project, which provided in-depth content, expert interviews and interactive story maps to enrich the Portal. Future work to expand the Portal is supported by funding from the Prince Albert II of Monaco Foundation. SCAR welcomed feedback from Members on both Portal content and new presentation formats.

- (292) Several Members expressed gratitude for SCAR's work on the Portal and encouraged all Members to support its ongoing operation and further development, including making suggestions on potential information summary topics.
- (293) SCAR thanked Members for their contributions to the Portal, whether through authorship or financial contributions, and noted it could not provide this resource without them.
- (294) Belarus presented IP 100 *Initial air quality monitoring data in the area of the Belarusian Antarctic Station (Vecherniy Oasis, Enderby Land, East Antarctica)*. Belarus noted that for the last 20 years, it had conducted integrated monitoring and assessed the collected data annually. Belarus reported that it had, for the first time, obtained ground-based measurement data on atmospheric pollutants near the Belarusian Antarctic Station. Belarus noted it would conduct further ground-based measurements and report back to CEP 29.
- (295) The Committee noted the following Information Papers were submitted under this agenda item:
- IP 53 *INVEMAR becomes a Collaborating Centre of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)* (Colombia).
 - IP 54 *Gradiente espacial del microfitoplancton entre el Pacífico sudoriental y la Península Antártica Occidental* (Colombia).
 - IP 55 *Contaminación por microplásticos en aguas superficiales del norte de la Península Antártica Occidental* (Colombia).
 - IP 58 *Microplásticos en krill del norte de la Península Antártica Occidental: implicaciones para la red trófica* (Colombia).
 - IP 96 *Harmonized monitoring and data compilation of marine plastic litter* (Japan).
 - IP 98 *Long-term Monitoring Initiatives to Assess Environmental Impacts of Station Operations and Scientific Activities* (Japan).
 - IP 125 *The Southern Ocean Observing System (SOOS): Enhancing Integration, Coordination and Collaboration to Upscale Observations in a Changing World* (SCAR).
 - IP 179 *Presence of Microplastics in Antarctica and Their Ecological Implications for Environmental Management* (Ecuador).

- IP 180 *Assessment of the Distribution and Density of Macroplastics in the South Shetland Islands (Antarctica) during 2023–2025* (Ecuador).

(296) The Committee noted the following Background Papers were also submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 38 *Environmental Monitoring Activities on the Fildes Peninsula, King George (Vaterloo) Island in the 2025/2026 Season* (Russian Federation).
- BP 39 *Russian Studies of the HPAI Situation in the Period 2025–2026* (Russian Federation).
- BP 57 *Information on the Implementation of the NUTEC Plastics Initiative in Antarctica* (Argentina).

Item 11: Inspection Reports

(297) The Committee noted that no papers were submitted under this agenda item.

Item 12: General Matters

(298) Argentina stated that it considered there were no technical grounds to support a separate reference for the area referred to as “Southern Ocean”, which corresponds to the southern zones of the Indian, South Atlantic and South Pacific Oceans, as it had expressed in its reservation in the IHO.

(299) France stated that in order to make progress on valuable guidelines for use by Members, it had been flexible regarding proposed changes related to climate change. France, however expressed it had strong concern about the gradual disappearance of references to climate change in the work of the Committee.

(300) France emphasised that climate change was a reality affecting all countries, regardless of borders. Cautioning that refusing to even name climate change constituted a dangerous precedent, France considered this a worrying development for the credibility of a committee whose work was grounded in scientific fact, and sent a negative message for its future. France further noted the risk that, by refusing to acknowledge climate change, science itself could be called into question, despite the substantial work of SCAR and other Members, which had clearly demonstrated the connection between climate change and the degradation of Antarctic ecosystems. Recalling that science sat at the heart of the Antarctic Treaty, which had long united Members around the shared objectives of peace and environmental protection, France emphasised that the CEP must continue advancing its work without compromising the very rationale for its existence.

(301) Most Members and ASOC supported the statement by France recalling that only three years ago the ATCM had adopted the Helsinki Declaration on Climate Change and the Antarctic (Resolution 2 (2023)), which reaffirmed its firm commitment to combat the adverse impacts of climate change in Antarctica.

(302) The United States agreed on the importance of drawing on the best available science to inform the work of the Committee, and emphasised that the Committee's work should be clear and precise and focus on the specific changes that impact Antarctica.

(303) The Committee noted that no working papers were submitted under this agenda item, and the following Information Papers were submitted under this agenda item:

- IP 6 *Ross Sea Environmental Awareness Manual: Balleny Islands, Victoria Land, Ross Island* (Germany, Italy, Republic of Korea, New Zealand and the United States)
- IP 46 *Alternative Fuels Taskforce Update* (COMNAP)

(304) The Committee noted that the following Background Papers were also submitted under this agenda item:

- BP 25 *Team effectiveness in Antarctic ex-pedition operations* (Portugal)
- BP 76 *Planificación Ambiental en las Plataformas Antárticas del Perú* (Peru)

Item 13: Election of Officers

(305) The Committee agreed to re-elect Ceisha Poirot (New Zealand), for a further two-year term and congratulated her on her re-election.

Item 14: Preparation for the Next Meeting

(306) The Committee adopted the Preliminary Agenda for CEP 29 (Appendix 2).

Item 15: Adoption of the Report

(307) The Committee adopted its Report.

Item 16: Closing of the Meeting

(308) The Chair closed the Meeting on Friday, 15 May 2026.

Appendix 1

CEP Five-year Work Plan Progress Tracker

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☒				
5YWP Environmental Pressure (1a): Introduction of non-native species and wildlife disease					
Priority Actions					
Identify areas at high risk of wildlife disease and develop a monitoring program for such areas.	☐	☒			
Develop rapid response mechanisms and strategy for use in the instance of NNS and wildlife disease outbreaks.	☐	☐			
Identify biosecurity measures to prevent intra-continental species introductions.	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
Review the progress and contents of the CEP Non-native Species Manual (5 years).	☒	☒			
Review reports on implementation and effectiveness of biosecurity measures and the NNS manual (as appropriate).	☐	☒			
Review updates on status of known and new established non-native species (as appropriate).	☐	☒			
Consider the current threat caused by the highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI) (annually)	☒	☒			
5YWP Environmental Pressure (1b): Impacts of tourism and NGO activities and implications of growth and diversification					
Priority Actions					

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☐				
Develop mechanism enabling rapid considerations of and changes to existing Visitor Site Guidelines when immediate action is required for site management due to particular and urgent environmental concerns.	☐	☐			
Develop tools and guidance – in addition to Visitor Site Guidelines – to avoid or minimize environmental impacts of tourism and NGO activities.	☐	☐			
Discuss and prepare a framework for an environmental monitoring programme to assess the impacts of tourism and NGO activities that will also consider the potential for using sensitivity and carrying capacity to reduce impacts (relevant to action 2a-1).	☐	☒			
Develop a framework for pre-assessment of new, novel or particularly concerning activities (also listed as action 2d-4).	☐	☐			
Advance recommendations from ship-borne tourism ATME (2010) and the CEP tourism study (2012).	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
Regular review of all existing Visitor Site Guidelines to ensure that they are accurate and up to date, including precautionary updates where appropriate (5 years).	☒	☒			
Regular review of the General Guidelines for Visitors to the Antarctic in collaboration with COMNAP, IAATO and other relevant expert organisations.	☐	☐			

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☒				
Proactively monitor tourism trends (in collaboration with IAATO and the Secretariat) in order to identify and advise the ATCM on the need for additional management measures.	☐	☐			
5YWP Environmental Pressure (1c): Climate Change Implications for the Environment					
Priority Actions					
Implement the Climate Change Response Work Programme, keep it updated and review and revise in light of relevant input and discussions.	☐	☒			
Regular Actions					
Consider subsidiary group report, including CCRWP updates (annually).	☒	☒			
5YWP Environmental Pressure (1d): Local and long-range pollution					
Priority Actions					
Develop a framework for systematic, standardised and comparable sampling and data collection of pollution in the Antarctic as per Resolution 5 (2019).	☐	☐			
Identify appropriate mechanisms for updates on status and trends of pollutants in Antarctica, including a database to share and store information.	☐	☐			
Assess the need for guidance /regional plan on avoiding pollution.	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
Review of the Clean-Up Manual to consider and include local pollution information (as appropriate).	☐	☒			
5YWP Management Response (2a): Facilitating monitoring and state of the environment reporting					

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☒				
Priority Actions					
Consider objectives for environmental monitoring needed to fulfil the requirement of the Environmental Protocol and develop an initial framework of parameters that based on environmental values and cumulative impact, would require monitoring to meet those objectives.	☒	☒			
Identify existing monitoring activities and data available to undertake and report on an initial gap analysis between the existing monitoring portfolio and what is required.	☐	☒			
Consider and facilitate the development of possible mechanisms to facilitate access to monitoring data in collaboration with SCAR, COMNAP, CCAMLR (CEMP) and other relevant expert organisations.	☐	☒			
Develop a dashboard system or other appropriate mechanism enabling future periodic summary of monitoring activities in order to derive effective measures.	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
5YWP Management Response (2b): Considering marine spatial protection and management					
Priority Actions					
Identify needs for spatial marine protection and management measures.	☐	☐			

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☒				
Consider connectivity between land and ocean, and complementary actions that could be taken by Parties with respect to MPAs, incl. providing advice relating to Resolution 5 (2017).	☐	☐			
Consider approaches to managing threats to the marine environment (e.g. pollution, wastewater discharge, etc.).	☐	☐			
Consider how the protected areas system could be used to address the protection of terrestrial and marine environments from activities not covered by CCAMLR.	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
Maintain dialogue (or sharing of information) with SC-CAMLR on complementary actions within the competence of the ATCM (Resolution 5 (2017)) (continuously).	☐	☐			
Hold joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshops to progress spatial protection and management (c. 5 years)	☒	☒			
5YWP Management Response (2c): Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system					
Priority Actions					
Undertake work to advance actions agreed by the Committee from discussions on the protected areas workshop (2019) as presented in the final report of CEP XXII (para 182).	☐	☐			

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☒				
Develop criteria for assessing the suitability of bird colonies for ASPA designation, including to identify what constitutes ‘major colonies of breeding birds’ as set out in Article 3.2(c) of Annex V to the Environmental Protocol, and identify IBAs that meet those criteria. (CEP XX report, paragraph 157).	☐	☐			
Assess the extent to which type locality of species are or should be represented within the series of ASPAs (CEP XXIX report, paragraph 160).	☐	☐			
Consider criteria for prioritising areas requiring protection based on risk.	☐	☐			
Consider further mechanisms for protection of outstanding geological values.	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
Review of ASPA/ASMA management plans, on the basis of the input from the Subsidiary Group on Management Plans, and proposed new locations (annually).	☒	☒			
Consider the report of the SGMP (annually).	☒	☒			
Maintain and update Protected Area guidance material (continuously).	☒	☒			
5YWP Management Response (2d): Implementing and improving the EIA process					
Priority Actions					
Develop guidelines for assessing cumulative impacts.	☒	☒			
Develop guidance on how to undertake an environmental baseline condition survey.	☒	☒			

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☒				
Progress recommendations from the EIA assessment of effectiveness report (CEP XXIV, para 73).	☒	☒			
Develop a framework for pre-assessment relating to new, novel or particularly concerning activities (also listed as action 1b-3).	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
Review draft CEEs (as required).	☒	☐			
Review EIA guidelines and consider wider policy advising ATCM on updating, strengthening or otherwise improving existing rules and measures (5 years).	☐	☒			
5YWP Management Response (2e): Increasing the understanding of Antarctic biodiversity					
Priority Actions					
Consider status and threats to Antarctic biodiversity to inform management/protection of Antarctic biodiversity.	☐	☒			
CEP to review further scientific advice on anthropogenic impacts on wildlife, and on basis of this consider any need for further management actions or measures.	☐	☒			
Consider the risks for disease when developing biodiversity protocols or tools.	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
Consider the conservation status of Antarctic species at risk due to climate change (in line with CCRWP action).	☐	☒			

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☒				
5YWP Management Response (2f): Repair and Remediation of Environmental Damage					
Priority Actions					
Develop an inventory of past sites of activities.	☒	☒			
Develop an action plan with guidance and priority ranking to implement remediation where needed.	☐	☐			
Develop a rapid response mechanism to respond to new or emerging issues.	☐	☐			
Regular Actions					
Review of the Clean-Up Manual and include new tools as appropriate. Members to work on the development of new techniques or guidelines, including for the management of waste of unclear origin in Antarctica (5 years)	☐	☒			
Exchange of information on experience with repair and remediation (as appropriate)	☒	☒			
5YWP Management Response (2g): Designating and managing Historic Sites and Monuments					
Priority Actions					
Develop criteria for maintenance and management of HSMs, especially in the context of climate change and its impact on the environment, structure and/or objects.	☐	☐			
Implement a regular review process of HSMs for effectiveness of management/conservation plans (if relevant) with regard to climate change and its impacts on the special values and potential clean-up.	☐	☐			

Action	CEP 27 (2025)	CEP 28 (2026)	CEP 29 (2027)	CEP 30 (2028)	CEP 31 (2029)
	Status: Not started ☐ ; In Progress ☒ ; Complete ☒				
Further develop criteria for Conservation Management Plans for historic sites, structure and/or objects.	☐	☐			
5YWP Operational Priority (3a): Effective Operation of the CEP and Strategic Planning					
Priority Actions					
Use the 5YWP actively to frame the CEP meetings.	☒	☒			
Consider opportunities for enhancing the working relationship between the CEP and the ATCM.	☐	☐			
Consider opportunities for enhancing broader participation by Members in the work of the Committee.	☐	☒			
Implement a regular review of priorities based on ATCM requirements and changing circumstances.	☐	☐			
Consider and discuss fundamental issues relating to the overall functioning of the CEP in light of the aims of the Environmental Protocol and the tasks of the CEP described in Art. 12 of the Protocol.	☐	☐			
Consider how to increase the transparency of CEP meetings including by utilising existing mechanisms more effectively.	☐	☐			
Keep CEP science knowledge and information needs current		☒			
Regular Actions					
Keep the five-year work plan updated (annually).	☒	☒			

CEP Five-year Work Plan

1. Environmental Pressure Priorities

1a. Introduction of non-native species & wildlife disease

Context: *Antarctica's biodiversity and its intrinsic values are potentially at risk from the introduction of non-native species, derived from a range of sources including human activities. Whilst guidance has been developed to minimise the risk of unintentionally introducing plants and invertebrates to the terrestrial environment, less attention has been given to marine non-native species (NNS) risks and microorganisms. Because of steadily growing human activities in the Antarctic Treaty area and progressing climate change, the risk of non-native organisms arriving and establishing is likely to increase. Further, the highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI) is a new threat to the area which deserves special attention and response measures. Regionality: This issue is of continent-wide importance, but particularly where human activities move between local and biogeographic regions such as in the Antarctic Peninsula region where human activity is increasing and climate is changing rapidly.*

Interlinks with:

Climate Change Implications for the Environment; Tourism and NGO activities; Monitoring and state of the environment reporting; Biodiversity knowledge; Implementing and improving the EIA provisions of Annex I; Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system

Objective: Promote prevention measures. Facilitate monitoring of and surveillance for NNS and wildlife disease, particularly in high-risk areas, and ensure that – also through CEP actions – operators have enough information and tools to prevent and respond to NNS and wildlife disease.

Priority Actions:

1. Develop rapid response mechanisms and strategy for use in the instance of NNS and wildlife disease outbreaks.
2. Identify areas at high risk of wildlife disease and develop a monitoring program for such areas.
3. Identify biosecurity measures to prevent intra-continental species introductions.

Regular Actions:

- Review the progress and contents of the CEP Non-native Species Manual (5 years).
- Review reports on implementation and effectiveness of biosecurity measures and the NNS manual (as appropriate).
- Review updates on status of known and new established non-native species (as appropriate).
- Consider the current threat caused by the highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI) (annually).

1b. Impacts of tourism and NGO activities and implications of growth and diversification

Context: Tourism and non-governmental activities in the Antarctic have grown steadily since they began in the 1950s. The numbers of tourists and tour operators have increased as has the number and geographic spread of sites being visited. The range of activities being undertaken has also diversified. It is recognised that tourism has the potential to result in impacts on the environmental, intrinsic, wilderness, aesthetic, and scientific values of Antarctica. Unforeseen cumulative impacts may also arise. Future development of Antarctic tourism and potential management responses need to be considered in light of the associated environmental implications, also in the context of other pressures being faced in the region, such as climate change. **Regionality:** This issue is particularly important in the Antarctic Peninsula region, ie. that area of Antarctica where human activity, including tourism, is most intense and growing/expanding and where the climate is changing rapidly. It is also important to maintain awareness of development in land-based tourism.

Interlinks with:

Introduction of non-native species & wildlife disease; Climate Change Implications for the Environment; Repair and Remediation of Environmental Damage; Pollution; Monitoring and state of the environment reporting; EIA provisions; Biodiversity knowledge; Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system

Objective: Facilitate research and monitoring to understand the impacts of tourism and non-governmental activities, seen also in light of other environmental impacts and activities. Through CEP actions provide tools and guidance to avoid or minimize environmental impacts.

Priority Actions:

1. Develop mechanism enabling rapid considerations of and changes to existing Visitor Site Guidelines when immediate action is required for site management due to particular and urgent environmental concerns.
2. Develop tools and guidance – in addition to Visitor Site Guidelines – to avoid or minimize environmental impacts of tourism and NGO activities.
3. Discuss and prepare a framework for an environmental monitoring programme to assess the impacts of tourism and NGO activities that will also consider the potential for using sensitivity and carrying capacity to reduce impacts (relevant to action 2a-1).
4. Develop a framework for pre-assessment of new, novel or particularly concerning activities (also listed as action 2d-4).
5. Advance recommendations from ship-borne tourism ATME (2010) and the CEP tourism study (2012).

Regular Actions:

- Regular review of all existing Visitor Site Guidelines to ensure that they are accurate and up to date, including precautionary updates where appropriate (5 years).
- Regular review of the General Guidelines for Visitors to the Antarctic in collaboration with COMNAP, IAATO and other relevant expert organisations.
- Proactively monitor tourism trends (in collaboration with IAATO and the Secretariat) in order to identify and advise the ATCM on the need for additional management measures.

1c. Climate Change Implications for the Environment

Context: *Observations, modelling and global assessments describe significant changes in Antarctic physical and living systems, both marine and terrestrial. Changes in the Antarctic environments and dependent and associated ecosystems are linked to and influence climate change drivers globally. While climate change has global impacts and will contribute to ecosystem disruption and loss of biodiversity beyond the Antarctic region, the impacts on the Antarctic environment itself are also of substantial concern. Climate change may benefit some Antarctic species in the short-term, for example, by expanding the size of ice-free areas available for colonisation, or with warmer waters increasing biological productivity in the ocean. However, the loss of habitat for some species, the threat of non-native species establishing and outcompeting native species, the increasing exposure to re-released contaminants due to melting ice and the loss of natural values are some of the potential negative implications of climate change. Regionality: This issue is of continent-wide importance, although there are substantial variations in the degree of change and associated consequences.*

Interlinks with:

Introduction of non-native species & wildlife disease; Monitoring and state of the environment reporting; Biodiversity knowledge; Repair or remediation of environmental damage; Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system; improving the EIA provisions of Annex I; Long-range and local pollution

Objective: To support efforts to monitor, mitigate, prepare for, adapt and build resilience to the environmental impacts of a changing climate and the associated implications for the governance and management of Antarctica through the implementation of the Climate Change Response Work Programme (CCRWP).

Priority Actions:

1. Implement the Climate Change Response Work Programme, keep it updated and review and revise in light of relevant input and discussions.

Regular Actions:

- Consider subsidiary group report, including CCRWP updates (annually).

1d. Long-range and local pollution

Context: Antarctica is one of the cleanest, least polluted places on Earth. However, there is growing evidence that Antarctica is increasingly exposed to chemical stressors, both long-range transport of chemical contaminants and pollutants and local discharges. Some of these chemicals have been detected in the Antarctic environment and can accumulate in the Antarctic biota. Microplastic pollution has also been found in Antarctica, but the presence and effects of microplastics within food webs are still little understood. Similarly, the extent and effects of globally transported pollutants in Antarctica are poorly understood.

Regionality: This issue is of continent-wide importance.

Interlinks with:

Climate Change Implications for the Environment; Repair or remediation of environmental damage; Facilitating monitoring and state of the environment reporting

Objective: Facilitate initiatives to systematically monitor and track long-range and local pollution and enable Parties to respond appropriately, including communication to/with relevant local and global organizations. Furthermore, provide guidance and tools to monitor, exchange data, reduce and respond to local and global pollution (primarily chemical and plastic pollution).

Priority Actions:

1. Develop a framework for systematic, standardised and comparable sampling and data collection of pollution in the Antarctic as per Resolution 5 (2019).
2. Identify appropriate mechanisms for updates on status and trends of pollutants in Antarctica, including a database to share and store information.
3. Assess the need for guidance /regional plan on avoiding pollution.

Regular Actions:

- Review of the Clean-Up Manual to consider and include local pollution information (as appropriate).

2. Management Response Priorities

2a. Facilitating monitoring and state of the environment reporting

Context: *In order to meet the overarching objectives of the Protocol on Environmental Protection to the Antarctic Treaty (the Environmental Protocol) to protect the Antarctic environment it is helpful and necessary to develop relevant management actions. These may include actions to understand and report on if and how the Antarctic environment, on a continental, regional and local scale is changing, including understanding how human activities contribute to those changes. Environmental monitoring is fundamental to assessing and understanding change on all scales. Regionality: This issue is of continent-wide importance.*

Interlinks with:

Climate change implications; Biodiversity knowledge; Tourism and NGO activities; Repair or remediation of environmental damage; Long-range and local pollution; Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system

Objective: Encourage and facilitate coordinated and systematic monitoring efforts to understand the pressure on and state of the Antarctic environment. Enable reporting on state and trends for key environmental values in Antarctica.

Priority Actions:

1. Consider objectives for environmental monitoring needed to fulfil the requirement of the Environmental Protocol and develop an initial framework of parameters that based on environmental values and cumulative impact, would require monitoring to meet those objectives.
2. Identify existing monitoring activities and data available to undertake and report on an initial gap analysis between the existing monitoring portfolio and what is required.
3. Consider and facilitate the development of possible mechanisms to facilitate access to monitoring data in collaboration with SCAR, COMNAP, CCAMLR (CEMP) and other relevant expert organisations.
4. Develop a dashboard system or other appropriate mechanism enabling future periodic summary of monitoring activities in order to derive effective measures.

2b. Considering marine spatial protection and management

Context: *The biological and physical processes of the marine and terrestrial environments in the Antarctic Treaty Area are closely connected. Therefore, it is necessary to consider ocean-land connectivity to address protection and management needs. The Environmental Protocol aims to protect the Antarctic environment and associated and dependent ecosystems, which clearly link the continent and the surrounding ocean. While CCAMLR is responsible for marine spatial protection and management under the CAMLR Convention, the ATCM can take decisions within its competence with regard to marine spatial protection and management in accordance with the Antarctic Treaty and the Protocol. Regionality: This issue is of continent-wide importance.*

Interlinks with:

Implementing a systematic approach to the protected areas system; Climate Change Implications for the Environment; Biodiversity knowledge; Monitoring and state of the environment reporting; Long-range and local pollution; Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system; Implementing and improving the EIA provisions of Annex I; Non-native Species and Diseases

Objective: Facilitate monitoring, protection and management of marine environmental values in i.a. marine ecosystems, species, processes and areas within the framework of the provisions of the Environmental Protocol.

Priority Actions:

1. Identify needs for spatial marine protection and management measures.
2. Consider connectivity between land and ocean, and complementary actions that could be taken by Parties with respect to MPAs, incl. providing advice relating to Resolution 5 (2017).
3. Consider approaches to managing threats to the marine environment (e.g. pollution, wastewater discharge, etc.).
4. Consider how the protected areas system could be used to address the protection of terrestrial and marine environments from activities not covered by CCAMLR.

Regular Actions:

- Maintain dialogue (or sharing of information) with SC-CAMLR on complementary actions within the competence of the ATCM (Resolution 5 (2017)) (continuously).
- Hold joint CEP/SC-CAMLR workshops to progress spatial protection and management (c. 5 years).

2c. Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system

Context: Annex V to the Environmental Protocol establishes a framework for designating Antarctic Specially Protected Areas (ASPAs) and Antarctic Specially Managed Areas (ASMAs). These areas are intended to support the objective of protecting comprehensively the Antarctic environment. Important work has been done to underpin the development of a representative series of ASPAs, including spatial analyses to identify distinct 'Environmental Domains' and 'Antarctic Conservation Biogeographic Regions'. The Antarctic Treaty Parties have agreed that these spatial frameworks are useful references to guide the designation of ASPAs within a systematic environmental-geographic framework, and the Committee for Environmental Protection (CEP) has recognised the need for a more systematic approach to the development of the protected area system. Regionality: This issue is of continent-wide importance.

Interlinks with: Climate change implications, Tourism and NGO activities, Biodiversity knowledge; State of the environment and marine spatial protection; Implementing and improving the EIA provisions of Annex I

Objective: Assess the effectiveness of the current series of ASPAs with regard to the provisions of Article 3.2 of Annex V and provide advice on the further elaboration of the series of protected areas within a systematic environmental-geographical framework, as well as the managed areas in accordance with Article 4 of Annex V.

Priority Actions:

1. Undertake work to advance actions agreed by the Committee from discussions on the protected areas workshop (2019) as presented in the final report of CEP XXII (para 182).
2. Develop criteria for assessing the suitability of bird colonies for ASPA designation, including to identify what constitutes 'major colonies of breeding birds' as set out in Article 3.2(c) of Annex V to the Environmental Protocol, and identify IBAs that meet those criteria. (CEP XX report, paragraph 157).
3. Assess the extent to which type locality of species are or should be represented within the series of ASPAs (CEP XXIX report, paragraph 160).
4. Consider criteria for prioritising areas requiring protection based on risk.
5. Consider further mechanisms for protection of outstanding geological values.

Regular Actions:

- Review of ASPA/ASMA management plans, on the basis of the input from the Subsidiary Group on Management Plans, and proposed new locations (annually).
- Consider the report of the SGMP (annually).
- Maintain and update Protected Area guidance material (continuously).

2d. Implementing and improving the EIA process

Context: *The Environmental Protocol requires an EIA to be undertaken prior to an activity occurring in the Antarctic Treaty Area, and applies to almost all scientific, logistical and non-governmental activities that occur in the region. The EIA process is a key tool in helping to meet the Parties' commitment to comprehensively protect the Antarctic environment. The real benefit is the contribution it can make to planning an activity. Building EIA concepts into the processes and procedures for organising an activity from the very beginning increases the rigour of the planning process and greatly improves the identification of alternative, more environmentally friendly options. Increasing pressures on the Antarctic environment (through for example climate change and expanding human activity) means that the management benefits of the EIA tool will be increasingly important. It is therefore important to continue to review and, where appropriate, improve the effectiveness of the Antarctic EIA system.*

Interlinks with:

Climate Change Implications for the Environment; Tourism and NGO activities; Biodiversity knowledge; Facilitating monitoring and state of the environment reporting

Objective: Ensure clear guidance to all those responsible for activities in the Antarctic Treaty Area on conducting appropriate assessments of the activities. Assist through guidance material Parties in assessing, authorizing and permitting activities on basis of EIAs. Allow for a continuous improvement of the EIA process, where appropriate, including EIA follow-up and associated monitoring activities to assess the effectiveness of mitigation and management measures.

Priority Actions:

1. Develop guidelines for assessing cumulative impacts.
2. Develop guidance on how to undertake an environmental baseline condition survey.
3. Progress recommendations from the EIA assessment of effectiveness report (CEP XXIV, para 73).
4. Develop a framework for pre-assessment relating to new, novel or particularly concerning activities (also listed as action 1b-3).

Regular Actions:

- Review draft CEEs (as required).
- Review EIA guidelines and consider wider policy advising ATCM on updating, strengthening or otherwise improving existing rules and measures (5 years).

2e. Increasing the understanding of Antarctic biodiversity
Context: <i>Antarctica's biodiversity faces multiple threats. Fundamental knowledge about the environment is required in order to understand changes, impacts, risks, which species are found where, what are their dynamics, etc. While significant advances have been made in recent years, Antarctica's biological and ecological domains remain, to a large extent, unexplored. This hampers the development and implementation of effective management actions to protect biodiversity. At the same time, in accordance with the Environmental Protocol, management action should be considered on basis of the best scientific and technical advice available in keeping with the precautionary approach. <u>Regionality:</u> This issue is of continent-wide importance.</i>
Interlinks with: Climate change implications; Monitoring and state of the environment reporting; Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system; EIA provisions; Introduction of non-native species & wildlife disease; Tourism & NGO activities
Objective: Keep up to date on status and trends in biodiversity as well as the threats it is faced with and implement and inform relevant management actions.
Priority Actions: 1. Consider status and threats to Antarctic biodiversity to inform management/protection of Antarctic biodiversity. 2. CEP to review further scientific advice on anthropogenic impacts on wildlife, and on basis of this consider any need for further management actions or measures. 3. Consider the risks for disease when developing biodiversity protocols or tools. Regular Actions: • Consider the conservation status of Antarctic species at risk due to climate change (in line with CCRWP action).

2f. Repair and Remediation of Environmental Damage

Context: *Environmental damage in Antarctica might occur as the result of chemical, physical or biological processes resulting from human activities in the region. Furthermore, it might occur as a result of one-off or irregular activities, emergency situations as well as situations in which the environment has been impacted or degraded over longer periods of time. For example, chemical impacts might arise from pollution events, such as the critical failure of a fuel tank; a coastal shipping disaster, or the slow degradation of abandoned bases; leaking fuel tanks, or presence of waste dumps. Physical impacts might arise from regular foot and vehicle traffic causing tracking, or damage to vegetation, as well as from the establishment and ongoing operation of Antarctic stations and bases. Biological impacts might arise through the introduction and establishment of non-native species (cf. 1a.). The environmental and geographic characteristics of Antarctica means that response actions and approaches used elsewhere may need to be adapted, while taking into account the high standards of environmental protection in Antarctica relative to many other parts of the world. Regionality: This issue is of continent-wide importance, wherever there have been or are human activities ongoing in both marine and terrestrial environments.*

Interlinks with: Long-range and local pollution; Climate Change Implications for the Environment; Facilitating monitoring and state of the environment reporting; Introduction of non-native species & wildlife disease

Objective: Facilitate actions to identify, respond to, repair and remediate environmental damage in Antarctica. Furthermore, assess whether all actions that should have been taken with respect to repair and remediation have been taken and promote actions where they still may be required.

Priority Actions:

1. Develop an inventory of past sites of activities.
2. Develop an action plan with guidance and priority ranking to implement remediation where needed.
3. Develop a rapid response mechanism to respond to new or emerging issues.

Regular Actions:

- Review of the Clean-Up Manual and include new tools as appropriate. Members to work on the development of new techniques or guidelines including for the management of waste of unclear origin in Antarctica (5 years)
- Exchange of information on experience with repair and remediation (as appropriate)

2g. Designating and managing Historic Sites and Monuments

Context: *Human presence in Antarctica is, seen in the global context, extremely short. Since the first sighting of the continent in 1820, the extent to which humans have left their mark here is relatively limited. In such a context, the limited historical evidence of a connection between man and land becomes extremely visible and special. Parties therefore have given full recognition to the historic sites, structures and objects as part of humankind's cultural heritage. The Environmental Protocol makes the Historic Sites and Monuments (HSM) list the key mechanism for the protection of historic values in Antarctica.*

Interlinks with:

Tourism and NGO activities; Climate Change Implications for the Environment; Operating and further elaborating the Antarctic Protected Area system; Facilitating monitoring and state of the environment reporting

Objective: Provide Parties with guidance and support in assessing and managing heritage.

Priority Actions:

1. Develop criteria for maintenance and management of HSMs, especially in the context of climate change and its impact on the environment, structure and/or objects.
2. Implement a regular review process of HSMs for effectiveness of management/conservation plans (if relevant) with regard to climate change and its impacts on the special values and potential clean-up.
3. Further develop criteria for Conservation Management Plans for historic sites, structure and/or objects.

3. Operational Priorities

3a. Effective Operation of the CEP and Strategic Planning

Context: *The CEP was established under the Environmental Protocol to advise the ATCM on matters relating to the protection of the Antarctic environment. After more than 25 years of work, the Committee has consolidated itself as a highly relevant and important component of the Antarctic Treaty system. The CEP agenda is normally full and broad and the Committee is in many ways “the workhorse of the ATCM”. Focus on strategic planning provides for a focus of CEP activities on the environmental issues requiring the greatest attention.*

Interlinks with:

Objective: Ensure that the CEP systematically works to provide advice in implementing the objectives of the Environmental Protocol to the ATCM in a prioritized, strategic and efficient manner, facilitating broader participation by Members in the work of the Committee.

Priority Actions:

1. Use the 5YWP actively to frame the CEP meetings.
2. Consider opportunities for enhancing the working relationship between the CEP and the ATCM.
3. Consider opportunities for enhancing broader participation by Members in the work of the Committee.
4. Implement a regular review of priorities based on ATCM requirements and changing circumstances.
5. Consider and discuss fundamental issues relating to the overall functioning of the CEP in light of the aims of the Environmental Protocol and the tasks of the CEP described in Art. 12 of the Protocol.
6. Consider how to increase the transparency of CEP meetings including by utilising existing mechanisms more effectively.

Regular Actions:

- Keep the five-year work plan updated (annually).

Appendix 2

Preliminary Agenda for CEP 29 (2027)

1. Opening of the Meeting
2. Adoption of the Agenda
3. Strategic Discussions on the Future Work of the CEP
4. Operation of the CEP and strategic planning
 - a. Cooperation with other Organisations
 - b. Operations and strategic planning
5. Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) (Annex I)
 - a. Draft Comprehensive Environmental Evaluations
 - b. The EIA process
 - c. Other Annex I Matters
6. Conservation of Antarctic Flora and Fauna (Annex II)
 - a. Introduction of Non-native Species and Wildlife Disease
 - b. Specially Protected Species
 - c. Understanding Antarctic biodiversity
 - d. Other Annex II Matters
7. Waste Management and Pollution (Annex III and Annex IV)
 - a. Repair and Remediation of Environmental Damage
 - b. Long-range and local pollution
 - c. Other Annex III and IV Matters
8. Area Protection and Management Plans (Annex V)
 - a. New and revised ASPA/ASMA management plans
 - b. Historic Sites and Monuments
 - c. Site Guidelines
 - d. Marine Spatial Protection and Management
 - e. Other Annex V Matters
9. Climate Change Implications for the Environment
 - a. Implementation and Review of the Climate Change Response Work Programme
 - b. Other climate change matters
10. Environmental Monitoring and State of the Environment Reporting
11. Inspection Reports
12. General Matters
13. Election of Officers
14. Preparation for the Next Meeting
15. Adoption of the Report
16. Closing of the Meeting

3. Appendices

ATCM48 Synthesis Building Blocks and Workstream Outcomes

Building block 1: Managing growth

- Numbers (visitors, ships, aircraft, operators, etc.)
- Timing (length of season)
- Sites (number, types, location, regions, sensitivity, unvisited, protection of) and spatial management, on the basis of site and regional Antarctic scale considerations
- Infrastructure

ANTARCTIC LEVEL

1. Seasonal limit

Additional or alternative proposals; not necessarily mutually exclusive

1. Tourism and other non-governmental activities in the Antarctic Treaty area shall take place between [...] and [...] each year;
2. Tourism and other non-governmental activities in the Antarctic Treaty area shall have a seasonal limit to be set by the ATCM.

2. Land-based activities

Additional or alternative proposals; not necessarily mutually exclusive

1. The construction and/or exploitation of any structure or facility exclusively for tourism and other non-governmental activities to be operated in Antarctica over multiple seasons, where its construction, operations or removal is expected to have more than a minor or transitory impact on the Antarctic environment and its dependent and associated ecosystems, or the intrinsic, natural, wilderness, aesthetic, scientific and historical values of Antarctica, including but not restricted to buildings, wharves and jetties, and graded runways on exposed ground, shall be prohibited;¹
2. Tourism and other non-governmental activities in the interior of Antarctica shall only be allowed in designated areas (e.g., Areas of Special Tourist Interest (ASTI) focusing on these activities);
3. The establishment of new semi-permanent facilities for tourism and other non-governmental activities and the expansion of currently existing seasonal camps is prohibited.

ANTARCTIC AND REGIONAL LEVELS

3. Spatial distribution and/or opening or closure of sites: the role of science and precaution

Additional or alternative proposals; not necessarily mutually exclusive

1. The ATCM will adopt Spatial Management Plans for regions specified in Annex [...],
 - a) [based on a Systematic Conservation Plan;]
[based on a regional-scale EIA (SEA/Cumulative Impact Assessment) conducted by one or more Consultative Parties and that follows the procedure of a CEE in accordance with the Protocol;]

¹ Codification of Resolution 5(2022); aesthetic and scientific values have been added in conformity with Art. 3(1) of the Protocol.

- [based on the best available scientific knowledge relating to:
 - the natural characteristics of the environment, both marine and terrestrial;
 - Antarctic values (e.g., biodiversity, wilderness values, science values, historic values) and conservation objectives specified for the relevant region and sites;
 - human activities that take place and/or are planned;
 - sensitivities of the values for visitation, taking particular attention to cumulative impacts;
 - in light of the above components, the appropriateness and levels of visitation for the region and sites;
 - other factors agreed by Parties];
 - b) The Spatial Management Plan will include a mix of spatial management tools, which may include:
 - precautionary visitation numbers [at regional or site level], before unacceptable environmental change and/or biodiversity impacts (e.g., wildlife behavioural changes, impacts on soil or vegetation) occur;
 - (temporal) closures of sites (e.g., for wildlife or seasonal ice-free sites);
 - distinguish zones and sites, including:
 - 'active areas' in which higher visitation and diverse activities are allowed;
 - 'quiet areas' with reduced visitation and only low-impact activities (e.g., walking or kayaking);
 - areas where tourism and non-governmental activities are not permitted;
 - measures to ensure operational safety and the well-functioning of search and rescue (SAR), especially for airborne and continental/deep field activities, including permanent coordination and communication to ensure up-to-date information, contingency planning, and response capacity;
 - monitoring measures;
 - other tools agreed by Parties;
 - c) The Spatial Management Plan will be reviewed at least every 5 years on the basis of monitoring at regional and site level.
2. Tourism and other non-governmental activities in Antarctica are only allowed in the following regions of Antarctica: [...]
 3. Tourism and other non-governmental activities in Antarctica are only allowed at sites, included in Annex [...], for which the ATCM has adopted site guidelines/site regulations (or a provision with a similar aim through the designation of Antarctic Sites of Special Tourist Interest);
 4. The Antarctic Treaty Secretariat establishes and maintains a centrally managed ATCM database of sites visited by tourists and other non-governmental activities, including information on their environmental sensitivities, site guidelines/regulations, activities conducted at the site, number of visitors;
 5. The ATCM agrees to make the following best practices of IAATO legally binding for all tourist activities in the Antarctic:
 - a) A ship-scheduler supporting the implementation of Measure 15 (2009);
 - b) [...].
4. ***New sites/unexplored areas (not visited by tourism before, including newly accessible areas resulting from ice retreat)***
Additional or alternative proposals; not necessarily mutually exclusive
1. In implementing the Protocol's EIA requirements, Consultative Parties agree that, if an operator cannot undertake a comprehensive prior assessment of a site, or if sufficient

- information to make an informed decision is lacking, a precautionary approach must be adopted and access to the site shall not be authorised;
2. National Competent Authorities will assess applications for visits to sites that have not been visited for tourism or other non-governmental activities in the past on the basis of the following criteria: [...];
 3. On the basis of a proposal of one or more Consultative Parties, the ATCM may designate for a renewable two-year period “Zones of Potential Scientific Interest” to protect potential scientific value of areas not yet studied. A proposal will be based on available scientific information and the application of a precautionary approach and will be accompanied by a research plan to be implemented during the designation period. Its creation would be based on the interest and commitment of at least one National Program to develop research in the area, beyond the current level of scientific knowledge;
 4. Visits to sites that have not been visited for tourism or other non-governmental activities in the past, are prohibited, unless a prior EIA and long-term monitoring at that site is possible;
 5. Visits to sites that have not been visited for tourism or other non-governmental activities in the past, are prohibited, unless the following cumulative requirements are fulfilled:
 - a) a prior EIA at the minimum level of an IEE has been completed;
 - b) long-term monitoring at that site is possible;
 - c) site guidelines/regulations have been adopted by the ATCM;
 6. Visits to sites that have not been visited for tourism or other non-governmental activities in the past, are prohibited;
 7. Visits to sites [in the interior of Antarctica] that have not been visited for tourism or other non-governmental activities in the past, are prohibited.

SITE LEVEL

5. *Proposals at site level*

Additional or alternative proposals; not necessarily mutually exclusive

1. For currently visited sites that lack guidelines and which are considered appropriate for visitation, the ATCM will adopt site guidelines (within a period of ...year);
2. Site guidelines will be reviewed at least every 5 years in order to determine whether the site is (still) considered appropriate for visitation, and if so, to assess whether the site guidelines need revision;
3. Site guidelines will become legally binding, while ensuring flexibility to be able to change such regulation at site level in light of changing circumstances;
4. The ATCM may temporarily close sites to provide ‘recovery time’;
5. Tourist activities and other non-governmental activities involve at least 50% guides and staff that have a minimum threshold of experience [for example, for X days during at least two Antarctic seasons];
6. Parties shall require those under their jurisdiction organising or conducting tourism or other non-governmental activities in the Antarctic Treaty area:
 - a) to refrain from making any landings and from conducting any other off-ship activities in the Antarctic Treaty area from vessels carrying more than 500 passengers unless a lower number is otherwise specified in applicable ATCM measures;
 - b) in the case of vessels carrying 500 or fewer passengers,
 - operators shall coordinate with each other with the objective that not more than one vessel is at a landing site at any one time;
 - to restrict the number of passengers on shore at any one time to 100 or fewer, unless a lower number is otherwise specified in applicable ATCM Measures and to maintain a 1:20 guide-to-passenger ratio, unless a more restrictive ratio is otherwise specified in applicable ATCM measures;

- c) to maintain minimum distances from wildlife to avoid disturbance, with a general minimum distance of 5 metres for penguins and 30 metres for seals.

Building block 2: Managing diversification

- Activities
- Transportation modes
- Actors (e.g., independent actors with no link to State Party/responsible government entity)

1. General principles for the assessment of activities

- a) In assessing tourism and other non-governmental activities in the Antarctic Treaty area, Parties shall be guided by the following principles:
 - **Transparency and consistency:** assessment methods, information requirements and authorisation decisions should be understandable, reproducible and comparable across Parties;
 - **Proportionality and practicality:** the level of assessment, information required and conditions imposed should be appropriate to the nature, scale, location, duration, novelty and potential impacts of the activity;
 - **Precaution and evidence-base:** where information is limited, uncertain or insufficient to assess potential environmental, cumulative, regional or safety-related effects, Parties shall apply a precautionary approach, Parties shall also use the best available scientific and technical information;
 - **Integration and coherence:** assessment of activities shall be linked to Environmental Impact Assessment procedures, spatial management tools, monitoring mechanisms, information exchange and relevant ATCM instruments.
- b) Tourism and other non-governmental activities shall be assessed not only in relation to the impact on the environment and mitigation of potential impacts, but also in relation to their compatibility with the objectives and principles of the Protocol and relevant ATCM instruments.
- c) The principles listed above shall inform the application of the assessment criteria and support tools adopted under this Framework.
- d) For activities or categories of activities identified by the ATCM as requiring particular scrutiny, the principles above shall be applied through additional assessment procedures, which may include prior consultation, enhanced information requirements, specific activity guidance, monitoring and reporting requirements, or periodic review.

2. Criteria for the assessment of activities

- a) In assessing tourism and other non-governmental activities in the Antarctic Treaty area, Parties shall apply common assessment criteria endorsed by the ATCM.
- b) The common assessment criteria shall include, as appropriate:
 - **Environmental protection:** including potential impacts on biodiversity, ecosystems, wilderness and aesthetic values, and site-specific, regional and cumulative effects;
 - **Risk and safety:** including the degree to which the activity may create disproportionate risks, requires contingency capacities, affect Search-and-Rescue capacity, or relies on governmental programmes or other operators in the event of an incident;

- **Purpose and justification:** including the clarity of the activity's objectives and its compatibility with the objectives, principles and values of the Antarctic Treaty System;
 - **Educational or scientific benefit:** including whether the activity demonstrably supports awareness, learning, scientific understanding or conservation outcomes, and whether such benefits are proportionate to the activity's scale, location, risks and potential impacts.
- c) In applying the criteria above, Parties shall distinguish between criteria relating to the conduct of an activity, including mitigation of its impacts, and criteria relevant to whether the activity should be authorised.
 - d) The assessment shall consider whether the proposed activity may interfere with scientific research, long-term monitoring, reference areas, protected areas, station operations, other authorised activities or coordinated management arrangements.
 - e) The ATCM may provide further guidance on the application of the common assessment criteria to particular activity types, locations or operational contexts.
 - f) For activities where purpose and justification, educational or scientific benefit, wilderness values or substantial risk are relevant to the assessment, Parties shall apply further guidance adopted by the ATCM.
 - g) Where the application of one or more criteria identifies significant uncertainty, potential cumulative or regional effects, disproportionate safety risks or unclear compatibility with the Protocol, Parties shall apply a precautionary approach and may require additional information, modification of the proposal or further assessment before authorisation or denying authorisation.
3. ***Common classification, terminology and comparability***
- a) For the purposes of assessing tourism and other non-governmental activities in the Antarctic Treaty area, Parties shall describe and classify proposed activities by reference to the common assessment categories set out in Annex
 - b) Where a proposed activity combines several activity types, transport modes, locations or actors, the assessment shall address the combined and cumulative implications of those elements.
 - c) Comparable activities shall be assessed against the same substantive criteria, irrespective of whether they are conducted by commercial operators, private expeditions, media actors, science-associated actors or other non-governmental actors.
 - d) Parties shall record and exchange assessment-relevant information in a harmonised format, using the common assessment categories set out in Annex ..., in order to support comparability of assessments and information exchange between Parties.
 - e) The Annex could also include agreed terminology for the assessment of activities, including terms relating to activity types, transport modes, high-risk activities, educational or interpretive activities, scientific benefit, wilderness and aesthetic values, and cumulative, regional or site-specific effects.
4. ***Information requirements, support tools and guidance***
- a) Applications for the authorisation of tourism and other non-governmental activities shall include sufficient information to enable assessment against the principles, criteria and categories set out in this Framework.
 - b) Parties shall require applicants to provide assessment-relevant information in accordance with the standard information requirements set out in Annex

- c) The ATCM may adopt common templates, checklists or other support tools to assist Parties in applying the assessment principles, criteria and categories under this Framework.
 - d) Parties shall use the standard information requirements, templates, checklists or other support tools adopted under this Framework, as appropriate, in their national Environmental Impact Assessment and authorisation processes.
 - e) The ATCM may adopt consolidated guidance for the assessment of tourism and other non-governmental activities, drawing on relevant assessment-related provisions, principles, checklists and guidance already adopted within the Antarctic Treaty System, and informed by the best available scientific and technical information, best practice, available monitoring information and, where appropriate, guidance developed by observers or industry bodies
 - f) Support tools and guidance shall be developed and applied in a manner that supports existing Environmental Impact Assessment and authorisation procedures and avoids unnecessary duplication and be periodically reviewed.
 - g) The ATCM may provide for linked or centralised information systems to support access to assessment-relevant information, including information on activity types, previous authorisations of comparable activities, authorisation conditions, monitoring outcomes, reporting and relevant guidance.
- 5. *Processes for new, novel or significantly modified activities***
- a) Where a Party intends to authorise a novel or significantly modified tourism or other non-governmental activity, the Party shall assess whether the activity requires additional scrutiny in light of its nature, scale, location, transport mode, risk profile, cumulative or regional implications, or uncertainty regarding potential impacts.
 - b) For novel or significantly modified activities requiring additional scrutiny, Parties shall require enhanced information from the applicant, including information necessary to assess environmental effects, cumulative and regional implications, safety and contingency arrangements, logistical support, proposed monitoring and reporting, and any educational or scientific benefit.
 - c) Where information is insufficient to assess the potential impacts, risks or compatibility of a novel or significantly modified activity, Parties shall apply a precautionary approach.
 - d) Novel or significantly modified activities may be authorised on a limited or provisional basis, subject to strict conditions, monitoring, reporting and review.
 - e) Following any limited or provisional authorisation, the activity shall be reviewed in light of monitoring outcomes, reporting, observations and any other relevant information before it is authorised again, expanded, modified, restricted or discontinued.
 - f) A Party intending to authorise a novel or significantly modified activity requiring additional scrutiny shall notify other Parties in advance through [the ATCM / the CEP / the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat / an agreed information exchange mechanism] and provide sufficient information to allow for consultation or consideration.
 - g) The ATCM may identify categories of novel or significantly modified activities that require prior consultation or consideration before first authorisation.
 - h) The ATCM may agree that certain activities, or categories of activities, shall not be authorised until appropriate assessment criteria, guidance, monitoring arrangements or other safeguards have been adopted.
- 6. *Activity-specific guidance, categorisation or listing approaches***
- a) The ATCM shall adopt activity-specific guidance for recurring, established, emerging or higher-risk tourism and other non-governmental activities in the Antarctic Treaty area.

- b) Activity-specific guidance shall include, as appropriate, environmental, operational, safety, contingency, monitoring, reporting, educational or scientific, spatial and temporal requirements relevant to the activity type concerned.
- c) Where activity-specific guidance has been adopted, Parties shall ensure that authorisations are consistent with such guidance, unless more stringent requirements are applied under national procedures or other relevant ATCM instruments.
- d) The ATCM shall establish categories or lists of activity types, including activities that are [allowed / restricted / not allowed] or [generally acceptable / requiring additional scrutiny / not acceptable], and may identify specific assessment requirements, restrictions, monitoring obligations or reporting requirements for such categories.
- e) The activities listed in Appendix I may be allowed in the Antarctic Treaty Area if the NCA determines that the activity is in conformity with the provisions of the Protocol and other relevant ATS-instruments, taking into account the specific characteristics and circumstances and potential cumulative impacts. The activities listed in Appendix II shall only be allowed at sites for which the site guidelines/site regulations explicitly allow for such activities. Activities not covered by a category of activities listed in Appendix I or II are not allowed in the Antarctic Treaty area.

This listing would require assessment of current as well as new activities at ATCM level, based on agreed criteria, and would still involve and respect the role of NCA's for listed activities.

- f) Activities falling within a restricted category shall only be authorised where the applicant demonstrates compliance with the applicable assessment criteria, activity-specific guidance and any additional conditions adopted by the ATCM.
- g) Activities falling within a category identified as not allowed shall not be authorised, unless and until the ATCM has reviewed the category in light of new evidence or revised assessment criteria.

7. *Review of activity assessments and linkages with monitoring*

- a) Assessments and authorisation conditions for tourism and other non-governmental activities shall be reviewed, as appropriate, in light of monitoring outcomes, reporting, observations, inspection findings, incident information and other relevant evidence.
- b) Where monitoring, reporting, observations or other relevant information indicate environmental harm, cumulative or regional pressure, safety concerns, recurring compliance issues or uncertainty regarding predicted impacts, Parties shall review the relevant authorisation conditions and may require modification, additional safeguards, restrictions, enhanced information, further assessment or discontinuation of the activity.
- c) Parties shall ensure that information generated through monitoring and reporting is taken into account when applying assessment criteria, reviewing activity-specific guidance, updating information requirements, and assessing comparable future activities.
- d) Review processes under this Framework shall be carried out in a manner consistent with the tourism monitoring strategy [developed under Workstream/Building Block 4] and with existing Environmental Impact Assessment procedures, information exchange mechanisms and other relevant instruments of the Antarctic Treaty System.
- e) The ATCM shall periodically review assessment principles, criteria, information requirements, activity-specific guidance and support tools adopted under this Framework, taking into account relevant outputs from monitoring processes [under Workstream/Building Block 4].

- f) For activities with uncertain impacts, cumulative or regional implications, higher safety risks or novel characteristics, Parties may require enhanced review before the activity is repeated, expanded or authorised on a continuing basis.

Building block 3: Monitoring

- Monitoring, including environmental monitoring (e.g. data collection, management, access and use)
- Observation, inspection and supervision
- Funding
- Coordination
- Responsibilities
- Reporting

DEFINITIONS AND SCOPE

1. Tourism monitoring

- a) In Antarctica, tourism and non-governmental activity monitoring may be defined as routine, systematic and purpose-driven processes for collecting data and making observations. This data will allow the assessment of the status, trends and variability of environmental, social, cultural and historical values.
- b) Monitoring should integrate scientific and technical approaches, combining standardised field observations and other appropriate techniques with data provided by operators and visitors. Monitoring is primarily a technical activity informed by science. It does not necessarily require continuous involvement of research programmes, and or researchers, but should be firmly grounded in the best available scientific and technical information and supported by expert interpretation.
- c) Data generated through monitoring could directly inform adaptive management processes. In accordance with the precautionary principle, monitoring should prioritise early detection of change, identification of emerging risks, and timely management responses, even under conditions of uncertainty. The objective is not only to document impacts ex post, but to anticipate unacceptable change and prevent potentially irreversible environmental, cultural and historical damage.

2. Thresholds and indicators

- a) Thresholds serve a critical role in identifying when environmental or cultural conditions approach or exceed acceptable levels of change. While science can inform the identification of response curves, sensitivities and recovery dynamics, the establishment of thresholds ultimately remains a management decision linked to conservation objectives, desired conditions and societal values.
- b) Cumulative impacts result from the combination of impacts from different sources, such as climate change and visitors' pressure. It is not the purpose of this monitoring strategy to identify the sources of the impacts but the cumulative effects on the ecosystems in such a way when reducing the impact from some sources, the ecosystems can be better conserved and managed.
- c) Given that many tourism-related impacts develop gradually and may remain undetected until advanced stages, monitoring programmes should prioritise:
- indicators that are sensitive to early change;
 - parameters that are directly linked to management objectives;
 - rapid interpretation and communication of results; and

- timely management response under uncertainty.
- d) Early detection and precautionary intervention are preferred to delayed action based on long-term certainty. This approach reflects both ethical responsibilities of environmental stewardship and the practical constraints of managing fragile and slowly recovering ecosystems.
- e) Criteria for selecting indicators include:
 - relevance to desired conditions and management objectives;
 - sensitivity and responsiveness to change;
 - feasibility and cost-effectiveness of monitoring;
 - reliability, repeatability and comparability among observers and programmes; and
 - capacity to support long-term trend analysis and cumulative impact assessment.

PROPOSED MONITORING STRATEGY

3. General

1. This strategy is intentionally incremental, allowing progressive refinement as experience, data and institutional capacity develop, while ensuring that cumulative impacts remain below acceptable levels and that effects remain minor and transitory in accordance with the objectives of the Protocol.
4. It is recognised that monitoring requirements vary among sites, regions and activity types and that all sites require immediate or intensive monitoring and priority should be given to sites characterised by high vulnerability, high visitation pressure, rapid environmental change, or strategic importance for spatial planning and management. Once effective results are achieved in specifically selected areas, more sites may be gradually included.
5. The proposed monitoring should operate as a dynamic feedback system in which:
 - monitoring results inform management decisions and spatial planning;
 - management actions are evaluated through subsequent monitoring;
 - indicators, thresholds and methodologies are refined as necessary; and
 - institutional learning is progressively consolidated.
6. In this context, this monitoring strategy is intended to 1. support the identification of vulnerable sites and regions aimed at receiving tourists, 2. inform decisions on the use, closure, restriction of use or opening of new sites, 3. inform the design of site guidelines and regional management measures, and, 4. provide feedback to the assessment of current and new activities. Only sites and regions for which effective and proportionate monitoring can be implemented should be prioritised for sustained visitation.
7. To operationalize the proposed strategy, we propose:
 - Identification of Ecosystem-based monitoring domains;
 - Prioritisation of monitoring efforts based on vulnerability: Feedback monitoring;
 - Monitoring of observable and measurable effects by ecosystem domain;
 - Implementation and coordination mechanisms.

4. Guiding principles for the monitoring strategy

1. *Precautionary approach.* In the absence of complete knowledge, monitoring and subsequent management decisions should be guided by the precautionary principle and the use of the best information available. Priority should be given to preventing unacceptable change, detecting early warning signals, and intervening before impacts become irreversible or widespread.
2. *Adaptive approach.* Monitoring should operate as part of an adaptive management cycle in which objectives, indicators, thresholds and management measures are periodically reviewed and adjusted in light of new evidence and experience.

3. *Integration with conservation and management objectives.* Monitoring activities should be explicitly linked to the conservation values of the Antarctic environment and to established management objectives, including the protection of wilderness, scientific reference areas, biodiversity and ecosystem processes. Monitoring should support management questions and decisions, rather than operate as an isolated data collection exercise.

4. *Communication and transparency.* Monitoring results should be effectively communicated to decision-makers and systematically used to support evidence-based, transparent and precautionary management decisions at site, regional and continental scales.

5. *Long-term commitment.* Monitoring efforts should be sustained over sufficiently long time periods to allow detection of gradual change, assessment of recovery processes, and evaluation of management effectiveness.

6. *Coordination and cooperation among Parties.* Parties are encouraged to coordinate monitoring efforts, avoid duplication, share methodologies, harmonise indicators and promote cooperative approaches, under the coordination of the CEP and in close collaboration with relevant scientific bodies.

7. *Distinction from research.* Monitoring should be clearly distinguished from scientific research, while recognising that research outcomes play an essential role in identifying monitoring priorities, defining indicators, interpreting trends and refining management thresholds.

5. *Operationalisation of the monitoring strategy*

1. **Prioritisation of monitoring efforts based on vulnerability: Feedback monitoring**

- a. Feedback monitoring refers to a process in which management decisions are informed by the best available knowledge derived from monitoring of the same site or comparable sites. This approach allows evaluation of whether existing management measures are sufficient to minimise impacts and maintain conditions within acceptable limits. Where monitoring indicates that impacts are increasing or recovery is insufficient, management measures and monitoring protocols should be revised accordingly.
- b. Under this scope, vulnerability refers to the degree to which an ecosystem, habitat, cultural attribute or site characteristic is susceptible to, or unable to cope with, adverse effects resulting from natural or human-induced stressors. Vulnerability is not static but varies in space and time and reflects interactions among multiple drivers.
- c. Vulnerability should be understood as a multi-dimensional concept integrating:
 - intrinsic ecosystem sensitivity;
 - intensity, frequency and spatial concentration of visitation;
 - seasonal and life-cycle sensitivity;
 - cumulative pressures over time and across activities; and
 - capacity for recovery and resilience.

2. **Identification of ecosystem-based monitoring domains**

- a) As part of this monitoring strategy, an initial set of ecosystem-based monitoring domains is proposed, but subjected to refinements based on scientific literature and expertise:
 - high plateaus and areas of permanent coastal ice;
 - low coastal zones, including the marine coastal ecosystems;
 - rocky insular coastal zones;
 - areas with vegetation;
 - nunataks.
- b) These domains provide a pragmatic framework for structuring monitoring efforts, recognising the diversity of Antarctic environments and their differential sensitivity

to disturbance. Within each domain, observable and measurable indicators should be selected according to vulnerability, management relevance and feasibility.

- c) The marine realm is not included in this strategy and would require further conceptualization and planning, since its intrinsic characteristics differentiate these ecosystems from all others from a methodological and conceptual perspective.
- d) Indicators represent ecosystem conditions and risks regardless of their specific cause. Tourism may constitute a significant contributor, but monitoring focuses on ecosystem responses, trends and thresholds rather than attribution. This approach allows integration of multiple stressors, including climate change, and supports cumulative impact assessment and precautionary management.

3. Monitoring of observable and measurable effects by ecosystem domain

- a) The table below provides an initial, indicative, non-exhaustive set of observable and measurable effects associated with different ecosystem domains. These parameters represent ecosystem conditions and changes that may signal increasing vulnerability or unacceptable levels of disturbance. The precise effects for each ecosystem would need further refinement at the implementation phase. They are intended as practical references to support site-level monitoring design and prioritisation.

Ecosystem parameter	Observable effects	Measurable effects
Soil	Soil erosion and expansion of muddy areas; visible increase in erosion or variation in gelifluction zones; expansion of eroded areas	Soil compaction; variations in patterned soils
Vegetation (mosses and vascular plants)	Variations in moss and vascular plant cover; evidence of trampling; disappearance of lichens; visual signs of stress or degradation	Introduction and spread of non-native species; quantitative changes in vegetation cover
Aquatic ecosystems (coastal ponds, streams, mudflats)	Alteration of stream courses; trampling on ponds; changes in the shape or configuration of water bodies	Dry meanders; variations in water extent and persistence
Rocky zones in coastal areas	Disturbance of patterned ground; trampling on lichen vegetation; instability of natural formations	Absence of fruticulose and/or foliose lichens; damage patterns and surface erosion
High plateau ice	Noticeable ice compaction; presence of artificial structures such as igloos or trenches; visible modification of snow and ice surfaces	Variations in crevasse formation and size; compaction indices

Coastal ice	Physical changes in access points; variations in ice colour or melting patterns; signs of accelerated surface melt	Changes in melt rate and surface albedo (where feasible)
Nunatak rocky areas	Alteration of polygonal soils; trampling of soil-dwelling lichens; visible climbing erosion ('white paths')	Absence of fruticulose and/or foliose lichens; erosion intensity indicators

- b) It should be noted that these indicators are not exclusive to tourism. They represent observations of conditions or changes that—whether caused by tourism or by other factors—pose a risk to ecosystem integrity. The role of monitoring is to detect trends, identify emerging risks and support precautionary management responses.

4. Temporality

Monitoring cycles may range from annual to multi-year intervals, taking into account indicator dynamics, seasonal variability and recovery processes.

5. Implementation and coordination mechanisms

- a) The implementation of this monitoring strategy should be accomplished in collaboration among the interested parties and focused on the domains of interest. Parties are encouraged to harmonise methodologies and reporting formats, share data and best practices, contribute to common baselines including State of the Environment reporting, and ensure coherence with spatial planning and activity assessment processes.
- b) The Committee for Environmental Protection should coordinate and oversee monitoring efforts, in close cooperation with national Antarctic programmes, SCAR and relevant scientific groups, and other workstreams of the Tourism Framework.

Building block 4: Compliance and Enforcement

- Identification of causes of non-compliance, including reporting
- Addressing cases of non-compliance
- Observation, inspection and supervision

Building block 5: Governance

- Leadership role of the ATCM
- Advice from the CEP
- Cooperation and coordination, including between National competent authorities
- Addressing National competent authorities shopping, including relevant issues of national legislation
- In-field coordination
- Independent data management and information and reporting
- Exchange of information
- Fees
- Safety (ship safety, air safety, liability, insurance, emergency response, search and rescue, contingency planning, etc.)
- Liability
- Activities of state/non-state hybrid nature
- Not undermining the objectives of governmental activities
- Accreditation of operators
- Harmonisation of authorisation processes
- Institutional arrangements
- Addressing clear state responsibility for all tourist and other non-governmental Activities

Fees***1. Objectives/Purpose***

1. To support the development of a comprehensive framework, the initial objectives of fees could include:
 - Monitoring of tourism activities;
 - Data collection, storage, and analysis;
 - New, additional tasks required by a Secretariat, including to support data management and administration of the collection of fees.
2. As discussions on the framework advance, additional objectives could include:
 - Revision and elaboration of spatial management tools, including visitor site guidelines;
 - Expansion of observation activities (e.g. broader use of observers);
 - Administration of any caps or limits;
 - New, additional tasks required for a Secretariat to support implementation of the framework;
 - Other activities or functions to support implementation of the framework.

2. Principles

The following principles could guide the collection of fees and the establishment and operation of a fund:

- Efficiency and cost-effectiveness;
- Transparency;
- Accountability;
- Flexibility (as appropriate);
- Simple and pragmatic;
- Fairness;
- Predictability;
- Additionality.

3. **Collection of fees²**

1. Fees could be collected from:
 - Individual tourists; and/or
 - Operators.
2. Fee rates could be:
 - A flat, fixed fee;
 - A variable fee based on:
 - Length of time in the Antarctic Treaty Area (e.g., daily rate);
 - Type of operation (ship-based, land-based, air-based);
 - Number of landings/sites visited;
 - Visits to site with a higher maintenance cost (e.g., historic huts);
 - Type of activity and associated impact and/or risks;
 - Location or region visited (e.g., remote sites, deep-field).

4. **Administration of fees³**

1. Collection of fees could occur via:
 - Individual tourists pay direct to Secretariat (via electronic travel authorisation type system);
 - Operators collect fees on behalf tourists and transfer to Secretariat (directly or via NCAs).
2. To support the management and use of funds, the following options could be considered:
 - Management of collected fees carried out the Antarctic Treaty Secretariat;
 - Funded projects related to the objectives of framework should have the support of a Party and could be multi-party joint projects;
 - Committee established by the ATCM to evaluate projects and advise on the use of fund (such as a steering group which would report to the ATCM);
 - Clear procedures for evaluation of proposed projects;
 - Transparent reporting to all Members on performance of projects funded.

The further development of the items under building blocks 4 and 5, with the exception of possible collection of fees and their use, requires greater clarity on the overall structure, scope, objectives, and management approaches of the Framework before it can be further advanced beyond the discussions reflected in:

- ATCM48 IP076, *Development of a Tourism Framework: Status report on the discussions on institutional arrangements, including the role of the CEP as well as possible collection of fees and their use (Workstream 5)*; and
- ATCM48 IP084, *Development of a Tourism Framework: Status report on the discussions on practicalities, including cooperation between national competent authorities, in field cooperation, safety and the role of observers (Workstream 6)*.

² Consideration of possible fees for non-governmental visitors is needed.

³ Consideration of collection of fees for visitors not associated with an operator or an Antarctic Treaty Party is needed.

Building block 6: General Topics

- Objectives
- Scope
- Definitions
- Precaution
- Environment (consequences to, state of, cumulative effects of all kinds of anthropogenic activities, etc.)
- Assessment methodologies
- Primacy of scientific research in relation to all tourism and other non-governmental activities
- Addressing the status of science activities associated with tourism and other nongovernmental activities
- Protection of values
- Relationship to existing rules and instruments (of the ATS)
- Incorporation of existing Resolutions, guidelines, regulations, practices, as appropriate
- Avoidance or mitigation of non-climatic stressors to the environment
- Adaptive governance (flexibility; futureproofing)
- Public education and awareness

1. Objectives

Codification of Resolution 7(2009)

1. All tourism activities undertaken in Antarctica will be conducted in accordance with the Antarctic Treaty, its Protocol on Environmental Protection, and relevant ATCM Measures and Resolutions;
2. Tourism should not be allowed to contribute to the long-term degradation of the Antarctic environment and its dependent and associated ecosystems, or the intrinsic natural wilderness and historical values of Antarctica. In the absence of adequate information about potential impacts, decisions on tourism should be based on a pragmatic and precautionary approach, that also incorporates an evaluation of risks;
3. Scientific research should be accorded priority in relation to all tourism activities in Antarctica;
4. Antarctic Treaty Parties should implement all existing instruments relating to tourism and non-Governmental activities in Antarctica and aim to ensure, as far as practicable, that they continue to proactively develop regulations relating to tourism activities that should provide for a consistent framework for the management of tourism;
5. All operators conducting tourism activities in Antarctica should be encouraged to cooperate with each other and with the Antarctic Treaty Parties to coordinate tourism activities and share best practice on environmental and safety management issues;
6. All tourism organisations should be encouraged to provide a focus on the enrichment and education of visitors about the Antarctic environment and its protection.

Possible additional principles

7. Spatial management of tourism and other non-governmental activities shall be based on a science-based and precautionary approach, with attention for regional and local differences.

2. Incorporation of existing Resolutions, guidelines, regulations, practices, as appropriate

The ATCM is invited to consider:

- The designation of Decisions 5 (2003), 7 (2009) and 6 (2019) as “spent”;

- The designation of Recommendation XVIII-1 (1994) as “obsolete”, provided that ‘guns’ and ‘explosives’ are adequately covered by other current measures (which may need to be adjusted for this purpose); and
- The streamlining of information exchange requirements with respect to post visit reports under Resolutions 10 (2021) and 6 (2022) and the information exchange requirements under the Electronic Information Exchange System and, for that purpose, inviting Working Group 1 of the ATCM to compare these information exchange requirements.

Preliminary Agenda for ATCM 49, Working Groups and Allocation of Items

Plenary

- 1) Opening of the Meeting
- 2) Election of Officers and Creation of Working Groups
- 3) Adoption of the Agenda, Allocation of Items to Working Groups and Consideration of the Multi-year Strategic Work Plan
- 4) Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Reports by Parties, Observers and Experts
- 5) Report of the Committee for Environmental Protection
- 6) Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System:
 - a. Request from Canada to become a Consultative Party
 - b. Request from Belarus to become a Consultative Party
 - c. Request from Türkiye to become a Consultative Party
 - d. Request from Colombia to become a Consultative Party

Working Group 1: Policy, Legal, Institutional

- 6) Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System:
 - e. General matters
- 7) Operation of the Antarctic Treaty System: Matters related to the Secretariat
- 8) Liability
- 9) Biological Prospecting in Antarctica
- 10) Exchange of Information
- 11) Education Issues
- 12) Multi-year Strategic Work Plan
 - a. Policy, Legal and Institutional priorities

Working Group 2: Science, Operations, Tourism

- 12) Multi-year Strategic Work Plan
 - b. Science, Operations and Tourism priorities
- 13) Safety and Operations in Antarctica
- 14) Inspections under the Antarctic Treaty and Environment Protocol
- 15) Science issues, future science challenges, scientific cooperation and facilitation
- 16) Implications of Climate Change for Management of the Antarctic Treaty Area
- 17) Tourism and other Non-governmental Activities in the Antarctic Treaty Area, including Competent Authorities Issues

Special Working Group 3: Development of a Tourism Framework

- 18) Development of a Tourism Framework

Plenary

- 19) Preparation of the 50th Meeting
- 20) Any other Business

- 21) Adoption of the Final Report
- 22) Close of the Meeting



48th ANTARCTIC TREATY CONSULTATIVE MEETING

11 to 21 May, 2026, Hiroshima – Japan

HOST COUNTRY COMMUNIQUÉ

21 May 2026

Japan hosted the 48th Antarctic Treaty Consultative Meeting (ATCM48) and the 28th Committee for Environmental Protection (CEP28) in Hiroshima from 11th to 21st May 2026.

ATCM48 was organised by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Ministry of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology and the Ministry of the Environment of Japan, at the International Conference Center Hiroshima.

More than 400 participants took part in the event, including representatives from 29 Consultative and 15 Non-Consultative Parties to the Antarctic Treaty, along with observers and invited experts.

ATCM48 was chaired by Mr Uyama Hideki, Ambassador Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary in charge of the ATCM. As Japan is committed to environmental sustainability, the meeting was held in a paperless format, by minimising printed materials.

ATCM 48 was officially opened by Dr. Kunimitsu Ayano, State Minister for Foreign Affairs, Mr. Tsuji Kiyoto, State Minister of the Environment, and Mr. Matsui Kazumi, Mayor of Hiroshima. Noting that the Antarctic Treaty is one of the most successful models of collaboration and trust among nations, their remarks highlighted the necessity for demonstrating the ATCM's determination to advance international cooperation even amidst deepening divisions and tension in the

international community. They also highlighted Japan's progress in implementing Annex VI to the Environmental Protocol and called on Parties that had not yet concluded Annex VI to do so, in support of its early entry into force and effective implementation.

Hosting ATCM48 in Hiroshima, an International Peace Culture City, is of particular significance, given that the Antarctic Treaty is an extraordinary agreement with the vision that, even in uncertain times, nations can choose collaboration over competition by setting aside an entire continent for peace and science. Consultative Parties reaffirmed the principles of the Antarctic Treaty — peaceful use and international scientific cooperation — as a beacon of what is possible when countries come together in pursuit of shared knowledge and common purpose.

As part of the opening Plenary session, the Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research (SCAR) Lecture was delivered by Professor Jill Mikucki. It shed light on Antarctic groundwater, particularly its role in supplying bioavailable nutrients to the Southern Ocean as well as its impact on ocean–atmosphere interactions and the challenges it poses to benthic ecosystems.

The CEP made substantive progress in its work on the comprehensive protection of the Antarctic environment, including improving the Environmental Impact Assessment process, strengthening biosecurity and wildlife disease guidance and advancing discussions on species protection and environmental monitoring, including tourism. Recognising the rapid pace of change in Antarctica, the CEP continued to implement the Climate Change Response Work Programme and provided technical advice to inform the ATCM discussions. The work of the CEP reaffirmed the importance of sustained and effective effort to implement the provisions of the Protocol on Environmental Protection which will mark its 35th Anniversary in 2026.

The ATCM discussed the impacts of climate change on Antarctica and concurred on continuing international scientific cooperation to address this issue. Recognising the risks to the survival of the emperor penguin due to declining sea ice, the overwhelming majority of Parties strongly supported the designation of the emperor penguin as an Antarctic Specially Protected Species. In doing so,

they recalled that the CEP adopted Guidelines for Designations of Specially Protected Species, under which risk of extinction is to be assessed by the SCAR using criteria established by the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN). They noted SCAR's assessment, conducted in accordance with these Guidelines, that the emperor penguin is appropriately classified as Endangered under the IUCN Red List criteria.

ATCM reaffirmed the importance of protecting the emperor penguin as a priority and agreed to a) further implement the tools available under the Antarctic Treaty system to manage activities in the Antarctic Treaty area; b) communicate internationally the need to address pressures from outside the Antarctic region; c) encourage continued monitoring, research and reporting of results on the status of the emperor penguin. In addition, the CEP will continue to consider appropriate management measures and provide further advice to the ATCM.

Two new Antarctic Specially Protected Areas were established, and the management plans for thirteen Antarctic Specially Protected Areas were revised.

Antarctica remains remarkably untouched by human interference and is home to a natural environment of exceptional value. Safeguarding this pristine environment from the adverse effects of the growing tourists in recent years has emerged as a matter of paramount importance and shared responsibility among the international community.

In order to address the growth and diversification of tourism in Antarctica, the ATCM discussed possible measures for regulation and management, along with monitoring methodologies, and decided to continue working through the Intersessional Contact Group on the development of a comprehensive and consistent framework for tourism and other activities.

Transparency in Antarctic activities is the foundation of trust among Parties, which has enabled peaceful use and international cooperation in Antarctica. Based on the report by the Intersessional Contact Group on Information Exchange, the ATCM discussed means to comprehensively improve the Electronic Information

Exchange System (EIES) and adopted a Resolution which recommends that the governments of the Consultative Parties redouble efforts to use the EIES to consolidate national information exchanges as required under the Antarctic Treaty and the Protocol. In addition, the Parties welcomed the report on the inspection of sites conducted by the United States in January 2026 including stations of Australia, China, India, and the Russian Federation.

The ATCM examined the requests from Canada, Belarus and Türkiye for Consultative Party status, considering each candidate on its own merit. Although there was no consensus on the requests, constructive discussions were held and these parties are encouraged to continue to pursue Consultative Party status.

Prior to the ATCM, a Joint CEP/Scientific Committee for the Conservation of Antarctic Marine Living Resources Workshop on Climate Change and Monitoring was held to strengthen cooperation and coordination between the two committees to monitor and manage the effects of climate change in the Antarctic. A workshop on education and outreach also took place to share best practices and to exchange views on the role of education and outreach with a view to the International Polar Year 2032-33.

Exhibitions featuring the history of Japan's scientific research and Japan's activities for environmental protection in Antarctica were held by the National Institute of Polar Research and the Ministry of the Environment of Japan at the venue of the ATCM, commemorating the 70th anniversary of Japan's first Antarctic research expeditions.

The next ATCM (ATCM 49) will be held in Incheon, the Republic of Korea, from 17 May to 27 May 2027.